One Perfect Year at Stevenson High

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Seahawk, Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - High School, High School, Alternate Universe - Normal High School, Students, Inspired by Glee, Glee - Freeform, Show Choir, Cheerleaders, Teenage Drama, DRAMAtical Lesbians, Teenagers, Teen Romance, Teen Angst, Teen Crush, Useless Lesbians, Lesbian Character, POV Lesbian Character, Homecoming, Friends to Lovers, Best Friends, Friends to Enemies, Enemies to Lovers, catradora, idiots to lovers

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One Perfect Year at Stevenson High

by MaggieDerrick

Summary

It's She-Ra meets Glee in this Catradora high school AU!

When Adora and Catra start their junior year at Stevenson High School, they're expecting it to be a perfect year. Adora is in line to make captain of the exclusive Valkyrie Cheer Force, and with that much social capital, the girls are planning to rule the school.

But when Adora discovers she has a chance to audition for Vocal Rebellion, the school's glee club, everything starts to change in ways she never could have expected.

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NOTE: Because this is an AU, you don't have to be a fan of Glee or She-Ra and the Princesses of Power to follow along.

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Story is also cross-posted on Wattpad (star-powered)

CONTENT WARNINGS: Underage drinking, mild language, mild and implied sexiness

STATUS: Complete

Chapter 1

Adora was not a prideful person. In fact, she was pretty humble for someone others described as a "professional overachiever". She didn't brag or boast, and she always downplayed praise and compliments with courteous deflection.

But there were three steadfast exceptions to this rule: Adora was proud of her grades, which were objectively excellent across the board. She was proud to be a member of Stevenson High School's exclusive Valkyries Cheer Force. And, Adora was proud of her uncanny ability to curate the very best playlists in her entire friend group.

On the first day of junior year, Adora was enjoying her latest achievement—a back-to-school playlist perfectly balanced with smash hits from the summer's biggest stars, sleeper tracks from undiscovered indies, and carefully selected classics from the past four decades—as loudly as possible. She sang along unabashedly as her phone blasted one song after another from its tiny speakers, and bopped along to the beat like she was on stage. She could almost hear her imaginary fans screaming for more.

With a practiced technique, she pulled her dirty blonde hair into a sleek, Valkyries-regulated ponytail and twisted her bangs into her signature poof atop her head. Her uniform was cleaned and perfectly pressed after having spent the summer in her closet, waiting for September. As she belted out the lyrics to what had arguably been the song of the summer, she twirled in place just to watch the motion of her pleated skirt swirling in the mirror.

It feels so good to be back in my reds, she thought, admiring her strong silhouette. In some ways, her cheer uniform felt like a suit of armor—a respected symbol of strength in halls of SHS that left her and her teammates impervious to the petty cruelties of high school life. But it also felt a bit like a hug from an old friend; a familiar sense of belonging warmed her from the inside as she

smoothed her hand over the crimson V emblazoned across her chest.

"You're singing the words wrong."

Adora let out a shriek. She whirled toward the source of the voice to find her best friend and fellow Valkyrie, Catra, lounging on the window sill with a smug grin on her face.

"Catra!" Adora snapped.

"Hey, Adora," her friend drawled.

"You scared the crap out of me!"

"Well, I tried to get your attention but you were too busy putting on a show to notice."

A flash of heat raced across Adora's face. She narrowed her eyes at her friend. "You did not."

Catra succeeded in keeping a straight face for nearly half a second before bursting into laughter. It was a high, squeaky laugh that almost didn't suit Catra's cold and moody public persona. But Adora knew her best friend better than that, and her laugh was high among her favorite things about her.

"You're right," Catra said, gracefully sliding off the window sill and planting her hands on her hips. "I've been watching your little performance for, like, three whole songs already. Super cute."

"Creep." Adora turned her back so Catra couldn't see her blush. Of course, turning meant she was now facing the mirror. In the reflection, Catra caught her eye, tapped her own cheeks and playfully stuck out her tongue. Now it was Adora's turn to laugh. "Did I really sing it wrong? What're the lyrics supposed to be?"

"She's saying 'got a long list of ex-lovers', not 'got a lotta Starbucks lovers'."

"Oooh... That make a lot more sense."

"Of course it does." Catra came to stand beside Adora and grinned at her in the mirror. She tipped her head to the side and rested her cheek on her best friend's shoulder. "Lookin' good, *Captain*."

A thrill erupted in Adora's stomach, but she brushed it aside. "Not necessarily! Nothing is final until Coach Weaver says so."

There was a good chance today was going to be a very big day for Adora. By the time it was over, she might be the brand new captain of the Valkyries. Ever since she and Catra made the team in their freshman year—the only freshmen to make the squad in over a decade—she had been working her ass off in the not-so-secret hope that she might earn the top spot once their former captain graduated.

"Oh, please," Catra said with a roll of her mismatched eyes. "Coach Weaver has been grooming you for this since she recruited you—"

"Us."

"*You* in first year. And don't give me that 'us' BS. You and I both know you're the one she wanted for the squad. I was just along for the ride."

Catra wasn't wrong about this, though Adora hated that after all these years she still felt like part of a package deal. The Valkyries were an elite cheer squad: auditions were by invitation only. Shadow Weaver, the long-standing and multi-award-winning coach of the SHS Cheer Force had sought Adora out early that first September. But, Adora and Catra had been on the same team for everything since they were old enough to be on teams. Adora agreed to audition, but only if Catra was given a shot too.

"Yeah, well, the joke was on Coach Weaver, wasn't it? She had no idea how good you'd turn out to be."

That was the thing about Catra: where Adora had to work hard for everything from her good grades to her skills as an athlete, Catra was naturally gifted at, well, almost everything. Unfortunately for her, applying herself wasn't one of those things. She had a tendency to fly under the radar until Adora forced her into it.

"Whatever," Catra said, folding her arms across her chest. "None of that matters now, and do you know why?"

"Why?" she asked with a knowing grin. Adora did know why, but she was going to play along.

"Because *you're* going to be cheer captain and then *we're* going to run the school!" Catra launched herself onto Adora's back, who responded with a shriek of laughter. "Operation: One Perfect Year at Stevenson High is a go!"

Giggling, Adora wrapped her arms around Catra's legs and spun in circles while her best friend cackled and squealed for her to stop. Only when they heard Catra's phone ping did Adora quit. The room, however, kept right on spinning.

"Ugh, I'm gonna hurl." Catra wobbled to the window where she had left her backpack slumped against the wall and fished out her phone. She swiped on a new text and skimmed it with a scowl. "Better hurry up, princess. Looks like we're walking to school."

"What?" Adora balked as she snatched the bag she had meticulously packed the night before off her bed. "I thought Lonnie was picking us up."

Catra shrugged her backpack straps onto her shoulders and gave herself a quick once-over in the mirror. "Apparently Scorpia and Rogelio wanted to hit the gym before class, so she drove them in early."

"And people say *I'm* an overachiever."

"Oh, you're definitely an overachiever," Catra said, holding her hand out for Adora, who took it with a smile. "Now come on,

we've got a perfect year to start and I still want to pick up an iced coffee on the way."

Chapter 2

Adora and Catra hurried to the front doors of Stevenson High School, iced coffees in hand. With each step, Adora felt excitement building in her chest. She grabbed Catra's arm and gave her a shake.

"I can't wait to show the squad the routines we choreographed over the summer!"

Catra pulled the straw out of her mouth, giving Adora a quick glimpse of her pointed teeth she found so cute. "Seriously, we're going to look so good at championships. They might as well just give us the title now."

Up the steps and through the front door, Adora took a deep breath and let her bright blue eyes scan the school's busy front foyer. Nervous freshmen peppered a sea of familiar faces, all of whom made room to let the girls through without having to be asked. Lockers slammed and sneakers squeaked over freshly polished floors. The astringent smell industrial cleaner barely covered the familiar old building smell Adora had come to find so comforting.

Home at last, she thought, smiling blissfully.

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora watched the subtle transformation Catra made every time they walked into the school. With a toss of her head, she threw back her massive brown ponytail—the one she got up early just to wrestle into submission—and lifted her chin. When Catra walked into school, she stood a little taller than usual, sashaying down the halls like she owned the place. Her easy-going, playful personality gave way to serious boss vibes. It was the Valkyrie effect: all members of the Cheer Force became a bit more commanding when they put on the uniform. Being the most popular kids in school required a certain degree of attitude, and Catra took that obligation very seriously.

Only Adora knew how much of an act it really was. In a way, she kind of liked that there was a side of her best friend only she got to know.

Catra grabbed her hand and pointed down the hall. "Check it out, I can see Scorpia's head towering over everyone else. Let's go give them shit for ditching us this morning."

They all but skipped down the hall, the student body making way like a receding tide as they passed. Friends and teachers called hello to Adora, who was starting to feel like royalty with all the smiling and waving she was having to do to reciprocate. Condensation from her nearly empty cup was trickling down her wrist.

"Careful," Catra grinned. "You're going to give yourself carpal tunnel on the first day back."

"G'morning, slackers." Their teammate, Lonnie, flashed the pair a teasing smile as they joined the group. She stood with fellow Valkyries, Scorpia and Rogelio, two of the Cheer Force's bases—a pair tanks in charge of tossing flyers into the air during routines—and Kyle, a tiny wisp of a boy who truthfully had no business being on the squad in the first place. Adora assumed what he lacked in coordination he made up for in being small enough to toss easily. Catra believe one or both of his parents were legacies.

Regardless, they looked sharp with their vibrant red uniforms and heads held high. Adora smiled at each of them in turn, grateful to be back together at the start of what was going to be a truly perfect year.

"Well, we would have been here sooner if *someone* had given us a ride," she said, giving Lonnie a playful nudge with her elbow.

Lonnie was unphased. "I'm not your mama. If you two can't be ready to roll by swole o'clock, then you deserve to walk."

As if to drive Lonnie's point home, Rogelio flexed wordlessly. The group laughed.

"Aw, you don't need the gym anyway," Scorpia said. "Did you work out this summer, Catra? You look great."

Straw firmly in mouth, Catra glanced quizzically down at herself. "I look the same as I always do."

Though she really needed to make a stop at her locker before homeroom, Adora let herself get drawn into the conversation. Even though they'd all seen each other throughout the summer, the first day back to school always felt like a big reunion after a long absence. Jokes and stories were exchanged, as well as speculation about who was going to replace Octavia as captain now that she had graduated. The insinuation was heavily in Adora's favor and, though she did her best to be modest about it, knowing she had everyone's support made her feel more hopeful than ever. For just a moment, she let herself believe it was going to happen.

Lonnie was in the middle of telling a story about a comically disastrous date she, Rogelio and Kyle had involving mini putt and a poorly marked water hazard, when a flash of pink caught Adora's attention. Her eyes tracked the color through the milling crowd to where it stopped in front of a big cork notice board.

The pink was hair, and it belonged to a sophomore girl Adora knew of but had never spoken to. Curious, she watched as the girl pulled a poster from the bag hanging at her side and, after carefully choosing a space, hammered a stapler into each of its corners. Adora could just make out the text over the girl's shoulder.

GLEE!

Come audition for Stevenson High's show choir!

Adora's eyes grew wide. With a quick glance back at her friends—all of whom were doubled over in laughter—she side stepped away and scurried across the hall.

"The glee club is accepting new members?" she asked, making the pink-haired girl jump.

"Ah! Don't sneak up on people like that!" The girl blinked up at Adora and her expression morphed from surprised to stunned. "Oh! You're Adora!"

Awkwardness crept up the back of Adora's neck. She forced a smile. "I'm sorry, have we met before? I'm usually good with names, but—"

The girl flapped her hands dismissively. "Oh, no. I wouldn't expect you to know who I am. But, I mean, you're a *Valkyrie*. Everyone knows who you guys are."

A moment passed between them, the girl smiling wide while Adora shifted uneasily.

"So, you are..."

"Right! Sorry! My name's Glimmer." She stepped aside and held her hands out toward the poster she had just put up. "I'm the captain of Vocal Rebellion."

"Captain? What happened to Mara?"

Glimmer gaped at her. "You knew Mara?"

"Why do you sound so surprised?"

"I guess I'm just surprised you know about us at all."

Adora frowned. It was easy to feel like the center of the universe when you were a Valkyrie, but she didn't realize others thought of them the same way.

"I actually wanted to join Vocal Rebellion in first year," Adora admitted. For some reason, the confession made her feel a little sheepish. "But I had already been recruited to the Valkyries and

Mara said you guys don't accept members in multiple extracurriculars."

"What?" Glimmer cried. She crammed a hand into her bag a fished out another poster, which she then thrust into Adora's hands. "Then you have to come audition! Mara graduated last year. Since being elected captain, I decided to loosen the reigns a little bit. We'd love to have you."

Gazing down at the poster, Adora felt a childlike giddiness flooding her system. She thought about all her bedroom concerts held for imaginary fans, her epic playlists, her love of performing. It had crushed her when Mara turned her away in freshman year without even letting her try out.

This is *supposed to be a perfect year*, she reasoned with herself.

She glanced up to find Glimmer watching her with an expression of breathless hopefulness. Adora grinned at her.

"I'll be there!"

Chapter 3

Catra froze mid-stride and looked up from her phone. Minutes ago, she had fallen down a rabbit hole of memes. She was so engrossed in her feed that she hadn't noticed Adora lagging behind until she felt a tug at the back of her skirt.

"Adora, *what* are you doing back there?"

"I'm trying to fix your uniform. How are you already such a mess?"

"Rude much?" Catra twisted, trying to see what Adora was seeing. "Are you sure you're not just trying to check me out?"

"Oh, please." Adora fought to play it cool. Yes, Catra looked great in her uniform. And, sure, maybe Adora was guilty of letting her gaze linger a little longer than she should sometimes. But this time, her intentions were pure. "You and I both know Coach Weaver will lose it on you if your uniform is dirty, and right now it definitely looks like you sat in something."

Catra's attention was already back on her phone. "Whatever. If it's not a dirty uniform, she'll just find something else to rage at me about. Besides, I'm pretty sure it's just dust. Scorpia violated the ten-foot radius policy when we were in the library earlier and I backed into a shelf I don't think has been dusted at all this century."

Without thinking, Adora tensed. "So... did Scorpia finally make a move?"

To anyone with a functioning pair of eyes, it was painfully obvious that Scorpia was head over heels obsessed with Catra. She doted on her constantly, lavishing Catra with attention and praise, even when she didn't necessarily deserve it. Scorpia was also a hugger. Though she generally subscribed to equal opportunity when it came to who wound up on the receiving end of one of her

embraces, there was no denying Catra was her favorite target. It was actually kind of cute, or at least it would have been if Adora didn't find herself reeling with inexplicable jealousy every time the towering senior attempted to show her affection.

"Oh, I'm sure she'll work up the guts one of these days," Catra said, sounding absolutely over the whole thing. She didn't even look up from her phone this time. "But today was not that day. So, is my ass satisfactory or what? Because we're gonna be late."

Adora shook her head and gave the back of Catra's skirt a couple quick swipes with her open hand. "Huh, it came off. I guess it was dust."

"Whatever you say, pervert."

The pair jostled through the school, shoving one another playfully and pretending to trip the other up as they hurried for the gymnasium. Only a handful of students still loitered in the halls, chatting at their lockers or meandering for the exits now that the school day was over. The sound of the girls' giggling echoed in the emptiness around them, making them feel like the only people in the world.

They were only a couple paces from the gym doors, and all but sprinting, when Adora unknowingly stepped down onto the end of Catra's shoelace. With a startled yelp, Catra lurched forward. Her foot had come dislodged from the shoe. Adora skidded to a stop.

"I'm so sorry!"

"Adora! You filthy cheater!"

"I am not!"

Laughing, Catra stooped to fix her shoe and waved a hand toward the door. "Just go! I'll be right there."

Smiling, Adora rolled her eyes dramatically but did as she was told. She opened one of the gym doors just wide enough to slide

through, hoping to arrive discreetly. Inside, Coach Weaver stood facing a bench on which the rest of the Valkyries were already seated. Every one of them turned to look at Adora in unison.

So much for being discreet.

"Sorry I'm late," she said, scampering across the polished floor.

"Nonsense, Adora. You're just in time," Coach Weaver cooed with uncharacteristic brightness. "Hurry up and join the others."

Someone's in a good mood, Adora thought, trying to keep a straight face. *I wonder how long that will last?*

Adora had just settled in next to a beaming Scorpia when the gym door swung open again. Catra sauntered in without a word.

"Typical," Coach Weaver sneered. "How very *you* to be late for the first practice of the season, Catra."

Flinching only slightly, Catra glanced to the digital clock on the scoreboard, which showed there was still technically one minute until practice was scheduled to start. She opened her mouth, ready to argue, but Coach didn't give her the chance.

"Sit *down*, Catra."

The rest of the squad exchanged tense glances but said nothing. Coach Weaver was notorious for being unnecessarily hard on all of them, but none more so than Catra.

But if she was phased, Catra didn't let it show. With a defiant lift of her chin, she hiked up her backpack and breezed over to the bench.

"Sorry, Coach," she said, dropping down beside Adora. Then, in a whisper just loud enough for her best friend to hear, she added, "See? I told you she'd find something else."

Coach Weaver scanned her squad with a mix of satisfaction and disdain — a contradictory mix of sentiments she oscillated between so rapidly it was a wonder she didn't have whiplash. She was a tough woman to please, with a shockingly low tolerance for anything short of perfection. It was a jarring quality for someone who had chosen a career teaching young people. Despite it being the first practice of a new year, Coach Weaver didn't bother to welcome the Valkyries back or any other such pleasantries. Instead, she got right down to business.

"As you all know, since Octavia decided to abandon our squadron, we're now down a Force Captain."

"Wait," Kyle piped up. "I thought Octavia graduated."

The Valkyries let out a collective groan. Kyle was almost as dense as Coach Weaver was dramatic.

"Silence," she snapped, staring him down with scalding impatience. Kyle shrank back. Catra muffled a snort of laughter. "As I was saying, it is time to appoint a new captain."

The entire squad broke into excited whispers. Adora felt a kaleidoscope of butterflies take flight in her stomach. Filled to bursting with nervous excitement, she tucked her hands under her thighs to hide any trace of trembling—a show of weakness she knew Coach Weaver abhorred. From her right, Scorpia leaned over, squishing into Adora as if she wasn't even there.

"You've got my vote, Catra!" Scorpia whispered.

Catra, elbow on her knee and face cradled firmly in hand, wrinkled her nose. "What vote? This isn't a democracy."

Lonnie leaned in from Scorpia's other side, leaving Adora pinned under their collective weight. "And even if it was, we all know who would win."

"Will you two *please* get off me?" Adora wheezed.

"Ahem." Coach Weaver cleared her throat loudly enough to cut through the din of adolescent excitement. The Valkyries snapped to attention, and when Adora gazed up, she saw Coach Weaver was holding the captain's ribbons.

Three ribbons, one in each of the school's colors—two complementary shades of red and cream for accent—tied together and curled like something you might see slapped onto a birthday gift. As symbols go, it was a cheesy one. But among the Valkyries, those ribbons were everything. In fact, everyone in Stevenson High knew only one member of the Cheer Force got to wear the ribbons. To have them bouncing in your ponytail was the ultimate status symbol.

Coach Weaver raised her hand. The squad held a collective breath.

"Adora," she said. "Congratulations."

The Valkyries burst into applause. Elated, Adora jumped to her feet and forced herself to take measured steps—rather than of bounding gleefully the way she wanted—to accept the ribbons.

"Thank you, Coach. This is such an honor."

Coach Weaver laid the ribbons in Adora's hand. "I saw great promise in you from the moment you stepped into this school. Don't let me down."

Adora was unable to suppress her grin. She quickly secured the ribbons in her hair, earning her yet another round of cheers from the rest of the squad. *Her* squad. As she hurried back to her seat, she allowed herself a single squeal of delight. She plopped onto the bench, and Catra leaned in.

"Told you," she whispered. Her grin was as wide as Adora's.

"All right!" Coach Weaver shouted, clapping her hands loud enough to make them jump. "We've wasted enough time. I see you've all let your physiques lapse over the summer and it's

making me nauseous. Everyone in plank position. The first person to fall will be running extra laps."

The Valkyries lept into action. Adora dropped into position and stole a glance at Catra, who winked back at her.

Planks aside, their perfect year was already off to a great start.



Chapter 4

That night, Adora sat cross-legged in the middle of her bed, a sizable binder perched on her lap. It was the Valkyrie Cheer Force captain's manual—Coach Weaver had bestowed her with the tome at the end of practice with a warning that she would be testing her on its contents sporadically, as early as their next practice.

Their next next practice was tomorrow.

The door to her bedroom banged open. Adora didn't bother to look up as Catra stepped in, pillow under her arm, and kicked the door closed again behind her; she had been expecting her. It didn't matter that their rooms were only a floor apart in the cozy group home they'd grown up in, or that they saw each other every single day: they'd been observing their annual first day of school sleepover since junior high.

"Can you believe the size of this thing?" Adora groaned, picking up the binder and shaking it for emphasis. "I knew being captain was a big job but this is nuts."

"Let Future Adora worry about it," Catra replied.

"You heard Coach Weaver. She's going to start quizzing me on this thing tomorrow. I've got to be ready."

Something big and soft collided with Adora's face. Startled, she blinked upwards to find Catra standing over her, brandishing her pillow like a weapon in the lamplight. She was dressed in her regular sleep attire: underwear and a thrift-found t-shirt of a punk rock band that had fizzled out before they were born. Her voluminous hair was loose and wild, the effort she spent to tame it each morning nothing more than a suggestion now. This was the version of Catra no one but Adora got to see: rough around the edges, a little messy, and completely unexpected. Catra may have been hot in cheer uniform, but this was the version of her Adora liked best.

"Listen, nerd." Catra raised the pillow threateningly above her head. "Put the binder down or GTFO."

"This is *my* room!"

"Wrong answer."

The pillow came down again, but this time Adora managed to roll out of the way with a squeal.

"You're such a brat, Catra," she laughed, snatching the pillow from her friend's hands as she took another swing at her. "Fine, I'll pay attention to you. Are you happy now?"

Catra crawled onto the bed and dragged the binder over with a satisfied smirk. "Yes, very."

Adora smacked her in the face with the pillow for good measure and danced across the room before she could retaliate. Her phone was charging on the dresser. Picking it up, she tapped her music app and put her back-to-school playlist on shuffle. As the first song played, Adora glanced at herself in the mirror. She too had changed out of her reds, wearing an old pair of running shorts and a tank top for pajamas. But her ponytail was still adorned with her captain's ribbons, and she fussed over them in her reflection, inspecting them for any damage that may have resulted from Catra's assault.

"Wow, you weren't kidding. This thing *is* nuts."

Adora turned to find Catra perusing the captain's manual with a grimace.

"Right?" Adora said, throwing her hands up. "I have to meet with the cafeteria staff this week to go over a nutrition plan for everyone on the squad. And there are, like, fifty different drills in there I've never even heard of."

Catra shook her head and snapped the binder closed. "Coach Weaver is so extra."

"Yeah, but I guess that's what it takes to win."

The first song ended, and from its dying notes the next track began. Adora gasped excitedly: it was one of the songs she and Catra spent most of the summer developing a cheer routine to. She spun dramatically and pointed at her friend, who dissolved into giggles on the spot.

"On your feet, Valkyrie!" Adora commanded in what she had decided would be her default captain voice. "We're dancing to this! Hustle!"

Catra leapt up and, without missing a beat, the pair launched into their choreography. They sang along, belting out the lyrics as they twisted and posed just like they'd practiced. Adora watched their reflections dancing in the mirror and beamed: they looked great. They actually *sounded* great too.

Which is when she remembered the poster folded up at the bottom of her bag.

"Oh my gosh!" Adora cried, hitting pause on her phone. "I completely forgot!"

"Hey! I was dancing to that!"

"Yes, and singing, which is what reminded me that I have something I want to show you!"

Adora scrounged through her backpack while Catra watched on, arms crossed. After a moment of rummaging, Adora raised a triumphant fist into the air. The posted was clutched between her fingers.

Catra eyed it warily. "What is that?"

"Check this out." Adora stood up and unfolded the poster. Grinning, she held it out for her friend to see.

There was a beat of silence, then Catra laughed. She leaned around the paper so she could see Adora's face. "You're kidding, right?"

"What? No. Why?"

"Show choir, Adora? Seriously?" Catra looked somewhere between incredulous and horrified.

Adora balked. "Yes, seriously! You know how badly I wanted to try out for glee in freshman year."

"Right. And then you made the Valkyries, which is a way bigger deal."

"No, I was already in the Valkyries, which is why the glee captain at the time, Mara, wouldn't even let me audition. Remember?"

Catra frowned. "Oh, I remember."

"But Mara graduated!" Despite her friend's lack of enthusiasm, Adora couldn't hide her own. "A girl named Glimmer is in charge now, and she said they don't care if their members are in other extracurriculars. Will you try out with me? Please, please, pleeeease?"

"Adora, a minute ago you were talking about how intense your responsibilities as cheer captain are going to be this year. Now you want to throw glee club on top of that?"

She wasn't wrong, but Adora pressed on. "It'll be fine, Catra. I can handle this. Besides, it's better to try both teams now than in senior year when we have to worry about applying for college, right?"

"I guess." Catra shifted, her shoulders hunched with discomfort. "I just don't get why you'd want to join glee, of all things, when you've already got everything you've ever wanted."

"What I've always wanted was to at least have an audition," Adora reasoned. She set the poster on the dressed and reached out to take Catra's hands in her own. "You know how crushed I was when Mara turned me away."

Catra looked away. She remembered Adora's disappointment all too well, and the memory of that heartbreak was the only reason she felt herself relenting.

"Come on, Catra," Adora pleaded. "You're such a good singer. You've got to try out with me!"

"Oh, no." Catra pulled her hands back and held them up in the air. "I have zero interest in being a show choir kid."

Adora's face fell. She stuck out her bottom lip and pouted.

Catra sighed. "Listen, if it's that important to you, I won't stop you from auditioning."

"But... we're always on the same teams," Adora said in a quiet voice.

"We'll still be Valkyries together," Catra replied, crossing her arms again.

Adora looked down at the poster. It wasn't quite what she was hoping for, but at least she was finally going to get her chance. Her eyes flicked to the audition date and her heart sank.

"Oh no," she moaned, picked the poster up again. "We have practice at the same time as auditions!"

Catra didn't respond.

Adora lifted her eyes and smiled hopefully at her best friend. "Any chance you'd cover for me while I sneak out? Just one song and then I'll be back, I swear!"

Catra's eyes narrowed dangerously. But Adora batted her lashes and flashed that megawatt smile of hers and for a split-second Catra forgot how to breathe.

"Fine!" she huffed. "I'll cover for you, sheesh."

Adora let out a shriek of excitement and lunged forward, tackling Catra in a hug. "Thank you, Catra! You're the best!"

"Ew, cut it out," Catra groaned, attempting to wriggle free of Adora's grasp. "Don't make me change my mind."

"I still think you should audition too."

"Absolutely not."

Catra dug her fingers into Adora's sides. She knew exactly how ticklish Adora was, and had every intention of using that knowledge to her advantage. With a shriek of laughter, Adora let go. She leapt onto the bed to escape, and Catra followed. A vicious tickling match ensued, and the pair screeched and wrestled until a banging on the wall silenced them both.

"Will you two shut up?" shouted Adora's neighbour, a fellow foster kid she and Catra barely spoke to. "Some of us are trying to sleep!"

Adora and Catra looked at each other and immediately burst into another fit of giggles. Still tangled in one another's arms, they collapsed onto the mattress. By the time their laughter had subsided, Catra was nuzzled into Adora's shoulder, arms wrapped around her waist. For a moment or two, neither spoke. The only sound was their breathing.

"I know you're not sleeping," Adora whispered when it became clear her friend wasn't going to move.

Catra didn't answer.

"You know how I know?"

Still no response.

Adora gave Catra a tight squeeze. "You haven't started snoring yet."

"For the last time, I do *not* snore."

With one last laugh, Adora reached her free hand out and turned off the lamp. "Good night, Catra."

"Night, dork."


SHS
ATHLETICS

Chapter 5

Auditions for Vocal Rebellion were scheduled for Friday. The format was simple: each prospective member would perform a single song without musical accompaniment, before being interviewed by the glee club's captain and musical director.

Compared to the hoops–both literal and figurative–Adora had jumped through during her Valkyries try-out, she was confident that belting out one song and acing an interview wouldn't be a problem. After all, whether she was in the shower, getting ready for school, or running choreography with the Cheer Force, Adora was constantly singing. She wasn't shy either–performing was second nature to her at this point. When she skimmed the details on Glimmer's poster that Monday, Adora was certain she had her audition in the bag.

But the first week back at school was much busier than she anticipated. Not only had Coach Weaver made good on her threat to start quizzing Adora on the captain's manual as early as Tuesday's practice–nothing she couldn't handle with a bit of lunchtime cramming–she had also scheduled practice for every night that week. Between classes, cheer, and the swell of popularity that came with being captain of the Valkyries, Adora didn't realize she hadn't given any more thought to her audition until lunch on Friday.

The entire squad was eating at their regular table in the cafeteria, as they did every day, when Lonnie pulled a face.

"Ew."

"Tell me about it." Scorpia picked woefully through the salad on her tray. "I know we're on a special meal plan and stuff, but this is just sad. Dressing on the side? Come on."

Adora reached across the table and nudged Scorpia's plate an inch closer to her. "Stop complaining and each your damn vegetables.

You cannot live on protein alone."

"Not that." Lonnie rolled her eyes and pointed her fork to a point across the room. "That wannabe raver over there has been staring at us since we sat down."

The squad's collective gaze followed in the direction Lonnie's fork. Adora's stomach dropped. There, at a table filled with theater kids and would-be poets, was Glimmer. When their eyes met, she flashed a nervous grin and offered up a small wave.

Oh no, Adora thought, swallowing down a sense of rising doom. It's audition day and I have nothing prepared!

Not that Glimmer needed to know that. Adora smiled with the false confidence hammered into her from years of competitive cheer and was just lifting her hand to wave back when Catra snatched it in her own and force it back under the table.

"What are you doing?" Catra hissed, leaning in close so the others wouldn't hear. Her hand clenched around Adora's like a vice.

"That's Glimmer, the captain of Vocal Rebellion," Adora explained in an indignant whisper.

"I know who she is! Why are you acknowledging her in front of the whole squad? Are you nuts?"

When it came to social hierarchies at Stevenson High, the lines were clearly drawn and well observed. The Valkyries, along with the rest of the school's athletically inclined, were at the top of the proverbial food chain. Mingling with the commoners—especially the artsy types—was generally reserved for group projects and fundraisers.

But Adora had always been more approachable than the rest of her squadmates, and now she was worried Catra's interception had made her look rude. She leaned back surreptitiously, hoping to catch Glimmer's eye again, but the glee club captain was already deep in conversation with a handsome, smiling boy in a

crop top. When they tossed their heads back to laugh, Adora didn't get the sense they were doing it at the expense of someone else.

"Great," she whispered in Catra's ear. "I'll bet she thinks I'm a stuck-up bitch now."

Catra turned her face. They were so close their noses almost bumped. A sharp grin cut across her face. "You're a cheerleader — everyone thinks you're a stuck-up bitch."

"They do not!"

While the pair bickered in hushed tones, Kyle gazed warmly at them from the other side of the table.

"I'm glad you two are finally dating," he said with a smile. "You make a cute couple."

Scorpia snapped to attention. "Wait, you're dating? When did that happen?"

"It didn't!" Catra bristled. Adora could feel the heat of her blush from beside her.

Kyle blinked in confusion, glancing between them. "I just thought — I mean, you're holding hands and talking so close together. I figured—"

"They're always holding hands, you dummy," Lonnie said with a shake of her head. "Rogelio, talk some sense into your man."

For his part, Rogelio simply planted his forehead firmly in the palm of his hand and kept his mouth shut.

"So, you two aren't dating then?" Scorpia asked, sounding so hopeful she bordered on desperate.

"No!" Catra cried. She had already let go of Adora's hand, and now she threw both of her own in the air in exasperation. "Why

do you assholes have to make everything weird?" She kicked out under the table, aiming for Kyle but nailing Rogelio's shin instead.

"Careful!" Lonnie cackled. "If you hurt either of them, Coach Weaver will skin you alive."

As the rest of her friends shouted over one another, Adora gazed down at her hand. The phantom sensation of Catra's fingers still gripped her own, but their absence made her chest ache. They had been holding each other's hands since they were kids, and never once had snide comments or innuendo been enough to make Catra flinch away before. Adora was startled and, if she was being honest with herself, a little hurt that Kyle's oblivious misinterpretation of their closeness had rattled Catra this badly.

This, it seemed, was Adora's tipping point. She had enough on her mind without having to worry about Catra too. And yet, there she was, suddenly overwhelmed and desperately in need of some space. Without thinking, she pushed up from her seat so quickly she nearly took some poor freshman out at the hip.

"Sorry!" she winced. Flustered, she grabbed her tray and forced a smile. "Speaking of Coach Weaver, she wanted me to talk to the band director about our homecoming halftime number before today's practice and I totally forgot. I'll catch you guys later!"

She didn't wait for any replies, and she most definitely didn't look back at Catra as she hustled for the cafeteria doors. Dropping her tray and unfinished lunch at the sorting station, Adora wove through a maze of her peers until she finally spilled out into the hall. She took a deep breath, but it only helped so much, so she decided to step outside for some fresh air and room to think.

"Hey, wait up!"

Adora jumped at the sound of Catra's voice. She turned on the spot, nearly crashing right into her. Catra caught her by the shoulders before she had a chance to trip over her own feet.

"Catra, you don't need to—"

"Come on, Adora," Catra cut her off. "You and I both know you met with the band director, like, two days ago. What's really going on?"

Adora's mind raced. It didn't feel like the right time to drop, 'you stopped holding my hand and it hurt my feelings in a way I can't quite explain' on their friendship, so she moved down to the next pressing matter on her growing list of concerns. "I completely forgot that Vocal Rebellion auditions are today and I have nothing prepared and it's kind of stressing me out."

Catra tried, and failed, to suppress a smile. "Better luck next year?"

"Catra!"

"Okay, okay. Geeze." Catra crossed her arms and sighed. "What are you worried about? Just pick one of the songs you're always singing to yourself in the mirror and go for it. Although I recommend picking one you actually know all the right words to this time. Just a suggestion."

Adora groaned and buried her face in her hands. "I'm so screwed."

"You are not. You've got this, just like you've got everything else. Stop overthinking it."

When Adora didn't emerge from behind her hands, Catra tugged them down with a huff of impatience.

"You really think so?" Adora asked meekly.

"I know so," Catra insisted. Then she smiled and laced her fingers with Adora's, fitting their hands back together like two pieces of a puzzle.

Adora exhaled. She was starting to feel better already. "In that case, what do you think about running across the street with me

and grabbing a burger or something before class? Because Scorpia was right — that lunch was sad."

Catra tossed her head back and laughed.

"I thought you'd never ask."

Chapter 6

As a general rule, Adora preferred to be early. To class, to practice, to bed — whatever it was, if she could get to it early, she would.

Being on time for things wasn't ideal, but she could live with it if she had to.

But being late? As far as Adora was concerned, that was almost as bad as getting a B on exam she studied super hard for, or being called out by Coach Weaver in front of the rest of the squad for not smiling wide enough during a routine.

Being late was something Adora did her best to avoid. Unfortunately for her, there was nothing she could do about running late for her audition with Vocal Rebellion.

She couldn't skip practice outright; aside from the fact that Coach Weaver would have had her head, she *did* want to be there for her fellow Valkyries. But both practice and auditions were scheduled for almost the same time after class on Friday. The only things working in Adora's favor were that Vocal Rebellion auditions started fifteen minutes later than cheer practice, and that Catra made good on her promise to help.

After running through a warm-up with the rest of the squad, Adora bowed out, leaving Catra in charge of drills until she returned.

"I'll be back as soon as my audition is over," she whispered. She thrust the captain's manual into Catra's hands while the rest of the Cheer Force milled around, stretching and gossiping. "I marked the drills you need with sticky notes."

Catra flipped to the first one and scanned the page quickly. "What excuse did you feed Coach Weaver?"

"I told her I'm meeting with the cafeteria staff to make some adjustments to our meal plans."

"And she seriously bought that they would agree to meet with a student after school on a Friday?"

Adora shrugged her bag onto her shoulder. "I said they tried to push it to next week but I wouldn't take no for an answer. You know how she's always telling us to be assertive and that we're basically better than everyone else — she loved it."

At this, Catra snorted. "Yeah, I'll bet she did. Her little protégé, putting those lowly cafeteria workers in their place."

"Gross," Adora replied, pulling a face. "Anyway, are you sure you're good?"

"I know how to run drills, Adora. I'm fine."

"I know, it's just—"

"Adora, the last time you were this late for something I thought you were going to have an aneurysm. *Go*."

"Okay, I'm going!" Adora almost started to jog away but caught herself. Whirling back around, she gave Catra a quick, tight hug. "Thank you for doing this. You're the best!"

Catra pulled back from the embrace and gave her ponytail a flip.

"Oh, I know."

*

By the time Adora made it to the music room, she was already 10 minutes late. She was nervous, which was completely unlike her and only made things worse. She could hear excited chatter and boisterous laughter through the door, but couldn't actually see inside because a gigantic piece of highlighter-yellow poster board

that read, *GLEE CLUB AUDITIONS! JOIN THE REBELLION!* had been taped over the window.

Adora took a deep breath and told the butterflies in her stomach to take the rest of the night off. Then, when she was sure she wouldn't be walking in during the middle of someone else's song, she lifted her chin, slapped on her cheeriest smile, and opened the door.

The music room fell completely silent.

Every single person in the room—and there were more of them than Adora had anticipated—turned to look at her in unison.

No, not look — *gape*. Adora called on years of being trained to smile through a rolled ankle or pulled muscle to maintain her bright façade. In her gut, the butterflies had all but kicked down the door and screamed, "*We're back! And look—we brought friends!*"

"Oh my gosh! You actually came!" Glimmer jumped up from where she had been sitting behind a folding card table. She turned to Mrs. Angella Moon, an elegant woman who had taught Adora's civics class in sophomore year, and put her hands on her hips. "See? I told you I wasn't making it up."

Mrs. Moon put her hands up and sighed. "Yes, Glimmer, I'll concede. You *did* recruit a Valkyrie to audition after all. Well done."

At Glimmer's other side sat the handsome crop top-wearing boy from the cafeteria. He was in the process of collecting dollar bills from other students in the room.

"For what it's worth, I never doubted you for a second, Glimmer," he said as he folded the cash into a neat wad and slid his winnings into his pocket. "Not that I can say the same for everyone else."

"Thanks, Bow. You can use some of that to buy me ice cream later." Glimmer gave his shoulder a friendly nudge before bounding around the table. She ran over to Adora with a smile even Coach Weaver would have approved of.

"I'm *so* glad you're here! We were starting to worry you weren't going to make it."

"Yeah, sorry about that," Adora let out an awkward laugh. "The Cheer Force actually has practice right now and I had to get the squad started."

"No worries, we didn't mind waiting," Glimmer said. She toed the door closed and ushered Adora toward the others.

"You waited for me?" Adora was all at once touched and distressed — she had assumed auditions would be well underway by the time she arrived. Her eyes flicked to a sign-up sheet that sat on the table; it already had a handful of names scrawled down the rows, each one a performance she was going to have to sit through now. Catra was going to kill her. "That's so... thoughtful. Thanks."

"Cool. *Now* can we get this show on the road?" griped a girl with a fabulous turquoise braid and a bored expression. Adora recognized her right away as the captain of the Stevenson High swim team.

"Mermista!" Relief washed over Adora to see another athlete in the room. "I didn't know you were in Vocal Rebellion."

"I'm not, but I promised this one I'd try out." She gestured lazily to a boy sitting beside her. "Sooo, I guess we'll see?"

The boy, who wore clothes so fashion-forward Adora thought he might be in a costume of some kind, stroked his well-manicured mustache and flashed her a dazzling smile.

"Seahawk," he said, reaching out to shake her hand. "Mermista's boyfriend."

Mermista groaned. "I told you to stop introducing yourself like that. It's weird!"

Glimmer gave a forced laugh and steered Adora away from the couple and into an empty seat.

"Anyway, Mermista's right. We should get started." Glimmer smiled brightly and took the room in with a sweep of her sparkling eyes.

"So, who's ready to sing?"

Chapter 7

There was something different about Vocal Rebellion. Adora wasn't exactly sure what that something was, but she knew she liked it.

At first, she was agitated — she didn't have time to sit through a bunch of other auditions. She had told Catra she'd be back quickly, and she didn't want to give Coach Weaver any reason to get suspicious. But by the time the first audition was over, Adora found her restless worry replaced by excitement and delight. It was fun to watch people perform, to see them brave the stage and sing their hopeful hearts out. After all, it was this rush that made Adora want to join the glee club in the first place.

It didn't hurt that everyone in the room was so nice, either. When someone was performing, the rest of the group sat quietly and listened. There were no whispers of rude comments about the performer's pitch or clothes, no smug expressions or loud conversations from disinterested audience members. Instead, everyone was respectful with their attention, and when a number was over, the whole room clapped and cheered like it was the greatest performance they'd ever seen.

The interviews took place in front of everyone, and Adora paid close attention to the questions and her competition's answers.

"Why do you want to join Vocal Rebellion?" Glimmer would ask.

"What do you think you'll bring to this team?" questioned Mrs. Moon.

"Do you have any stage experience?" Bow would chime in.

More often than not, the interviews ended with everyone laughing over something or other; a funny story or clever answer. When asked what he would bring to the team, Seahawk claimed that both his roguish good looks and talent with pyrotechnics would

add a certain flair to the groups' performances. Mermista chalked her interest in joining Vocal Rebellion to getting herself one step closer to being a Disney princess.

"Those girls are always randomly bursting into song and turning every waking moment of their lives into musical numbers. It's super weird, but it's kinda part of the aesthetic so I'm just gonna roll with it."

"You don't have to randomly burst into song in glee club," Bow assured her. "We plan the routines in advance."

Mermists shrugged. "Whatever. I'm good either way."

Everyone was having such a good time. By the time it was Adora's turn, her face hurt from smiling and her sides ached from laughing.

Glimmer scribbled some notes onto her clipboard and grinned. "Okay, Adora. You're up!"

Adora jumped at the sound of her name. She took a deep breath and breezed to the front of the room.

You've got this, Adora, she thought to herself. *It's just like Catra said: don't overthink it, just sing*.

And so, she did. She had decided on one of her and Catra's favorite songs — a pop-rock ballad the two of them loved to belt together, Adora singing into an imaginary microphone while Catra rocked out on the air guitar in one of their bedrooms or in the back of Lonnie's car. She knew the words by heart, and she sang them without missing a beat while dancing along to steps she and Catra had choreographed over the summer. Years of performing cheer routines in front of the entire school had blessed Adora with confidence and stage presence, and she dazzled the room with her winning smile and infectious energy. She finished her number by striking a pose and then swooped down into a low bow.

There was a beat of silence.

In that split second, Adora's heart dropped.

Oh, no. Did I do something wrong? Why is everyone being so quiet?

She stood up to find the entire room staring stunned back at her.

Glimmer jumped to her feet, eyes sparkling. "That was *amazing*!"

Then, as if Glimmer's proclamation broke the spell Adora's performance had cast, the room burst into wild applause. Even Mermista seemed impressed, and Adora took that as a good sign. Relieved, she started towards her chair.

"Just one moment, Adora," Mrs. Moon's voice cut through the noise. "We still need to go through the questions."

"Oh! Right, sorry." Adora flashed an apologetic smile and stood at attention in front of the table.

Glimmer put her elbows on the table and cradled her chin atop her interlaced fingers. There was nothing subtle about her excitement. "So, Adora. What made you want to join Vocal Rebellion?"

Adora cleared her throat. She had been mentally practicing her answers throughout the other auditions, and she prattled off her responses with type-A precision. "I love singing and performing. I wanted to join the glee club in my first year, but the old captain told me you didn't accept members who are part of other extracurriculars, and, well..." She gestured at her Valkyrie reds. Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed Mrs. Moon's brow furrowed as she scribbled some notes on her clipboard.

"And what do you think you'll bring to the team?" Bow asked, smiling brightly.

"Well, I've got lots of experience performing in front of crowds," Adora said, tearing her attention away from Mrs. Moon's tight expression. "Oh, and I could totally help with choreography. My

best friend Catra and I spent the whole summer coming up with brand new routines for the Valkyries this year. Wait until you see them — they're so fun!"

At last, Mrs. Moon looked up from her clipboard. "On that note, I suppose I should address the elephant in the room."

Something about her tone was unsettling. The butterflies in Adora's stomach flutter their wings, readying themselves to take flight. She licked her lips and clasped her hands politely, waiting for the hammer to drop.

"I understand you were appointed as the new captain of the Valkyrie Cheer Force this year," Mrs. Moon said.

"Yes, I was."

"Well, first, let me congratulate you. That's a big honor."

Adora's tense shoulders relaxed. "Thank you, Mrs.—"

"But being captain is a big responsibility," Mrs. Moon continued, cutting her off. "Do you feel confident that you'd be able to fulfill duties in your role with the Valkyries and commit to Vocal Rebellion at the same time?"

"I do," Adora insisted, hoping no one would notice the way the grip of her hands tightened anxiously.

"And what about Coach Weaver? Does she know about this arrangement?"

Glimmer's eyes went wide. She rounded on Mrs. Moon, looking furious.

"Mom!" she hissed. "What are you doing?"

"I..." Adora glanced to Glimmer, her expression pleading. This interview was starting to feel more like an interrogation. "I don't

understand. I thought you said the rules were different now. Am I not allowed to be on both teams?"

"Of course you are!" Glimmer said, cutting a sharp look at Mrs. Moon. "Right, Mom?"

Mrs. Moon returned her daughter's dark gaze before turning her attention back to Adora. Thankfully, her expression was a lot kinder when she looked into Adora's eyes.

"Yes, the rules are different now," she said. Her voice was gentle. " I just want to make sure you know what you're getting into. It will be a lot of work to maintain your captaincy with the Valkyries, perform with Vocal Rebellion, stay on top of your classes and still have time for yourself."

This hadn't quite been what Adora was expecting. The moment Mrs. Moon started expressing concern, she was sure her chances of joining the glee club her over. Adora wasn't used to a teacher being responsible and looking out for her like this. Coach Weaver only cared that the Valkyries' grades were high enough to stay on the squad. And as for personal time, if she were allowed to schedule cheer practice for every single evening and weekend, Coach Weaver would do it in a heartbeat.

"I promise I can handle it," Adora said. "I'm super organized and I have great time management skills. And when things get busy, I can delegate. Catra stepped in for me tonight so I could be here. She's basically like an honorary co-captain."

That was only partly true, of course. Adora knew she'd have to find a better system for juggling her time than always relying on Catra to bail her out, but she figured that was tomorrow's problem to solve.

Mrs. Moon took a deep breath and regarded Adora with a critical eye.

"C'mon, Mom," Glimmer whispered. Beside her, Bow gave Mrs. Moon his best—and very effective—puppy-dog eyes.

"Very well then," Mrs. Moon sighed. "If you insist it won't be a problem, I suppose I don't have any other questions."

Sagging with relief, Adora thanked her, Glimmer and Bow and hurried back to her seat. Glimmer flashed her a quick thumbs up as she stood.

"All right!" she exclaimed with a clap of her hands. "That's it for auditions! Thanks to everyone who came out tonight. We'll be getting back to each of you by the end of the weekend. Don't forget to write down your email address and phone number on the sign-up sheet if you haven't already!"

Though the formal auditions were over, no one left right away. Instead, Vocal Rebellion and its hopeful members loitered around the music room, congratulating each other on their performances and chatting about the first week of classes. Adora stopped at the table to write down her contact information.

"That was a great performance, Adora!" Bow said, beaming from ear to ear.

"Thanks!" she replied, feeling buoyed by his compliment.

"I still can't believe a *cheerleader* wants to join Vocal Rebellion!" Glimmer squeal, her fists balled under her chin in excitement. "We're gonna be unstoppable this year!"

Bow cleared his throat. "Uh, we haven't made any official decisions yet, Glimmer."

Adora laughed. She didn't want to be presumptuous, but she was encouraged by Glimmer's enthusiasm. "Whatever happens, I appreciate the opportunity. This was a lot of fun!"

And it stayed fun for another half an hour. Without realizing it, Adora got swept up in the conversation, laughing at Glimmer and Bow's jokes and swapping song recommendations. She was programming their numbers into her phone when Mrs. Moon announced that everyone was going to have to leave.

"We only have the music room booked until five and the custodial staff is eager to start their weekends!" she announced.

Adora gasped. "Is it five already?"

Glimmer glanced up at the clock. "Five minutes past, actually."

"Oh no!" Adora scrambled for her bag and threw it over her shoulders. "I've got to go. Thanks again, guys!"

She didn't register the others' replies as she tore out of the music room and sprinted down the empty hallways to the back of the school. The sound of her sneakers hammering against the floor echoed around her, but it didn't drown out the pounding of her own heart in her ears. Slamming through the doors that lead to the sports field, Adora spilled out of the school into the evening and found it quiet and desolate. She didn't stop running until she rounded the bleachers and found the field empty.

"Shit," she whispered under her breath as she panted.

Practice was over. The Valkyries were gone.

Chapter 8

Catra wasn't replying to Adora's texts. She was seeing them – each one stamped with the time they'd been read. But she wasn't dignifying any of them with a response.

Adora swallowed down the icy dread rising up inside her. She tried calling—something neither of them really did—but it was disconnected after the first ring.

"Shit," Adora hissed. She picked up the pace. "I'm definitely in trouble."

Checking her phone screen every few seconds, Adora sprinted the rest of the way home. By the time she barrelled through the front door of the group home, her face was flushed both from exertion and embarrassment.

How did I manage to lose track of time like that? She wondered as she darted down the hallway to her room. It was so unlike her to be that irresponsible. She tried not to imagine how furious Coach Weaver must be. With her heart in her stomach, she quickly opened her email, fully expecting an angry message to be waiting for her, written in all caps.

But the only new email was a newsletter from online clothing store she'd bought something from one time; it was trying to lure her back with a 10%-off coupon. Irritated, she tapped unsubscribe and refreshed her inbox. Still nothing. Her stomach clenched. She wasn't convinced the radio silence from Coach Weaver was actually a good thing.

She paused at her own bedroom and shoved the door open. "Catra?"

The room was dark and empty.

Adora tossed her backpack onto the floor and rounded back for the stairs, which she climbed two at a time. Catra's door was

closed, but a sliver of light reached out from the crack above the floor. Adora held her breath and pressed her ear beside a yellow plastic sign that read *BEWARE OF CAT(RA)* with a silhouette of a prowling feline underneath. The sign had been a gag gift from Adora years ago—she had scribbled in the parentheses-encased *ra* at the end with a Sharpie, feeling so funny and clever at the time. Catra had laughed, and that's all that mattered.

Adora listened, but the room behind the door was quiet.

"Catra?" she called, knocking softly on the door.

When she didn't get a response, Adora turned the handle and opened the door a crack. She hesitated, half expecting something to collide with the door—a pillow thrown in anger, or perhaps even a textbook.

But when nothing happened, Adora stuck her head in and found the room as empty as her own. Catra's bag was dumped on the bed. Her sneakers lay in random places amid the clean and dirty clothes strewn across the floor, evidence of having been unceremoniously kicked off. The window was open, letting in a breeze that rattled Catra's broken blinds. Adora sighed.

"Of course."

Adora tucked her phone into the waistband of her skirt and shimmied out the window. Catra's room sat above the house's garage. Ages ago, Catra popped the screen out of the window so she and Adora could steal out to its roof when they needed a break from the noise and fullness of the group home. It was a short drop from the window to the roof below, and years of practice and cheer allowed Adora to land with surprising softness. She blinked in the twilight and found Catra exactly where she expected to: hunched tightly into herself and perched way closer to the edge than Adora was ever comfortable with. She was also still in her Valkyrie reds, save for her feet, which were barefoot as per her preference. Though her ears twitched, Catra didn't bother to look up as Adora approached.

"I'm so sorry, Catra," Adora said, stepping carefully across the shingles and easing down beside her friend.

Catra's shoulders tensed.

"Cover for me, Catra! Just one song and then I'll be back, I swear!" Catra parroted Adora's words from earlier in the week. She still wouldn't look at her. "You left me hanging, Adora."

Shame clawed at Adora's insides. "I know, and I *really* am sorry. They waited for me to get there before starting auditions and I had to sit through everyone else's songs before I could—"

Catra cut her a furious look, and Adora's words died in her throat.

"I had to lie to Coach Weaver about why you never came back," she spat. "And then she got mad at *me.* As if you not being there was somehow *my* fault!"

Adora winced. She could absolutely imagine Coach Weaver finding a way to pin her own misstep on Catra. It wouldn't have been the first time. Yet, Catra had done it anyway, and her heart ached with tenderness. Adora reached out and gingerly laid her fingers on Catra's arm.

"I'm sorry. I never wanted you to get in trouble because of me."

Catra rolled her eyes, but said nothing.

"I'm serious!" Adora insisted, scooting a little closer despite her fear of the roof's edge. "And it'll never happen again, I promise."

Though her expression was still icy, Adora felt Catra's tension thaw slightly beneath her touch.

"Oh, yeah? Does that mean you didn't make the cut?"

Adora flushed and pulled her hand back. "No. I mean, I won't know until the end of the weekend. I just meant that I won't do that to you again."

Catra looked down, her eyes landing on the place where the phantom of Adora's touch still lingered. "Sorry, I wasn't trying to be a bitch. It's just..." She sighed.

"I know, I'd be mad at me too if I were you." Their eyes met and Adora offered a hopeful smile. "But I really appreciate you doing that for me."

"Whatever," Catra said, looking away to hide the fact that Adora's smile had been infectious. "Don't go making a big deal about it – I've got a stone-cold reputation to keep up."

"Yeah, sure," Adora replied, testing her luck by leaning her head against Catra's. When her friend didn't flinch away, she took it as a good sign.

They sat in silence for a minute or two, watching the sun set over the neighbourhood. As the light faded, the late summer heat gave way to a slight chill that whispered of the impending autumn. Catra leaned into Adora and savored her warmth.

"Well? Are you going to tell me how it went or nah?"

Adora blinked up at her with surprise. "Really? I didn't think you'd care."

"Oh, I don't give a shit about glee club," Catra said. "But if it matters to you then I guess I can be supportive."

"How very noble of you."

"I have my moments." Catra flopped onto her back. Adora followed her lead. The shingles were still warm from the sun's rays, and together they basked in what little heat they had to offer.

"I think it went well," Adora admitted with a shy smile. "It didn't feel much different from performing a cheer routine. Everyone was really nice, too. Like, super nice. I think you'd like them."

Catra snorted. "Don't push your luck."

Adora laughed. "Fine, be that way. And how did practice go? Aside from me being a bad friend and totally dropping the ball?"

"Flawless. Couldn't have gone better," Catra teased, winking at Adora. "You know, on second thought, maybe you should bail more often."

Adora gasped, feigning indigence. She gave Catra a shove. "Rude!"

"That's what you get for being a bad friend."

For a split-second, Adora wondered how far Catra was going to take this. She understood her being mad, but sometimes Catra had a hard time recognizing the sharpness of her own barbs. "You don't mean that, do you?"

"Of course I don't." Catra giggled with that squeaky laugh of hers. "But you should have seen the look on your face. You were like, 'No! The betrayal!'"

Relief warmed Adora from the inside. That was one of the many things she loved about their friendship: she and Catra might fight from time to time, but they always came back around to each other in the end. Smiling, Adora rolled to her side at watched Catra laughed on at her own cleverness.

After a moment, Catra went quiet. She looked Adora over, as if she was trying to decide if she had really forgiven her, then grinned. "Okay, it's getting too cold to be out here in a skirt. Sleepover in your room?"

Adora sat up. "Hell yes."

Catra was already up and striding gracefully for the window before Adora even got to her feet.

"Did you eat yet?" she called over her shoulder. "Let's order a pizza or something."

"How about sushi?" Adora countered, pulling her phone from her waistband. "We should at least pretend that we're trying to stick to the meal plan."

She went to unlock her screen, but froze. There was a message alert waiting for her: one new email. Groaning, she opened the app and braced herself for Coach Weaver's vitriol.

But the email wasn't from Coach Weaver — it was from Glimmer.

Somewhere on the edge of her mind, Adora knew Catra was shouting from inside about her stance on sushi.

But, Adora wasn't listening. The only thing she could focus on in that moment were Glimmer's words.

Hi Adora!

I know I said we'd be getting back to everyone by the end of the weekend, but I'm too excited to wait that long!

Congratulations — you're officially a part of Vocal Rebellion!

Chapter 9

Adora spent the weekend sneaking texts to Glimmer and working up the courage to tell Catra the news. After their heart-to-heart on the garage roof, things quickly went back to normal: joking, goofing off, and spending every moment together. These were the fun and easy days Adora loved the most. Even the hours they spent on Sunday sprawled out on Adora's bedroom floor doing homework—at her insistence, of course—was time she enjoyed. Adora didn't want to rock the boat by bringing up glee club, so she put it off. She put it off so long that suddenly it was Monday morning and she and Catra were standing at their neighbouring lockers getting ready for homeroom, and she still hadn't told her.

Which is precisely when Glimmer and Bow showed up.

"Adora!" Glimmer's bright voice soared over the hallway noise.

Adora's body tensed. She could feel Catra's mismatched eyes cut to her, boring into the side of her head, but she refused to meet them.

"Oh my god," Catra muttered under her breath. "Are they coming over here? Oh, yep, here they come..."

At this, Adora finally turned. The scene in the hallway seemed to slow as students watched Glimmer and Bow close the distance, thus committing the most egregious Stevenson High faux pas: approaching a Valkyrie without an invitation.

"Stop." Catra raised her hand, creating a barrier before the peasants could get any closer. She dragged her glare—the chilling one she was frightening good at—over Glimmer and Bow from head to toe. "What are you doing?"

To anyone else, that would have been all the warning they needed.

Glimmer, it seemed, did not care.

"Just wanted to say hey to the newest member of Vocal Rebellion!" she exclaimed. She swerved around Catra's hand and wrapped Adora in a tight hug. "Eeeee! I'm so excited!"

Bow beamed over Glimmer's shoulder. "Congrats, Adora! This year's glee club is going to be awesome."

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora could see Catra watching her expectantly. She was waiting to see if Adora was actually going to go through with this crazy idea. What Catra didn't realize was that Adora had already said yes — enthusiastically.

"Thanks, guys," Adora said, giving Glimmer a quick squeeze. All around them, people were watching and whispering.

With her hands on Adora's shoulders, Glimmer pushed her back and flashed a wide smile, delighted grin. "And don't worry, we can totally work around your cheer schedule. It's gonna be so great! Aaaand, now that you're an official member of Vocal Rebellion, we wanted to invite you to Bow's birthday party!"

Adora glanced at Bow. "When's your birthday?"

Bow shrugged sheepishly. "Technically, it's tomorrow. But the party is this Saturday because who wants to celebrate on a Tuesday? We're going to the beach and then everyone's coming back to my place for pizza and movies."

"Don't forget the slumber party!" Glimmer cheered, punching her hands in the air.

Catra crossed her arms and scoffed. "Who goes to the beach in September?"

"We do," Bow said, proudly planting his hands on his hips. "The forecast is calling for a beautiful day. Do you want to come too?"

As Catra recoiled, Adora held her breath. She knew there was no way Catra would say yes, but she couldn't help but hope.

True to form, Catra laughed. "Um, I don't think so."

Adora opened her mouth, ready to admonish her for being rude, but Bow just shrugged.

"Suit yourself. But the offer still stands if you change your mind."

Catra gave Adora an incredulous "can you believe this nerd?" look, but said nothing.

"I'll text you the details, okay?" Glimmer said, turning away and waving over her shoulder. "We'll see you around!" She and Bow disappeared into the crowd, squeezing passed Scorpia and DT as they made their way over to their squad mates.

"Did I just see that little gremlin hugging you?" DT asked, over-dramatically scandalized. "The audacity."

Adora looked to Catra. Her best friend's expression was closed and impossible to read. For a single, terrible moment, she wondered if Catra might blow her glee club ambitions right then and there. She wasn't stupid—she knew everyone, including Coach Weaver, would have to find out eventually—but she hoped to have a bit more time before that happened. She wanted to prove she could manage both lives before trying to blend them. But if Catra said something now, there was no doubt in Adora's mind that Coach Weaver could be calling her into her office for a reprimand—and maybe even to take back her ribbons—before the lunch bell rang. All she could do was hope Catra knew this too, and that she wasn't so upset that she would sell her out just to be spiteful.

"Oh, you know how it is," Catra grumbled, dropping her gaze to the floor. "Just some of our cheer force captain's fans paying their respects."

"Aw," Scorpia said. "That's sweet."

Adora forced out a laugh that sounded more nervous than she wanted it to. Catra slammed her locker closed and pushed passed

the others. "Come on, let's go."

*

The rest of the week was tense and exhausting. Between cheer and glee, Adora didn't have a single free night to herself. She crammed in her homework before classes and during lunch, and by the time she got to bed each night she was usually too tired to obsess over the slight chill that seemed to have settled between herself and Catra.

Adora had expected an argument. She had expected Catra to call her out and give her shit for not telling her she'd gotten into Vocal Rebellion. But Catra hadn't said anything about it all, and Adora didn't have the guts to bring it up either. At worst, Adora figured Catra would stay mad for a while, and then it would blow over the way their fights always did. She just needed to let Catra see that there was nothing to be upset about — that everything was fine.

By the time Saturday rolled around, Adora was more than ready for a break. She woke up early and packed her bag, changed into her swimsuit, and pulling a pair of shorts and a t-shirt over top. It wasn't until she caught a glimpse of her reflection in the mirror that she realized she was smiling. The truth was, Adora was excited — more than she expected and definitely more than she'd ever admit. The Valkyries rarely did anything like this together, which struck her as weird now that she was thinking about it.

Catra was still asleep when Adora's ride pulled up outside. She briefly considered dashing upstairs to say goodbye—after all, this would be the first time they wouldn't be spending the weekend together—but she paused. Catra didn't like being woken up at the best of times, and Adora definitely didn't think her going to spend the next 24 hours with her new glee friends would qualify as one of those times anyway.

And so, she sent a quick text that read, 'Have a great Saturday, sleepy head! See you tomorrow!' and hurried out the door.

Chapter 10

Bow was right — the weather was perfect for a day at the beach. The sky was bright and streaked with light, hazy clouds on the horizon. Adora kicked her shoes off and hopped from foot to foot on the sunbaked sand as she unfurled her towel next to Glimmer and Bow.

"I'm so glad you decided to come, Adora," Bow said. He was kneeling behind a seated Glimmer and methodically slathering entirely too much sunscreen across the tiny wing tattoos on her shoulder blades.

Adora beamed. "Thanks for inviting me. I really appreciate it, especially seeing as I'm still so new to the group."

"Of course." Glimmer grinned over her shoulder at her. "You're one of us now."

Bow nodded in agreement. "Yeah, you're our friend."

It had barely been a week since Adora's audition, but it didn't feel that way to her. Being with Glimmer and Bow was so easy that she sometimes forgot that she hadn't actually known them for years. In fact, everyone on Vocal Rebellion was easy to get along with, which was more than she could say for the Valkyries. Sure, she considered her squad mates to be her friends, but things weren't always friendly. Whether it was Catra being bossy, DT starting drama, or Lonnie losing her patience with Kyle, there was always some kind of fire that needed to be put out. Even Scorpia, who was one of the kindest people on the cheer force, was prone to letting her jealousy over Adora's closeness with Catra create friction (her crush was so painfully obvious and yet not remotely reciprocated, which almost made Adora feel bad. Almost.)

By comparison, the members of glee club were almost like one big, tight-knit family. Even though she'd only had a couple of practices with them so far, she already considered all of them

friends. She never doubted them when they complimented her performance or said they were happy to see her; never felt the need to over-analyze whether there was a snarky, double-meaning behind the nice things they said.

"Hi everyone!" Perfuma's chipper voice called over the sound of the waves. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow twisted on the sand to look back.

Perfuma was making her way across the sand toward them. A breeze swept gently across the water and played at the hem of her boho skirt. She was flanked on one side by Mermista, looking effortless and in her element, and Seahawk on the other, who appeared to be carrying all of their things. "I brought snacks!"

"No, she brought plants," Mermista corrected.

"Hey! There's nothing wrong with fruits and vegetables."

"You're right, there isn't." Mermista flashed a coy grin at the others. "But if you're looking for something with a bit more substance, we've got actual snack food too."

Seahawk, who had dumped most of his cargo onto the sand, reached into the cooler and produced a brightly colored bottle. "And fizzy drinks!"

Perfuma glanced around. "Is Entrapta coming?"

"She's going to meet up with us back at my place tonight," Bow said as he accepted a drink from Seahawk. "I guess she's got some project she needs to finish or something."

"This is Entrapta we're talking about," Glimmer said with a roll of her eyes. "There's *always* some project with her."

If there was a black sheep of glee club, it was probably Entrapta. Not only was she the oldest member of the group, she also didn't seem particularly interested in show choir. Instead, Entrapta, a self-proclaimed scientist and amateur programmer, was more

preoccupied with aggressively applying to the best robotics programs in the country.

"An arts-based extracurricular will look good on my college applications," she had said when Adora asked her why she'd joined Vocal Rebellion. "Besides, Glimmer said the glee club needed one more member for the team to qualify for regional championships."

Glimmer hadn't denied this. "She needed a club for her applications, we needed one more member. It's win-win!"

Adora wasn't surprised to hear Entrapta wouldn't be joining them until later. The idea of her on a beach seemed about as absurd as Catra on a beach, and when you considered how much Catra hated water, that was saying something. At the thought of her best friend, Adora pulled her phone from a pocket in the shorts she'd left folded at the foot of her towel. She squinted at the screen and saw it was empty; if Catra was up, she hadn't been bothered to reply.

Giving her head a shake, Adora tucked the phone away again. She wasn't about to spend the entire day worrying about whether Catra was mad at her or not. Instead, she turned to say something to Glimmer, just in time to see her get tackled from behind by a small blur.

"Glimmer!" the blur cried in a cheerful voice. The blur, Adora realized, was actually a girl, and she had her arms clutched possessively around Glimmer's neck.

"Frosta," Glimmer choked. "Get off!"

"Oops, sorry." Frosta backed off, smiling sweetly. She turned her attention to Bow. "Happy belated birthday!"

"Thanks, Frosta!" Bow replied. "Glad you could make it."

Adora leaned toward Glimmer and mumbled quietly, "Who's the little kid?"

Frosta's shot her a dirty look. "Excuse me? I'm *twelve*."

"Frosta goes to Ostertag Middle School," Glimmer explained. "She lives next door to me, so we like to invite her along to thing."

"And I'm very mature for my age," Frosta added with a self-satisfied huff.

Adora raised her hands in apology, but Frosta already appeared to be over it as she scampered over to the cooler to get her own fizzy drink from Seahawk. A few minutes later, Spinerella and Netossa, a couple who had been in Vocal Rebellion the longest showed up and the party officially a got started. Mermista was the first to run headlong into the water with Seahawk at her heels. Glimmer tossed a squealing Frosta into the waves like a beach ball. Bow pulled a volleyball from his duffle bag and he and Glimmer challenged Adora and Perfuma to a game of two-on-two. Spinerella and Netossa napped peacefully on a shared blanket under a wide beach umbrella.

Eventually everyone was in the water. Adora bobbed in the surf, laughing herself sore as she watched Glimmer and Mermista grapple with one another, perched atop the boys' shoulders. Hours had flown by without her even noticing. It wasn't until her stomach grumbled that Adora thought to take a break. She tramped up the beach back to the group's camp, a little wobbly on her feet from being tossed around by the waves, and flopped down onto her towel.

Pushing her wet blonde hair from her face, Adora pulled one of Perfuma's apples from the cooler and lounged on her back to eat it. She was enjoying the crash of the waves and the sounds of her friends' laughter as she watched a lone, fluffy cloud drift overhead when her phone chimed. She rolled onto her side and retrieved it from her shorts to find a text from Catra waiting for her.

I've only been awake for an hour and I'm already bored

Adora snorted. She clenched the apple between her teeth and tapped out a reply.

You could still take Bow up on his offer and join us!

Catra's response was almost immediate. *Ew. You know I hate swimmin*g

You don't have to swim, Adora reasoned. *You could nap in the sun. That's, like, your favorite thing in the world.*

OR I could nap in my own bed and not have to worry about getting sand in sensitive places.

The mention of sensitive places made Adora blush. She took the apple out of her mouth, positioned herself on her towel so the ocean was at her back, and shook out her hair. With her phone's front-facing camera, she checked her look—just tousled enough to look cute—and snapped a picture, which is sent to Catra with the caption, *Come be a beach babe with me!*

This time, Catra's response was a little slower. Adora could see that she was typing, stopping, and then starting again. When her reply finally came, all it said was, *I hope you're wearing sunscreen dork. Your cheeks look a little red.*

"Who are you talking to?"

Adora startled, dropping her half-eaten apple into the sand as Glimmer settled onto the towel beside her. Bow had come up from the water too. He knelt on his towel and rifled through the cooler. Adora pressed a hand to her racing heart.

"Glimmer! I didn't hear you coming."

"I'll bet you didn't." Glimmer gave her a cheeky smile. "You seemed a little preoccupied."

Now Adora was really blushing. She could feel the heat blazing behind her cheeks, but thankfully Glimmer didn't point it out.

"I was just texting with Catra," Adora said, surreptitiously turning her phone screen off. She wasn't sure what she was hiding — it's not like their conversation had been anything more than their usual teasing.

Bow, leaned forward on his towel so he could see Adora around Glimmer. "Did she change her mind? Is she going to join us?"

"I was trying to—" Adora's phone chimed again, distracting her mid-sentence. She glanced at the screen, which was now filled with a photo Catra's face. She must have taken the photo while hanging over the edge of the bed — her untamed mane of hair hung away from her head as if untethered by gravity. Her eyes were closed tight and her pink tongue protruded from between her lips. Catra had included a short caption:

See you tomorrow beach babe

It wasn't what Adora had been hoping for, but it made her smile anyway.

Chapter 11

Adora rode in the backseat, letting the rush of air through the open window dry her damp hair as she listened to Bow and Glimmer bicker about what movies they were going to watch that night.

"C'mon, Bow," Glimmer whined from the front passenger seat. "Slumber parties were made for scary movies."

Without taking his eyes off the road, Bow shook his head. "Well *this* slumber party was made for romantic comedies, so too bad."

Groaning, Glimmer swiveled to look back at Adora. "What do you want to watch? We need a tie breaker here."

"Sorry, Glimmer," Adora laughed. "I think the birthday boy gets to make the rules today."

Bow beamed victoriously and winked at her in the rear-view mirror. "Thank you, Adora!

"Boooo!" Glimmer slumped back down, defeated.

A short while later, Bow pulled into the driveway of a large, stately old home in a neighborhood Adora had never been to before. She gazed wide-eyed down the wide street lined with towering oak trees that shaded neatly manicured lawns and two-storey homes. Compared to the busy, cramped street where Adora had spent most of her life, this place was quiet and peaceful.

"Wow," she breathed as she shouldered her bag and followed Bow and Glimmer up the walk. The front doors of Bow's home opened to reveal two men waiting at the threshold.

"Welcome back, kids!" one of the men said, shining the same bright smile that Bow often wore. His dark eyes sparkled over a

pair of half-moon glasses and his long hair was fashioned into dreadlocks. “How was the beach?”

“It was awesome,” Bow replied as the men pulled him into a tight hug.

“And who do we have here?” asked the second man. He was shorter with a neat mustache, and he eyed Adora curiously.

Bow glanced back and grinned. “This is Adora, the newest member of Vocal Rebellion! Adora, these are my dads, Lance and George.”

Adora wasn’t used to meeting parents. She thrust a hand out awkwardly as a nervous laugh bubbled at her lips. “Hi, I’m Adora. Err, wait, Bow just said tha—”

She didn’t have a chance to finish her sentence before George and Lance pull her into a crushing hug as well.

At the same moment, the convoy of cars carrying the rest of the party pulled up to the house. George and Lance ushered everyone inside, where a plenty of pizza and ice cream was waiting. Adora was mortified when, despite Bow having explicitly told everyone not to bring gifts, the others proceeded to shower him with wrapped boxes and ribbon-laden bags overflowing with tissue paper.

“I’m so sorry, Bow,” she fretted during a brief moment when she was able to pull him away from the others. “I didn’t bring you a gift and I feel terrible about it.”

“Are you kidding?” Bow said. “You’re the only one who listened to me. Besides — the fact that you actually came if gift enough for me.”

“Are you sure?”

“Absolutely.” He looped his arm around Adora’s and pulled her toward the kitchen. “Now come on, let’s get some ice cream.”

The whole group spent the night spread out like a game of Tetris made of sleeping bags on the living room floor. Adora half-watched the cheesy rom com Bow picked, letting her attention get pulled away by one conversation after another. At one point, as she was listening to Mermista tell everyone about the time Seahawk got them kicked out of the Dolphin Club social, Adora felt her phone buzz. She pulled it from her pocket to find an alert — Lonnie had just posted a new picture. Adora tapped the notification. A photo filled the screen: Lonnie had taken a selfie in the mall food court, and her grinning face took up the bottom right corner of the photo. Over her shoulder, Catra, Scorpia, Kyle, and Rogelio squeezed into the frame. Catra looked bored, her pink tongue peeking between her lips as she flipped the camera off. Scorpia's arms were wrapped around Catra's middle in a tight and unrelenting hug.

Jealousy flared in the pit of Adora's stomach. For as long as they'd known each other, the only person who was allowed to touch Catra was Adora. Catra had never appreciated Scorpia's hug-first-ask-questions-later approach to friendship, and she had never been shy about letting her know that. Adora told herself this was nothing — that the second after Lonnie snapped the photo, Catra probably squirmed out of Scorpia's embrace with a few choice words, just like she always did. But telling herself that did nothing to make her feel better.

"Everything okay over there?"

Adora's head snapped up and her eyes found Bow watching her closely from across the room.

"Oh, yeah. Everything's fine," she said with an unconvincing laugh. "Just looking at a pic one of my squad mates posted, that's all."

Glimmer leaned into Adora's space and glanced down at the photo. "Huh. I always wondered if you guys were actually friends or if you just moved in a pack because you're all Valkyries."

“Oh, we’re all friends,” Adora said, feeling a little defensive. “I mean, some of us are a little closers. Like, Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio are all dating. And Catra, she and I have been best friends forever.”

Mermista let out a quick snort. “Right. ‘Best friends’.”

Something about the way she said it sent a hot blush racing across Adora’s cheeks, which just made everyone else laugh.

“What?” she squawked. “We are!”

“I didn’t say you weren’t,” Mermista replied, raising her hands in mock surrender.

Adora could feel someone standing behind her. She craned her head back and found Netossa peer down at the photo still glowing on her phone.

“Uh oh,” Netossa said, her voice teasing. “Looks like your ‘bestie’ is getting cozy with someone else.”

“That’s just Scorpia,” Adora said, talking fast. “She’s a hugger. It’s kind of her thing.”

“Oooh, Adora’s jealous!” Frosta shouted.

“What? No, I’m not!”

From where she was curled on the couch, Spinerealla smiled kindly. “Don’t be embarrassed, Adora. I think it’s cute!”

“Have you told her how you feel?” Perfuma asked, joining the crowd of people invading Adora’s personal space to steal a look at the photo.

In that moment, Adora thought she might die of humiliation. “What are you talking about?”

Suddenly everyone was talking at once, laughing and teasing playfully at Adora's expense while she tried in vain to convince them they were all crazy.

"Everyone stop giving Adora a hard time!" Bow's voice cut over the giggles and overlapping voices, all of which fell silent at his command.

"Thank you, Bow," Adora huffed. She clicked her phone off, shunning the offending photo into the void. She wasn't upset — she knew her friends weren't trying to hurt her feelings. Still, having her friendship with Catra aired out like that was stirring something up inside, and she wasn't quite sure it was something she was ready to face. So, she did what she did best: she crammed her feeling down and pretended they didn't exist.

There was a beat of silence before anyone spoke again.

"So," Mermista drawled. "What does your crew think about you hanging out with all of us?"

Adora focused her attention on pushing her phone back into her pocket so she wouldn't have to meet anyone's curious stares. "Uh, well, technically Catra's the only one who knows."

"Wait a sec." Glimmer sat up straight. "They know you're in Vocal Rebellion though, right?"

"Uhhh." Adora's mind scrambled for a way to deflect the question, but lying had never been her strong suit. Not that it would have mattered — her moment of hesitation told the others everything they needed to know."

"Adora!" Bow cried. "Why haven't you told them?"

"And how have you managed to keep it a secret?" Glimmer asked, her voice leaping up a few impressive octaves.

"You're not…" Perfuma hesitated. She blinked at Adora, her big eyes full of hurt. "You're not ashamed of us, are you?"

This sent another ripple of chatter through the group.

"No, of course not!" Adora said, waving off the suggestion with a desperate flap of her hands. "I just… I don't think Coach Weaver is going to be very happy when she finds out, so I'm trying to put it off for as long as I can."

Spinerella shifted off the couch and joined the others on the floor. She put a gentle hand on Adora's shoulder. "Don't you think dragging it out might upset her more?"

A hard lump rose in Adora's throat and she swallowed it down. She had spent plenty of time asking herself the same question.

"It might. But I want to prove to her that I can manage both teams first, y'know? That way she'll know that she doesn't have to worry about my commitment to the squad, and she won't have any reason to make me quit glee."

Seahawk's brows darted up with alarm. "Would she do that?"

Adora laughed darkly. "Coach Weaver takes winning super seriously. I wouldn't put it past her. That's why I need to make sure I don't give her a reason to doubt me."

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Glimmer and Bow exchange a concerned glance.

"That sounds like a lot of pressure to put on yourself, Adora," Bow said.

"Yeah." Glimmer picked up Adora's hand and held it between her palms. "I love having you in Vocal Rebellion, but if this is too much for you—"

"It's fine, I promise!" Adora said, jumping in before Glimmer could finish. "I mean, the next few weeks might be a little chaotic while we get ready for homecoming, but after that everything will be fine!"

Bow scooted closer and put a hand on top of Glimmer's and Adora's. "And then you'll tell Coach Weaver, right? And the rest of your friends?"

Adora sighed, then smiled. "Yes. Once homecoming is over, I'll tell everyone. I just need to keep it a secret for a little bit longer, otherwise one of my friends is bound to let it slip. They mean well but…" She opted not to finish that thought.

"Waaaait." Mermista's eyes narrowed. "Doesn't catgirl know though?"

Again, Adora could feel heat rising inside her at the mention of Catra. "Well, yeah, but she's my best friend — she'd never say anything. She's the reason I was able to sneak away to audition in the first place."

Glimmer frowned. "Are you sure we can trust her?"

"Absolutely," Adora said, nodding firmly.

Quick glances where shared between the others, and Adora could tell they weren't completely convinced. She opened her mouth, ready to defend Catra's honor once more, when Bow smiled.

"Well, if you trust her, then that's good enough for us."

"And no matter what happens, we'll support you," Glimmer added. "Right team?"

The entire group answered in an enthusiastic swell of assent, coupled with a crushing group hug. Though she had to gasp for breath, Adora couldn't help but smile. With friends like these, she felt unstoppable.

Whatever happened next, she could handle it.

Chapter 12

Adora wasn't exaggerating when she said the weeks leading up to homecoming were going to be intense. As the Valkyries doubled down in preparation for their first big performance of the year, Bow's birthday party—and the brief bit of respite it provided—faded into the distance. With classes, homework, rehearsals, and practice, Adora's schedule was packed.

The glee club did what they could to help out, including keeping rehearsals light and scheduling them during lunch hours until after homecoming. And no one complained about it either — not even Entrapta, who usually used her lunch break to sneak in a bit of extra time in the science lab. When Adora asked Glimmer how she could repay her for the favor, she was rebuffed with a wave of the captain's hand.

"It's fine, Adora," Glimmer said, pulling her into a tight hug. "This is what friends do for each other."

Adora melted gratefully into the embrace. Still, while she was relieved that Glimmer was so accommodating, she couldn't shake the feeling that she was letting everyone down. She wasn't even a month into the school year and already she was struggling to keep her head above water.

At least she was good at looking like she was keeping it together. She created a countdown to homecoming on her phone and promised herself the reward of an epic nap if she managed to make it without dropping the ball. That plus her promise to the others that she would tell Coach Weaver what she'd been up to was all the motivation she needed to maintain the appearances of being on top of her game.

Still, Adora was only human, and she was prone to slip up once or twice.

One afternoon, as Vocal Rebellion was running through their big show stopping number, Adora did one of the many things Catra loved to tease her about: she screwed up the lyrics. It wouldn't have been so bad had she not also been in the middle of a solo.

"I am *so* sorry, you guys," she said, flushing with embarrassment. "That was not my best, and I know I can do better. It won't happen again, I promise."

The rest of the team shared startled, wordless glances. With a soft smile, Bow stepped forward and laid his hands gently on Adora's perpetually tense shoulders. "Adora, relax. So you screwed up a line — big deal! It's not the end of the world."

Adora shook her head, the ribbons atop her ponytail swaying with the motion. "It's a big deal to me. There's no excuse for such a stupid mistake."

"I don't know about that," Entrapta mused from the floor. During this brief pause in rehearsal, she had already sunk to sit cross-legged on the floor and pulled a tablet out of who knows where. "I forget lyrics all the time and it's never been a problem."

A part of Adora wanted to gently remind Entrapta that it was likely because she never had any solos, but she couldn't figure out how to say so without coming across as a stuck-up bitch. Thankfully, Glimmer stepped in and saved her from herself.

"Don't take this the wrong way, Adora, but... we're not the Valkyries. Perfection might be what's expected of you there, but here we're just trying to have fun. And if you're not having fun, what's the point?"

"Right," Perfuma chimed in. "Be gentle with yourself, Adora. You deserve it."

Adora mulled this over in the days that followed. She made a private promise to herself to try being a little kinder to herself when she messed up. Surprisingly, this was easier for her to do than she expected. Unfortunately, this newfound leniency found

its way into other aspects of her life, and not everyone was quite as receptive to the mantra.

A few nights before homecoming, while Adora was running the Valkyries through their main routine for the fourth time that night, Kyle lost his balance while being held aloft by Scorpia. He fell back with a shocked squeak, and likely would have broken something had Lonnie and DT not been there to catch him. Adora hurried forward. Both Kyle and Scorpia were already apologizing over one another before she reached them.

"I'm sorry, Captain," Kyle groveled, still a little shaken. "I got sloppy, it won't happen again."

"No, no, it was me," Scorpia rebutted. "My stance was all wrong."

Adora folded her arms and stared them down. Under normal circumstances, this is where she'd bark some of the many demoralizing criticisms she'd learned from Coach Weaver over the years. She was expected to make examples of screw ups like this, pushing her squad mates into better performance with a stern lecture and a touch of public humiliation. From the pained expressions on both Kyle and Scorpia's faces, they were waiting for it.

Instead, Adora sighed. "It's fine. Are you hurt?"

Kyle and Scorpia glanced wide-eyed at each other.

"Uh… no?" Kyle said.

"Okay, good. The last thing we need are injuries before the big rally." Adora could feel the rest of the squad's eyes boring into her, but she didn't acknowledge them. "The first few runs looked fine. Let's move on to cool-down and then we can call it a—"

"Adora!" Coach Weaver's voice boomed through a completely unnecessary megaphone from the sidelines, making the entire squad jump in unison. "Come here at once."

Wincing, Adora rushed to do as she was told. Her stomach dropped at the look of bitter disappointment on Coach Weaver's face.

"Yes, Coach?" she said with a touch of caution.

"Just what do you think you're doing?" Coach snapped.

"I, uh…"

"I didn't make you Force Captain so you could go easy on these embarrassments!"

Adora opened her mouth to apologize when a hand grip her elbow. She turned as Catra stepped up to her side.

"We were reading about different leadership techniques that other cheer teams use to whip their squads into shape," Catra said, shooting Adora a look that begged her to play along. "We figured we could give them a try and see what happens."

Coach Weaver stepped into the girls' space, looming over them darkly. "And what technique would this be? Do you think winners are made by coddling and hand-holding?"

Swallowing hard, Adora played along. "I thought maybe a softer approach might—"

"A *softer* approach?" There was danger in Coach Weaver's voice. "Is there a problem with the way I coach this squad, Force Captain? This award-winning squad, might I add?" Adora shook her head and Coach Weaver eased off. "If any member of this squad can't handle the cold hard truth about their mediocre performance, then they have no right to be here. Do I make myself clear?"

"Of course, Coach Weaver." Adora clenched her hands into fists to keep them from shaking and pressed them into her sides.

“And *you* ,” Coach Weaver barked, rounding on Catra. She waved a finger so close to her face that Adora worried she might take Catra’s eye out. “I named Adora Cheer Force Captain for a reason. She does not need you meddling in how she runs this team. Do you understand?”

Catra glanced away but stood her ground. “Yes, Coach Weaver.”

With that, Coach Weaver stormed away to snap commands at the rest of the squad. Once she was out of ear shot, Adora turned to Catra.

“Why did you do that?” she asked in a harsh whisper.

For a moment, Catra stared her down with an expression Adora couldn’t decipher — like she wanted to say something, but her mouth wouldn’t obey. Then, as if the spell was suddenly broken, Catra scoffed and rolled her eyes.

“You’re such an idiot.” She grabbed Adora by the arms and gave her a light shake. “You need to get it together. Another slip-up like that and Coach Weaver is going to know something’s off.”

Adora let out a sharp exhale. “Yeah, you’re right. Thank you, by the way. You didn’t have to put yourself on Coach Weaver’s bad side for me.”

Catra pulled back and folded her arms across her chest. “Whatever. I’m always on her bad side, remember?” Before Adora could reply, Catra walked to the sidelines where the squad’s bags were piled and pulled theirs from the heap. She tossed Adora hers without looking and turned for the door. “Come on, let’s get out of here.”

Rather than go home, Adora and Catra hopped on a bus to the mall after practice. Neither of them really enjoyed shopping, which is why they had left finding homecoming outfits until the last minute. The only good thing about having to spend the next couple of hours trying on dresses was knowing they’d be charging it to the Valkyries’. For reasons neither of them understood, Coach

Weaver had managed to secure a budget from the school with a line item specifically for "public appearances". If they were out on squad business, they were expected to look their best, and homecoming was no exception.

The girls breezed in and out of stores, on the hunt for the perfect red gowns for the occasion. As was Valkyrie tradition, the whole squad would be attending the post-game homecoming dance together, each dressed in crimson. Adora thought it was fun; she loved the way it felt to strut into the crowded gym, surrounded by her fabulous friends all dressed to the nines. Catra on the other hand thought the whole thing was dumb, which is why she always let Adora pick her outfits for her.

"What do you think of this one?" Adora asked, holding up a flouncy tea-length number.

Unimpressed, Catra raised an eyebrow. "Do I look like a princess to you? You know I don't do tulle."

Adora snorted with laughter. "Which is what makes it funny."

"I'll bite you. Don't think I won't."

"It wouldn't be the first time." Adora tucked the tulle-laden dress back onto the rack and surveyed the stack of gowns already draped over her arm. "What do you think — should we get this over with?"

Catra, her own arms weighed down with Adora's picks for her, jutted her chin toward the fitting rooms. "If we can get this done in fifteen minutes I'll buy us a round of fro-yo."

"Deal."

They crammed themselves into side-by-side fitting rooms and got to work. Adora stripped down to her underwear and shimmied into her first dress, determined to find a winner within the allotted time limit. Catra never offered to buy anything, so she wanted to take advantage of the rare moment. But those best laid plans fell

apart as soon as they stepped out of their respective stalls and instantly dissolved into laughter. They sashayed and posed dramatically, vamping for selfies along the way. By the time the fifteen minutes were up, Adora had only tried on three dresses, with five more to go.

Sweating from both the messing around and the constant changing, Adora slid into the next dress. It was a bit flashier than what she'd normally go for, with floss-thin straps and an open back that made her feel more exposed than she was used to. The scarlet satin hugged her athletic figure in all the right places and had a satisfying swish to the floor-length skirt. She gave it a couple of twirls in front of the mirror, watching the fabric swirl around her legs with a smile.

"I think I found a winner!" she called to Catra.

"Me too!" Catra's voice came from just outside of Adora's fitting room curtain. Adora poked her head out and stopped dead.

Catra lounged back on one of the plush benches that littered the fitting room area wearing, not a dress, but a crisp burgundy suit. The ends of a loose bowtie hung around her neck, framing the collar of a magenta dress shirt that was unbuttoned halfway down her chest. She was in the process of rolling up the sleeves of her blazer when she noticed Adora staring, and she flashed her a proud grin.

"What do you think?" Catra asked, gesturing down her body with a flick of her hand.

There was no way Adora was going to answer that question honestly. The suit looked like it had been made for Catra, and she looked fantastic in it. No, she looked better than fantastic — she looked straight up sexy. Adora's fingers gripped the curtains of her fitting room so tightly she risked pulling the whole thing down. She cleared her throat to disguise her awkwardness.

“Coach Weaver would lose her mind if you showed up to homecoming in that.” Adora said. She told herself to look away—to stop staring for the love of all that was good in the world—but she just couldn’t do it. Catra smirked and jumped to her feet.

“But it looks good, right?” she asked, stepping into a mirrored alcove where she could survey herself from different angles. If she had noticed the fierce blush that colored Adora’s face, she didn’t say anything.

“Yeah,” Adora breathed, sounding a bit more swoony than she would have liked. “It’s a good look on you.”

“I wish I could be like DT and just wear whatever I want to this thing,” Catra muttered at her reflection, deflating just a bit. “Imagine how much easier my life would be if Coach Weaver didn’t hate me?”

“First of all, I think Coach Weaver knows DT would set her car on fire if she ever tried to tell them what to wear.” Adora stepped out from behind the curtain and came up behind Catra, who had busied herself with her cuffs again. “And second, she doesn’t hate you, Catra.”

“Yeah, well she sure doesn’t like me.” Catra’s eyes darted up and met Adora’s in the mirror. A look of shock flitted across her features as she took in the dress Adora had already forgotten she was wearing. But she recovered quickly, and in the time it took her to turn around, Catra was back to looking smug. “So this is the winner, huh?”

“Do you like it?” Adora asked. She twisted her hips left, then right, so the Catra could see the way the gown flowed around her when she moved. “It’s a little skimpy, but I like the way it looks when I spin.”

Catra’s face split into a bright smile — not the self-indulgent grin she usually wore but an honest to goodness smile. “It’s perfect. I think this calls for another selfie.”

Adora retrieved her phone and the pair struck a pose, draping their arms around each other so they looked more like a couple on a date than friends in a fitting room mirror. For a fleeting moment, Adora imagined walking into homecoming on Catra's arm—imagined the gawking and whispers they'd get from the rest of the student body—and her heart tripped over itself. She wanted to tell Catra to forget Coach Weaver — to just buy the suit, consequences be damned. But they both knew better than that, and Catra was already pulling away.

"Okay, give me a minute and I'll pick something else," Catra said as she slid back into her fitting room and pulled the curtain closed. "Just know that I am deeply sad about having to part with this suit."

Huffing a quiet laugh, Adora pressed a hand to her chest. She could still feel her heart racing as she whispered to herself,

"You and me both."

Chapter 13

When it came to sporting events at Stevenson High, the stands were always packed. This was true no matter what the sport, or how well or poorly the team was playing. The truth was, people came to watch the Valkyries. The game—whatever it may be—was just a bonus.

The annual homecoming rally was the Cheer Force's first public performance of the year, which always guaranteed a big turn-out. People showed up hours in advance just to make sure they had a good seat to watch the award-winning, nationally acclaimed squad kick off the year. It may not have been a championship production, but that didn't make it any less important in the eyes of the squad's fans.

As they waited in the tunnel below the stands, Adora took one deep breath after another, feeling the rumble of the crowd rattle her heart in her chest. Normally she found the fanfare thrilling — like a shot of adrenaline right when she needed it most. But this was her first homecoming rally as Force Captain, and her reputation—not to mention Coach Weaver's willingness to accept her secret dual life—hinged on this night going perfectly.

Not that she was going to let the rest of the squad know she was nervous. As far as they knew, she was as cool and collected as ever.

"What's the matter?" Catra's voice cut through the mental pep talk Adora was giving herself. Adora jolted with a gasp and turned to find Catra hovering at her side and watching her closely.

"Don't sneak up on me like that!" Adora hissed. She shook out her pom poms to give her anxious energy something to do.

Catra raised an eyebrow and grinned. "Uh oh. You're not nervous, are you?"

“What? No!” Adora puffed her chest and scowled, then quickly glanced around to see if the rest of the squad was listening in before lowering her voice to a whisper. “Why, do I look nervous?”

With a snort of laughter, Catra draped an arm over her shoulder. “You’re a pretty terrible actor, Adora. But don’t worry, I doubt the others have noticed.”

Adora forced a weak smile. “Just you, huh?”

“Uh, duh. Like you can keep anything from me.”

“I just… Tonight really needs to go well.”

“It will.” Catra tipped her head so that her face took up the entirety of Adora’s view, blocking out the rest of the world. “You’ve run us through these routines a million times. We’re perfect, and you made us this way. So just chill and try to have fun for a change.”

“Yeah, you’re right,” Adora said, her shoulders relaxing ever so slightly. “Thanks Catra, I needed that.”

Catra smiled and gave Adora a playful shove. “Whatever. Rally the troops, Captain. I think it’s almost game time.”

Taking one last deep breath, Adora squared her shoulders and called the Valkyries into position. Her squad leapt to formation with precision.

“Alright, Valkyries!” she cried, her voice echoing off the tunnel’s concrete walls. “It’s time to give these guys a show. Are you ready?”

The squad let out a cheer so loud that it drowned out the roar of the crowd above. Out on the field, music blared to life over the loudspeakers, overlaid by the announcer who was officially kicking off the rally. Adora waved her squad to the mouth of the tunnel and smiled back at them over her shoulder. Catra was right: they really were perfect. Each of her friends’ faces were bright with

excitement and determination — valiant warriors waiting for their general to lead them into battle.

A fire erupted in Adora's stomach, burning away the anxiety and doubt. Over the PA, the announcer called their name.

"Let's hear it for your Stevenson High Valkyries Cheer Force!"

Adora gave a nod. "Let's do this!"

*

A few hours later, the entire squad was gathered in the sprawling basement suite of DT's house, collectively riding the high of their flawless first performance of the year as they got ready for the homecoming dance.

"Oh man," Scorpia shouted as she swooped through the room, her gown draped over her arm. "I'm still getting chills just thinking about how loud the crowd cheered for us — chills!"

Lonnie, who was doing her makeup, glanced up in the mirror and smirked. "Right? We crushed it tonight!"

"All the more reason to celebrate, darling," DT drawled from Lonnie's side, surveying their reflection critically. "Be a dear and pass me the eyeliner, will you? These bitches are uneven."

Adora sat on an ottoman in the middle of the room, flushed with pride and beaming at her squadmates like a proud mother hen. They really had done an amazing job — not even Coach Weaver could come up with anything to berate them about, and that was her specialty. Catra had been right — she'd had no reason to be nervous.

Scorpia gave the door of DT's en suite bathroom a polite tap. "You almost finished in there, Wildcat?"

"Yeah, yeah," Catra's muffled voice replied. "Just a sec."

A moment later, the door swung open and Catra breezed out in the floor length gown she had begrudgingly settled on. Her long hair was loose and swept to the side in a glamorous dramatic side-part. She side-stepped Scorpia, who was fawning loudly over how great she looked, and made a beeline for Adora.

“Can you help me do this thing up?” she grumbled. “I think the zipper is stuck.”

Because she was never allowed to wear what she wanted, Catra had developed a habit of seeing just how much she could get away with instead. It was a small act of rebellion that usually meant things like plunging necklines and regulation-defying hemlines — anything to test just how much she could get away with before she got into trouble.

So far, that hadn’t happened, which just went to show how much sway the Valkyries had in the school.

Tonight’s button-pushing number was missing a generous percentage of fabric in the form of artfully placed cut-outs in hard to ignore places. Her toned legs peeked out between twin floor-to-thigh slits whenever she moved. She whirled around in front of Adora with a huff, already fed up with the effort it took to look as fabulous as she did.

Adora stood with a smile and shifted Catra’s thick hair out of the way.

“What do you think?” Catra asked. “Will this get me kicked out of the dance?” It was the same thing every time — as if getting kicked out of a school function was a game she hadn’t quite figured out how to win.

“On anyone else? Yes,” Adora laughed. “On a Valkyrie, not a chance.”

“Dammit.”

“Maybe next year.”

Adora's tugged gently at the zipper, which was snagged at the small of Catra's back. When she finally got it loose, she pulled it up slowly, letting her finger trail up the valley of her friend's spine. If asked why she was lingering, Adora planned to blame the finicky zipper. But Catra didn't seem to care, and she shivered slightly when Adora pulled away.

"You look nice, by the way," Catra said, shaking her hair and letting it fall back over her shoulders.

Adora blinked down at herself, wondering what Catra meant. After all, Catra had already seen the dress. The only thing different now was that Adora's hair was down, and Catra had seen that plenty of times before. In fact, Adora so rarely wore it out of a ponytail that she wasn't even sure what to do with it, so she had simply tucked it behind her ears and secured it in place with a pair of gold wing-shaped clips. She liked them because they reminded her of the mythical Valkyrie warriors the cheer squad was named for, and also because she was a dork.

"Who," she asked incredulously. "Me?"

Catra laughed, breaking the spell they had briefly fallen under. "Of course you, dummy. Who did you think I was talking to?"

"Well excuse me for not knowing how to accept a compliment from you." Adora gave Catra a poke in the ribs for good measure. "It's such a rarity that I thought I might have been hearing things."

"You've taken enough hits to the head," Catra said with a shrug. "Anything's possible at this point."

Across the room, DT's phone pinged. They glanced at the screen with an air of indifference, then smiled. "That's our cue, darlings. Our chariots await."


Maggie
Derrick

Chapter 14

The Valkyries rolled into the Stevenson High gymnasium shoulder to shoulder. The homecoming dance was already technically underway, but everyone knew the party didn't really start until the squad showed up. Standing back-lit in the double doors, Adora held her breath as the crowd of students turned in unison and fell momentarily silent. Then, just as quickly, everyone broke into a whoop of applause and cleared a path for their Cheer Force.

Adora was immediately surrounded by a swarm of classmates, each talking over one another as they lauded her on the squad's performance and congratulated her on making captain. She smiled and politely accepted their hugs and high-fives, while Catra steered them through the crowd like a bodyguard.

"How's it feel to be a celebrity?" Catra said, raising her voice over the pulsing music.

"Oh, stop," Adora replied. She waved off the suggestion with feigned modesty and Catra laughed.

Bodies jostled and danced around as Adora scanned the crowd. She could see a table set up against one wall, where students were casting their votes for homecoming queen and king. A hulking shadow moved into Adora's peripheral vision, and she glanced up to find Scorpia standing there.

"We should go cast our votes before we forget!" Scorpia said with a wide smile. "I'm gonna vote for you, Wildcat."

Catra recoiled with a scowl. "Do not do that."

"Why not? You'd make a beautiful homecoming queen."

Adora grinned and folded her arms. "Y'know, I think Scorpia's right. I think I'll cast my vote for you too, Catra."

“What?” Catra’s voice cracked. Her fists were balled at her sides, and her irritation left Adora howling with laughter. “Whose side are you on?”

“Yours, obviously.” Adora wiped at the corner of her eyes. “Come on, Scorpia. Let’s go exercise our democratic right to embarrass Catra.”

“Don’t you dare!” Catra snarled.

But Adora was already weaving through the crowd. She was almost to the table when she heard someone call her name. It took a moment of standing on her toes and peering over heads before she caught a glimpse of Bow waving at her, a shock of pink hair jumping up and down at his side.

For a split second, Adora forgot where she was — she forgot *who* she was, and who she was there with. At the sight of her friends, her face split into a wide smile and she changed course to meet them.

A hand closed around her wrist and pulled her back.

“What are you doing?” Catra hissed in her ear, standing close against Adora’s back.

Adora twisted around, bringing them face to face. For a dizzying moment, she was completely consumed with how little space was between them, but then Catra broke her gaze away to glance over Adora’s shoulder and the moment was over.

“That’s Bow and Glimmer, from gl—”

Catra’s palm pressed against Adora’s mouth, silencing her. “I didn’t ask who, I asked *what*.”

Behind Catra, Adora could see Scorpia hovering just out of ear shot. She glanced between her and Catra, then lifted her eyes to where Glimmer had climbed Bow’s back and was now hanging off his shoulders so she could see.

“Ugh, Catra.” Adora pulled back and swatted Catra’s hand away. “Will you relax?”

“You can’t just waltz over there and talk to them. Are you crazy?”

“Oh, come on. Everyone’s talking to me tonight. No one’s going to care if I say hi.”

Bristling, Catra took a breath and tried to compose herself. “You know as well as I do that the Valkyries don’t socialize with the glee club in public. Especially not the captain. You’re going to blow your cover!”

But Adora was already edging away. “New captain, new rules. Besides, they’re my friends. I’m just going to say hello and then I’ll be right back, okay?” She turned away before Catra could reply. The sound of Catra angrily calling after her was quickly drowned out by music and laughter as she pushed through the crowd.

“Adora! Hey!” Glimmer shouted as Adora came into view. She dropped from Bow’s shoulders and skipped forward. “You. Were. AWESOME!”

It took Adora a moment to realize she was talking about her performance with the Valkyries. “You came to the game?”

“Of course we did!” Bow said, beaming. “We weren’t going to miss a chance to support one of our own.”

“Aw, you guys.” Adora was touched. She wondered if the Valkyries would ever come out to watch her perform with Vocal Rebellion, but when she tried to conjure the mental image, all she saw was Catra sulking in the front row.

“Great job out there, Adora.” Mermista’s voice cut in from the right, where she and Seahawk emerged through a mass of students dressed in matching outfits. “Love the dress, by the way.”

Perfuma hurried alongside them with a squeal.

“I’m so proud of you!” She threw her arms around Adora’s shoulders for a quick hug. “Where are your friends? Can you dance with us for a bit?”

Adora stepped back with a nervous laugh. She could feel the eyes of other students watching her closely. “Actually, I’m here with the rest of the squad. Y’know, Valkyrie tradition and all.” She turned to gesture back at Catra and Scorpia, but found the space where they’d been standing filled with other people. “Uh, anyway. I just wanted to come over and say hi. Thanks for coming to the rally — that’s so sweet of you. You all look amazing, by the way!”

And, as was usually the case when she was hanging out with Vocal Rebellion, Adora lost track of time. The dance swirled on around them as they laughed and joked. It wasn’t until the song overhead faded out that Adora realized she’d been “saying hi” for a lot longer than planned.

As the crowd fell into a buzz of excited whispers, Adora felt a hand press lightly onto her back. She turned, expecting to see Catra, but found DT grinning down at her instead.

“There you are, darling. We’ve been looking everywhere for you.”

“Oh yeah?” Adora cast an anxious glance at Vocal Rebellion, who gazed at DT with a mix of reverence and curiosity. “How come?”

The gym was suddenly filled with the energetic voice of the class president as they informed the breathless crowd that the moment had come: it was time to crown this year’s homecoming royalty. While they spoke, DT stared the others down, pinning them under their perpetually critical gaze. A few of them shifted uncomfortably. Then DT smiled brightly and turned their attention back to Adora.

“A little birdie told me you may want to move a bit closer to the stage,” they whispered.

Adora cocked her head. “Why?”

DT let out a quiet, delighted titter of laugher, which they hid behind their hand. “Oh, sweetie. Thank goodness you’re pretty.” Then they leaned closer and whispered, “It’s time for your coronation, princess.”

At that same moment, the class president was on stage opening an envelope. “And now, put your hands together for this year’s SHS homecoming queen: the brand new captain of your Valkyries Cheer Force—”

The crowd erupted into applause, overcoming the sound of Adora’s name as it was called. It was pretty much a sure bet that Adora was going to win—what with her being both cheer captain and the most popular girl in school—but it wasn’t until she felt the hands of others urging her to the stage that it really felt real. She climbed up the stairs in a daze and let the class president lead her to stand next to a boy she’d only kind of knew: Adam, captain of the school’s football team.

Of course, Adora thought as she smiled at the crowd, just like she’d been trained to do. *We’re such an embarrassing cliche*.

Adam, stiff with discomfort, gave her a tiny wave. She returned the gesture as a cheap tiara was placed on her head to great fanfare. Squinting against the bright lights, Adora tried to find her friends (she could just imagine Catra, howling with laughter at her expense) but from the stage the crowd was nothing more than a shadowy blob.

“Hey,” Adam whispered in her ear, making her jump. “Congrats.”

“Yeah, you too!”

He cleared his throat and fidgeted with the hem of his suit jacket. “Uh, listen. I know we’re technically supposed to dance together now, but would you mind if I danced with my boyfriend instead?”

Adora was so relieved, she actually burst out laughing. “I don’t mind at all. You two have fun!”

Each grateful to the other, Adora and Adam shared a quick handshake, which got a round of laughter from the crowd. Then they hurried off the stage, waving and smiling until they were back on the dance floor. Adam broke away with a nod and hurried into the waiting arms of another boy on the football team. For a moment she stood, smiling after them. Then she realized she was being watched, and it dawned on her that everyone expected her to dance too.

She scanned the crowd. It was easier to see without the stage lights blazing in her eyes, and she found who she was looking for quickly enough.

Catra stood leaning against the wall, arms crossed with a drink propped up in her hand. She was listening intently to Scorpia, who gestured animatedly as she spoke. Adora breezed toward them, ready to rescue her friend from the conversation, when Catra tossed her head back and laughed. For a split second, Adora faltered; this wasn't one of Catra's condescending fake laughs — she was honestly laughing at whatever Scorpia said. Giving her head a shake, Adora forced the smile back to her face.

"Hey," she chirped brightly when she reached them. "Mind if I cut in?"

"Aren't you supposed to be dancing with what's his face?" Catra asked, smirking as her eyes caught on Adora's tiara.

"Yeah, but he wanted to dance with his boyfriend." Adora hitched her thumb over her shoulder to where the boys were already swaying dreamily in one another's arms. "So, I need a new partner. What do you say?" She held out her hand toward Catra. "Wanna dance?"

This seemed to take Catra by surprise. Her cheeks reddened and her aloofness slipped.

"Uh, sure." She handed her cup to Scorpia, who made no attempt to hide her disappointment as she accepted it. "Can't say no to

the queen, right?”

Adora ignored the jab and led Catra out onto the dance floor. Without thinking, their hands fell naturally into place—Adora’s at Catra’s waist, and Catra’s on Adora’s shoulders—and it was as easy as anything else. But as they started to dance, Adora couldn’t deny the tension ballooning between them.

“What?” Adora asked when Catra’s eyes flitted upward.

“That tiara.” Catra tried not to snicker and failed. “I’m sorry, but it looks stupid.”

Somewhat relieved, Adora laughed too. “Yeah, I’ll bet it does.”

They danced on in silence. Adora frowned as Catra refused to meet her gaze.

“So,” Adora said after another excruciating moment without speaking. “You and Scorpia looked like you were having fun.” She felt Catra’s body go rigid under her hands.

“Don’t start,” Catra scoffed. For a second, her eyes cut to Adora’s, and Adora was surprised to find them brimming wiht hurt and anger. “Who else was I supposed to talk to while you were out committing social suicide with your new friends?”

Adora flinched back. “Catra, don’t be like that. What was I supposed to do? Pretend I didn’t see them waving at me?”

“You would have before,” Catra snapped back. Her hands tightened instinctively, nails biting into Adora’s bare shoulders. “What’s happened to you?”

“Why are you being so dramatic?” Adora asked. Indignation bubbled up inside of her. “What’s your problem?”

Catra scowled and looked away, her face twisted with the effort it took not to answer. But Adora wasn’t letting her off the hook that easily. She tugged her closer, trapping their bodies together and

making it impossible for Catra to ignore her. Catra let out a soft gasp, but recovered quickly. She glared up at Adora in a way Adora simply wasn't used to.

"Operation One Perfect Year, remember?" Catra whispered at last. Adora was certain Catra could feel her heart racing through her chest. "You were going to be named cheer captain and we were going to run the school together. But instead you've been too busy with your stupid glee club and your dorky new friends. I barely see you outside of practice anymore!"

"Catra, we literally live in the same house!"

"Ugh! Forget it," Catra snarled, squirming against Adora's grip. "Just let go of me."

"Catra, I—"

"I said—"

"You're not being fair."

"Let. GO."

Catra's voice carried over the music, startling the couples who danced around them. Shocked, Adora's hands fell away. She let Catra pull away and, for a breathless moment, they simply stared at each other while everyone else stared back at them. Though her eyes glistened, Catra's expression was hard.

Adora reached for her. "Catra, let's talk about this, okay?"

Catra answered with a noise of disgust. She sneered at Adora's hand before knocking it away.

Then she turned on her heel and stormed away, leaving Adora stunned and alone in the middle of the dance floor.

Chapter 15

Adora didn't intend to spend most of her weekend mad. In fact, she hadn't even started off angry: she started off worried.

Worried she had screwed up. Worried she had done something wrong.

As soon as she got home from the dance, Adora went straight to Catra's room, where she was met with stony silence and a locked door.

When she tried again the next morning, Catra was already gone.

How long are you going to avoid me? Adora texted when Saturday night came and she still hadn't heard a word. Up popped the read receipt, followed by nothing.

That's when she got mad.

"Fine!" she shouted at her phone, as if it were some voodoo stand-in for her best friend. "Be a stubborn brat — see if I care!"

The problem was, she *did* care. And that just made things worse.

Adora vented her frustrations to Glimmer and Bow in a group chat.

A: *She hasn't said a word to me since the dance. I don't even know where she is right now — she's been gone all day.*

B: *What exactly is she mad about? What did she say to you at the dance?*

A: *She said I'm ruining Operation: One Perfect Year*

G: *Uhh… what?*

Adora hesitated. It wasn't that the plan she and Catra had was embarrassing, but something about sharing the details with other people felt like a betrayal. She decided to keep things vague.

A: *It was just a plan we had… She thinks me being part of Vocal Rebellion is ruining it*

G: *Being part of VA? Or being friends with us?*

A: *I dunno… probably a bit of both*

G: *Yikes*

B: *I'm sure she just needs some time to cool off. She's your best friend — she'll come around!*

Adora grimaced, her thumbs flying across her phone screen as she typed her reply. *Maybe. But tbh I'm too mad to talk to her right now anyway. I don't even think I wanna be here when she comes home*

G: *!!!!!!*

A: *…. What?*

G: *You know what this means??*

B: *Yes! Sleepover time!*

A: *Sleepover time?*

G: *SLEEPOVER TIME!!!*

When Glimmer and Bow made up their minds about something, there wasn't much anyone could do to talk them out of it. Within fifteen minutes, they were parked outside of the group home. Adora heard the thumping bass from the speakers of Bow's dads' car before she even got Glimmer's text announcing their arrival. Grinning, she scooped up her bag—packed with everything she'd

need straight through to Monday—and shouted a quick goodbye as she darted out the front door.

In the loud backseat, with Bow smiling at her in the rearview mirror and Glimmer twisting around to shake an open bag of candy at her, Adora's tension melted away. It wasn't until Bow was pulling away, and she had turned to pull her seatbelt over her shoulder, that Adora saw it: a silhouette perched on the garage roof. Two pointed ears, black against the night sky.

Shit.

She didn't hear a word from Catra for the rest of the weekend.

Glimmer and Bow did their best to keep Adora distracted. Camped out on Glimmer's bedroom floor, Adora let them shove bowls of ice cream at her while she seethed.

"Screw you, nutrition plan," she huffed, digging into a bowl of raspberry swirl as the three of them cycled through funny animal videos on Youtube.

"Don't you think it's weird that Coach Weaver gets to tell you what to eat?" Bow asked, eyeing the way Adora shoveled the ice cream into her mouth with pity.

"Whatever it takes to win," she replied, wiping her lips with the back of her hand. "We need to be in peak physical condition if we want to keep our title."

Bow didn't seem convinced. "Do you though?"

"Ooh! Speaking of which, let's see if there are any Valkyrie videos on here," Glimmer said. She typed the squad's name into the search bar and hit enter. Adora could have told her there were plenty of videos of them online, but her mouth was full again. "Hey, look! This one is from your nationals performance from last year."

Glimmer hit play and the three of them watched in rapt silence. While she and Bow gazed in awe, Adora scrutinized every move she and the cheer force made. Technically, the routine had been flawless—they *had* won, after all—but there was always room for improvement.

"Wow," Glimmer breathed, her sparkling eyes tracking Adora and Catra as they moved through a series of synchronized backflips across the screen. "This is so cool. Is it as fun as it looks?"

Adora tipped her head as she considered the question. Once upon a time, her answer would have been an automatic and enthusiastic 'yes!'. She loved spending time with her friends and performing. She loved challenging herself athletically, and she loved competing. Still, she'd be lying if she said it was all pom poms and pep. Her eyes flitted to where her crisp uniform hung over the back of Glimmer's desk chair.

"Yeah, it's fun," she said, choosing her words carefully. "But it's also a lot of work, especially when you're competing at such an elite level. Coach Weaver has really high expectations for us — as far as she's concerned, losing is never an option."

"Would it really be so bad if you lost though?" Glimmer asked. "Like, what if you guys just cheered because it was fun and not to win titles. Would that be so awful?"

"Oh no," Adora shook her head. "Coach Weaver would never let that happen."

At this, Bow shifted uncomfortably. "She sounds pretty tough, Adora."

"She is, but that's why we're so good."

Bow and Glimmer did that thing where they communicated solely through a pointed look. Adora recognized it at once — she and Catra had the same trick.

“Adora,” Bow said, his tone gentle. “Are you sure she’s going to be okay with you being in Vocal Rebellion?”

Adora stared down into the melting ice cream sludge at the bottom of her bowl. “I guess we’ll find out on Monday.”

“But…” Glimmer hesitated. “But what if she says no?”

A tense silence fell between the three of them. It was a prospect Adora didn’t want to consider. To her, if she let the thought have any space in her mind, she ran the risk of accidentally manifesting it into reality.

“She won’t,” Adora said with so much confidence that even she believed it. “She’s got no reason to say no.” As if to drive her point home, Adora flashed the brightest smile she had in her arsenal. “Don’t worry, guys. I’ve got it all under control.”

*

Adora stayed at Glimmer’s place for the rest of the weekend. On Monday, she, Glimmer, and Bow got a ride to school with Mrs. Moon, which meant they arrived on campus much earlier than Adora was accustomed to. With the halls relatively quiet, she took the opportunity to hang out with Glimmer and Bow out in the open, without worry of gossip or prying eyes. It was so much easier when she didn’t have to pretend not to know them, and in those quiet and easy moments, she decided to double down on what she’d told Catra at the dance. She was the captain now: if anyone was in a good position to change the way the social hierarchy of Stevenson High functioned, it was her.

When the first bell rang, Adora said goodbye to the others.

“Well see you for rehearsal at lunch!” Glimmer said, pointing at Adora for emphasis.

Adora laughed. “You bet. See you then!”

She watched Glimmer and Bow disappear around the corner, then turned to head for homeroom only to run straight into someone behind her. She stumbled back, but a lithe hand caught her around the wrist before she could fall.

"Careful, darling."

Adora blinked up at DT in surprise as they tugged her back upright. "Oh! Hi, DT. Sorry, I didn't see you there."

DT's green eyes lifted and, for a split-second, seemed to focus on the corner around which Glimmer and Bow had turned. Adora's heartbeat raced. She wondered how long they had been standing there.

"Not to worry," DT cooed with a flippant wave of their hand. "It's not like you damaged the goods. Anyhoo, gotta get to homeroom." They sashayed past Adora, wiggling their fingers at her as they went. "See you at practice, darling."

Adora waited until DT was swallowed up in the sea of students before she let herself exhale.

"That was close," she muttered under her breath. "Glimmer and Bow are right — enough's enough. I'm telling Coach Weaver tonight."

*

Before Valkyries practice, Adora had Vocal Rebellion rehearsal. Between the two, she knew which one she was looking forward to more.

The door to the band room swung open just as Adora sprinted up to it, forcing her to skid to a stop.

"Hello, Adora!" Mrs. Moon said in her smooth, accented voice. She smiled softly at Adora. "I'll be right back. I forgot the permission forms for sectionals on the copier."

“Sounds good!” Adora replied, sliding past her into the room. Excitement thrilled at the pit of her stomach. With all her focus having been on homecoming, Adora had almost forgotten about Vocal Rebellion’s upcoming trip to show choir sectionals. It would be her first real performance as a member of the glee club, and just thinking about it made her break out into a wide grin.

In the band room, she found Glimmer and Bow at the ready. They glanced up when she entered and returned her winning smile.

“What do you say?” Adora asked. “Are you ready to rock sectionals, or what?”

Chapter 16

Catra had given the rest of the Valkyries some bullshit excuse to get out of joining them for lunch.

"Who gives a Valkyrie lunch hour detention?" Lonnie asked, her nose wrinkling at the thought.

"A teacher who knows Coach Weaver would lose her mind if that detention overlapped with her practice time," Catra replied, deftly avoiding Lonnie's actual question. "Anyway, whatever. I'm sure I'll be able to get myself out of it. Save me a seat, okay?"

She was too proud to tell them the truth — she was going to talk to Adora.

After watching Adora leave with her stupid glee friends on Saturday night, Catra had been furious. She tore up her room in a rage, sending clothes and school books flying and screaming into her pillow until she exhausted herself. She stayed up all night, staring at her phone and willing Adora to send another message so she could finally give her a piece of her mind.

But that text never came, and when Monday morning rolled around without Adora, Catra realized she was getting a taste of her own medicine. It was bitter, and she didn't like it at all.

And then, as the school day progressed and Catra only spotted Adora in fleeting glimpses between the shoulders of the classmates who were still whispering about the spectacle at homecoming, she realized it was probably time to apologize. Adora had never gone this long without talking to her — never let this much time pass without managing to patch things up between them.

Catra may have hated the way the glee club was coming between her and Adora, but she hated not having Adora around even

more. Adora, Catra reasoned, was worth swallowing her pride for, even if it was just this once.

She trudged down the hall, making her way to the wing of the school that housed the band room. It wasn't a part of the school she spent a lot of time in, and just being there felt strange and alien to her. With her hands balled into tight fists at her sides, Catra kept her eyes locked straight ahead.

Just get in, say you're sorry, and then get out, she thought. *By the time the bell rings, everything will be back to normal.*

"Catra!"

The sound of Coach Weaver barking her name made Catra's heart plummet. She whirled around to find the coach bearing down on her, already angry. Instinctively, Catra drew herself into a defiant stance and folded her arms across her chest.

"What?" she said.

"Don't take that tone with me, Valkyrie. I won't stand for it," Coach Weaver snarled. "Where is Adora? Why isn't she with you?"

Mind racing, Catra searched for a plausible explanation for why Adora wasn't in her usual place at her side when another teacher, Mrs. Moon, breezed up beside them.

"Coach Weaver!" Mrs. Moon exclaimed, far more pleasantly than the coach deserved. "Congratulations on that spectacular performance at the homecoming rally. Your squad was marvellous, as usual." She suddenly seemed to notice Catra standing there, and turned a warm smile on her as well. "Excellent work out there!"

Catra, so unaccustomed to being praised by someone with any degree of authority, had to remind herself that the polite thing to do in this situation was to say 'thank you'. Even then, all she managed to produce was a tight smile.

Coach Weaver scoffed. “It was hardly a performance worthy of commendation, but I suppose it’s not fair to expect you to know what nationally acclaimed showmanship looks like. Speaking of which, how is your little troupe of vaudevillian cast-offs shaping up this year, Angella?”

As Mrs. Moon’s smile faltered, Catra felt an icy rush of fear. There was a very good chance Mrs. Moon would blow Adora’s cover if she answered that question. Catra cleared her throat and jumped into action.

“Actually, isn’t the glee club supposed to be rehearsing right now?” She could feel Coach Weaver’s eyes burning into her, no doubt wondering why she knew anything about Vocal Rebellion’s schedule. Whatever. Catra resigned herself to coming up with yet another lie to deal with that problem later. “They must be wondering where you are, Mrs. Moon.”

At this, Mrs. Moon’s face brightened again. “It’s alright. I was actually just on my way to pick up our permission forms for *sectionals*.” She added a bit of emphasis to the word *sectionals*, giving Coach Weaver a pointed look as she did so. “I told them to get started without me.”

“And they have!”

Catra turned with a start to find DT slinking up to the group. A sly grin curled its way up their face as they continued talking.

“I was just passing by the band room and I must say, those little rebels are sounding pretty good, Mrs. Moon.” DT gave her a playful wink. “I was a little surprised to hear Adora soloing, but she seems to be holding her own just fine.”

The blood in Catra’s veins turned to ice. It felt like she was falling. She had to remind herself to breathe. When she looked up at Coach Weaver, she found her glaring ominously back.

“Did you say Adora?” Coach Weaver asked, her words tight and measured.

“Oh, yes!” Mrs. Moon said, completely oblivious to the tension that was hardening around her. “We were so thrilled when she auditioned for Vocal Rebellion this year — she’s been an excellent addition to the ensemble!”

“Of course she has,” Coach Weaver replied with a saccharine sweetness that set Catra’s hair on end. She was all too familiar with that voice — like the warning rattle of a poisonous snake in the moment before it strikes. “Anyway, you best not keep them waiting. If you’ll excuse me, my Valkyries and I have some official business to discuss.”

Mrs. Moon took a step back and offered a weak smile. “Ah, right. Well, lovely chatting with you.”

She retreated without looking back.

Coach Weaver waited until she was gone before snapping her fingers in DT’s face.

“You,” she barked. “Leave us.”

DT scowled but compiled without argument. During this momentary distraction, Catra tried to make a break for it — she had to get to the band room before Coach Weaver did. But the old woman was faster than she looked. Catra had barely taken her first step when she felt Coach Weaver’s bony fingers snare around her elbow.

“And just where do you think you’re going?” she hissed.

Catra swallowed. “Lunch?”

Coach Weaver’s grip tightened. Catra pulled a sharp breath in between her clenched teeth.

“Do not lie to me, Catra. You knew about this, didn’t you?” When Catra didn’t answer, Coach Weaver jostled her menacingly. “You’ve been protecting her all along, haven’t you?”

"She just wanted to try it out," Catra cried. She was immediately flooded with shame. "She's been keeping up with her captain's duties the whole time, so what does it matter?"

Coach Weaver shoved Catra forward.

"Walk."

*

Adora flopped down in one of the plastic band chairs and took a long pull from her water bottle. It still surprised her how exhausting singing and dancing could be. While she caught her breath, she smiled at the other members of Vocal Rebellion. They had just finished running through their second number for sectionals and, though she may have been biased, Adora thought they sounded amazing.

"I'm so excited to do this in front of an actual audience!" she said.

Bow wiped his brow with the back of his hand and smiled. "Competition at sectionals is going to be tight, but I actually think we have a decent chance this year."

"Uh, *heck yeah* we do!" Glimmer was almost vibrating with excitement. "We should probably start talking about costumes. When it comes to these competitions, you need to look as good as you sound."

The group descended into chatter, tossing ideas around. They were in the middle of a heated debate over the legitimacy of glitter as a fashion medium when the door slammed open.

"Geeze, Mom," Glimmer said, turning. "Go easy on the—"

Her words evaporated into dead silence

Adora glanced up, curious. What she saw sent a tingling numbness racing down to her very core.

Coach Weaver stood in the doorway with Catra in tow. Her face was tight with an anger that somehow managed to intensify when her fiery gaze landed on Adora. She let out a growl and shoved Catra forward into the room with such force that, for a moment, Adora thought Catra might fall. Instinctively, Adora leapt to her feet, but Catra managed to catch herself.

"I cannot believe what I'm seeing," Coach Weaver boomed, her voice filling the space and making the students of Vocal Rebellion shrink away. "I name you captain of the most elite cheer squad in the country and this is how you repay me? By diluting your attention with this glorified circus act?"

"It's not like that!" Adora replied. Her gut was churning — this wasn't how she wanted this conversation to happen.

"How long did you plan on keeping this from me?"

"I was going to tell you today, before practice." The words tumbled out of Adora's mouth in a hurried jumble. "I wanted to wait until after homecoming so I could prove to you that I can still handle my responsibilities as Cheer Force Captain and be part of glee at the same time."

Coach Weaver tossed her head back and let out a dark and discomfiting peel of laughter. "What kind of a fool do you take me for, Adora? Did you really think I wouldn't notice that something was amiss? Do you think leaving *her*—" she waved a hand at Catra, who flinched back at the gesture. Coach Weaver made no effort to hide the disdain in her voice "—in charge while you're off galavanting with this cast of variety show rejects constitutes 'handling your responsibilities'?"

Adora's mouth went dry. At last, her eyes met Catra's—the first time they'd made eye contact since the disastrous dance—and her heart sank. Catra trembled, subdued. She was her best friend, her… Adora's heart ached at the thought that Catra could have been so angry that she would betray her like this.

“I can do this, Coach,” Adora said, her voice quivering every so slightly.

“I disagree.”

“I mean it.” Adora stepped forward, her hands out, pleading. “I swear, if you just—”

“That’s not what I mean,” Coach Weaver spat. “I don’t care whether or not you can handle both — I care about your complete and total commitment to this squad. You will either quit Vocal Rebellion, or you will give me your ribbons.”

A collective gasp rose from the room. Adora clutched at the crimson V on the front of her uniform. “You’re going to take away the captaincy if I stay in glee?”

Again, Coach Weaver laughed. “No, Adora. I’m giving you an ultimatum: if you choose show choir over the Valkyries, then you’re off the squad entirely.”

Catra buckled where she stood. Her eyes turned to Adora, wide with disbelief, but Adora’s gaze remained locked on Coach Weaver. For a breathless moment, Adora looked as though she might cry.

And then her expression hardened. Her bright blue eyes narrowed into a savage glare.

“If that’s the way this is going to go, then fine,” she said. She reached up and yanked the ribbons from her ponytail, sending her long blonde hair tumbling over her shoulders. With a shaky breath in, Adora tossed the ribbons onto the floor between her and Coach Weaver. “I choose Vocal Rebellion.”

Again, the watching crowd gasped. Shocked whispers were hissed back and forth. Adora stood her ground as Coach Weaver recoiled.

“What in the world is going on here?” Mrs. Moon’s shrill shout cut through the tension. She stood in the still open doorway, watching the confrontation between Adora and Coach Weaver warily.

Coach Weaver drew herself up and turned to Catra.

“Pick those up.” She gestured to the discarded ribbons at Adora’s feet.

Catra hesitated. Her eyes flickered between the ribbons and Adora. Her hands shook.

“Now!” Coach Weaver snapped, loud enough to frighten Catra into obeying.

While Mrs. Moon chastised Coach Weaver for speaking so harshly to a student, Catra scurried forward. She scooped up the ribbons and held them gently against her heart, cradling them like an injured bird. She lifted her eyes, and Adora’s breath caught at the brokenness she saw in them.

“Adora?” Catra whispered, her voice cracking.

“I expect to see your uniforms returned to my office before classes tomorrow,” Coach Weaver said, fracturing the moment like a fist through glass. “Catra, come with me.”

For the second time, Catra hovered, uncertain of her next move. She couldn’t bring herself to look away from Adora. She was waiting for her to say something, anything, to make this all go away.

Adora squeezed her eyes shut so she wouldn’t have to see the hurt on her friend’s face.

“I’m sorry, Catra.”

She didn’t open them again until she heard the door slam shut.

When she looked again, Catra was gone.

Chapter 17

That afternoon, Adora did something she had never done before: she skipped class.

AP calc, history, biology, and even P.E. — she skipped every single one in favor of hiding under the bleachers behind the school. Later she would learn that Glimmer asked her mom to give her a free pass. Mrs. Moon had reluctantly agreed, if only because she'd witnessed the spectacle first-hand herself. Even a teacher understood the gravity of what transpired in that band room: the dethroning of a Valkyrie—especially the captain—was a huge deal.

Adora couldn't imagine going on with her day as if nothing had happened. She couldn't stomach the idea of facing her now-former squadmates in class. Even though Catra was the only one of them who knew she was out of the Valkyries, Adora knew how fast word spread in Stevenson High.

And then there was Catra. Just the thought of her made Adora want to put her head between her knees and take a few deep breaths. Every time she closed her eyes, she saw Catra's shattered expression; those wide mismatched eyes full of shock and hurt as they followed the ribbons from Adora's hand down to the floor between them. Thinking about Catra broke Adora's heart for so many reasons. She knew she had hurt her by choosing Vocal Rebellion over the Valkyries. But Catra had sold her out to Coach Weaver, and that hurt Adora too. She wasn't sure she could sit in the same classroom with her and act like everything was okay.

While she was alone under the bleachers, hiding behind the curtain of her own blonde hair, Adora cried. She clutched her backpack to her face like a pillow and let it swallow her sobs so no one would hear. Thankfully she'd gotten most of the tears out of her system by the time Glimmer and Bow slinked down into the grass beside her.

"Hey." Glimmer's hand touched Adora's shoulder softly. "How're you holding up?"

Adora replied with a long moan from within the tight ball she had curled herself into.

"I'm so sorry that happened to you, Adora," Bow said. He sounded so sincere Adora thought she might start to cry all over again. "Are you okay? How can we help?"

"I don't know," Adora replied. She lifted her head and rubbed her temples to soothe the headache blooming behind her eyes. "I don't even know what to do with myself right now. I mean, what am I if I'm not a Valkyrie? I've basically been on that squad since my first day at this school."

At her side, Adora felt Glimmer shift.

"Do you regret your decision?" Glimmer asked. "Because if you want to change your mind—"

"No." Adora shook her head resolutely. If it had ever been that simple, she would have been grovelling in Coach Weaver's office by now. "Don't get me wrong, I love being a Valkyrie, but..." She sighed and ran her fingers through her loose hair. "Until I joined Vocal Rebellion, I didn't realize what I was missing. Everyone is so nice, and not just to each others' faces. You don't have to worry about what you wear or who you talk to—"

"You don't have Coach Weaver yelling at you all the time, either," Glimmer cut in. Bow shot her a warning look, but Adora nodded.

"I didn't realize it doesn't have to be that way," she said.

They were quiet for a while. Both Glimmer and Bow slipped their arms around Adora, holding her in a gentle group hug. Adora leaned into the embrace and found herself feeling safe for the first time all day.

"I can't believe this is happening," she wailed. She could feel panic creeping back into the pit of her stomach. "What am I supposed to do now?"

Bow tipped his head. "What do you mean?"

"I don't know how to be at this school without being on the squad," Adora said, her voice rising. She gestured down at herself frantically. "I've worn this uniform almost every day since freshman year — I don't even know what I'm supposed to wear to school tomorrow!"

Glimmer and Bow glanced at one another.

"Why don't you wear your regular clothes?" Bow asked.

Adora blinked at him. "I don't have regular clothes, Bow!"

At this confession, Glimmer's mood brightened instantly. "In that case, this calls for a trip to the mall!"

"I can't do that," Adora said.

"Why not?" Glimmer replied. "You're already skipping class. And you said it yourself: you don't know who you are without the Valkyries. That makes this the perfect time to reinvent yourself, starting with a new wardrobe!"

"Glimmer, I can't afford a new wardrobe." Adora felt the heat of shame creeping up her neck. The Valkyrie uniform was the closest thing to a status symbol Adora had ever known. When she was in her reds, no one needed to know that she lived in a group home and didn't have a dime to her name.

But Glimmer was undeterred. She fished around in her backpack until she found her glittery purple wallet, and held it up like some hard-won prize. "Don't worry, I've got you covered. Well, my mom's credit card does." She slipped the plastic card from its sleeve and fanned herself with it. "Technically it's for emergencies, but I'm pretty sure this qualifies."

Adora waved her hands in protest. "No, Glimmer. I can't let you do that. I'm not some charity case."

"I never said you were," Glimmer said. She gave Adora a warm smile and laid her free hand on her arm. "Besides, it's not charity — it's a gift, and it's one I want to give. What's the point of having a little extra if you don't spread it around, right?" When Adora hesitated, Glimmer pressed on. "Please let me do this for you, Adora."

From the other side, Bow leaned in. "You know she's not going to let up until you say yes, right?"

"Yeah, I know," Adora sighed. "Okay, you win. But just a pair of jeans and a shirt or two. Nothing too crazy."

Glimmer jumped to her feet with a squeal of excitement. "No promises! Let's go!"

By the time Bow pulled into the mall parking lot, Adora could feel herself relax. She let Glimmer lead her from one store to the next while Bow trailed patiently along, a boba straw between his lips. Glimmer had been right not to make any promises: in every store they entered she shoved Adora into a fitting room to wait while she acted as her personal shopper, flitting from rack to rack, gathering clothes the way a bee collects pollen. Adora was more of a dress-up doll than a willing participant, but she had to admit Glimmer had good taste. Bow made the endless parade of outfits easier to handle by enthusiastically cheering for the winners and politely shutting down the losers.

It didn't take long for a single pair of jeans and a top or two to balloon into several shopping bags full of clothes. Adora couldn't bring herself to stand next to Glimmer while she paid for each purchase — she didn't want to know how much money her friend was spending on her. But Bow held her hand and Glimmer never stopped smiling, so all she had to do was say thank you.

Which she did. Many, many times over.

Eventually, Adora was able to convince Glimmer she was too hungry to keep shopping. Though she didn't have a lot of money at her disposal, she did have enough to treat her friends to dinner at the food court. They loaded up on burgers and fries, and shot the paper wrappers from their straws at each other until the mall security guard silenced their racous laughter with a stern warning look.

"So, how are you feeling now, Adora?" Bow asked as he wadded up the wrapper from his burger. The moment the guard looked away, he bounced it off of Glimmer's head. She retaliated by stealing the rest of his fries.

Adora let out a snort of laughter. "A lot better. Thank you so much for doing this for me, you guys."

"You're welcome," Glimmer said, beaming around a mouthful of Bow's pilfered fries. It was as gross as it was funny, which made them dissolve into giggles all over again.

They kicked around the mall as long as they could, putting off the inevitable until Bow's dads called to ask when he was coming home. Despite the armfuls of shopping bags that weighed her down, Adora felt lighter than she had all day when she got out of the car in front of the group home. She attempted to wave at Glimmer and Bow as they pulled away, but the bags made it awkward and that made them all laugh again. She was still trying to catch her breath when she kicked the front door closed behind her and waddled down the hall to her room. It took some maneuvering, but she managed to turn the handle and booted her door open wide with her toe.

It wasn't until she shuffled over to her bed to put everything down that she realized she wasn't alone. Something on the mattress shifted, and Adora jumped back with a yelp just as the bedside lamp snapped on. There, still in her disheveled reds and her hair a mess, was Catra.

"Where have you been?" Catra asked. Her voice was hoarse, and Adora wondered if that meant she'd been crying. For a split second, Adora felt bad for her. The sight of Catra's long legs tucked under her and the skirt of her uniform hiked up her hips, was almost distracting enough for Adora to forget how upset she'd been only a handful of hours ago. Then Catra's eyes dropped to the shopping bags and her expression hardened. "What are those?"

That was all it took for Adora to remember what Catra had done. She glowered down at her before turning on her heel to put everything down on her desk instead. "I have to turn in my reds tomorrow, remember? I needed something else to wear, so I went shopping." She was disgusted by how cold the words sounded as they fell from her lips.

"You're joking, right?" Catra sounded so incredulous that Adora couldn't help herself from looking back at her over her shoulder. "You're not actually leaving the squad."

Adora scoffed bitterly. "You make it sound like I was given a choice."

Catra shook her head as she slid off the bed. In a few quick strides she was across the room and at Adora's side, staring imploringly up at her as she reached for her hand. "Come on, Adora. You know Coach Weaver didn't—"

Without thinking, Adora pulled her hand back. Catra recoiled as if she'd been struck.

"Why did you do it, Catra?" Adora snapped.

"Why did I do what?"

"Why did you rat me out to Coach Weaver? I know you were mad at me for hanging out with Glimmer and Bow, but I never thought you would do something so low."

"Are you kidding me?" Catra's eyes were wide with anger now. "I didn't tell Coach Weaver shit! DT's the one who let it slip."

Adora was taken aback. She thought back to DT, first at homecoming and then in the hallway that morning as she was making plans with Glimmer and Bow. Of course they'd heard everything, and of course they'd been the one to tell Coach Weaver — creating chaos was DT's specialty.

"You know DT," Catra said, her voice cutting into Adora's thoughts. "They're a shit disturber by nature."

"Right," Adora replied absently. She forced herself to focus — to look Catra in the eyes. When she did, she found her friend staring back at her cooly.

"I can't believe you thought I would do that," Catra hissed, crossing her arms like a barrier between them.

"Well, what was I supposed to think?" Adora retaliated, the volume of her voice rising with her temper. "You got mad at me at the dance and stormed off, and then you didn't talk to me all weekend."

Catra bristled, her eyes flashing. "I'm your best friend, Adora! You're supposed to know I wouldn't do something like that to you, no matter how pissed off I was!"

This hit Adora like a wave of relief. She hadn't wanted to believe that Catra—her Catra—would be capable of hurting her that way.

"You're right," she said, softening her voice. She reached her hands forward like an invitation and gave Catra a hopeful smile. "I never should have doubted you. I'm sorry Catra."

For a moment, Catra didn't speak. She eyed Adora's hands warily, as if decided whether to accept the apology. Slowly, she unraveled her arms and reached out, pausing just as her fingertips brushed against Adora's palms. Then, without warning, she launched herself forward, closing the space between them and wrapping

Adora in a strong embrace around the waist. The gesture was so unexpected that it took Adora's breath away, even as she pulled her own arms around Catra's shoulders and held on tight.

They stood locked in each others' arms for a long time. Adora breathed in Catra's familiar scent as her friend's purring rattled around her heart. This had been what Adora was worried about the most — what would become of her and Catra now that she was off the Valkyries? But now, for the first time since relinquishing her ribbons, Adora felt like everything was going to be okay.

She closed her eyes and savored the way her body fit against Catra's. They were as close as Adora had wanted to be when they danced at homecoming, and this almost felt like a second chance. Catra pulled back slightly and rested her cheek against Adora's. She was so soft and warm, her contented purr still vibrating in Adora's ear. Adora's heart tripped over itself as Catra turned so that her lips hovered only a breath from her jawline. This wasn't at all how Adora thought this day was going to end, but she wasn't about to complain. She just hoped her thunderous heartbeat wasn't giving away just how badly she wanted this.

"I'll come with you tomorrow," Catra whispered. Her lips brushed so close, sending a thrill racing across Adora's skin. "First thing. We'll go to Coach Weaver and apologize and everything will go back to normal."

Adora nuzzled in closer and sighed. She gave herself permission to smooth her palms down Catra's back, moving slowly so she could commit every dip and expanse of her muscles to memory.

"You know that won't make a difference to Coach Weaver. Saying sorry won't change her mind about letting me stay in glee club."

All of Catra's softness turned to stone in an instant. She yanked herself back from their embrace so quickly that Adora was left fumbling after her.

"Who said anything about glee club?" Catra asked, her brows knitting together. "We're talking about getting you back on the squad."

"Well, yeah." Adora frowned. "But I'm not going to quit Vocal Rebellion to do that."

For the second time that day, Adora watched Catra's face fall. But her friend's surprise quickly gave way to anger. Growling through gritted teeth, Catra shoved Adora away.

"What is the matter with you?" Catra shouted. That she was furious was clear, but something in her voice hinted at a desperation Adora wasn't used to seeing from her. "You've busted your ass for the last two years to make Cheer Force Captain and now you're just going to throw it all away for... for some show choir?"

"I like being part of Vocal Rebellion, Catra." Adora clutched her hands into fists at her sides. "It's fun and I'm making friends. Everyone is so supportive and there's no Coach Weaver there to make my life miserable every time I make a mistake. It's... it's nice."

With every word Adora said, Catra shrunk further away from her. A nasty snarl curled across the lips that, only moments earlier, had been making Adora weak at the knees.

"And what about our perfect year, huh?" Though her expression was still steely, Catra's voice shook with a threat of tears. "We've been planning this year since we started. You don't get more popular than we are right now — we can do whatever we want! This is everything we've ever wanted!"

"Well maybe it's not what I want anymore!"

Catra looked at Adora like she was a stranger. "Then what do you want, Adora?"

Her words were icy, and sounded more like a threat than a question.

Adora licked her lips and chose her next words carefully. "I want to be happy, Catra. I want to have fun with my friends without having to stress about who I can and can't talk to, or worrying about getting screamed at because my best is never good enough." There was something so cathartic about finally saying all these things out loud. It was the first time Adora had acknowledged this darker side of being a Valkyrie, and it felt like taking back power she hadn't even realized she was missing. Emboldened, she took a step toward Catra. "C'mon, Catra. You know the way Coach Weaver treats us isn't okay. What she did to us in the band room today wasn't right."

For a moment, Catra's resolve faltered. She wrapped her arms around herself in the way she always did when she didn't feel safe. Adora saw her chance, and she reached for her again.

"You don't have to let her treat you like that anymore," Adora said as she placed her hand to Catra's cheek. Catra closed her eyes and sank into the touch. "Come with me, Catra. We can still spend the year on the same team and have a perfect year, just like we planned."

Catra's eyes snapped open. She jerked away again. "No, Adora! Don't you get it? I like being a Valkyrie! I like being treated like I'm special — like I'm more than just some loser orphan kid that nobody wanted. You're not the only one who had to work hard to make it this far. Coach Weaver didn't even want me on the squad in the first place, remember?"

Adora winced. "But you always said you didn't care about things like that."

"Well I was lying, obviously!" Now Catra was crying. Hot, angry tears streaked down her face as she shook. She batted them away and scowled.

A knock came at the door; two gentle raps followed by their house mother's voice. "Adora? Catra? Is everything okay in there?"

The girls stared each other down. Adora caved first and tried to take Catra's hand.

"Please, Catra. I don't want to fight with you. But I can't go back, not—"

Catra didn't give her a chance to finish before swatting her hand away. "If you want to leave, then fine." She stormed to the door and wrenched it open, startling their house mother. Pausing at the threshold, Catra threw back one last dirty look.

"Bye, Adora." Her voice hovered somewhere between bitterness and despair. "I really am going to miss you."

Chapter 18

Despite only getting a couple hours of sleep, Adora was out the door the next morning before anyone else in the house woke up. She clutched her Valkyries gear—two uniforms tucked neatly into garment bags and a duffle crammed with her shoes, poms, and other accessories—and power-walked the handful of blocks to the school. All she wanted was to get this over with as quickly as possible, preferably before anyone saw her.

Glimmer and Bow met her at the front doors, coffee cups in hand. They looked as exhausted as Adora felt, and she felt guilty for not being firmer when she insisted they didn't have to be there for this. But when Bow handed Adora a cup of her own and Glimmer looped their arms together, she was immediately glad they were there.

"You got this, Adora," Glimmer whispered, giving her arm a squeeze.

"We're going to be right beside you every step of the way," Bow added with a warm smile.

Adora felt stupid for being so anxious about facing Coach Weaver. After all, she was just dropping off her uniforms — she didn't even need to talk to her if she didn't want to. But Coach Weaver had been a dominating presence in her life since freshman year. At first, Adora had been frightened of her, what with her ruthlessness and unreasonably high expectations. But eventually she'd come to respect Coach Weaver. Despite her questionable leadership skills, you couldn't deny that Coach Weaver got results. Besides, being the best had a way of dulling the sting of suffering.

Or, at least it had. Now, as Adora looked back on her time with the Valkyries, she felt as though she'd been brainwashed. How could she have ever believed that the culture of torturous workout regimens, relentless practice schedules, and the demeaning negative reinforcement that constituted Coach Weaver's recipe for

success was anything other than toxic? With Vocal Rebellion providing her with some much needed perspective, Adora found herself increasingly grateful to have been kicked off the squad.

Still, Adora knew she wasn't out of the woods yet. Her guts churned at the thought of disappointing Coach Weaver. With every step she took, she reminded herself of what Glimmer had told her the night before as they wandered the mall: *you don't owe her anything*.

The halls were mercifully empty as the three of them hurried toward Coach Weaver's office. When they reached the door, Adora's stomach dropped when she saw it part way open. She glanced at Glimmer and Bow, who both gave her encouraging nods.

She took a deep breath, lifted her chin, and reached out to knock on the door frame.

"Adora." Coach Weaver's voice drifted from inside the office before Adora's knuckles had the chance to strike. "Come in."

Adora pushed the door open a bit further. Coach Weaver sat behind her desk, the surface of which was adorned with neatly arranged trophies and awards. More sat on shelves that lined the walls, interspersed with photos of Valkyrie squads throughout the years. From behind her steepled fingers, Coach Weaver stared Adora down cooly.

"Have a seat."

"I'm just here to drop off my reds," Adora said, thrusting her uniforms forward. Her eyes searched for a place to drop them so she could get the hell out of there.

"Did I stutter?" Coach Weaver's tone had a mocking lilt to it. "I said sit."

Without thinking, Adora did as she was told and dropped into an empty chair.

Coach Weaver lifted her head and looked over Adora's shoulder. "You two — close the door behind you."

Adora glanced back to find Glimmer and Bow hovering in the doorway, their faces tight with uncertainty. "It's okay, you guys. I'll be out in a minute."

"Okay," Glimmer said, sounding skeptical as she backed slowly into the hallway. "We'll be right outside the door if you need us."

Coach Weaver reclined in her chair. "Your thinly veiled distrust is duly noted. Now get out of my office — I've heard chronic underachievement is contagious."

Glimmer and Bow's eyes widened, but they knew better than to pick a fight with school faculty. They hustled out of the room with matching scowls and slammed the door behind them.

For a few uncomfortable moments, neither Adora or Coach Weaver spoke. Adora recognized the power move — Coach Weaver liked to let heavy silences linger just to watch a person squirm. She was determined not to be the first to speak, but with every minute that dragged on, Adora could swear the air in the room grew thinner.

Much to her private shame, she caved at minute five.

"I don't want to take any more of your time," she said, averting her eyes to the uniforms still draped over her forearms. "I'll just leave these here—"

"That's it then, is it?" Coach Weaver tipped her head as she pinned Adora under her icy glare. "You're really choosing to walk away after everything this squad has done for you?"

Guilt burned in the pit of Adora's gut and rose up her throat like bile. She swallowed it down in an effort to maintain her composure and recited the words she had practiced in the mirror that morning. "Thank you for the opportunity. I'm grateful for the experience—"

“Oh, please,” Coach Weaver snapped. She slapped her palms into the polished wood of the desk as she leaned menacingly over it. “Don’t spout that drivel at me.”

Adora pressed her lips into a tight line.

Again, Coach Weaver sat back. “Come now, Adora. We both know this isn’t what you really want.” Her hand dipped out of sight into one of her desk drawers, only to reappear with the Captain’s ribbons twisted around her long fingers. “*This* is what you’ve spent the last two years striving for. Think of the prestige — the power you’re giving up. You’re the best Cheer Force Captain this squad has ever seen. Imagine what we’ll be able to accomplish together.”

Manipulation was one of Coach Weaver’s greatest strengths. Adora knew this — she’d watched her use it against every member of the Valkyries—herself included—more times than she could count. Still, a hint of longing fluttered inside of her as she gazed at the Captain’s ribbons, and she had to shake her head just to get the thought out of her mind. She jumped to her feet, unwilling to let Coach Weaver pull her back under her spell.

“I’m happy with my decision,” Adora said. She dropped her uniforms and duffle bag onto the chair she’d just been sitting on. “Thanks anyway, though.”

She whirled around and hurried for the door. It wasn’t until her fingers grazed the handle that Coach Weaver said another word.

“This is your last chance, Adora. If you walk out that door, you will never wear a Valkyrie uniform again. Do you understand?”

Adora swallowed. Something about hearing those words out loud made her head spin. But then she heard the sound of Glimmer’s and Bow’s talking in the hall, and though she couldn’t make out what they were saying, their muffled voices were somehow loud enough to drown out her doubt.

“I understand perfectly,” she replied. Without sparing her former coach a final glance, Adora wrenched the door open only to find herself face to face with Catra.

The girls froze mid-motion. Catra’s hand was outstretched, like she had been reaching for the door just as Adora yanked it open. Her eyes were wide with surprise. Over Catra’s shoulders, Adora could see Glimmer and Bow grimacing and mouthing words of apology back at her.

“Catra,” Coach Weaver hissed, snapping both Adora and Catra back into the moment. “Get in here at once.”

Immediately, Catra’s expression hardened. Adora started to step aside, but Catra didn’t wait, shoving bodily past her. Adora stumbled into the hallway.

“Close the door.” Adora heard Shadow Weaver bark. She looked back just in time to see Catra’s glare disappear behind the door as it slammed shut.

“We’re so sorry, Adora,” Bow said as he and Glimmer rushed to her side. “We tried to distract her so that wouldn’t happen, but—”

“It’s fine,” Adora sighed. She glanced back at the office door. Even though it was faint, she could tell by the cadence of Coach Weaver’s voice that she was already giving Catra shit for something. Part of her wanted to bust down the door and come to her friend’s defence, but she knew better now.

Catra didn’t want her — not like this. She was just going to have to learn how to be okay with that.

Warmth crushed in around her as Glimmer and Bow enveloped her in a tight hug.

“Come on,” Glimmer said. “Let’s get out of here.”

Chapter 19

It wasn't that Adora didn't know Stevenson High had a clearly defined caste system, she just wasn't used to being on the bottom of it.

After two years of being surrounded by only the coolest people in school, she was completely unprepared for life on the other side of the social divide. She was used to being the center of attention — to being someone everyone else looked up to and admired. But from the moment she took to the halls without the Valkyries uniform to protect her, Adora was a nobody just like everyone else.

The normal, everyday clothes Glimmer bought may as well have been comoflogue for how invisible Adora felt in the days that followed her fall from grace. It was weird to walk into classrooms and not be met with half a dozen waves and hellos. The crowds didn't part when she walked down the halls anymore. Now she was one of the people expected to jump out of the way whenever one of the cool kids needed to get by. It all made Adora feel like a tourist in a foreign land, and the culture shock hit her hard.

Of course, she wasn't completely anonymous, and unfortunately the attention she did get was way worse than being ignored altogether.

Valkyries don't fall in a vacuum. When word got out that the Cheer Force Captain voluntarily surrendered her ribbons so she could join the glee club, that tea managed to flood every corner of the school before the lunch bell rang. On that first day, Adora felt like a pariah. She sulked between Glimmer and Bow as she walked the halls, avoiding the stunned stares and not-so-subtle whispers of her peers. For days she heard people—some of whom she'd never even met before—snickering and making jokes at her expense.

But nothing stung quite as badly as the first time she ran into her former squad.

It was only a couple of days after she turned in her reds. For the most part, Adora had only seen the Valkyries from a distance — strutting through the halls like they owned the place or laughing loudly from their exclusive table in the cafeteria. Even in the classes she shared with them, Adora didn't bother trying to strike up a conversation. After all, as long as there were other people around, she knew they wouldn't give her the time of day. That was how the unwritten rules of popularity worked, after all.

On that particular morning, Adora and Glimmer made a pit stop at the washroom before homeroom. They were in the middle of strategizing for Vocal Rebellion's upcoming run to regionals as Adora bumped the door open with her shoulder.

"That's a good idea. I was also thinking we could tighten up the choreography in the—"

Adora stopped short, freezing in the vestibule of the narrow room. Glimmer wasn't paying attention and ran right into her.

"What the heck, Adora?" Glimmer said squeezing around her immobile friend with a huff. It was then, without Adora in the way, that Glimmer saw them: Scorpia and Lonnie, standing at the mirrors and gazing back at them with matching startled expressions. It looked as though they'd caught them mid-gossip session; Scorpia's mouth hung open while Lonnie cut an awkward glance in Adora's direction.

Surprise quickly gave way to optimism, and Adora couldn't help but smile. The truth was, as much as she loved Glimmer and Bow, she still missed her old friends and the sense of familiarity that came with them.

"Hey, guys," she said, stepping toward them with a hopeful spring in her step. "How's it going?"

But the pair of Valkyries didn't share her enthusiasm. Scorpia at least had the decency to look conflicted, shifting her weight from one foot to the next with obvious unease. Her mouth worked wordlessly, like there was something she wanted to say, but couldn't. She settled for giving Adora a sheepish smile before glancing away.

Lonnie's eyebrows lifted with thinly veiled disdain. "Sorry, Adora. You're gonna have to find a different washroom."

Blinking with disbelief, Adora did a double-take. "Wait, what?"

"Hey! You can't kick us out of here!" Glimmer snarled between clenched teeth. She looked ready for a fight, with her hands balled into fists in front of her.

"Uh, yes we can," Lonnie replied. She crossed her arms in front of her and lifted her chin defiantly. "You know how this works."

Glimmer made to lunge forward, only to be stopped by Adora's gentle hand on her shoulder.

"Are you serious?" Adora looked from Lonnie to Scorpia, who was resolutely avoiding her gaze by staring up at the ceiling. "You guys... we're *friends*. You're not really going to shut me out just because I'm not a Valkyrie anymore, are you?"

Lonnie answered with a dismissive shrug. "Like I said, you know the rules."

A dry lump formed in Adora's throat. Yes, she did know the rules. How many times had she stood by, complacent, as Octavia kicked scared freshmen out of washrooms and out of seats just because she could? This was how the social hierarchy worked at Stevenson High — she didn't get to call the shots anymore, she just had to follow them.

Swallowing hard, Adora turned away. "Come on, Glimmer. Let's get out of here."

Glimmer balked. "But—"

Adora took her by the arm and pulled her out the door before she could protest further. In the hallway, Bow leaned against the wall, waiting for them.

"Are you two okay?" he asked when he saw the tense expressions on their faces. Adora trudged along beside them while Glimmer filled him in on what happened.

"Oh, Adora," Bow said. "I'm really sorry. That's awful."

"It's bullshit, that's what it is," Glimmer fumed. "I can't believe people have been so quick to turn on you just because you're not a cheerleader anymore!"

But Adora just shook her head. "No, Lonnie's right — this is how it works. I knew that when I left the Valkyries. I guess I just..." She trailed off.

"You thought your friends would still be your friends," Bow finished.

"For what it's worth," Glimmer said, taking Adora's hand, "anyone who gives up on you that easily was never your friend to begin with. You'll never have to worry about that with us. Right, Bow?"

"Right!"

Adora smiled for their benefit. "Thanks, guys."

She knew they were just trying to help — hell, for all she knew, Glimmer was right. But if she was, that almost hurt more than getting shut out by her old squad in the first place.

By the end of the following week, Adora found she was settling into her new place in the social pecking order. Sure, she still felt uncomfortable and out of place in her new clothes. She missed the sense of purpose and identity that her old uniform afforded her, but at least she wasn't cold all the time anymore. Plus,

without the pressures of her captaincy or having to juggle two extra curriculars at once, she was finally able to relax a little (Just a *little*, of course. Relaxation had never been something that came naturally to Adora). All she had to worry about now was keeping her grades up and helping Vocal Rebellion get ready for regionals.

Still, Glimmer's words were never far from Adora's mind. This was especially true on days like today, as she sat in the cafeteria at lunch, stealing glances at her old table. Catra perched on the surface, holding court over the rest of the Valkyries with an air of superiority Adora could feel from across the room. Adora's stomach turned as she watched Scorpia moon over Catra, hanging over every velvety word that slipped from that fanged mouth of hers. Her guts clenched tighter at the sight of DT, their chin resting daintily atop their fingers as they tittered over something Catra said. Adora could only imagine how pleased they were with the chaos they'd caused.

Adora's eyes flicked back to Catra's face, and her heart ached. She'd be lying if she said she didn't miss her. In truth, she missed her every moment of every day. And as she watched Catra now, in the same room and yet worlds apart, Adora hoped Glimmer was wrong. As much as the fracture between them hurt, Adora refused to believe their friendship hadn't been real.

A flash of movement out of the corner of her eye caught Adora's attention. She looked up to see Kyle weaving between the tables, rushing toward the rest of the Valkyries. When he reached them, he said something to Catra, his words lost amid the din of the cafeteria. Adora watched Catra frown and roll her eyes. Gracefully, Catra jumped down from the table and stalked off toward the door. Adora knew Catra well enough to recognize the hint of distress in her body language — the way she pretended to be annoyed, but the downward tilt of her ears and tightness in her shoulders betrayed a vulnerability she was trying so desperately to hide.

Adora couldn't help but hope she was okay.

*

Catra paused outside of Coach Weaver's office door and collected herself. Like putting on a mask, she smoothed her face into an expression of bored indifference. She stood up straight and fluffed her ponytail. Then she knocked.

"You wanted to see me, Coach Weaver?" she asked, poking her head inside.

Coach Weaver was seated behind her desk. Her eyes were trained on her screen of her computer, watching footage from one of the Valkyries' latest practices. She clicked her tongue and shook her head.

"Absolutely embarrassing," she tutted at the screen. Then, without looking up, she gestured for Catra to enter. "Close the door behind you."

Catra did as she was told. Wordlessly, she threw herself down in the chair that sat opposite of Coach Weaver's desk and crossed her arms. For another couple of minutes, Coach Weaver ignored her in favor of finishing the video, only breaking her silence to hiss or sigh when she spotted something about the squad's performance that displeased her.

Only when the video ended did she turn her attention to Catra. Coach Weaver pressed the tips of her fingers together and leaned her elbows on her desk. "It's been nearly two weeks. When can we expect Adora to return to the Valkyries? Surely her foray into mediocrity has shown her just how much better off she was as one of us."

Groaning, Catra tipped her head back in frustration. "You've got to let this go. Adora isn't coming back."

"Did you speak with her like I told you to?"

"Yeah," Catra lied. "And like I said, she's not interested. She made her choice."

The truth was, Catra and Adora hadn't spoken to each other since that final argument in Adora's room. In fact, since their encounter outside of Coach Weaver's office, they'd each gone out of their way to avoid one another at all costs. The last thing Catra wanted to do was go crawling back to Adora and beg her to reconsider the way Coach Weaver expected her to.

Coach Weaver pinned Catra under her inscrutable gaze and let the silence between them linger until Catra squirmed with discomfort.

"What?" Catra snapped, feeling her cheeks flush.

"Oh, nothing," Coach Weaver teased as she sat back in her seat. "It's a little surprising to learn that your relationship wasn't as strong as I originally thought. Then again, Adora *did* choose to leave you behind, so I suppose I should have expected this."

Catra's breath caught in her throat. Coach Weaver may as well have reached over the desk and slapped her across the face. In the back of her mind, Catra knew she was just trying to manipulate her — that Coach Weaver knew Adora's absence had left a gaping wound in Catra's spirit, and she wasn't above using it to her advantage. The problem was, digging into that wound had the desired effect, and Catra was powerless against the pain it caused. Hurt and ashamed, Catra shrank back and wrapped her arms around herself for comfort.

"No matter," Coach Weaver continued. She reached behind her desk and pulled open one of the drawers. "We'll just have to try a different approach, won't we?"

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As soon as classes ended that day, Adora hurried to change into her gym clothes. She was the first to arrive in the band room and was already well into stretching when the rest of Vocal Rebellion started trickling in.

"Is this really necessary?" Entrapta asked, looking down at her own gym clothes-clad body with the same discomfort that Adora

felt in her regular wardrobe. "I've spent my entire high school career avoiding physical education class for a reason, you know."

"Yeah, and I'm still not sure how you've managed to pull that off, to be honest," Bow said, tossing his backpack onto an empty chair.

Glimmer stepped into the middle of the room and put her hands on her hips. "Listen, I know not all of us are big on working out, but I think Adora's onto something. And now that we finally have enough people to qualify for regionals, I think we should give ourselves every chance for success. Don't you?"

"Right!" Adora chirped, jumping to her feet. "Cardio is a great way to improve your stamina. If we practice singing while running, we won't end up getting winded half-way through our performances."

Mermista groaned from where she stood leaning against the wall. "I guess that makes sense."

"Of course it does." Glimmer grinned, her eyes sparkling. "Now stretch it out, Rebels — we roll out in five!"

Exactly five minutes later, Adora led the glee club out of the school and into the back field to train. She brought them into the bleachers, and paused at the steps while her friends gathered around her.

"This is an exercise I learned in cheer," she explained, gesturing up the stairs. "We're going to do a few laps of running up and down the steps in a single file. Once we build up a bit of stamina, we'll move onto singing while we run. It's great for your cardiovascular health!"

Her friends exchanged uneasy glances. No one aside from Adora seemed particularly excited about the idea, but Bow cleared his throat and smiled.

"If you say it'll help, I'm in," he said, flashing a supportive thumbs-up.

"I suppose tending to one's physical health *is* a form of self-care," Perfuma ventured helpfully, though judging by the furrow in her brow as she gazed up the long flight of steps, it seemed she was trying to convince herself as much as everyone else.

"Exactly!" Adora pumped her fist. "Everybody ready? Let's do this!"

Without waiting for a response, Adora charged up the steps. Soon the bleachers echoed with the sound of their footsteps and the huffing of their breath. When she descended, Adora observed everyone else's form.

"Don't forget to lift your knees," she called over her shoulder. Her chipper encouragement was met by a corus of groans.

"Hey, Adora," drawled a familiar voice.

Adora stopped so suddenly that the result was like a train derailment behind her. First, Bow collided with her back, followed by Glimmer crashing into his and so on until the entirety of Vocal Rebellion was heaped on the steps in a sweaty, gasping mass. Laughter wafted up from the field below, where the Valkyries stood like an imposing crimson army.

"Wow," Catra snarked from the center of the squad. "If this isn't the saddest thing I've ever seen, I don't know what is."

Adora flinched. Embarrassment mixed with anger and manifested as a hot blush across her cheeks. "Do you mind? We're a little busy here."

Catra tossed her head back and laughed that squeaky laugh of hers. "Oh, Adora. That's cute. And, yes, we do mind actually. You're in our spot."

"Ugh, not this again," Glimmer huffed, still out of breath. "You can't just push us around because you're Valkyries."

"I'm sorry, are you new?" Catra raised an eyebrow.
"That's *exactly* why we can push you around. Well, that and..." She shrugged and gestured vaguely in their direction. From over her shoulder, DT pretended to cough.

"Glee club," they muttered between coughs, earning a fresh rounding of laughter from the squad.

"Come on, Catra," Adora said. She took another step, bringing her closer to the girl who was once her entire world. "There's plenty of space for both of us."

Smirking, Catra followed Adora's lead. She stepped up until only a single stair separated them from one another. Catra was short enough to begin with, but even being a step lower, she still exuded the confidence of someone twice her size. She stared Adora down with unshakable poise.

"Here's the thing," Catra said, her dual-colored eyes boring into Adora's. "I'm the boss of this squad now, which means I get to decide where and how we practice."

Adora blinked. "Wait. You're the—" Her eyes snapped up to Catra's ponytail. There, resting atop her voluminous mane, sat the Captain's ribbons. "Coach Weaver made you Captain?"

A quick burst of anger flashed across Catra's features before she caught herself. Squaring her shoulders, Catra sneered. "Don't sound so surprised."

"I'm not, I just—" Adora wasn't sure what to say. She wasn't even sure how she felt.

"Like I was saying," Catra continued with a toss of her hair. "I call the shots now. Today we're using the bleachers to train, and we need a—" she paused to drag her gaze along the jumbled line that was Vocal Rebellion "—distraction-free space so we can focus."

"That's not fair!" Glimmer cut in with a stomp of her foot.

"Sorry, Sparkles," Catra replied. "You know the rules. Come back when your little song and dance club earns a national championship, and maybe then we'll talk."

Adora narrowed her eyes darkly. "Let it go, Glimmer. This isn't worth it." Glimmer opened her mouth to protest, but Adora cut her off with a shake of her head. "C'mon, guys. Let's get out of here."

She watched as the rest of Vocal Rebellion trampled down the stairs. Cutting Catra one last glare, she tried to shove past her, only to be jerked to a stop by a hand on her arm. Catra's fingers curled around her upper arm and held her in place, though she continued to stare straight ahead.

"I hope it was worth it," Catra whispered.

Scowling, Adora yanked her arm from Catra's grip. "Whatever, Catra. Congrats on making Captain. You and Coach Weaver deserve each other."

Adora surged down the rest of the stairs before Catra could respond and stormed by her former squad without so much as a glance back. If there had been any lingering doubt about her decision to leave the Valkyries, it was completely gone now. She kept her gaze focused ahead to where Glimmer and Bow stood a few yards down the field waiting for her.

"Are you okay?" Bow asked in a hushed voice.

Drawing herself up tall, Adora gave her friends a wide smile.

"Totally, Now, come on — we've got a regional championship to get ready for."

Chapter 20

For the first time since the club's inception, Vocal Rebellion was performing at sectionals. Up until this year, Stevenson High's glee club always fell short of having enough members to officially qualify for any legitimate competitions. But the new roster sat at twelve students—the bare minimum needed—and that changed *everything*.

"This performance needs to be flawless," Glimmer said during rehearsal. She was pacing back and forth across the band room floor, her expression tight and focused. Sectionals were only a week away, and her nerves were starting to show. "We'll be the only team there who hasn't competed before, so we're the underdogs by default."

"Which isn't necessarily a bad thing," Bow reminded her. "We can lure them into a false sense of security, and then blow them away. Right, Adora?"

Adora let out a weak laugh. "Yeah, exactly."

He had deferred to her because the strategy had been her idea in the first place. In fact, almost everything about their routine for sectionals had been Adora's doing and, at least in theory, she had covered all her bases. Adora spent countless hours watching videos of winning show choir performances from around the world and taking meticulous notes about what she saw. From this, she devised a set list — a carefully curated act of three separate performances that perfectly balanced songs that would best showcase the team's vocal talents while also energizing the crowd. She even came up with the idea to build the setlist around a theme, which was how they wound up with an entire routine built around songs about fighting and perseverance: the perfect way to introduce Vocal Rebellion to the world.

After that miserable confrontation with Catra and the Valkyries on the bleachers, Adora welcomed the challenge — after all,

developing winning strategies was kind of her specialty. She was glad that preparations left little room in her life for anything else. Adora didn't want to think about being shut-out by the people she once considered her friends, and she definitely didn't want to dwell on the drama festering between her and Catra.

While Bow worked on the vocal arrangements and Glimmer, Mermista, and Sea Hawk dedicated themselves to cultivating the perfect wardrobe for the team, Adora developed their choreography. She put her years of cheer to good use and trained the team until they moved in perfect synchronicity. She taught them how to add energy to their moves so that even the most basic steps looked impressive, and she always reminded them to smile. When Perfuma mentioned she had a friend in the school band who could help them with their musical arrangement, Adora inserted herself into that process too. It didn't matter that she didn't have any experience writing music or playing instruments — she still spent long nights going back and forth with them until Vocal Rebellion had a perfect score to perform to.

Yes, thanks to Adora's obsessive attention to detail and championship experience, Vocal Rebellion looked and sounded better than they ever had. They were totally ready for their first sectionals competition, save for one tiny detail.

"Don't worry, Adora," Glimmer said, giving her the most reassuring smile she could. "I know you'll remember the words when it really matters."

Groaning, Adora dropped her head into her hands to hide her burning humiliation.

Vocal Rebellion's big finishing number had been Adora's favorite part of the whole performance. It had taken some creative tweaking to match the tempos, but by leveraging the distinctive use of electric guitar in both songs, Adora had created an amazing mash-up of Survivor's "Eye of the Tiger" and Pat Benetar's "Hit Me With Your Best Shot". Sure, they were old songs, but if her plethora of research had taught her anything it was that the best

show choir performances drew on a nostalgia factor to win over audiences. She and Bow had worked it out so that the performance would look like an on-stage song battle; a sing-off between two rival gangs. Sea Hawk would be leading "Eye Of The Tiger", but it had been Glimmer's idea to let Adora lead "Hit Me With Your Best Shot". At first, Adora resisted — she was a decent singer, but she had nothing on Mermista or Netossa, both of whom would be soloing throughout the routine. Besides, as much as Adora was looking forward to the performance, she wasn't looking to be center stage. But Glimmer had insisted, claiming Adora had earned it after all the work she'd put in.

Unfortunately for all of them, it didn't seem to matter how hard Adora tried — she kept screwing up the lyrics. Sometimes she subbed in the wrong word, other times she forgot a line entirely. It was the very thing that Catra used to tease her about, and that made it even worse.

"I appreciate your faith in me, Glimmer," Adora mumbled from behind her hands. "But maybe we should just cut our losses and give the solo to someone else. It's like you said: this performance needs to be flawless, and—"

"And it will be," Glimmer cut her off, beaming brightly. "It's just pre-show jitters. We all know you've got this, right?" She directed the question to the rest of the team, who replied with an encouraging round of applause that made Adora want to melt into a puddle just to escape her embarrassment.

"Thanks guys," she said weakly, forcing a smile. "I sure hope you're right."

*

Adora was already awake when Glimmer's alarm clock went off that Saturday morning. While Glimmer slept peacefully on one side of her queen-sized bed, Adora—who had been staying over as much as they could get away with now that she and Catra were avoiding each other—Adora laid awake, staring at the ceiling

and going over the lyrics of her solo. In the privacy of her own mind, she had the song locked down. She knew every word and every note. Why she always choked in front of everyone else was still a very frustrating mystery. But as the gentle chimes of Glimmer's alarm filled the room, Adora had to accept that she was out of time. All she could do now was hope that Glimmer was right when she very confidently proclaimed that, once they were on stage, the energy of the performance would take over and everything would be fine.

The girls got ready in a flurry, triple checking their bags and costumes as they did their make-up and swallowed as much breakfast as their nervous stomachs would allow. Bow arrived part-way through the chaos, bringing a much-needed calming presence to the scene. When the time came, Bow climbed into the back seat of Mrs. Moon's car beside Adora and Frosta, who was coming to watch the show.

"Seat belts, everyone!" Mrs. Moon sang, checking on her passengers through the rearview mirror. "Is everyone ready?"

"Yeah!" Frosta shouted, pumping her fists into the air as Bow buckled her in. "This is gonna be awesome!"

Adora clutched her thighs and stared out the window, mentally begging her meager breakfast to stay put.

"Hey."

She glanced back to see Glimmer twisted around in her seat. "Relax — you're going to be great."

"Yeah," Bow agreed, reaching around Frosta to give Adora's shoulder a playful shove. "Let's go have some fun."

Taking a deep breath, Adora smiled. "You're right. Let's do this."

Sectionals were taking place at a middle school on the other side of the city. Mrs. Moon let the kids off at the front doors before

parking the car. Adora, Glimmer, Bow, and Frosta loitered at the entrance, flagging down their teammates as they arrived.

"Oh, wow," Perfuma breathed after giving everyone a tight greeting hug. Her dark eyes scanned the busy lobby with surprise. "There are so many people here already."

Adora looked around. There were definitely a lot of people—certainly more than she expected for a show choir competition—but she hadn't really noticed. She was used to performing in front of huge crowds. Even if the audience tripled by showtime, it still wouldn't be the biggest one she had performed for with the Valkyries, and that at least made her feel a bit better. Her eyes fell on a marquee that listed the three glee clubs who would be performing: the Mystacor Academy's Music Makers, Elberon Secondary's Songsters, and Stevenson High's Vocal Rebellion.

Mrs. Moon breezed up with a stack of programs in her hands. "Well, everyone — we're officially registered for our very first sectionals competition!" The members of Vocal Rebellion let out a cheer that filled the lobby and turned heads. "The show begins at 11 a.m., and there will be half hour breaks in between each school's performance."

"When are we up?" Glimmer asked, bouncing on the balls of her feet with excitement. Her mother pursed her lips and glanced down at the programs, shuffling them needlessly.

"It seems we drew the third slot."

A beat passed as this information settled over the team. Glimmer broke the silence with a shrill scream.

"*Third?* You mean we have to go last? UGH!"

"It's okay," Adora said, taking her friend gently by the shoulders. "We can use this to our advantage. This way we can scope out the competition and make adjustments based on what we learn."

Bow shook his head and grinned. "Are you ever *not* strategizing?"

Adora considered the question for a moment and shrugged. "Nope, I don't think so."

"Alright then," Mrs. Moon said with a clap of her hands. "Let's drop off our things in the green room and then find our seats."

The teacher's lounge had been repurposed into a private space for the competing teams to store their gear and rehearse during the day. When the members of Vocal Rebellion filed through the door, they were surprised to find the other two school's already settled in. The room, which had been buzzing with chatter and vocal warm-ups only seconds earlier, fell completely quiet. Every head in the room swiveled to face them. Adora and Bow shared a quick, uncomfortable glance.

"Good morning, everyone," Mrs. Moon chirped into the silence, seemingly unperturbed by the stares. "I'm Mrs. Angella Moon, faculty advisor for Stevenson High's Vocal Rebellion." She gestured to Glimmer, who gave a little wave before edging closer to Adora. There was a murmur of greetings from the other teams. While Mrs. Moon strode up to the other faculty advisors and immediately fell into easy conversation, Adora watched as their competition bent their heads together to whisper.

Vocal Rebellion laid their bags along an unclaimed wall. Adora pretended to dig for something at the bottom of her backpack while she eavesdropped on a gossiping group of students from Mystacor Academy.

"I heard this is their first time competing," said one girl in a hiss of a whisper.

"Like, *ever*?" replied her incredulous friend. "Oh, that's so sad." It took everything Adora had not to react to the false pity dripping from the girl's words.

A kid who had been practicing vocal runs within earshot of the girls grinned down at them smugly. "Wait until they see what a *real* glee club can do."

The first girl giggled into her hand. "Right? It's gonna be so embarrassing, I can't wait."

Now Adora couldn't help but roll her eyes. Zipping her bag, she straightened up and turned to her team. "Let's huddle up somewhere private."

With a smattering of polite waves, Vocal Rebellion hustled back into the hallway. Adora led them away from the gathering crowd, which had already swelled considerably in the few short minutes they'd spent in the green room. They found a quiet corner and gathered in a circle.

"Can you believe that?" Perfuma squawked, her long fingers curled into tight, angry fists. "They were all whispering about us! They don't even know us!"

"Uh, duh," Mermista said. "It's a competition. Did you expect them to welcome us with a big group hug?"

Perfuma scoffed and folded her arms. "Well, I expected some kind of camaraderie at least."

"Guys, it's okay," Adora said. She kept her voice low. "Don't let them get in your head. You're right, Perfuma — they *don't* know us, and that's a good thing. Let them think we're just a hapless group of nobodies."

Glimmer flashed a devious grin. "Right — lure them in..."

"And then prove them wrong!" Bow lifted his palm for a high-five, which Glimmer was happy to provide.

Holding her head high, Adora smiled. For the first time in a long time, she felt confident and in control. "Exactly. We've done everything we can, now all we have to do is go up there and show them what we're made of."

Her teammates smiled back at her, excitement crackling between them like electricity before a storm. Adora held her hand, palm

facing down. The others followed her lead, stacking their hands in the middle of the circle.

"Everybody ready?" She asked.

"For the rebellion!" Glimmer cried, trusting her hand downward in the pile and detonating it like a bomb. Everyone's hands flew up as they shouted their reply in unison.

"For the rebellion!"

Chapter 21

Adora took a seat in the auditorium and looked around. The din of overlapping conversations filled the room up all the way to its high ceilings, the air vibrating with anticipation. She still couldn't believe how many people had come out to watch a high school show choir competition on a random Saturday.

This would blow Catra's mind, she thought. Feeling a touch self-righteous.

But that smugness only lasted for a moment. Thinking about her friend had the same effect as a nail in a tire: it pierced her ego and left her deflated. She wondered if Catra even considered her a friend now. Ever since that day on the bleachers, Adora had been haunted by the last thing she said to her.

You and Coach Weaver deserve each other.

It was the cruelest thing she could think of, and in the heat of the moment she meant every word. But Adora wasn't a spiteful person, and as soon as she calmed down she was overwhelmed with guilt.

Not that it mattered now — even if she apologized, she wasn't sure Catra would want to hear it. These days, in the rare, fleeting moments when the pair found themselves in one another's orbit, there was no warmth left in Catra's gaze. It was almost enough to make Adora sick to her stomach, but she held her ground. As much as she hated fighting with Catra, she didn't regret her decision to leave the Valkyries. She didn't blame Catra for being upset, but she was disappointed that Catra couldn't bring herself to respect her choice.

Before Adora could spend too much time dwelling on whether it was time to start referring to Catra as her *ex*-best friend, the lights in the auditorium dimmed and a hush fell over the crowd. In the darkness, Glimmer gripped Adora's forearm tightly.

“Here we go!” she whispered. Adora could hear the smile in her voice.

A single spotlight hit the stage, illuminating a woman who introduced herself as the emcee for the day. She welcomed the crowd to sectionals, and was met by a rousing round of applause in return. Then, after briefly explaining how the competition would unfold and introducing the judges, the emcee introduced the first team to the stage: Elberon Secondary’s Songsters.

“What a stupid name,” Frosta whispered from the end of the row, which was met by an embarrassed shush from Mrs. Moon and a snort of laughter from everyone else.

As the Songsters performed, Adora sat forward in her seat and paid close attention. She watched their choreography and made mental notes on their song selections. There was nothing particularly remarkable about their setlist. Adora had a feeling they chose numbers based on what worked best for them vocally without considering how the song would resonate with the audience. It wasn’t bad, but it wasn’t exciting either.

After the performance, Vocal Rebellion crammed around a cafeteria table to debrief over lunch.

“What did I tell you, Mermista?” Adora said between bites of her sandwich. “Top 40 songs are just too risky. Elberon used that new song for their finale and only half the audience was into it.”

“Yeah, yeah.” Mermista rolled her eyes. “I still think they just chose a shitty song, but whatever.”

“Maybe we can try something current in a mash-up at our next performance?” Bow suggested diplomatically, which seemed to satisfy both parties.

Glimmer slammed her hands down on the table, making everyone else jump. “I don’t know about you guys, but I’m feeling pretty good about our chances right now.”

“Let’s not get ahead of ourselves,” Adora cautioned. “And keep your voice down, the Elberon kids are watching us.”

Perfuma glanced over her shoulder to where the Songsters were sitting a couple tables over. She waved. “Great job up there!”

“Stop fraternizing with the enemy!” Sea Hawk hissed, scandalized. He yanked her hand down.

“What?” Perfuma said with a pout. “Just because they’re rude and unwelcoming doesn’t mean we have to stoop to their level.”

A few minutes later, Spinerella and Netossa pushed back their chairs in unison and got to their feet.

“Alright. Time to finish up, rebels,” Netossa said. “Mystacor’s act starts in five.”

The team hurried to finish what was left of their lunches and made their way back to the auditorium. During her research, Adora learned that the Mystacor Music Makers had won the previous year’s sectionals, only to be knocked out in regionals. She was keen to see if she could pinpoint what made them good enough to win, but not quite good enough to make it through the next round. As the lights went down, Bow leaned over.

“Adora’s got her serious face on,” he whispered to Glimmer.

“Shh,” Adora admonished without taking her eyes off the stage.

From the very first note, Adora could tell what made the Music Makers winners. That they were talented was clear: their vocals were flawless. Their ensemble was much bigger than Vocal Rebellion’s, which meant they had a much more impressive range overall. Adora made a mental note to talk to the others about recruiting some more big voices to round out their own team if they survived this competition.

But as gorgeous as the Music Makers’ voices were, their choreography left a lot to be desired. Adora figured they were

playing it safe, favoring careful dance moves over compromising their vocals. Maybe they thought their incredible performance made up for their stiff choreography, but if Adora had learned anything from the countless videos she'd watched, it was that a strategy like that would only get them so far.

A thrill raced its way through her. For the first time she felt certain —not just hopeful, but totally sure—that Vocal Rebellion had a real shot at winning this thing. They had a solid setlist, they had legit talent, and they had badass choreography too. As long as nothing went wrong—

Adora's stomach plummeted. If they wanted to win, they were going to have to be perfect. And the only thing standing between Vocal Rebellion and perfection was her.

When the performance ended, Adora followed her teammates to the green room in a daze. She didn't remember changing into her costume, but suddenly she found herself in a team huddle, completely dressed and stage-ready.

"Adora?" Bow's voice cut through her frantic thoughts. "Are you okay?"

"Are you sick?" Entrapta asked, pressing her hand to Adora's forehead. "You're awfully pale."

Swallowing, Adora shook her head and backed out of the circle.

"I seriously think someone else should take my solo," she said. Her chest was tight with stress and worry. It had been so long since she had been nervous about a performance that it took her a moment to realize that's what was wrong.

"No way!" Glimmer replied, smiling brightly. "C'mon, Adora. You're being way too hard on yourself."

"I'm serious," Adora pressed on. She could hear the panic coloring her voice, but she was powerless to do anything about it. "I think

we have a real shot, but it won't happen if I screw up the lyrics. I don't want to ruin this for everyone."

A pair of soft hands took Adora by the shoulders. She glanced up to find Mrs. Moon gazing down at her, a kind expression on her face. "Adora, you aren't going to ruin anything."

"But—"

Mrs. Moon waved off Adora's protest. "The fact that we're here in the first place is a huge accomplishment — one all of you should be proud of. But none of the hard work you've put into preparing for this will have been worth it if you don't enjoy yourself. All that matters is that you do your best and have fun."

Adora opened her mouth, but found her voice failed her. If this was Coach Weaver she'd been talking to, Adora's solo would have been ripped away from her ages ago, only to be replaced with a generous helping of belittling and extra work to make up for her shortcomings. With the Valkyries, winning was the only option — Adora had never been given permission to simply *enjoy* herself before.

"Mom's right, Adora," Glimmer said. "No one's going to hold it against you if you stumble a bit up there."

Perfuma threw her arms around Adora's shoulders. "I'm just glad we get to do this together."

Before she could argue, Adora found herself at the center of one of Vocal Rebellion's signature group hugs. Despite the crush of the embrace, Adora couldn't help but grin.

"Okay, you win!" she laughed, trying and failing to squirm away. "Let's do this thing already!"

Vocal Rebellion made their way to the auditorium, where they were mic'd up in the hallway. Mermista and Glimmer would be leading the opening number — a soaring rendition of Kelly Clarkson's "Stronger" to pump up the crowd. The plan was for the

girls to enter through the two auditorium doors and sing up the aisles to the stage. The rest of the team would follow their lead, bursting in once the first chorus started. They split up, half of the team lining up behind Mermista and the other half behind Glimmer. Adora took her spot between Glimmer and Bow, and while the others whispered excitedly to one another, she closed her eyes and took deep breaths to calm her nerves.

Behind the doors, the audience fell silent. Adora opened her eyes and noticed Glimmer's stance had stiffened, her breath coming faster than usual. With only a couple moments to spare, Adora wrapped her in a tight hug from behind.

"You've got this, Glimmer," she whispered.

Glimmer softened. "Thanks, Adora."

The emcee's muffled voice announced their school and the music started. Mermista and Glimmer nodded to one another, and just like that, it was show time.

Rather than have the team worry about the doors, a pair of stage hands had been assigned to help. When hers was pulled open, Mermista strutted over the threshold to start the song, tossing her head back with that signature confidence she exuded so effortlessly. Adora heard the audience let out an elated whoop as the door swung shut. Then it was Glimmer's turn. The stage hand yanked the door open and, for a split second, Adora could see the crowd. Smiling spectators twisted in their seats to watch Glimmer make her entrance. Adora let their energy wash over her as her eyes took in as many faces as she could, only to freeze when her gaze landed on one.

There, seated at the end of a row two from the back of the house.

A cascading mass of wild brown hair and two pointed ears stuffed beneath a baseball cap that had been pulled down low over two different colored eyes.

Different colored eyes that met Adora's and widened, as if in slow motion, as the door swung shut again.

Catra?

Adora's head spun. It didn't matter that Catra was clearly trying to hide her appearance, Adora would know her anywhere.

But she didn't have time to dwell on what Catra's presence meant. Both doors burst open again just as the chorus hit. As she hurried into the auditorium, Adora tried to steal another look, but she was leading the line and had to keep the pace. All she saw as she strode down the aisle was the Catra out of the corner of her eye, sinking down into her seat as she passed.

When she reached the stage, Adora looked out across the audience. But it was impossible to see anyone against the blazing lights, and Adora had no choice but to carry on.

The vibe in the auditorium was electric. Mermista and Glimmer sang their hearts out as the rest of the team fell into perfect harmony behind them. The steps Adora choreographed came as naturally as breathing, and in no time the wide smile she wore on her face came just as easily. She didn't have to remind herself to keep her expression bright and cheerful — she was having a blast.

When the song ended, the cheers from the audience were nearly deafening. Chest heaving, Adora gulped down a few breaths and looked at the others. If the grins on their faces were any indication, they were all just as elated as she was. Sea Hawk caught her eye and gave her a thumbs up. Even Entrapta looked to be enjoying herself, and that was saying something.

Glimmer stepped to the front of the stage, which was everyone else's cue to get into formation for the next number.

"Hi everyone!" Glimmer said once the crowd's volume subsided. Her voice vibrated throughout the auditorium. "We're Vocal Rebellion." She paused for another round of applause. "We may

be the underdogs this year, but we're not going down without a fight!"

Before turning away, she gave them all a cheeky wink. She was a natural born performer.

The opening notes for their ballad number blared from the speakers. As far as Adora was concerned, it had been a no-brainer to pick Rachel Platten's "Fight Song" for their rebellion-themed setlist, just like it had been an easy decision to give the solo to Netossa. Her voice was as big as her personality, and she carried the song with a perfect balance of power and emotion. While she held down the melody, the rest of the ensemble filled in the harmonies, and they all nailed the choreography.

Adora was so consumed by the performance—by the thrill and the energy of it all—that she almost forgot that her own solo was coming up in the next song. But as the ballad wound down, her heart started to hammer in her chest. This was it — she was either going to get the words right, or she was going to screw up in front of all these people.

In front of Catra.

Again, her eyes lifted to the space where she'd seen Catra sitting. She still couldn't see anyone's faces through the lights, but she was certain she could feel Catra watching her. Adora figured that knowing Catra was out in that sea of spectators—that she had gone out of her way to be there even though she hated glee and, maybe, hated Adora too—would ratched up her anxiety even higher than it already was. She could hear Catra's voice in her head, echoing the countless times she had teased her about screwing up song lyrics in the past.

But instead of sending her into a spiral of fear and self-doubt, Adora found her heart rate settling. Maybe it was the opportunity to show Catra just how wrong she'd been, or maybe it was just the familiarity that came with performing for someone who knew her better than anyone else, but Adora suddenly felt calm.

She was ready.

Vocal Rebellion took their places, divided into their warring factions. The distinctive guitar riffs of “Eye Of The Tiger” thrummed through the auditorium, instantly sending the audience into a fit of cheers. Sea Hawk launched into his solo as the two sides dance-duelled across the stage.

Before Adora even had a chance to worry, it was her turn. The melody blended into “Hit Me With Your Best Shot” and Adora didn’t think — she just sang.

And she crushed it.

Dancing and singing, Adora put on the performance of her life. She hit every note without missing a step of choreography, and she got every word right.

The whole number flew by like a dream, and before Adora knew it, the song was over. Her hands were in the air and the crowd was on its feet.

At that moment, Adora didn’t care if they won or not. Vocal Rebellion had just aced their first sectionals performance, and that was enough for her.

In a haze of adrenaline and relief, Adora and the others jogged off stage, throwing waves at the still-cheering crowd as they made their way behind the velvet curtain. Mrs. Moon was literally jumping with joy as she raced forward to wrap her daughter in a tight hug. While the team celebrated, the emcee took the stage to announce a brief intermission while the judges made their final decisions.

The house lights went up. Adora saw an opportunity, and crept back to the side of the stage.

She peered out between the curtains and scanned the seats. For a split second, she wondered if she should confront Catra — jump

down from the stage, march up the aisle and demand to know what she was doing there.

But when her eyes fell on the seat at the end of the row, two from the back, she found it empty.

Catra was already gone.

Chapter 22

Catra couldn't decide what she felt more: embarrassed or angry.

She had chosen a seat near the back of the auditorium thinking there was no way Adora would see her from the stage. It was just her dumb, terrible luck that the Vocal Hellions decided to make a grand entrance from the auditorium doors instead. And of course Adora would see her sitting there, trapped and feeling stupid for ever thinking she could get away with sneaking into the show in the first place.

The moment the performance was over, Catra darted from her seat. She ran like she stole something, and didn't slow down until she made it to a bus stop. When the bus came, Catra found an empty seat and threw herself down, sinking as low as possible. It was only once the bus pulled away and she was sure Adora hadn't followed her that she ripped the ball cap off her head and twisted it furiously between her hands.

Stupid, stupid, stupid! she thought miserably. *What the fuck was I thinking?*

But Catra knew exactly what she'd been thinking when she made the decision to sneak across town to watch Adora's first performance with the glee club: she had to know.

She had to know what it was about that dumb show choir that made Adora choose it over the Valkyries.

She had to know why it was so easy for Adora to choose them over her.

But Catra wound up getting more than she bargained for. She had crept into that auditorium fully expecting to die of second-hand embarrassment. She thought the whole thing would be cringe-worthy, and that it would be all the fuel she needed to feel better about herself.

Instead, Catra actually kind of enjoyed the show, and she hated herself for it. She hated how impressed she was with Vocal Rebellion's entire routine, and how rapt she'd been with Adora's performance. She hated how genuinely, unapologetically happy Adora looked as she sang and danced with her new friends.

Needless to say, the whole excursion had backfired spectacularly. Instead of feeling better, Catra felt worse — worse about Adora, and definitely worse about herself.

Catra glared out the window and drummed her long black nails along the top of her thigh. There was no way Adora wouldn't try to confront her about this. Just the thought of being cornered and having to come up with some bullshit lie about why she was there made Catra want to crawl out of her skin.

I'll just deny it. I'll burn this fucking hat and deny everything until Adora thinks she's going crazy.

But even that plan implied she would have to face Adora at some point, and she definitely wasn't ready for that. Catra pulled her phone from her pocket and chewed on her bottom lip as she scrolled through her contacts. She considered her options. Even though it was probably a bad idea, her thumb hovered over the name of the one person she knew would have her back, no matter what.

Sighing, Catra swallowed her pride and opened a new text message.

Hey Scorpia. Can I come over?

*

By Monday, all of Catra's conflicting feelings had amalgamated into a single mass of irritation. Irritation with herself, irritation with Adora, and irritation with her painfully gracious host.

Scorpia had opened her home to Catra without a second thought. She didn't ask questions, nor did she bat an eye when Catra asked

if she could crash on her floor until Monday. As Catra expected, Scorpia was delighted to have her all to herself for two nights in a row, and she went out of her way to make her brooding houseguest as comfortable as possible. She gave up her bed for both nights, paid for brunch and takeout, and hung breathlessly on every word Catra said. Not that Catra did much talking. Thankfully, Scorpia was the queen of conversation and had no problem filling in the many long, awkward stretches of silence with her personal brand of happily oblivious babble while Catra sulked.

"Wow, what a great weekend," Scorpia chirped, smiling widely over the steering wheel as she drove them both to school on Monday morning. "I feel like we finally got the chance to bond, y'know? Did you have fun, Wildcat?"

Catra propped her elbow on the armrest of the passenger side door and cradled her chin in her hand.

"Yeah, sure," she replied as she watched the town whip by the window. Then she caught herself and cleared her throat. "Thanks for letting me stay over. I, uh... I appreciate it."

"I'm the one who should be thanking you!" Scorpia's dark eyes sparkled as she stole quick glances at Catra out of the corner of her vision. "If someone told me a couple months ago that one day you'd text me out of the blue and ask to spend a whole weekend with me, I think I'd probably pass out. We should do it again sometime!"

Guilt wriggled in Catra's stomach like a mound of worms. It wasn't that she disliked Scorpia — she was one of the nicest people Catra had ever met. But she knew how Scorpia felt about her, and the last thing she wanted to do was give her any false hope.

Well, that was actually the second last thing she wanted to do.

The real last thing Catra wanted to do was face Adora right now, which is the only reason she'd texted Scorpia in the first place.

She may have been taking advantage of Scorpia's crush, but Catra would much rather deal with the fallout from that than deal with Adora.

Scorpia turned into the school parking lot and coasted into a spot near the doors. Getting such a great parking spot was probably the only good thing about having to be at the school two hours before classes started. Catra took a deep swig from the steaming cup of coffee Scorpia bought for her on the way — something told her it was going to be a long day, even without the morning practice.

Catra wasn't a modest person: she knew perfectly well that the Valkyries were flourishing under her leadership. Unfortunately, that didn't seem to matter to Coach Weaver. The fact that Adora still hadn't come crawling back, begging to rejoin the cheer force, festered in their coach like a disease. She was furious, and made no effort to hide it, taking her petty rage out on the remaining squad instead. If she wasn't making them do extras—the squad's lingo for extra laps, extra push-ups, extra crunches, extra everything—she was pulling power trips like assigning double practice days like this one. The Valkyries were up to three days a week where they were required to practice both in the morning and again after class, and Catra only assumed things would get worse as they got closer to their next competition.

As she and Scorpia made their way through the deserted school, Catra caught Scorpia yawning out of the corner of her eye.

"Oops," Scorpia scratched the back of her neck, embarrassed. "Sorry. I swear I'm awake."

"That makes one of us," Catra replied with a shrug. "I think these doubles are going to kill me."

"Yeah, about that... Do you have any idea what this is all about?" Scorpia asked, a touch of caution in her voice. "I mean, I'm no expert or anything, but I thought we were doing pretty well. Does

Coach Weaver really think we need this much extra practice time? I know she likes to push us but, sheesh."

Catra stiffened and turned away.

"*We're* awesome," Catra said. "But Coach Weaver was probably a drill sergeant in a past life, so making her underlings suffer is the only thing that brings her joy. It's that simple."

Within a few minutes, the rest of the Valkyries arrived, yawning and grumbling over take-away cups of coffee. When they had finished their warm-up and Coach Weaver still hadn't arrived, Catra took initiative and started running the squad through drills. They were nearly an hour into practice when the gym doors burst open with a bang.

The Valkyries froze and watched as Coach Weaver stormed across the floor, muttering furiously to herself. Catra sighed and braced herself for whatever tirade was no doubt coming her way.

"What's up, Coach?" she asked, not bothering to feign actual interest. Her eyes tracked Coach Weaver as she paced in front of the squad.

"What's *up*? *What's up* is the glee club won their sectional competition this weekend," Coach Weaver snarled. She stabbed an accusatory finger in Catra's direction as if she somehow was to blame.

Catra blinked with surprise.

They won?

For a fleeting moment, a vague sense of pride fluttered in her chest.

"Aw, good for them!" Scorpia said without a hint of irony or malice. Catra tried to shoot her a warning glance, but Scorpia wasn't looking. "Should we send them a congratulatory gift basket or something?"

Catra dropped her forehead into her palm with a groan as Coach Weaver pinned Scorpia under a withering stare.

"Err," Scorpia let out a nervous laugh. "I mean... boo to those guys, right?"

With a shake of her head, Coach Weaver turned her attention back to Catra. "You. My office. Now."

"Oh, c'mon!" Catra replied through gritted teeth, playing up her irritation to hide the small part of her that worried Coach Weaver had found out she had sneaked into the show. "I don't even talk to Adora anymore! How is this my fault?"

But Coach Weaver ignored her. Instead, she scanned her squad with a narrowed gaze.

"Take these two with you," she snapped, pointing at both Scorpia and DT, who shared a befuddled look with one another before scampering to follow Catra.

Huh, Catra thought. *This is... different.*

The three uneasy Valkyries filed silently into Coach Weaver's office and stood in a line in front of her desk.

"The nerve," Coach Weaver hissed as she followed in behind them, closing the door with a slam. "The absolute audacity."

Catra caught the other two throwing her questioning looks and all she could do was shrug in response.

Drawing her chair back, Coach Weaver dropped down and glared at her three charges one at a time. When her eyes finally fell to Catra, they narrowed dangerously. Catra clutched her hands at her sides, her fists so tight that her sharp nails bit into her palms.

"I just got out of a meeting with Principal Hope and Mrs. Moon. It seems they've banded together to add insult to our already considerable injury."

The Valkyries glanced at one another, each hoping one of them had any clue what their coach was talking about.

Coach Weaver scoffed in disgust. "It was bad enough when that school-sanctioned charity case of a club stole our star," Coach Weaver growled. "But now that they've won a single competition, Principal Hope has decided to relocate a portion of the Valkyries' budget to that group of social sub-basement dwellers."

DT raised an eyebrow and folded their arms. The allure of potential drama was no longer enough to maintain their interest. "That's truly tragic, Coach. But what does that have to do with us?"

Lacing her fingers together, Coach Weaver set her hands on the desk and leaned forward. "It's an insult to our organization — to everything I've worked so hard for. I won't stand for it. You three are going to put a stop to the glee club before they have a chance to do any more damage."

Unable to stop herself, Catra rolled her eyes. "Right. And how exactly do you expect us to do that?"

She expected Coach Weaver to snap at her — to give her shit for daring to be so insubordinate. But instead, Coach Weaver chuckled, a sound so unassumingly foreboding that Catra couldn't help but shudder.

Coach Weaver leaned forward, lifting her hands so she could rest her sharp chin atop her fingers with a creepy sort of delight.

"How? Come now, Catra. Use your imagination." There was a note of cruelty in her voice. "I expect you to take them down from the inside, of course."

Chapter 23

Something about winning with Vocal Rebellion felt different than winning with the Valkyries, but Adora couldn't quite put her finger on what that something was. Maybe it was the fact that it was the club's first win ever, and she had been part of making that happen. Or maybe it felt different because winning hadn't been the point; no pressure, no expectations — all she had to do was have a good time with her friends.

Whatever the difference was, Adora liked the way it felt.

One the evening of their sectionals win, Mrs. Moon took all of Vocal Rebellion out for a celebratory dinner. Even the team members who didn't usually hang out outside of rehearsal joined in, as did any family and friends who had been at the show. Needless to say, by the time they were all crammed into the back of the restaurant, the atmosphere was so loud and jubilant that it felt more like they'd won nationals than the first round to qualify for them.

Elated, Adora sipped on her soft drink and basked in their well-earned glory. Across the table, Bow sat between his parents, who listened proudly as he explained his process for arranging vocals for the team. For all the support they showered on their son, Adora got the sense this was the first time George and Lance really understood how much show choir meant to Bow. To Adora's right, Glimmer was on a video call with her own father—a state diplomat who spent most of his time traveling for work—regaling him with a play-by-play of the team's victory.

It was only then, surrounded by her chattering friends, did Adora's mind drift back to Catra. The image of Catra hiding under that ball cap at the back of the auditorium, and the wide-eyed shock on her face when their eyes met, was burned into Adora's mind. Her hand drifted down to her back pocket, itching to pull out her phone. She was overcome by a need to text Catra, but she hesitated when it dawned on her that she didn't know what to

say. Sure, she could ask her why she'd come, but Adora knew she wouldn't get a response to that. Perhaps she could thank Catra for coming to the show and see if that was enough to thaw some of the ice between them.

But before she could work up the nerve, Glimmer got to her feet and raised her glass into the air.

"A toast to us!" she cried over the noisy restaurant. Patrons at other tables turned in their seats to watch the commotion as Vocal Rebellion and company cheered and clinked glasses.

Once their food arrived, the party drifted into a few minutes of silence. Adora took the lull in conversation as an opportunity to share her idea.

"So, I was thinking about regionals—"

Bow snorted. "Of course you were."

"Just hear me out!" Adora said.

"Only if you promise to relax and enjoy the win when you're done," Glimmer replied, smirking.

Adora threw her hands up in surrender. "Fine, deal. I just wanted to run an idea by you guys. What do you think about recruiting more members?"

Mermista leaned closer so she could join the conversation. "Why? I think we've got a pretty good thing going on just the way we are." From his spot at Mermista's side, Sea Hawk nodded in agreement.

"We have a *great* thing going on," Adora agreed, waving off the implication that there was anything wrong with the team as it was. "But I was thinking about the Mystacor team — they're huge, and they had a lot of really strong voices on their roster."

“Okay.” Perfuma sounded perplexed as she chewed her bottom lip. “But they lost.”

Adora nodded. “Yeah, this year. But if they’d had better choreography, they would have given us a serious run for our money. The competition is just going to be way stronger at regionals — I think it would help our chances if we had a couple more really strong singers on the team.”

Entrapta hummed and tapped her chin thoughtfully. “Statistically speaking, that plan would certainly improve our odds.”

“I agree,” Netossa chimed in. “Don’t get me wrong, I love soloing, but I’m willing to share some of that limelight if it means we have a bit of an insurance policy on our side.”

Smiling fondly, Spinnerella pressed a kiss into Netossa’s cheek. “That’s very noble of you, dear.”

Bow and Glimmer looked to one another.

“It couldn’t hurt,” Bow said. “I mean, as it stands now, if any of us got sick and couldn’t perform, we’d be disqualified on the spot.”

Glimmer shrugged. “Makes sense to me. We can start recruiting right away. And who knows, maybe having a sectionals win under our belt will help attract new members!”

By the time Adora got home that night, she was exhausted. She was grateful to have one more day left in the weekend. With no plans for her Sunday, she was willing to give herself permission to sleep in for a change.

After stopping by the kitchen to say hello to Madam Razz* and a couple of the younger kids who were helping her bake something that smelled heavenly, Adora shuffled down the hall to her bedroom. She paused at her door and looked up at the ceiling. It took her a moment of hesitation before she finally decided to toss her bag in her room and head upstairs. Adora’s socked feet

padded gently up the carpeted steps and carried her to Catra's door.

Again, Adora paused. She pressed her ear to the door and listened. Silence. The light was off, but she knocked anyway. Sighing, Adora pushed the door open and slipped inside.

She knew Catra well enough to know she wouldn't be there, not after being spotted in the auditorium. Catra was too proud for that kind of thing. Still, Adora couldn't help but be disappointed.

Closing the door softly behind her, Adora crept to Catra's unmade bed. Before she could think better of it, she tucked herself into the nest of sheets and pulled the duvet up to her chin. Head on Catra's pillow, Adora inhaled deeply and let the lingering scent comfort her.

Exhaustion swept over Adora like a tide, and she fell asleep quickly.

When she awoke the next day, Adora was still in Catra's bed, and she was still alone.

*

The following Friday, Adora wandered the halls of Stevenson High with a stack of posters in one hand and a tape gun in the other. It was early, and she had volunteered to come in before classes to hang up the new recruitment posters. She was putting them anywhere and everywhere she thought they'd be seen, plastering them on washroom doors, by the vending machines, on the walls where you had to wait in line in the cafeteria and in every single classroom.

She was contemplating how long the posters would last if she hung them up in bathroom stalls when she heard a conversation drifting around the corner ahead of her. Adora froze mid-step when she realized the pair of voices belonged to Mrs. Moon and Coach Weaver.

"What could *those two* possibly have to talk about?" Adora mumbled to herself. Unease twisted at the pit of her stomach. Moving on her tip-toes, Adora sneaked closer to the corner and listened in.

"Are you sure?" Moon asked, a note of incredulity in her voice.

Coach Weaver responded with a laugh that was no doubt intended to sound light and friendly but instead came across as mildly creepy. "Of course, Angella! Think of it as a peace offering — my way of apologizing for my egregious behavior on Monday morning."

Adora cringed. She recognized that fake sweetness in Coach Weaver's voice.

After a beat of uneasy silence, Mrs. Moon sighed. "Well, I suppose it must have been jarring to get that kind of news out of the blue."

"It was a little unexpected, yes. But I'm nothing if not adaptable. And if your—" Coach Weaver hesitated and cleared her throat "—*little rebels* are open to the idea, then at least I'd have the satisfaction of knowing my Valkyries' budget was going to good use."

"And what would this mean for Adora?" Mrs. Moon asked.

Adora's breath caught in her throat. *Me? What about me?*

By now, students were trickling into the halls. A group of sophomores strode by, laughing and chatting loudly. Their voices drowned out Coach Weaver and Mrs. Moon, and Adora had to stop herself from shushing them as she strained to hear. But even after the group passed, Adora still couldn't hear the conversation. Cautiously, she held her breath and peered around the corner, only to find the hallway empty.

"Damnit," she hissed as she scanned the halls. There were plenty of students milling around, but Coach Weaver and Mrs. Moon

were gone.

Adora wasted no time. She fired off a text to Glimmer and Bow explaining what she'd overheard and headed for her locker as she waited for a response.

Weird, Glimmer finally texted back. *Mom told me Principal Hope gave us some of the Valkyries' budget after we won sectionals, but that's all I know*.

Bow chimed in a few seconds later. *You know Coach Weaver better than we do, Adora. What do you think she means by 'peace offering'?*

Given that 'peace' isn't in her vocabulary I honestly have no idea. Adora typed with one hand as she worked her locker combination with the other. *But she's definitely up to something.*

Well, we can ask my mom about it at rehearsal this afternoon, Glimmer replied.

Adora sighed and slid her phone back into her pocket. She could tell her friends weren't taking this seriously. It didn't matter how many stories she'd told them, they didn't know what Coach Weaver was capable of the way she did.

It was for this reason that Adora spent the entire morning anxious and distracted. Her foot tapped out the seconds leading up to lunch time, and she was the first person out the door when the bell rang. She hurried to Bow's locker, which was the closest to the band room and therefore the spot where she always met up with the others. She bounced on the balls of her feet while she waited. By the time Glimmer and Bow appeared through the lunchtime crowd, Adora couldn't hide her anxious unease.

"Where have you two been?" she said, exasperated. "C'mon, we've got to hurry."

Glimmer and Bow shared a quizzical glance.

“Adora, the bell rang three minutes ago,” Bow said.

“Is this about the thing with Coach Weaver?” Glimmer asked, leaning against one of the other lockers as Bow shoved his bag inside of his own. “What are you so worked up about?”

“You guys don’t know her like I do,” Adora pointed out. They started their short walk to the band room. “Coach Weaver never does anything nice for someone else unless she’s getting something out of it. Do you think your mom knows not to trust her?”

Glimmer raised a judgemental eyebrow. “Adora.”

“What?”

“I think you’re being paranoid.”

“I’m not being—”

“Guys, chill!” Bow paused in the doorway of the band room and waved his hands at them both. “Let’s talk to Mrs. Moon first, and then we can decide how worried we should be, okay?”

Even though it was framed as a polite suggestion, Adora recognized that Bow had effectively put an end to the conversation. Begrudgingly, she followed her friends into the band room and shifted her focus back to confronting Mrs. Moon.

But Mrs. Moon wasn’t there yet. She still hadn’t arrived by the time the last of the glee club took their seats. Chewing her bottom lip, Glimmer leaned forward and propped her elbows on her knees.

“Where is she?” Glimmer huffed. “Maybe I should—”

Just then, the door swung open and Mrs. Moon bustled in.

“Sorry to keep you waiting, everyone.” She held a stack of sheet music in her hands, which she shuffled with an air of distraction.

“But I have some good news!”

Adora looked to Glimmer and Bow, both of whom glanced back with wide eyes.

“As you know, we’re trying to recruit more members to Vocal Rebellion. I’m delighted to tell you that we already have a few students who are interested in auditioning!”

“Oh,” Adora said aloud, even though she definitely meant to keep that sound of disappointment private. She slumped down in her seat as Glimmer sat upright in hers.

“Seriously?” Glimmer’s eye sparkled with excitement. “Who?”

As if on cue, the band room door swung open. Adora swiveled to look, and her mouth fell open at what she saw.

There, looming in the doorframe, stood Catra, Scorpia, and DT.

Catra scanned the room, taking in the members of Vocal Rebellion as if they were prey. When her gaze landed on Adora, Catra’s eyes narrowed. Her mouth crept into a smug smirk.

“Hey, Adora.”

Chapter 24

Adora could feel the stares of every person in the room turn to her in unison, but the only eyes that mattered were the dual-colored ones glinting back at her.

"Catra, what are you doing here?" she squawked, sounding a touch less composed than she wanted to. The fact that she was flustered didn't escape Catra's notice, whose eyebrows quirked knowingly.

"Me?" Catra pressed her fingertips to her chest with feigned surprise. She reached over her shoulder to Scorpia, who pressed a sheet of paper into Catra's waiting hand. A mischievous grin stretched across her lips as she brandished the paper — one of the recruitment posters Adora had hung herself. "I'm here to audition."

Without thinking, Adora jumped to her feet.

"But you can't!" She paused, fully aware that she was making a scene but completely unable to stop herself. "I mean, Coach Weaver..."

Adora's words failed her, so she resorted to gesturing vaguely. A quick glance around the room told her that no one else seemed to be following her train of thought. Bow forced a tight smile while Glimmer shook her head.

Mrs. Moon cleared her throat. "Coach Weaver and I have already discussed the arrangement. She's aware of the audition."

Adora couldn't help but notice the way Mrs. Moon's gaze avoided meeting her eyes as she looked out across the room. This must have been what Mrs. Moon and Coach Weaver were talking about in the hallway.

With a satisfied toss of her ponytail, Catra planted a hand on her hip and lifted her chin. Adora could tell she was in her element —

she recognized the way Catra held herself when she had control of a room. What Adora didn't understand was why, after everything that had happened, Catra was asking—no, *demanding*—to audition for a show choir she had zero respect for.

"So, are we going to do this or what?" Catra deadpanned, sounding almost bored.

"Mrs. Moon, can we have a second to talk about this?" Adora asked, gesturing at the Rebels. "As a team?"

Blinking, Mrs. Moon mouthed in wordless surprise before finally waving a hand dismissively. "Alright, then."

Before Mrs. Moon could change her mind, Adora rounded on her teammates and ushered them into a corner on the other side of the room.

"Adora, what's gotten into you?" Bow hissed, cutting a covert glance at the trio of Valkyries waiting by the door. Adora grabbed his shoulder and whirled him back around.

"I think *this* is what Coach Weaver is up to," Adora whispered back.

Glimmer pursed her lips and shrugged a shoulder. "I mean, my mom *did* just say Coach Weaver talked to her about them wanting to audition. Sooo..."

Adora sighed. "Right, but why? Coach wouldn't let me be on both teams, but suddenly it's okay for three members of the squad—including the new captain—to join glee? Catra has never been interested in joining Vocal Rebellion before. Trust me, I tried."

"I don't get it," Mermista said. She folded her arms across her chest and gave Adora a pointed look. "Didn't you and that girl used to be, like, best friends? I figured you'd be excited that she wants to join."

A fiery blush raced up Adora's neck and spilled across her cheeks. She looked to Bow and Glimmer for help. She hadn't told them everything—not even close—but they at least knew how torn up she was about Catra pulling away from her. They both gave her a reassuring smile.

"Yeah," Perfuma cut in, using that gentle voice she usually saved for mediating arguments and talking her friends through freak-outs. "Maybe this is her way of apologizing."

Mortified at the direction this conversation was taking, Adora buried her burning face in her hands.

"Anyway," Bow said, his voice cracking with discomfort. "Glimmer, didn't you say Principal Hope gave us part of the Valkyries' budget? If Coach Weaver is as obsessed with winning as Adora says she is—"

"She is!" Adora interjected defensively.

Bow gave her a patient nod and continued. "Maybe this is her way of making sure she can claim part of our victory. If we take regionals with four Valkyries—er, three and one former Valkyrie, I guess—you know she'll take some of the credit."

Adora opened her mouth to argue, but found she couldn't come up with anything to say. She hadn't considered this idea before, but it did sound like something Coach Weaver would do.

Glimmer put a hand on Adora's shoulder. "Listen, when I took over as captain of Vocal Rebellion, I rewrote the bylaws to say anyone can audition. We have to let them try out, but that doesn't mean we have to let them in. If it bothers you that much, we'll just let them do their thing and then come up with some reason to say no after, okay?"

Adora's stomach dropped. "Wait, no—"

"Oh, dastardly," Seahawk said, smoothing his fingers over his moustache. "I like it."

The rest of the team murmured in agreement, while Adora waved her hands frantically. "That's not going to work."

"Just relax, Adora," Glimmer said with a grin. "I've got this."

Before Adora could stop her, Glimmer turned on her heel and marched back across the room to where Catra leaned against the wall, examining her long black nails.

"Alright, let's do this," Glimmer announced. "Who's going first?"

Catra's eyes flashed. She pushed off the wall and motioned for Scorpia and DT to join her. "Actually, we've got a group performance planned. We're kind of a package deal."

She wasn't asking for permission — she was telling Glimmer exactly how it was going to go. Adora flopped back onto her chair wait a groan.

"Whatever." Glimmer shrugged. "That's fine by me."

The rest of Vocal Rebellion took their seats while DT paired their phone with the band room speakers and queued up some music. The moment Glimmer sat down, Adora leaned in to whisper in her ear.

"Glimmer, this is a bad idea." She could feel Catra watching, but she refused to play into her game by looking back. "We're going to need to come up with a *really* good reason why they can't join."

"Don't worry, Adora," Glimmer said, waving off her concern. "It's not like I'm going to hurt Catra's feelings or anything. I'll let them down easy."

"You don't understand. Catra's—"

But Adora didn't have the chance to finish her thought. The first few trumpeted notes of Demi Lovato's "Confident" blared from the speakers, and Adora sank low in defeat.

Shit.

Adora couldn't blame Glimmer for the emboldened expression she wore — between Demi's power and range, the song was a bold and challenging choice.

But Adora knew what Glimmer and the rest of Vocal Rebellion were about to find out: Catra was an incredible singer.

Where Adora was a decent vocalist who had to work hard to make herself better, Catra was naturally talented but otherwise indifferent to her gift. It was one of the reasons Adora tried convincing Catra to audition with her in the first place. For years, Adora had watched her best friend belt out even the most difficult songs with ease in the privacy of her bedroom. She knew exactly what Vocal Rebellion was in for.

From the very first note, the trio of cheerleaders demanded their audience's attention. They launched into the kind of flawless choreography the Valkyries were famous for, and while Scorpia and DT worked the harmonies and background vocals, Catra took center stage and owned it.

Out of the corner of her eyes, Adora could see the shock on her teammates' faces. Catra hit every big note and delivered on complicated runs in a way that would make a professional recording artist jealous.

Why does she have to be good at everything? Adora though miserably as she watched Catra wail throught the crescendo at the bridge, earning a few impressed gasps from around the room.

With every snap and dip, every sway and strut, the Valkyries moved like they were casting a spell. As much as she wanted to look away—to deny Catra the satisfaction of seeing just how flustered she made her—Adora was powerless to do anything more than gape and blush. It certainly didn't help that Catra became a different person whenever she performed — provocative and impossible to ignore.

The trio sashayed forward, getting right into their audience's faces. Catra made a point of positioning herself directly in Adora's line of vision when the choreography called for her and the others to sink low on their haunches before body-rolling back to standing. Face burning, Adora scowled and dug her fingertips sharply into her knees. Catra responded with a wink. Then she whirled back around, flicking her skirt with a toss of her hip and striding away.

Catra was hot and she knew it. Worse: Adora knew it, and Catra knew *that* too.

Adora sank even lower in her seat. *I am so screwed.*

In a big finishing move, Scorpia pulled out the big guns by scooping Catra up into a lift. Held aloft like some kind of prize, Catra threw a hand in the air to punctuate her final note while DT sank into splits at Scorpia's feet.

There was a split second of perfect silence. The only sound in the room was the heavy, post-performance breathing of the three Valkyries who continued to hold their poses like the consummate professionals they were. Then, as if the spell was suddenly lifted, the room erupted into applause. Adora wanted nothing more than for the ground to open up beneath her and swallow her whole.

Gracefully, Catra leapt to the ground and tossed her hair back over her shoulder.

"We'll give you kids a minute to huddle up," she said, once again dictating the situation like some kind of mob boss.

The members of Vocal Rebellion hurried back to the corner and put their heads together.

"What the heck, Adora?" Glimmer said, somehow managing to make her whisper sound shrill. "You didn't think to mention that Catra is a secret superstar before the audition?"

"I tried to," Adora snapped back. "But you wouldn't listen!"

Mermista looked stunned. "How did a voice *that* big come out of someone *that* tiny?" She held her hands up, palms facing one another as if to indicate that Catra was barely bigger than a foot-long sub.

"We can't say no to them." Netossa spoke with such conviction that the rest of the group fell silent at her words. "Listen, you know I love the limelight, so this isn't easy for me to admit. But, that?" She pointed back at Catra for emphasis. "We can win regionals with a voice like that."

It was a hard point to argue against, but Adora was determined to try.

"But— I mean, what about Coach Weaver? Doesn't anyone else think there's something weird about this?"

"I don't understand," Entrapta said, cocking her head with confusion. "It was *your* idea to recruit strong new voices to the team. I'm no expert, but that performance had everything you said we need."

Adora swallowed hard. "Yeah, I know. But—"

"What's the problem?" Mermista lifted her brows. "You're not jealous, are you?"

"What?" Adora cried, before catching herself and lowering her voice a few octaves. "I am *not* jealous of Catra."

Perfuma stifled a giggle behind her hand. "I don't know about the rest of you but I'm pretty sure I noticed an energy shift during that performance. It's almost like there was some electricity in the air. You know, with all those sparks flying?"

"Stop," Adora whined when Perfuma's teasing earned a few snickers around the circle. "Please, just stop."

"Okay, enough," Bow said. "We have to make a decision."

Glimmer chewed on her bottom lip, clearly conflicted. "Adora, I—"

Adora sighed. She knew this was a battle she wouldn't win from the moment Catra opened her mouth. "It's fine, Glimmer. You're guys are right — we need this if we want to win."

From the front of the room, Mrs. Moon cleared her throat. "Well, Rebels? Do we have a decision?"

Before turning, Glimmer gave Adora's arm an apologetic squeeze.

"We do." Glimmer turned to face the Valkyries, who were lounging in some chairs. Catra lifted her eyes cooly. In a last ditch-effort to take back some power, Glimmer drew herself up tall and offered a gracious smile. "Welcome to Vocal Rebellion."



Chapter 25

Though she would never admit it out loud, Catra felt unstoppable after the audition. Everything had gone even better than she'd hoped — not only had she, Scorpia, and DT nailed their performance, but they were accepted into the glee club without a second thought. Catra had braced herself for a fight, certain that their performance alone wouldn't be enough to win Captain Sparkles and her merry band of misfits over. But it had been easy — no sweet-talking required. And even though she hated everything about Coach Weaver's petty plan to embed the Valkyries into Vocal Rebellion, the look on Adora's face had definitely been worth it.

At the memory of Adora's crimson cheeks and flustered expression, Catra drew herself up a little taller as she strode through the school. Students scampered out of the way as she, flanked on either side by Scorpia and DT, swept down the hallway like models on a runway: enviable and completely unshakable.

"Okay, is it just me or was that a *lot* of fun?" Scorpia asked, grinning from ear to ear. "We were awesome!"

"And did you see the looks on their faces?" DT pressed a palm to their chest and pretended to swoon. "It's like they'd never seen true talent before. Poor lambs."

Catra sneered. It would have been funny had she not already seen what the glee club was capable of. "Let's just remember why we're doing this, okay? We have a job to do."

"Whatever you say, kitten," DT drawled, flicking a non-existent speck of lint off the blazing V of their uniform. "But seriously, can you believe that's what Adora ditched us for? Yikes."

Catra faltered, her shoulders tensing involuntarily. But she wasn't going to let Adora get to her, not now. She shook her hair back and took a breath. "Yeah, well, until we find a way to burn this

thing down, we've got to play nice with those nerds. Anyway, I need to make a pitstop. I'll see you at practice."

"Do you need company?" Scorpia asked brightly. "I've got a spare next period."

Catra cut her a sharp look. "No, Scorpia. I don't need company to pee."

DT snorted a laugh while Scorpia deflated a bit.

"Got it, Wildcat," Scorpia said, a hopeful smile playing at her lips. "See you after class."

Ducking away from the others, Catra made a beeline to the closest washroom. She let out a sigh of relief when she found it empty. The truth was, she didn't really need to be there, she just needed a quiet moment to herself. At a sink on the far end of the room, Catra gripped the edge of the counter and took a few slow breaths. Her reflection stared back at her from the mirror. From her neatly pressed uniform to her carefully coiffed hair, she was a picture of Valkyrie perfection. But the furrow of her brow gave her away, and she knew she needed to get a hold of herself before she could venture back out into the school she was supposed to rule.

Her mismatched eyes flicked up to the ribbons adorning her ponytail, and she scowled. She hated this stupid plan. She didn't want to do it for so many reasons, and it made her miserable to know that she didn't have a choice in the matter. Coach Weaver didn't care that being part of the glee club meant Catra wouldn't be able to avoid Adora anymore. It didn't bother her that, in order to earn the trust of Vocal Rebellion, Catra was going to have to pretend she wasn't still furious with Adora for choosing them over her.

Catra wasn't stupid — she knew perfectly well that the only reason Coach Weaver really wanted glee club gone was because

she wanted Adora back on the squad. After the audition, Coach Weaver had been waiting for them outside of the band room.

"Well?" she asked, her words clipped with impatience.

Catra had shrugged. "What do you think? We're in."

"Excellent." It was the closest thing Catra was going to get to a compliment, and she was embarrassed by how much that scrap of kindness lifted her. "Do not waste time — I want the glee club dissolved with time to spare before Nationals, do you understand?"

Yeah, Catra understood.

Dueling desires made a battleground out of her heart. If she did what Coach Weaver wanted, she'd have Adora back, without having to worry about Vocal Rebellion getting in the way. But would that really matter? Besides, for the first time in her life, Catra was the one in control. She was on top, with social capital that gave her a kind of power she'd never had before. Did she really want to give that up?

Catra scoffed at her reflection. *Yeah, right*.

Deep down, she knew that sense of control was just an illusion, though it was fun to pretend. After all, if it weren't, she would have been able to tell Coach Weaver to shove it — she never would have agreed to this stupid plan in the first place.

Not that she'd agreed to it at all, but that's not how being a Valkyrie worked. Coach Weaver always got what she wanted.

Besides, when it came to Coach Weaver, hating her with every fiber of her being didn't do Catra any good — there was still a traitorous part of her that wanted to prove her wrong. And that part, no matter how foolish Catra knew it to be, was strong enough to keep her playing Coach Weaver's game, shitty odds be damned.

So, Catra took a breath and gave her head a shake. She stared down her reflection until her tense expression melted into a mask of smug satisfaction. It was time to get her head back in the game.

*

Between the audition, a full day of classes, and two hours of Valkyries practice, Catra was beyond exhausted when the day finally came to an end. Rather than walk, she let Scorpia drive her back to the group home. As they pulled up to the curb, Catra looked to Adora's window and found it dark. Though it irked her to know that probably meant Adora was off spending another night with her replacement friends, Catra was relieved to know she wouldn't have to face her right away.

"You okay, Wildcat?"

Scorpia's voice was soft, but Catra had been so lost in thought that the question made her jump.

"What? Oh, yeah, I'm fine. Just tired." She crammed her hands into the pockets of her varsity jacket and ducked her chin into the popped collar.

"Well, in that case, I hope you sleep tight." Scorpia flashed a warm smile that Catra could only reciprocate a fraction of. Then, just as Catra reached for the door handle, Scorpia caught her gently by the elbow. "Listen, I know you're the strong and broody type but, if you ever need to talk or vent or anything, I'm here for you. You know that, right? Just give me a call and I'll be there."

Catra sighed. Under normal circumstances she'd be embarrassed by Scorpia's eagerness, but nothing really felt normal these days and she didn't have the energy to come up with a snarky response. Besides, it was kind of nice to know she had someone in her corner, even if there was no way she'd ever take Scorpia up on the offer.

"Sure," Catra said, pushing the door open with one hand and grabbing her bag with the other. "And thanks. Y'know, for everything."

It was as diplomatic as Catra was willing to get, but it seemed to do the trick; Scorpia beamed, clearly satisfied with what little Catra had to give. Catra stood on the sidewalk and waved as Scorpia drove away. The autumn nights were growing colder by the day, and already the streets were dark and lonely. Burrowing deeper into her jacket, Catra turned on her heel and rushed for the door.

"Catra."

Adora's voice rose from the shadows, punctuating the quiet in a way that made it seem like she was shouting. Catra leapt back with a startled yelp. Her eyes darted up to the top step, where they found Adora blocking the door with her hands on her hips.

"What the fuck, Adora?" Catra hissed through gritted teeth. "You scared the shit out of me. What were you doing? Hiding in the bushes or something?"

"We need to talk."

Catra swallowed. It wasn't often Adora took that authoritative, no-bull shit tone with her. Then again, Catra rarely found herself on Adora's bad side. Still, she'd been expecting some kind of confrontation after today, so she tipped her chin up and stared Adora down as if the anger in her ex-best friend's voice didn't cut her down to her core.

"Any chance we can do this inside?" she drawled, doing her best impression of someone with somewhere better to be. "I'm freezing."

But Adora was already off the steps and closing the distance between them with quick, wide strides. Catra fought her urge to shrink away when Adora crowded her space, holding her ground defiantly.

"What do you think you're doing?" Adora asked.

"I thought I was coming home from practice, but—"

"Stop it," Adora snapped, and this time Catra did flinch. "You know what I'm talking about."

Catra narrowed her eyes but said nothing. After a tense moment of silence, Adora's shoulders sank.

"Come on, Catra," she said. The hard edge in her voice was gone now. Instead, she sounded exasperated. "You literally laughed in my face when I asked you to audition for glee, and now you're suddenly interested in joining Vocal Rebellion? Coach Weaver put you up to this, didn't she? Why? What's she up to?"

Hot indignation boiled in the pit of Catra's stomach. It didn't matter that Adora was right — the fact that she immediately jumped to accusations made Catra want to scream. She knew she was supposed to be playing nice, but something inside of her wasn't interested in following the rules.

"Are you serious?" Catra snarled, shoving past Adora. "That's the first place your mind went? Thanks a lot."

But Adora wasn't about to let Catra storm away on her like she usually did. As Catra pushed toward the door, Adora grabbed her by her arm and whirled her back around to face her. The move caught Catra by surprise, as did the fact that she suddenly found herself mere inches from Adora's face.

"We both know what Coach Weaver's like, Catra. Besides, I heard her talking to Mrs. Moon this morning. I know there's something else going on. Please, just tell me why you're doing this."

Catra scowled. "Maybe I was doing it for you. Did that cross your mind, or were you too busy assuming the worst of me?"

Finally, Adora's icy expression faltered, and her grip softened. Taking advantage of this momentary weakness, Catra tried to pull

away. But Adora held fast, doubling her hold on Catra by grabbing her other arm too. They were so close that Catra could feel the warmth of Adora's breath on her cold cheeks.

"Is that true?" Adora's voice was small, her words painfully hopeful.

Catra licked her lips and steadied her nerves. "Why wouldn't it be?"

"I just— We haven't been..." Adora hesitated, her eye's searching Catra's in the dim street light. "I mean, that would be amazing. But... I guess I'm just confused."

For a split second, the world stood still. For a heartbeat's worth of time, Catra forgot why she was so angry. She wanted to know what Adora was thinking so badly it hurt. It was as if whatever Adora said next could be all Catra needed to call the whole thing off.

"What are you confused about?" she asked.

Adora shook her head. "I don't understand why Coach Weaver is suddenly okay with this after she wouldn't let me be on both teams."

Catra wasn't sure what she was hoping to hear, but it certainly wasn't that. That brief wisp of hope dissipated like smoke from an extinguished candle, and all at once Catra's anger and resentment flooded back to her like the darkness the flame left behind. Humiliation scorched Catra's insides at having dared to hope that Adora wanted her more than she wanted the truth — more than she cared about whatever Coach Weaver was doing behind the scenes.

She closed her eyes and composed herself. When she opened them again, Catra gazed up at Adora through her lashes and leaned forward into the modicum of space between them. This time it was Adora's turn to be taken by surprise.

"Y'know, Adora, I thought you'd be happy about this," Catra said, dropping her voice to a husky whisper. She pressed closer still and pouted her lips. She was close enough to feel the heat of Adora's blush radiating from her flushed cheeks. "After all, isn't this what you wanted?"

Adora swallowed. "Catra, I— I mean, yes. But—"

Catra smiled. *Gottcha*.

She could have left it there.

She could have wrapped her arms around Adora and hugged her tight.

She could have told her how happy she was that they were finally able to be together again.

But Catra wasn't ready to play nice — not yet, anyway.

In a sudden move, she jerked away, and this time Adora didn't see it coming. Catra stepped back, far enough that Adora couldn't grab her again. She pressed a finger to her lips and arranged her face into an expression of feigned surprise.

"Actually, come to think of it—" she reached up and made a show of fluffing her Captain's ribbons "—I guess *I've* got everything you wanted, huh?"

The sight of Adora's face falling was the sweetest revenge Catra could ask for. She gave Adora's forehead a quick, teasing poke before turning away. She paused at the door and glanced back to where Adora stood, gobsmack and gaping wordlessly.

"It's weird how things work out, isn't it?" Catra winked. "See you at rehearsal, princess."


Maggie Derrick

Chapter 26

"All I'm saying is regionals might feel like it's still a long ways off, but winter break is going to be here before we know it." Adora was talking a mile a minute, her hands gesturing wildly as she tried to emphasize her point. Glimmer and Bow strode along at her side as they made their way through the busy hallway. "And you know what's after winter break?"

"January?" Bow said, even though it clearly wasn't the answer Adora was looking for.

"Regionals!" Adora tossed her hands in the air and Bow stifled a laugh.

"Okay, Adora, I get it!" Glimmer huffed. "I know the competition schedule, okay? I just thought it would be a good idea to let the new team have a bit of time to get used to each other before we started building our routine."

An uneasy silence fell around the friends. Glimmer wasn't wrong, nor was she lying — it *had* been a good idea to give Vocal Rebellion a couple of weeks to get used to their three new members. Having Catra, Scorpia, and DT on the team shifted the groups' dynamic, what with their big personalities and dubious intentions. Adora had spent every day since the Valkyries' audition waiting for the other shoe to drop. She was perpetually on edge, watching for some sign that something was off. As much as she wanted to believe that Catra had joined the glee club in an effort to mend their friendship, Adora couldn't shake the fact that something just didn't feel right.

That was the part that Glimmer was leaving out: Adora's insistence that something was amiss had them so spooked that they decided to wait and see if the Valkyries were really up to no good. And, though things between Adora and Catra were just as tense as they had been before, even she had to admit that everything seemed pretty… normal.

“We’ll start planning today, okay?” Glimmer said, breaking the quiet. “We can spend the entire practice— ugh!” She came to a dead stop mid-stride, tossing her head back in frustration.

Adora and Bow craned their heads and saw what had Glimmer so irritated — a group of senior students was loitering in front of her locker, including her neighbor who had the door of his wide open, making it impossible to reach hers. He leaned casually against it as he talked with his friends, completely oblivious to the fact that Glimmer was waiting impatiently to get by.

“He always does this,” Glimmer growled under her breath. “I am *not* in the mood to deal with this jerk today.

She wasn’t wrong — the kid was a bit of a jerk.

“We’ll just ask them to move,” Bow said, giving Glimmer’s shoulder a reassuring squeeze.

“Right,” she scoffed. “Like that ever works.” Usually when Glimmer’s locker neighbor was holding court with his gang, the Best Friends Squad had to stand aside and wait until he and his goons moved on.

Adora glanced at her phone — the break was almost over.

“Don’t worry.” She smiled at her friends. “‘I’ve got this.”

Before Glimmer or Bow could talk her out of it, Adora pressed forward and wedged herself into the raucous group of seniors. When they turned their attention to her, Adora lit up with a dazzling smile.

“Hey there! My friend needs to get to her locker,” she said brightly, pointing at the space where the ringleader was leaning. “Would you mind?”

The senior let out a snort of laughter. He shoved off the locker and leaned menacingly into Adora’s space. “I *would* mind, actually. You kids can wait until we’re done.”

Adora rolled her eyes. She wasn't afraid of this guy, but there also wasn't much she could do. Even though it had been months since she was kicked off the cheer squad, Adora couldn't believe how rude kids could be if you weren't in a set of reds.

"Did you just roll your eyes at me?" the senior snapped, drawing himself up tall. All around them, his friends laughed and jeered. "Listen, loser, you need to know your—"

"Hey!"

Adora turned with a start. There, standing beside Glimmer and Bow, was Catra. Scorpia and DT flanked her on either side like a pair of bodyguards. Catra crossed her arms and narrowed a menacing glare at the senior. "What, are you too dumb to understand a simple sentence? She told you to get out of the way."

Swallowing, Adora glanced back at the guy. "Well, technically I *asked*, but—"

"Beat it," Catra snapped, cutting her off.

The senior scowled. He hesitated, clearly conflicted. "I don't have to do shit."

Catra lifted her chin, unphased. "Scorpia?"

Scorpia stepped forward, towering over the senior with a generous few inches to spare. She reached past him and grabbed his locker door, slamming it shut with enough force to make his entire entourage flinch, all while smiling warmly.

That was all it took to send the senior and his gang into retreat. They shot a few dirty looks back over their shoulders and muttered under their breath, but that was all — the confrontation was over.

"There ya go, Sparkles," Catra announced, stepping aside with a sweep of her hand. "All clear."

Glimmer blinked. “Uh, thanks?” She glanced to Adora, who could only gape wordlessly in reply. “But… why?”

“Why what?” Catra asked, her tone disinterested.

“We’re on the same team now, remember?” DT purred, wrapping an arm around Glimmer’s shoulder. “When you’ve got the Valkyries in your corner, you’re pretty much unstoppable.” They tipped their head toward Adora and smirked. “Isn’t that right, princess?”

It took every ounce of willpower Adora had to keep her expression neutral. “Yeah, sure.”

Catra yawned and breezed past Adora. “Anyway, we’ve got places to be.” She lifted a hand and waved over her shoulder without looking back. “See you cool kids at practice.”

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow watched the Valkyries disappear into the crowd. They waited until they were sure the cheerleaders were out of earshot before daring to speak a word.

“Okay, *what* was that?” Glimmer squawked.

“Is this our life now?” Bow asked. He looked equal parts confused and impressed.

Exasperated, Adora sighed. Her shoulders slumped in defeat. “I guess it is.”

*

When classes ended for the day, Vocal Rebellion met in the band room for practice. Adora sat in a seat, hunched over the notebook in which she’d been collecting ideas for the team’s performance at regionals. Out of the corner of her eye, she could see Catra across the room, slouched in a chair next to Scorpia, who was in the middle of a very animated conversation with Perfuma. She knew the Valkyries had a qualifier coming up, and normally that would mean evening practices every single day. But apparently Coach

Weaver had decided to make yet another concession where her unholy trinity was concerned, and Adora did her best not to let that get to her.

She reminded herself that, whatever arrangement Coach Weaver had made, it probably wasn't as good as it looked from the outside. Earlier that day, Adora noticed Catra drifting off in class. As she watched Catra's eyelids droop, Adora felt compassion swell instinctively at her core. She remembered all too well how exhausting it was to juggle both glee and cheer. Despite everything, she actually felt bad for Catra.

Maybe there was a lingering sense of gratitude after what had happened at the lockers, but Adora decided to swallow her pride. She wadded a piece of paper into a ball and surreptitiously flicked it at Catra when the teacher wasn't looking. Catra sat up with a jolt, surprised into wakefulness. She cut a look back at Adora, who responded with a quick, tight smile before looking away.

There, Adora thought. *We're even*.

Now, Catra still looked weary, but as far as Adora was concerned, she was on her own from this point on.

Once everyone was present and accounted for, Glimmer skipped to the front of the room and clapped her hands. "Alright everyone! Tonight we're going to spend our practice time brainstorming ideas for regionals."

A ripple of excitement traveled through the room. Everyone picked up their chairs and dragged them into a clustered circle so they could face one another as they floated ideas. Pen already in hand, Adora took notes and tried to ignore the fact that Catra was seated directly across from her.

After a few minutes of chatter, Mermista spoke up above the din. "Okay, I think we're getting ahead of ourselves here. First things first: are we doing another theme this time, or nah?"

After a beat of silence, Adora glanced up from her notebook to discover every set of eyes in the room was on her. She flinched back in her seat. “What? Why is everyone looking at me?”

“You came up with the theme last time,” Spinerella offered. “I guess we figured you had another brilliant idea for this performance too.”

DT glanced around the circle. “What was the theme last time?”

“Rebellion,” Catra answered.

Adora’s gaze snapped up, and for the first time since practice started, she and Catra made eye contact. They had never addressed Catra’s presence at sectionals and, based on Catra’s red-faced expression, it seemed she realized her mistake.

“I mean, that’s what I heard,” Catra said, trying to play it off.

“Well, Adora?” Bow asked. “Any ideas?”

Pulling out her phone, Adora opened her music app. She had plenty of ideas, and had—of course—already arranged them into carefully crafted playlists. “What about—”

“Oh!” Perfuma sat up straight and waved a tanned hand into the middle of the circle. “Can we do something fun and happy? Like, ‘friendship’, or—”

“Gross,” Catra cut in with a scowl. “This isn’t a concert for kindergarteners.”

Adora huffed quietly. She knew that was probably a jab at her, but she wasn’t about to take the bait.

“We could always sing about love,” Seahawk said, leaning into Mermista’s side. She responded with a groan.

“Or heartbreak,” DT countered. “There are plenty of songs about love gone wrong.”

Glimmer sighed. “Too cliche. Anyone can sing about being in love or having a broken heart. We need something that’s relatable but… different.”

Lips pursed, Adora scanned her music. Her eyes fell on a newer playlist, something she’d put together only a couple months earlier when everything in her life changed. She hesitated, wondering if the idea was too obvious.

“What about—” she paused to clear her throat, which had suddenly gone alarmingly dry “—what if we went with ‘yearning’?”

The room fell quiet as the club considered the word. Blushing, Adora felt the need to deflect — to explain herself before anyone could overthink her suggestion.

“It’s the best of both worlds,” she blustered. “Like a mix between love and heartbreak, still hopeful…” She trailed off.

Glimmer tapped her chin thoughtfully. “I like the idea of narrowing it down a bit. Do you have any songs in mind?”

Brightening, Adora held up her phone. “I’ve got a few here that I think could work.”

She froze as Catra got to her feet and cut across the circle toward her.

“Let me see,” Catra demanded, grabbing the phone from Adora’s hand. She regarded the playlist with an impassive expression, and Adora held her breath.

Then, slowly, a smile slid across Catra’s face. She nodded and handed the phone back to Adora.

“Nice,” she said, and Adora could tell she meant it. Catra grinned at the rest of the team. “Vocal Rebellion, I think we’ve got our theme.”

Chapter 27

Catra sat in one of the stiff chairs in Coach Weaver's office, her arms crossed tightly as she fought to stay awake. It was too early for this—before the Valkyries' morning practice, which was early enough as it was—and she couldn't even pretend to give a shit.

Coach Weaver paced behind her desk, hands clasped tightly behind her back.

"You're wasting precious time," Coach Weaver hissed as she made another lap.

Miserable, Catra sank lower in her seat. "What do you want from me? I'm working on it, sheesh."

"You know what I want from you." Coach Weaver whirled around, her dark hair whipping as she moved. Catra jerked back but kept her glare strong. "What is taking so long?"

"If you want us to take the glee club down from the inside, you've got to give us time to earn their trust first," Catra said, her stomach churning with what might have been guilt. "They're not stupid — they know something's up."

Or at least Adora does, she thought. She bit her lip and forced the memory of that night on the front steps of the group home back into the recesses of her mind.

"Is that so?"

Catra's ears perked up. She recognized that tone — the way Coach Weaver masked her distrust in notes of intrigue. Slowly, Coach Weaver rounded her desk and came to stand at Catra's side. It was as though Catra could feel the ill-intent radiating off of her, and she edged to the far side of her seat just to be free of it.

“Have you done something to rouse suspicion?” Coach Weaver asked.

“Of course not,” Catra balked, letting her facade of indifference slip and immediately hating herself for it.

Coach Weaver placed a hand on her shoulder. Her long fingers curled, the tips digging in tightly until Catra winced. “I expect movement on the plan. The next time we meet, you *will* have something to tell me.”

Fuck you, is what Catra thought.

“Whatever you say, Coach,” is what she said.

*

After morning practice, Catra sulked through the halls alone. She’d managed to shake Scorpia and DT — the last thing she wanted to do right now was deal with their prying questions. Exhausted, she stopped at her locker and tossed her bag to the bottom. She couldn’t even be bothered to hang it up properly. After fishing out the books she needed for first period and tucking her phone into the waistband of her uniform skirt, Catra took a moment to give herself a quick appraisal in the mirror mounted on her locker door. There was an empty space just above the top right corner of the mirror where a photo used to sit. In it, she and Adora stood close, wrapped in each other’s arms after last year’s win at nationals, with their tongues sticking out at the camera from between their grinning lips. It had been an amazing moment, one Catra hoped to remember for the rest of her life.

She tore the photo down the day Adora chose Vocal Rebellion over her. As far as she knew, it was still buried at the bottom of her locker underneath her bag and the chaos of loose notes she had no intention of ever looking at again.

Still, she had grown so accustomed to seeing Adora’s face when she looked into the mirror that it took her a moment to realize the Adora she could see hovering over her shoulder now wasn’t a

photo, but a reflection. In fact, it wasn't until Adora smiled back at her that Catra's sleep-deprived brain understood what was happening, and she whirled around with a gasp.

"What are you doing?" she demanded.

Adora's smile faltered. Her eyes dropped downward and Catra followed their trajectory to find two cups of iced coffee clutched in Adora's hands.

"Sorry," Adora said without looking up. "I didn't mean to sneak up on you. I just— this is for you." She thrust a cup toward Catra. "You seemed tired yesterday, and I know morning practices suck, so I thought you could use the caffeine."

Catra hesitated. There was no doubt in her mind that this was about the paper ball in yesterday's biology class. A part of her burned with both embarrassment and bitterness that Adora could see her struggling to keep up. Even with Coach Weaver's enabling, being captain of the Valkyries and a member of Vocal Rebellion was taking its toll. But there wasn't much she could do to hide it — after all, Adora had been there herself, not that long ago.

Coach Weaver's words echoed through Catra's mind.

The next time we meet, you will have something to tell me.

Pursing her lips, she took the cup Adora was offering. As her hand wrapped around the plastic, her fingers grazed Adora's, sending a flood of self-loathing into the pit of Catra's stomach.

"Thanks." It was all she trusted herself to say under the scrutiny of those pale blue eyes.

Adora responded with that goofy, hopeful smile of hers. "No problem. See you at practice."

And just like that, Catra was alone again.

*

On Catra's orders, Scorpia and DT met her outside the band room before glee practice for a quick meeting.

"Okay, listen," she hissed, as her fellow Valkyries circled in close. "Coach Weaver is getting pissy. We need to give her something to prove that we're actually trying to sabotage Vocal Rebellion, so I need both of you to do some digging today. Talk to these nerds and try to find something we can use against them."

Scorpia bit her lip and shifted, obviously uncomfortable. "I dunno, Wildcat. I've been keeping an eye out, but they all seem so—"

"Ugh, do not say *nice*," DT interrupted with a huff. They then turned their attention to Catra with an eyebrow raised. "Why are we messing around when you know Adora better than anyone? You must know something about her that we can—"

"Did I stutter?" Catra snarled. "I said what I said — just get in there and find something, okay?"

With mutters of acquiencese, the circle broke and the Valkyries made their way inside. They paused in the doorway and considered their options. Scorpia was the first to make a move, beelining to where Perfuma sat chatting brightly with Netossa and Spinerella, while DT slouched off toward Mermista and Seahawk, who were bickering about who knows what. Adora sat between Glimmer and Bow, their heads bent together as they discussed the musical arrangements for regionals. Catra huffed — she had no interest in inserting herself into that conversation. The last thing she needed was to give Adora the idea that her peace offering had worked.

And then her eyes turned to the one chair that sat apart from all the rest. In it, a lilac-haired senior sat cross-legged with a tablet balanced on her ankles. Entrapta was completely engrossed in whatever was on the screen, and didn't seem to notice nor care about anything happening around her. In fact, during Catra's brief

tenure in glee club, she hadn't once gotten the sense that Entrapta cared about show choir at all. When she wasn't singing, Entrapta was stealing moments to work on her tablet or tinker with some new electronic mess of wires and circuit boards she carried around in the deep pockets of her overalls.

Catra smiled — she had her mark.

Slinking across the room, Catra grabbed a chair and pulled it up to Entrapta's side. That didn't get Entrapta's attention, nor did the loud way Catra flopped down into the seat, so Catra cleared her throat and leaned in to peer over her shoulder.

"Whatcha lookin' at?" Catra asked.

At last, Entrapta looked up. Her magenta eyes turned to Catra in surprise. Then she swiveled to look past her own shoulder. She turned back to Catra and tilted her head. "Are you talking to me?"

"Uh, yeah? Who else would I be talking to?"

Entrapta shifted. "Sorry, I'm not used to people starting conversations with me. Or, maybe they try but I'm not paying attention. Anyway, what did you ask again?"

Catra smiled. What was that word DT liked to use to describe nerds like this?

Oh, right. *Tragic*.

"I asked what you're looking at," Catra said patiently. She pointed to the tablet. "You seem pretty into it."

"This?" Entrapta held the tablet up so Catra could see the screen. "I was just reading up about this amazing internship opportunity."

Catra quickly scanned the website — a listing for some company called Horde Technologies. "Never heard of them. What do they do?"

When she looked up, Catra found Entrapta gazing back at her in awe.

"Are you seriously asking me about tech?" Entrapta asked, her eyes wide and starry. "No one ever wants to talk about tech with me!"

Hoo boy, Catra thought. *Coach Weaver better appreciate this*. She smiled brightly.

"Is this company a big deal or something?"

"Only the biggest deal in advanced robotics! I would love to work for them some day — they're changing the game in the A.I. field."

"Sounds fancy," Catra said, nodding as if she cared. "So what's the deal with this internship?"

At this, Entrapta deflated a bit. "Oh, it's amazing. Whoever gets it will be working directly with Dr. Hordak. He's a brilliant researcher and technician. He's literally my hero. But the position starts in the new year."

Catra cocked her head thoughtfully. An idea was starting to form like a storm cloud in her mind. "Like, during the semester?"

"Yeah. I'd still get credits and stuff, but…" Entrapta hesitated and sighed. "I don't know, maybe I should wait. Besides, I told Glimmer I'd help her out with glee club."

"How so?" Catra asked, genuinely curious now. So far she hadn't seen Entrapta do more than provide distracted back-up vocals.

"Well, you know how show choirs need to have a minimum number of members to be eligible for competitions? Glimmer needed one extra person on the team and I needed an arts extra curricular to round out my college applications." Entrapta shrugged. "It's a pretty perfect arrangement when you think about it."

At that moment, the swirling storm clouds in Catra's mind erupted. Lightning flashed, and all at once she knew what she needed to do.

Feigning an air of excitement, Catra plastered on her best cheer smile and leaned in close.

"You realize that doesn't matter anymore, right?" Coyly, Catra hooked her finger through a lock of one of Entrapta's long pigtails and twirled it. "Now that me, Scorpia, and DT are on the team, Vocal Rebellion has more than enough members. And it's not like having glee club on your record is going to hold a candle to actual, real world experience, right?" As she watched Entrapta's eyes grow somehow wider, Catra knew she had her. She just needed to seal the deal. "Besides, Glimmer's *such* a good friend — I'm sure she'd understand if you had to leave if it means you get to work with your hero."

"Oooh my gosh. You're right!" Entrapta whispered. She was almost vibrating with excitement. "Do you think I should do it? Should I apply?"

"Uh, I think it would be a crime not to," Catra replied.

Entrapta erupted with a joyous squeal so loud that Catra had to clamp her hands over her ears to spare her eardrums. "Thank you, Catra! I'm so glad you joined glee club. I'm going to do it — I'm going to apply today!"

Catra was so pleased with herself that she didn't even squirm when Entrapta wrapped her in a tight, bone-crushing hug.

For the first time in a long time, Catra felt like things were finally coming together.

Chapter 28

"Wow," Glimmer breathed, her sparkling eyes taking in the scene before her.

Unable to contain her excitement, Adora's mouth split into a wide grin. "I know, right?"

"Let me get this straight," Bow said. "*All* of these people are here... for a cheerleading competition?"

"Technically it's a qualifier," Adora corrected. "But yes."

"Are you sure?" he pressed, sounding intimidated.

Adora put one hand on his shoulder and the other over her heart. "I wouldn't lie to you, Bow."

"Wow," Glimmer whispered again.

The three of them stood shoulder to shoulder in the middle of a busy convention center concourse floor. They had borrowed Bow's dads' car and driven nearly an hour to the next city over just to be there. The energy in the building was not unlike that of a beehive: buzzing, as everyone moved with energy and purpose. Adora bounced on the balls of her feet as she returned the waves and calls of hello from people she only ever saw at cheer events. She may not have been a cheerleader anymore, but that didn't mean she loved the pomp and circumstance any less.

Glimmer turned in place, incredulous. "I can't believe this many people are here because of cheerleading! This place is packed!"

"People take competitive cheer pretty seriously," Adora replied distractedly. Her eyes combed over the schedule, which she crossed referenced against the time on her phone. "Okay, come on. Our division is up soon and I want to make sure we get good seats!"

Having spent her fair share of days competing in this very convention center, Adora knew exactly where they needed to be. She led the way through the mob of spectators, uniformed squads, and cheer moms, while Glimmer and Bow hurried to keep up with her brisk pace. When they rounded the corner into B Hall, Adora's shoulders tensed with irritation when she saw the first few rows of audience seating were already spoken for.

"Ugh," she muttered, craning her neck as she wove around clusters of people and professional camera equipment. "Let's go up to the front anyway and double check — maybe there are some free seats that we can't see from back here."

At her elbow, Bow laughed. "Adora, relax. The only thing you have to do today is watch and support your friends. Does it really matter where we sit?"

Adora opened her mouth to argue that—yes, obviously it mattered where they sat—when Glimmer cut in.

"Do they even know we're here?"

Adora paused. She wondered where Glimmer was going with this. "Well, no. I kind of wanted it to be a surprise."

Glimmer folded her arms and raised an eyebrow. "Right, because Catra *totally* seems like the kind of person who appreciates surprises."

She made a good point.

Lips pursed, Adora looked back over her shoulder and considered their options. No, she hadn't told Catra or the others that she was planning on coming today. In truth, she thought of it as her way of returning the favor to Catra, whose clandestine appearance at sectionals had unwittingly given Adora the confidence she needed to nail her solo. But she still hadn't told Glimmer and Bow about that, so instead she had proposed this field trip to the city as a way to show support for their Valkyrie team mates.

But Glimmer was right — spotting Adora in the audience would likely have the opposite effect on Catra than what seeing her had done for Adora. Not wanting to be the reason Catra tripped up on stage, Adora relented to better logic.

"Okay, I guess the fourth row is fine," she conceded with a sigh. So they shuffled down the row and found three seats together; close enough to the stage to still have a good view, but not so close that they'd be immediately spotted. Bow stood aside and motioned for the girls to take the seats with the best vantage points, to which Glimmer snorted a laugh and pulled him down beside her. While they whispered and giggled with one another, Adora pored over the program and took notes the same way she would have if she were still a Valkyrie. Old habits really did die hard.

When she was sure the others weren't looking, Adora pulled out her phone, opened her messaging app, and stared at an incredibly brief exchange from early that morning.

Good luck today! she had texted after watching Catra toss her duffle bag into the trunk of Scorpia's car and climb into the passenger seat. Through her bedroom window Adora watched Catra read the message, phone in one hand as she used the other to pull her seatbelt over her shoulder. Catra's brow quirked as Scorpia put the car in drive, and she glanced at Adora's window just as they pulled away. Their eyes met for only a fraction of a second.

A minute later, Catra replied.

Thanks

It was the first time Catra had replied to one of Adora's messages since their falling out earlier in the year. It was just one word, but Adora stared at it like the letters of the word made up the path of a secret treasure map. Adora wasn't naive — she still couldn't shake the sinking feeling that the Valkyries were up to something. But in those moments where she allowed herself to suspend her

disbelief—moments that were coming more and more frequently as time passed—the more Adora let herself enjoy having Catra back in her life. Things between them were still fraught, and often Adora felt like if she moved too fast, she might wake up to discover it had all been a dream. But one word answers were better than radio silence, so Adora decided to take what she could get.

Adora was so focused on the one word still glowing on her screen that she didn't pay much attention when Glimmer's and Bow's whispering shifted from playful and gossipy to frantic.

"Oh, shit! She's right there!"

"Do you think she saw us?"

"I don't know, get Adora down!"

Before she could look up, the hood of Adora'a sweatshirt was wrenched over her head and pulled down low over her face. She let out a yelp of surprise.

"Bow, what are you doing?" she hissed, trying to pry his hands off her hood.

"Shh, keep your voice down," he whispered back.

"Why?"

Glimmer leaned across Bow's lap and peered up into Adora's face through the small opening of her hood. "Coach Weaver's over there being interviewed by someone."

Stomach dropping, Adora sank low in her seat and took over control of her hood from Bow. her eyes darted around furtively until she spotted Coach Weaver, who stood in front of a video crew answering questions with an air of superiority that Adora could feel from across the room.

"Who is she talking to?" Bow asked.

"It's a media interview," Adora grumbled. "Everyone wants to talk to the coach of the reigning champs."

"Huh." Bow nodded. "Yeah, I guess that makes sense."

"A media interview," Glimmer said. She ran a hand through her hair and sighed. "A convention center full of fans. Geeze, you really gave up a lot when you picked us over the Valkyries, Adora."

Now it was Adora's turn to lean across Bow's lap. She took Glimmer's hand and squeezed it. "None of those things matter to me, Glimmer. I don't regret my choice."

"That's a good thing," Bow said, gently pushing the girls back from his personal space. "Because I think you're officially out of time to change your mind — looks like they're about to get started."

He pointed to the stage, where a woman from the organizing committee was striding out with a wide grin and bouncing, perfectly coiffed hair. With a bright and chipper voice, she alerted the audience that the level 5 senior division routines were about to get started. People hurried to take their seats, flooding in from the hallway until all the chairs were full and the stragglers were left standing against the back wall. Adora stayed low and tracked Coach Weaver as she breezed around the room and disappeared backstage. Only then did she straighten up, but she left her hood on.

Adora leaned into her friends to explain how the rest of the event would work. Each team would get to perform two routines: one technical routine, where they would be scored on their stunts and form, and one freestyle routine, which was less structured and would judge them based on the creativity of their choreography and overall execution. Privately she wondered if Catra kept the routines the two of them came up with together over the summer, or if she abandoned them in the way she felt Adora had abandoned her and started fresh.

Throughout the other teams' performances—all of which were high-energy and full of the spectacular stuns expected of level 5 teams—Adora whispered notes to Glimmer and Bow about the technique on display. She told them how to recognize things that would cost teams precious points, and explained the kind of grace and strength that went into moves that the athletes on stage made look easy. Awestruck, her friends hung on every word, all without tearing their eyes away from the performances.

Then the Stevenson High School Valkyries Cheer Force was called to the stage. The entire room erupted in applause for the national champions as they took their places. Adora's heart leapt to her throat at the sight of them — at how effortlessly confident they looked with their red uniforms gleaming in the light and their smiling faces held high.

There was a beat of silence as the squad struck their starting pose in the moment before the music started. Adora's eyes fixed on Catra, who held herself like a queen, poised and unshakable.

"You got this, Catra," Adora whispered under her breath.

And then the music started, blasting from the speaker system and eliciting a fresh round of cheers from the audience. Adora was thrilled: at least for the technical routine, Catra hadn't changed a thing. The song was a bit older — an upbeat party remix that mashed-up a DJ track called "So Real" with a song by Jess Glynne called "Warriors". Adora and Catra had come across it one lazy summer afternoon while combing through an online music streaming app. They both took to it immediately, and Adora added it to her "Force Captain" playlist as a way of manifesting their future.

As the Valkyries performed, Glimmer and Bow oooh'd and aww'd right along with the rest of the crowd. Adora was grateful that her friends were so enthralled by the performance, not only because it made her swell with pride, but also because it meant they were too distracted to need her commentary. Even if they'd wanted her input, she herself was far too invested to be of any help. Adora

watched every flip and twist, every mount and toss, with breathless focus. She counted out the beats, running through the routine she'd help create in her mind and giving a subtle pump of her fist for every difficult move the squad pulled off. They were spectacular, and as she watched Catra twist mid-air and land in the waiting arms of her tanks, Adora knew her former team was in good hands with Catra at the helm.

It wasn't until the routine came to a close that Adora realized, somewhere along the line, she had stopped watching the rest of the squad. She had been so entranced with Catra's graceful movement and flawless technique, that she had to shake her head when it was over just to bring herself back into the present. It was only then that Adora realized she must have missed something.

Standing at Catra's side, Lonnie held her finishing pose with the same air of triumph as the rest of the squad. But something about her expression looked tense, her smile bordering on a grimace and a light sheen of sweat glistening on her brow. Catra was saying something to her out of the corner of her mouth without looking, or letting her own smile waver. When it came time for the team to exit the stage, Adora watched Catra say something to Rogelio, who immediately scooped Lonnie up and placed her on his shoulder. All the while, Lonnie never stopped smiling. She beamed at the audience from her perch and waved until she and the others disappeared backstage.

The program called for a brief intermission between the technical and freestyle routines. Adora jumped to her feet.

"C'mon," she motioned to Glimmer and Bow. "We have to get backstage."

"Why?" Glimmer asked, tilting her head curiously. "I thought you wanted to lay low."

"Yeah, Adora," Bow agreed with a nod. "Besides, if you try to get back there, Coach Weaver will see you for sure."

But Adora shook her head. "I'm willing to risk it."

Glimmer and Bow exchange a wide-eyed look of surprise.

"You are?" Glimmer balked, standing up anyway.

Bow frowned but followed her lead. "How come?"

Adora was already making her way down the row. She glanced back at her friends over her shoulder and waved for them to follow.

"Because something's wrong."

Chapter 29

Getting backstage was the easy part. It didn't matter that none of them had passes draped around their necks like everyone else — Adora was such a familiar and well-liked face in the local cheer circuit that no one thought twice about letting her, Bow, and Glimmer breeze into the performers' area.

The hard part was staying inconspicuous and out of sight while they waited for Coach Weaver to leave.

Hood up, Adora loitered behind a clustered cheer team and stole sneaky glances between their shoulders. From what she could see, Coach Weaver was giving the Valkyries a hard time about something, as usual. They stood in front of her in a neat line and took their berating in stoic silence. Adora huffed and shook her head. She didn't miss being treated like that at all.

Finally, someone hurried to Coach Weaver's side and got her attention. They motioned to the exit into the main hall and Coach Weaver nodded.

"I think this is it," Glimmer whispered from where she and Bow crouched behind a mound of gear bags, peering through ankles. Adora joined them, keen to stay out of sight as Coach Weaver swept through the room. Most people were smart enough to scamper out of her way. Those that weren't fast enough were unceremoniously shoved instead. No one dared to challenge her.

"Man, she is…" Bow hesitated, choosing his words carefully.

"A bitch." Glimmer finished for him. "She's a bitch."

"Okay, come on," Adora huffed as she jumped to her feet. "We might not have much time before she comes back."

The three friends darted across the room toward the Valkyries, where Rogelio and Kyle were gingerly helping Lonnie into a seat.

Catra paced in front of them, her tail twitching with agitation. Adora caught their conversation as she drew closer.

"Don't be stupid," Catra snapped. Her voice was tense. "You'll just make it worse. And if you make it worse then you might not be able to perform at Nationals, and then we'll *really* be in trouble."

Kyle handed Rogelio a cold compress from the team first aid kit. Rogelio in turn pressed it to Lonnie's ankle, who hissed a breath in between her clenched teeth.

"Do you have a better idea?" Lonnie retorted. "Because if we screw this up, we won't have to worry about Nationals because we won't be going at all."

"Just, let me think." Catra massaged her furrowed brow with her fingertips. "We can fix this, I just need—"

Adora cleared her throat. "What's going on?"

Catra spun around so quickly, Adora thought she might fall over herself.

"What are you doing here?" Catra's eyes were wide and bewildered.

"Are you okay?" Bow asked, ignoring Catra and instead directing his question at Lonnie. She grimaced and shook her head.

"I landed wrong on my final dismount," she grunted.

Nodding thoughtfully, Adora sighed. "I thought that might have been what happened."

"Does Coach Weaver know?" Glimmer asked, edging closer to Lonnie and eyeing her rapidly swelling ankle with concern.

"Um, hello?" Catra raised her voice over the conversation. She threw her hands up in frustration. "Are you all deaf? Seriously, *why* are you here?"

Adora reminded herself that Catra was stressed, and tried not to take her attitude personally. "I wanted— I mean, we wanted to watch you guys compete. Y'know, moral support and stuff?"

A soft blush colored Catra's cheeks. She made a couple unintelligible noises that sounded like they could have been words had she not been so flustered. Glimmer folded her arms and gave Adora a knowing look.

"I told you she wouldn't like the surprise."

Now Adora was the one to blush. She fanned her hands frantically in the air as if that would do anything to wave away the awkward tension that had settled over her. "That's not the point! The point is, we noticed something was wrong and wanted to come back and make sure everything was okay, which—" she gestured toward Lonnie "—obviously it isn't."

"I don't need you to rub it in, Adora," Catra snarled, getting up into Adora's face. "I can handle this."

Adora gaped, her shoulders slumping. "Catra, I… I'm not trying to…" She paused and took a steadying breath. Inwardly, she berated herself for thinking things might have been getting better between the two of them. But she was here now, and she wasn't the type of person to give up, especially when her friends needed her. "How can I help?"

Catra narrowed her eyes. "I said, I can handle this."

Shaking her head, Adora refused to let Catra push her away. "Put me in."

At this point, the rest of the Valkyries were clustered behind Catra like a whispering entourage. Scorpia tipped her head in curiosity.

"Put you in?" she said. "Like, into the routine?"

"Yeah. Unless you've changed it, I still remember the choreography." Adora decided now probably wasn't the time to

mention that she'd helped arrange it in the first place. An incredulous murmur moved through the Valkyries. Catra stood rigid, her arms folded as she stared Adora down. Scorpia and DT flanked her sides and huddled in close.

"Tick-tock, kitten," DT purred, curling their long fingers around Catra's shoulder. "We're running out of time here."

Scorpia's dark eyes flitted between Catra to Adora and back again. "Don't get me wrong, I don't like it either. But it's gotta be better than the alternative…"

"Ugh!" Catra stepped forward, shaking off her cohorts. She looked down to where Glimmer and Bow were still hovering around Lonnie and pointed a sharp finger at them. "You two, go keep an eye on Coach Weaver. Distract her if you have to — just don't let her come back here until we're back on stage." Glimmer and Bow looked at one another with surprise, then shrugged. Meanwhile, Catra shifted her attention to Lonnie. "Kyle, Rogelio — help Lonnie find somewhere to lay low until this is over."

Then, Catra reluctantly lifted her eyes back to Adora. She snagged Adora by the wrist and pulled her away from the others.

"Don't make me regret this," Catra growled.

And, for a reason she couldn't quite pin down, Adora smiled. "Wouldn't dream of it."

It took a bit of mixing and matching from the spare uniforms the team carried with them—Lonnie's top and shoes with Catra's shorts and skirt—but they managed to cobble together some reds for Adora to wear. Catra hurried them into a washroom and unceremoniously shoved Adora into an open stall, all without looking at her once.

While she changed, Adora watched Catra's feet pace back and forth from underneath the stall door.

“Coach Weaver’s going to lose her fucking shit,” Catra muttered, more to herself than to Adora. “She’s going to be so pissed.”

“She’d be angrier if you guys lost,” Adora said softly as she shimmied into her borrowed shorts.

Catra scoffed, but instead of her usual scathing, she simply sounded tired. “That’s easy for you to say.”

Though her skirt was undone and her shoes untied, Adora flung the stall door open anyway. She was starting to lose patience with Catra’s griping.

“What’s that supposed to mean?” She snapped, the skirt’s waistband clutched in her fists at her hips.

But Catra just rolled her eyes. She grabbed Adora by the arm and turned her around. “Stop being dramatic.”

“Me?” Adora squawked, too indignant to think much of it when Catra’s fingers finished the work of zipping the skirt up at the back. “You’re the one who—”

“Shh.” Catra cut her off, whirling Adora around again like an unwitting dance partner and backing her up against the counter. “There’s only enough room in this washroom for one emotional crisis and I already called dibs. Now, sit.”

Too surprised to argue, Adora did as she was told instead. With a little hop, she came to sit on the edge of the counter. Catra grabbed one of Adora’s feet and propped it against her stomach so she could tie the laces. While she worked, Catra kept talking.

“I think the judges probably caught Lonnie’s dismount, so we’re gonna need to make up some points in freestyle.” She finished with the first shoe and moved onto the other. “We won’t have time to do a run-through before we’re up. Are you sure you remember how this number goes? Because we can’t mess this—”

Catra finished with the second shoe before she finished her thought, so Adora took advantage of her distraction. She dropped her foot and reached forward, snagging Catra's hands in her own. She pulled Catra closer, and clutched her hands to her heart.

"Catra, take a breath." Adora smiled down at her from her perch on the counter. "We've got this."

For a moment, all the tension and stress seemed to melt away. Standing between Adora's knees, Catra gazed up at her. Adora felt Catra's fingers unclench and brush the V on her chest reverently. Bravery crested inside of her like a wave, and Adora decided to push her luck. She smiled and released Catra's hands, placing her own on Catra's shoulders instead.

"Thanks, by the way."

Catra blinked, as if in a daze. "For what?"

"For letting me help." Adora shrugged, a dopey smile tugging on her lips. Catra's hands still rested absently on her chest, and Adora wondered if that subtle touch was enough for Catra to feel how her heart pounded under the uniform. "For letting me be part of your team, Captain."

This seemed to be enough to bring Catra back to the present. Her shoulders grew tense under Adora's hands and she stepped back. Blushing furiously, Catra scowled and trained her glare off to the side.

"Yeah, well, whatever," Catra grumbled. "This is not because I like you."

The moment—whatever it had been—was over.

Sighing, Adora jumped down from the counter and brushed off her skirt. "Right. Got it. Come on, then — let's get this over with."

They strode back to where the Valkyries were waiting. Adora poked her head around the curtain to survey the audience. She

spotted Glimmer and Bow hovering a few paces back from where Coach Weaver stood answering more media questions. Her heart swelled at the sight of them doing their best to keep an eye on their target without drawing attention to themselves — a covert mission all for her sake. Through all the drama between her and Catra, Adora knew she was lucky to have friends like Glimmer and Bow.

"Okay, Valkyries!" Catra barked over the backstage noise. She clapped her hands loudly to get attention. "I wanna see you all stretching. We can't afford anymore injuries. We're back up in five."

Given that it had been a hot minute since Adora practiced a cheer routine, she did as she was told. She ran through her old pre-performance stretching routine as she recounted the choreography steps in her mind. As she eased into a quad stretch, Kyle shuffled up beside her.

"Thanks for doing this, Adora," he whispered, smiling sheepishly. "It's nice to have you back on the squad, even if it's just for a little while. We've missed you."

Adora's heart clenched at the sincerity in his words. She was ashamed to admit she hadn't given much thought to how the Valkyries felt about her leaving, and she certainly hadn't considered that they might actually miss her. So she smiled brightly for Kyle and placed a hand on his shoulder. "I miss you guys too. And I'm happy to help — that's what friends do, right?"

At that moment, event organizers flitted around the backstage area, moving from team to team to let them know that the second half was about to get started. The emcee from earlier took to the stage to call the audience to their seats, and Catra waved the Valkyries into one last huddle.

"We know this routine forwards and backwards," she said, turning her stern gaze to each of her squad-mates one after the other. "Don't let this last minute change-up throw you off your game."

Her mismatched eyes locked onto Adora's, and in that fleeting moment, Adora knew she was speaking directly to her. "We've got this, right?"

Adora nodded. "Hell yeah we do."

And for the first time that day, Adora watched Catra smile — really and honestly smile.

"Alright, Vals," Catra said, thrusting her hand into the center of the circle. Grinning, the others followed her lead and stacked their hands on top of hers. "Let's go get what's ours!" The Valkyries let out a battle cry and threw their hands in the air just as their name was called. It was go time.

Adora bounded out onto the stage, surrounded by her former squad. A roar from the audience sent a thrill racing up from her stomach straight to her heart. The industrial lighting made it impossible to see Glimmer and Bow, but she knew they were out there — she was certain she could hear their cheers over all the rest. Those same blinding lights also meant she couldn't see Coach Weaver, and for that she was grateful.

The Valkyries struck their starting pose. In the split second before the music started, Adora stole a quick glance at Catra and found her doing the same thing back at her. It was all so familiar, so comfortable and right. And, at that moment, they were best friends again. All of the fighting and hurt was nothing more than a bad dream, and they were back exactly where they were supposed to be: at each other's side. Catra grinned, and Adora did too.

Any lingering uncertainty Adora had about the routine's choreography evaporated. The music started—a clean, competition-friendly version of Kesha's "Raising Hell"—and every step came flooding back to Adora as clear as the day she and Catra came up with them. Adora's mind immediately slipped back into performance mode. It was like she transformed into someone new — someone bigger and stronger and virtually unstoppable.

When Adora performed as a Valkyrie, she felt like exactly that: like a warrior.

Adora smiled so hard it hurt, but not because she had to — she was having a blast. The song was energetic and peppy, and the moves were cheeky and fun to match. Though she hadn't flipped or twisted in months, the muscle memory was still there. And, just like they'd planned it from the beginning, her choreography synced up perfectly with Catra's; so much so that, in many ways, it felt more like they were dancing with each other than with an entire cheerleading squad. They beamed at each other every time their eyes met, and soon they were laughing too. Adora may not have missed being on the squad, but she definitely missed this.

Sooner than Adora would have liked, the song came to an end. She and the squad hit one last powerful pose and held it while the audience screamed and applauded. After a few beats, the Valkyries took their bows and joined in the cheering, waving and smiling back at the audience. Adora was still laughing, high on the adrenaline of the performance. When she turned to exit the stage, Catra was right there beside her, smiling and breathless.

And then, before Adora had a chance to react, Catra lunged forward and wrapped her arms around her shoulders. She buried her face into the curve of Adora's neck and squeezed so tight that it almost hurt. It took Adora a split second to realize what was happening, but once she did, she hugged Catra around the waist and spun her around for good measure.

Catra was cackling when Adora put her down, her hands lingering on Adora's strong shoulders. Something inside of Adora urged her to do something, *anything* — to reach up and brush the hair from Catra's face or—

But the sight of something over Catra's shoulder grabbed Adora's attention before she could make a move. Her eyes flicked up to find Coach Weaver looming just off stage. It was impossible to tell what the woman was feeling from this distance, her mood impossible to read.

Adora froze, rooted in place. Catra stopped laughing and tipped her head curiously. She followed Adora's gaze and looked back over her shoulder, only to whip back around when she realized what Adora was staring at.

"Go," Catra said, just loud enough for Adora to hear her over the applause still reverberating through the crowd below. "I'll take care of it."

"What? No!" Adora shook her head. "I'm not going to leave you to deal with—"

"Just get out of here, okay?" Catra was more forceful this time, and pulled back from Adora's grip for what felt like the millionth time. Adora's breath hitched painfully. How many times would she be left grasping after this girl?

She pulled her eyes back to Coach Weaver, who was emerging from the wings and looked ready to cross the stage toward them. With her heart in her throat, Adora looked back to Catra and gave her a wordless nod before darting in the opposite direction. She didn't look back as she leapt from the stage and tore around the rows of audience seats. Her mind barely registered the shouts of her name or the sound of the emcee calling the next team to the stage. She burst out of the hall doors, into the concourse and back to real life.

A few moments later, Glimmer and Bow emerged from the hall as well. Without saying a word, they rushed to Adora, grabbed her by the hands, and then kept running. It wasn't until the three of them raced through the convention center doors and out into the cool afternoon air that they finally slowed down to catch their breath.

"You were amazing up there, Adora," Bow said, slapping her on the back.

"Thanks." She grinned back at him. "It was a lot of fun."

Glimmer doubled over, hands on her knees and panting hard. When at last she caught her breath, she peered up at Adora with a hopeful expression. “You still don’t regret leaving though, right?”

Adora laughed. “Not for a second.” She reached out a hand to help Glimmer back up. “Come on, let’s get out of here.”

The three friends made their way to where Bow parked the car. Crisp autumn air played against Adora’s bare legs. She shivered.

“Thanks for your help back there,” she said, pulling Glimmer and Bow into one-armed hugs at her sides. “We couldn’t have pulled that off without you keeping an eye on Coach Weaver.”

Glimmer and Bow shared one of their telepathic looks.

“Speaking of which, we overheard something kind of strange while we were tailing her,” Bow said. He sounded uneasy.

“What do you mean?” Adora asked, anxiety blooming in the pit of her stomach.

“She was being interviewed by some magazine,” Glimmer answered, “and she kept talking about you like you were still on the team. She was even still calling you the Captain of the squad.”

The idea was so absurd that Adora couldn’t help but laugh.

“Are you sure?” she asked as she slid into the back seat of the car. “That doesn’t make any sense.”

“Definitely,” Bow said, taking his spot in the driver’s seat and closing the door behind him. He found Adora’s eyes in the rearview mirror. “Maybe she just didn’t want to look bad in front of everyone?”

Adora rubbed her chin as she turned the idea around in her mind. “Maybe. But I don’t see why anyone would care whether or not I was still on the team, let alone still the Captain.”

Glimmer craned around in the passenger seat. “We were wondering if we were reading too much into it, but… it’s weird, right?”

“Yeah,” Adora sank back in her seat, her mind already lost in thought. She looked out the window, her gaze unfocused as a gust of wind sent a scattering of leaves dancing across her vision. “It’s definitely weird.”



Chapter 30

Chapter Notes

> AUTHOR'S NOTE: This chapter contains the following content/trigger warning: foster system, childhood physical abuse. If you would like to skip this content, you can jump down to the *** and start reading from there. Reader discretion is advised.

There was a feeling Catra always got in the moments just before she found herself in trouble. No matter how old she got, or how much she pretended not to care, the feeling always came back, and it was always the same. It felt like falling — like that tingling weightlessness of missing a step on the stairs just before you start to plummet. The feeling would chase away everything else until all that was left was ice in her veins and the primal, instinctual urge to run.

When she was younger, that's exactly what she did. As a small, frightened child dropped into the foster system, Catra was in trouble all the time, whether she'd done anything to deserve it or not. She quickly became familiar with the tingling feeling of the earth giving out beneath her; it preceded every blistering reprimand, each onslaught of slaps and blows. It was, in a sad way, the only bit of certainty she could rely on. The fear she felt in those moments was so visceral, so all-consuming, that she'd cry until she gave herself a headache or made herself throw up. She would spend hours cowering beneath her bed, tucked in the back of closets, or, in the case of one of the many homes she was bounced between, perched far back on top of the kitchen cabinetry where no one would think to look for her.

As she got older and colder, Catra stopped running. For a while, she froze, and took her abuse in a stoic, detached way that made her feel like she was watching a scene in a movie instead of living it first hand.

Then came the day she finally decided to fight back.

Being a very tiny eight years old didn't stop her from breaking her foster dad's nose one evening when he reached for her in a red-faced rage. She drove the heel of her palm straight into the delicate cartilage between his eyes and watched him howl as he bled. In that moment, she felt stronger than she ever had.

But still: the falling feeling had come first.

She ran away that night—not for the first time in her young life—and was picked up by the police as she wandered the darkened suburban streets. That was when she was finally moved into Madame Razz's group home.

That was when she met Adora, and her whole life changed.

Fighting back had been worth it.

That same falling feeling came on fast when Catra saw Coach Weaver lurking just off stage. Her blood turned to ice as she told Adora to leave, that she would handle it. The audience was still on their feet, and though Adora tried to argue, Catra insisted. She watched, her entire body tingling, as Adora's silhouette ran to the back of the room and out the hall doors. Only once she was sure that Adora was gone did Catra make her way off stage.

Coach Weaver wasted no time, seizing her by the elbow and directing her away from the rest of the squad the moment she was out of the audience's view. Catra took a deep breath, wiped all emotion from her face, and readied herself for what she knew was coming.

She can't hurt you, she mentally reminded her frantically racing heart. *She's a teacher — she's not allowed to hurt you*.

Not physically, anyway.

But apparently the day wasn't finished surprising Catra. If she thought Adora turning up backstage was an unexpected twist—

and, given that Catra had done the same thing to her, it shouldn't have been—it didn't compare to what Coach Weaver had in store for her.

***

Catra stayed in the quiet hallway on the other side of the performance hall long after Coach Weaver stalked away. She still felt like she was falling, her body braced in anticipation of something bad that was yet to come. It was hard to say how long she'd been standing there when she felt someone watching her.

"Hey, Wildcat," Scorpia said softly, stepping into Catra's unfocused line of vision. "Are you okay?"

To Catra, it seemed like she was speaking another language. She blinked and squinted up into Scorpia's concerned face. "Huh?"

"Is everything alright?" Scorpia tried again. "I saw Coach Weaver come back alone, so I thought I should come check on you."

"Oh, yeah." Catra rubbed the back of her neck absently. The tingling was receding, warmth leaking back into her extremities again. "I'm fine."

"What did you tell her? Was she mad?"

Catra started walking. She didn't know where she was going, just that she had a sudden urge to move. Standing still was making her anxious. Scorpia fell into step at her side.

"She wasn't, actually."

"What?" The volume of Scorpia's incredulous exclamation jumped a few decibels. "Are you sure? Because this feels like a trap."

At this, Catra huffed a laugh. She didn't blame Scorpia for being skeptical. "Believe me, I know. But I told her it was all part of the plan, and she bought it. She even said it was brilliant."

Brilliant. That had been Coach Weaver's actual choice of words. Even the memory of that scant scrap of praise left Catra swelling with pride.

Scorpia let out a sigh of relief. "You are so smart. I wouldn't have thought to take credit like that. Then again, I probably wouldn't have been able to say anything. Coach Weaver is, uh, kind of intimidating."

They had found their way to the main lobby. Catra drifted to the floor-to-ceiling windows and watched the autumn leaves scatter in the breeze. The adrenaline had faded from her system and all she wanted now was to take a nice, long nap.

"Do you think it'll help?" Scorpia asked after a few silent moments.

Catra frowned. "What are you talking about?"

"The plan. Do you think what happened today will actually help?"

Wrinkling her nose, Catra gave Scorpia a side-eyed glance. "Scorpia, you *know* none of this was part of the plan. You were *there*."

"I know, but—" Scorpia shrugged "—what if it did? Maybe Adora just needed to be reminded of what she's missing. Would you— I mean, would that make you happy?"

Her words blew through Catra like wind through a broken window. Sighing, Catra closed her eyes. She was so tired.

"Adora already knows what she's missing," she said at last. She lifted her eyes to Scorpia, and saw her staring back with a touch of pity. "And she doesn't care. So, no, I don't think it's going to help." Catra turned away from the windows. "Come on, let's get back."

*

In much the same way that they hadn't acknowledged Catra's presence at Sectionals, she and Adora acted like the incident at the cheer meet didn't happen. Catra awoke on Monday morning to find the borrowed uniform freshly dry cleaned and hanging from her bedroom door knob. This, of course, made her feel guilty about leaving Adora's clothes crammed into the bottom of a plastic shopping bag outside of her door, but there wasn't much she could do about it now.

They avoided each other the same way they had for months. When it came time for glee club rehearsal, they took their seats without so much as glancing at one another. The whole thing would have felt like a dream had it not been for the four other people in the room who had been there too.

"Hey guys," Bow chirped brightly as he tossed his bag in front of an empty seat. "How's Lonnie's ankle?"

Scorpia perked up. "She'll have to stay off it for a few more days, but she's gonna be fine."

"Well, tell her I wish her a speedy recovery!"

"How did the rest of the thing go?" Glimmer asked from Bow's side. "Did you win?"

DT gazed down at their manicure with an air of disinterest. "If you're asking if we qualified for Nationals, then the answer is yes."

Glimmer's face split into a wide, genuinely delighted smile. "That's awesome! Congrats!"

"What are you guys talking about?" Mermista asked as she leaned forward from the back row.

Bow twisted in his seat to face her. "We went to watch the Valkyries compete this weekend!"

Catra sank lower in her chair. *Kill me now*, she thought with a scowl.

The only thing getting her through this increasingly awkward moment was knowing that she had to leave early to make sure the gym was ready for Valkyries practice, which was scheduled to start as soon as glee ended.

"What!" Perfuma squawked with indignation. "Why didn't you say anything? I would have loved to join and cheer on our team mates!" She pouted at Scorpia, who giggled nervously.

"Can we get started?" Catra cut in, her foot tapping with irritation. "I'm kinda double-booked right now."

"Right," Glimmer replied, jumping to her feet. She made her way to the front of the room and uncapped a dry erase marker. "Okay, today we only have one job: we need to finalize our set list for Regionals. We've been throwing a lot of ideas around, but we haven't made any decisions yet and I need to submit our selections by the end of the week."

The room immediately burst into conversation, with the members of Vocal Rebellion making cases for their favorites of the songs from Adora's "yearning" playlist. Catra let out a breath and relaxed. She didn't really care what songs they picked, so she leaned back, closed her eyes, and waited for someone to assign her a solo.

"I can't sing this song with Mermista!" Seahawk lamented when the group assigned the couple the opening number — a duet version of Bastille's "Another Place" they had done with Alessia Cara. "It's about a breakup!"

"No," Adora corrected. "It's about a *potential* breakup."

"How is that better?" he howled. Peeking out of one eye, Catra was unsurprised to find him on the verge of tears.

Mermista groaned and hid her face in her hand. "Ugh, stop being so dramatic! It's just a song, not a self-fulfilling prophecy."

"Besides," Glimmer said from where she stood by the white board on which she'd been keeping track of everyone's ideas. It was covered from edge to edge with the notes she made in looping cursive. "We can't just rely on our voices for this one — we need chemistry on that stage! We need to work the theme and really make sure the audience *feels* these songs."

From her side, Bow chuckled. "Now who's being dramatic?"

Glimmer ignored him. "What I'm saying is, it makes perfect sense for Seahawk and Mermista to take this song."

"That's right, hot stuff," DT said, directing a sharp grin in Seahawk's direction. "Pour all that angst into a tear-jerking performance. The judges will love it."

Begrudgingly, both Seahawk and Mermista eventually agreed. Glimmer wrote it on the board, which was as good as writing it in stone. One down, two to go.

"Okay," Bow mused, reviewing their options. "What do we feel about this one?" He pointed to a song called "You and I" by LÉON. "It would be a solo. Netossa? Do you want to put your hat in the ring for it?"

Leaning forward in her seat, Netossa furrowed her brow. "I don't know. It's a great song, but it's not really my sound. Maybe—"

"Oh!" Scorpia sat up so quickly that it made both Catra and DT jump. "Could I give it a shot? I *love* this song."

Catra gave Scorpia an incredulous look and Scorpia flushed.

Netossa let out a thoughtful hum. "Y'know, I could see that. You've got the right vibe for it."

"Okaaay," Bow said, watching Glimmer closely to ensure they were on the same page on the decision. Scorpia let out an excited squeak. "Does anyone else want to audition for the solo before we make it official?"

Though she could feel several sets of eyes snap to her, Catra wasn't willing to dignify any of them with her attention. She didn't care what she sang — she didn't even care if she got a solo. If Scorpia wanted this so bad, Catra would let her have it. Not that it was going to matter anyway.

"Alright then," Glimmer relented. She turned and scribbled Scorpia's name next to the song title. Scorpia was almost vibrating with delight. From the next row, Perfuma leaned forward and gave Scorpia's strong arm a squeeze.

"Congratulations, Scorpia!"

Conversation picked up again. Catra's eyes flicked to the clock just as Glimmer cleared her throat to get everyone's attention again.

"We're almost done," Glimmer announced, waving her marker triumphantly. "We just need to choose our ballad."

At the same time, Catra scooped her bag off the floor and looked between Scorpia and DT. "I'm outta here. See you two at practice."

"Later, Kitten," DT cooed with a wiggled wave of their fingers.

"Wait!" Glimmer said. "Don't you want to help choose the last song?"

Catra shrugged. "I told you I had to leave early, Sparkles. Besides, I trust you kids to make an executive decision without me. Scorpia and DT can fill me in later."

She gave Glimmer a salute and slipped out of the room without looking back.

Twenty minutes later, after she'd chased some straggling members of the basketball team out of the gym and picked a few drills from Coach Weaver's absurdly overstuffed Captain's manual, Catra was ready for practice. She had just started stretching when the first of the Valkyries arrived, including Scorpia and DT.

"Well?" she asked without looking up from her lunge. "Did I miss anything important?"

"You missed me talking them out of doing a mash-up for the ballad number," DT answered. "Can you imagine? Talk about tacky."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "I'm pretty sure their mash-ups are what helped them win at Sectionals."

DT pressed their fingers to their mouth and feigned shock. "Really? Well, oopsie! My mistake."

Smirking, Catra turned her attention to Scorpia. "Speaking of sabotage, great idea volunteering to take that big solo. I can think of a dozen ways we can use that to our advantage."

"Ha! I know, right?" Scorpia laughed, though it sounded anything but convincing. She rubbed the back of her neck as she glanced away. "Totally had that planned all along..."

"But you haven't heard the best part, darling." DT reached down and pulled Catra to her feet. Catra bristled at being treated like a doll, but kept her biting remarks to herself for the time being. "They want *you* to sing the ballad number."

"I figured that would happen," Catra said. "What song did they pick?"

DT shimmied their shoulders with barely-contained delight. "'Stay' by Rihanna. Isn't that delicious?"

Catra nodded; it was a perfect choice. Then she paused.

"Wait, that's a duet. Who am I singing with?"

Scorpia and DT looked at one another in silence. Scorpia bit her lip — she looked uncomfortable. DT, on the other hand, looked ready to burst with joy.

Comprehension hit Catra like a splash of cold water in the morning.

"No," she breathed, watching as Scorpia winced and DT grinned.

"You have got to be fucking kidding me."

Chapter 31

Adora was anxious.

She stole a glance at her phone, checking the time for the fifth time in as many minutes. Valkyries practice should have been over by now and, unless she decided to go somewhere else afterward, Catra would be home soon. Adora rolled her shoulders and shook out her hands as if she was psyching herself up to go on stage. She reminded herself that there was no point in worrying about it, and went back to cleaning her already tidy room for a distraction.

This wasn't her fault. She hadn't even wanted a solo in the first place. And when Vocal Rebellion almost unanimously chose "Stay" as their ballad number for Regionals, Adora assumed Netossa and Spinerella would take the parts.

It had actually been Netossa's idea to give the song to Catra.

"This is the perfect song for deploying our secret weapon," she'd explained after pitching the idea. "There's a lot of power in Rihanna's part of the song, some high parts too. It would give Catra the chance to use her range and surprise the judges the way she surprised us."

A murmur of agreement swept around the room. Adora knew better than anyone just what a good fit Catra would be for the song — she could already hear it in her mind. But when she tried to imagine who would share the stage with her, Adora's mind went blank. She was so deep in thought, mulling over the pros and cons of different pairings, when the sound of her own name drew her attention back to the present.

"Huh?" She sat up and looked around. Everyone was staring back at her.

"I was just saying that you should take the duet with Catra," Glimmer said. She was writing it down on the white board as if it

had already been decided.

“What?” Adora squawked. “No, that’s not— why would you...” She looked to her teammates, hoping to find some back-up—or at least someone else who wanted to volunteer for the chance to solo—but instead found a room full of people nodding back at her.

DT’s lips curled into a wide grin. “Oh, this is perfect. Yes, a thousand times yes to this idea.” At their side, Scorpia was trying to whisper something to them, but they held her back at arm’s length.

“Come on,” Adora scoffed. She could feel the heat building behind her cheeks. “You don’t really believe she’d be cool with that.”

“Why not?” DT asked, cocking their head to one side as if they were actually confused. “You two are besties, aren’t you?”

Adora opened her mouth and paused. She wasn’t sure how to answer that question anymore.

“And don’t forget — there needs to be *chemistry* between singers in this routine,” Glimmer added without turning away from the white board.

“Wha— what is— what’s that supposed to mean??” Adora spluttered. She pressed her palms to her flaming cheeks, but it was no use — her friends snickered and gave her knowing looks, and Adora wanted to melt into the floor out of sheer humiliation.

“It means you two are comfortable with each other,” Bow said gently as he draped his arm around Adora’s shoulder. “We saw you two on stage — you were great together! That’s the kind of thing we need if we want to win at Regionals.”

“Do we need to vote on it?” Glimmer asked, looking out over her team with a smirk.

“They have my vote,” Perfuma chirped brightly, to which Spinerella and Netossa boisterously agreed. Soon the whole room was

casting their vote in favor of Adora and Catra's duet, and all Adora could do was sink into Bow's side and accept her fate.

Hours later, she still hadn't managed to shake her all-consuming sense of dread. She wondered how Catra took the news when Scorpia and DT told her. With her room as clean as it was going to get, Adora stole another glance at her phone only to discover that only a few minutes had passed since her last check-in.

"Ugh, fine!" she shouted at no one, throwing her hands up in frustration. "I guess I'll do my homework or whatever."

She settled down at her desk and dragged her algebra books from her bag. It didn't take long for her to sink into the work, the entirety of her brain power shifting gears from worrying about Catra to trying to navigate the equations in front of her. She was just starting the final question when a loud crash came from behind her. Adora jolted so hard in her seat that she cracked her knees off the bottom of her desk.

Wincing, Adora twisted in her chair and found Catra's diminutive silhouette somehow managing to fill the doorway.

"Is this your idea of a joke?" Catra snarled, stomping into the room and kicking the door shut behind her. Adora gaped back, trying to remember the last time Catra had been in her room like this. "A duet? Together?"

"That's typically how duets work," Adora pointed out as she got up from her chair.

Catra crossed the room in two long strides and scowled up at her. "You know what I mean!"

Adora sighed. "Listen, it wasn't my idea, okay? Everyone wanted you to have a solo because you're you, and Glimmer wanted to pair you with someone who—" she paused, stopping herself from using Glimmer's choice of words and choosing something a little more subtle instead "—someone you work well with. Everyone voted — I didn't have a choice."

“Why didn’t you just say no?” Catra shouted, incredulous.

Even though she had expected Catra to be upset, Adora was still surprised by how much it stung. She pressed her lips into a tight line and fought to keep the hurt from showing on her face.

“Why would I want to say no?”

Now it was Catra’s turn to gape. She gazed at Adora with a mix of confusion and disbelief. “I— Because we…”

She couldn’t seem to find the words to finish that thought.

“I really liked performing with you again, Catra,” Adora said earnestly. She gave her friend a hopeful smile. “And I thought…. maybe you liked performing with me too.”

Catra’s temper ebbed in the face of Adora’s vulnerability. Her brows knitted above her wary eyes, like she was trying to spot a trap. Adora could imagine the wheels of Catra’s mind spinning, trying to figure out her next move, as if their friendship had become nothing more than a chess match to be won.

Adora saw this prolonged silence as a chink in Catra’s armor. She pressed into it.

“If you really don’t want to sing with me, then I’ll tell Glimmer to find you a new duet partner,” she said, clutching her hands to her heart. “But… I’d really like it if we could sing the song together.”

A light blush dusted Catra’s cheeks as she glanced away. She wrapped her arms around herself protectively and let out a weak huff of an exhale.

“Okay, fine,” she relented, turning on her heel and stalking to the door. “But this is not because I like you.”

Despite herself, Adora smiled.

“Yeah,” she said. “I know.”

*

The semester was quickly coming to an end, and Catra was counting down every day that stood between her and winter break. She was exhausted and she was frustrated. All she wanted was to spend two blissful weeks in bed, sleeping until the new year.

She was going to need all the rest she could get. Waiting for her on the other side of the break was both show choir Regionals and cheer Nationals, not to mention the small matter of classes and exams along the way. The first couple months of the winter semester were shaping up to be the busiest days of Catra's life, and that was without the impending drama that would no doubt hit once she, Scorpia, and DT pulled off their plan to sabotage the glee club.

But with every day that passed, that nebulous plan of hers felt more and more like an afterthought. Despite everything, Catra was actually enjoying her time with Vocal Rebellion — so much so that she sometimes forgot the whole thing was a farce. Scorpia and DT weren't doing any better. Ever since being handed the finishing number, Scorpia had thrown herself into rehearsing her solo with so much enthusiasm that Catra sometimes forgot it was all for show. As for DT, they couldn't seem to stop themself from offering one great idea after another. Eventually Glimmer caved and named them the group's artistic director, and they took up the mantle with pride.

"Oh, I have another one." DT said one afternoon during practice, flapping their hands at the pen and notebook in Glimmer's hands. "Write this down: Blacklight. Makeup. We could choose colors that are hard to see when the regular stage lights are up. But the moment the black light comes on? BAM! Agony!"

Glimmer blinked at them. "Agony?"

"Yes! Stay with me here," DT snapped. "The duality of what it means to *yearn* — we could look happy and put together in the

bright light of day, and only in the darkness does the pain show—" They raked their fingers down their cheeks dramatically "—In this case, streaks of mascara tears that glow in the dark!"

"Okay, okay," Glimmer scribbled frantically. "I think I get what you're saying. Is that actually possible? Because that would be pretty cool."

"Of course it would be cool, darling. That's why I said it."

Catra listened to this exchange from where she sat slumped in her seat and snorted a laugh. She gazed around the room at the rest of Vocal Rebellion. Everyone was clustered together in breakout groups, working on details like costumes and choreography. Theoretically, she was "helping" DT and Glimmer, though she hadn't contributed a single thought to the conversation so far.

She became aware that someone was right behind her a second before she felt a hand close around her shoulder.

"Hey, it's just me." Bow smiled down at her when she jumped. "Seeing as everyone's busy working on stage stuff, I was thinking you, me and Adora could run through the ballad number."

Looking past him, Catra realized he'd already dragged Adora away from her group. She smiled weakly at her and gave an apologetic shrug of her shoulders.

"Sure, whatever," Catra huffed, getting to her feet.

The girls followed Bow over to the piano and stood awkwardly as he took a seat at the bench. He would be playing the music for them during their performance, which Catra was secretly grateful for. Knowing that it wouldn't just be her and Adora at center stage together took some of the pressure off. The rest of the ensemble would come in during the first chorus to harmonize like a church choir. The whole thing would be rather somber and moody.

Catra hummed and cleared her throat. Out of the corner of her eye, she could see Adora standing up a little taller, rolling her

shoulders back as she mentally prepared herself to sing.

"Ready when you are," Catra said, going out of her way to sound indifferent even though her heart was pounding. So far, she and Adora had managed to avoid singing in front of the rest of the team, using the fact that their number wasn't nearly as complicated as the other two songs as an excuse. In fact, they hadn't even practiced with each other yet. Or, at least not face to face. Most nights, Catra sat on her bedroom floor and listened to Adora practicing below. She'd sing her half of the duet in a whisper — in secret.

It was better that way. From downstairs, Adora couldn't see Catra in the moments when she lost herself — those times when the song hit her just right and left her crying alone in the dark.

Bow shook out his hands and started to play.

Catra closed her eyes and sang.

She didn't need to look to know the whole room had stopped to watch. Only once her part ended and Adora's began did Catra dare to open her eyes. Adora's voice was smooth and lovely, flowing over the lyrics like water over polished river stone. But her posture was stiff, and though she sounded good, something about her performance was lacking.

"Okay, stop," Glimmer shouted over the music and Bow fumbled to a halt. "Just stop."

Adora's face blanched. "Why? Did I sing the wrong words?"

Catra couldn't help but laugh. "Amazingly, no."

"It's not just you." Glimmer stomped across the room and planted herself between them. "It's *both* of you."

"What?" Catra bristled. "I sounded fine!"

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Sure, you both sounded *fine*. But we need more than fine for this number. We need the same chemistry you two had on stage at that cheer meet.” She took them each by the hand and dragged them to the middle of the room where she turned them to face one another. “Sing *to* each other, not *with* each other.”

“I’m going to kill her,” Catra growled, just loud enough for Adora to hear. Adora did her best not to laugh.

“Please don’t.”

“Once more, with feeling!” Glimmer called from the seat she had retreated back to. “Catra — eyes open this time!”

Catra clenched her hands into fists at her sides until her nails bit into the soft flesh of her palm. She took a breath, and lifted her gaze to meet Adora’s.

Once more, Bow began to play.

The idea of singing to Adora—of singing *this* song to her—made Catra’s head spin. But she had a reputation to keep, and she wasn’t about to let Adora and her big blue eyes and her sweet, hopeful smile make a fool out of her in front of all these people. So, Catra sang.

Just a few bars was all it took for Catra to notice the difference. She did sound better when she was singing to Adora; there was a delicious ache in her voice that hadn’t been there before. And all the while, Adora never once looked away. Her lips moved silently as she mouthed the lyrics while Catra sang them. Her brows lifted above eyes that sparkled with what Catra could have sworn was pride.

And then it was Adora’s turn. As she listened along, Catra suddenly realized that she was nodding to the tempo of the song, coaxing Adora along with every note she hit and each word she remembered. Adora didn’t falter or second-guess herself, not as long as her eyes were locked with Catra’s.

They hit the bridge of the song, their voices building off of one another, rising and falling like the tide. Catra hit her high notes and nailed her runs, and with every hard note, Adora's smile was like a silent reward.

And then, as they were moving through the final chorus, Catra felt her heart tighten. Her breath faltered as she sang those words that hurt so damn much.

"*Makes me feel like I can't live without you…*"

Don't cry, Catra thought. *Keep it together, you dumb fuck.*

But Adora could tell — Adora could see her breaking. She reached out, a small, tentative motion. Not asking, just being there in case Catra needed her. And as the song came to a close, Catra thought she might just give in.

"*I want you to stay.*"

She sang her final run.

The piano faded.

And when the rest of Vocal Rebellion burst into applause, Catra realized her fingertips hovered barely a whisper away from Adora's.

She and Adora reacted at the same time, snapping their hands back to their sides.

"Now, that's what I'm talking about!" Glimmer shouted, thrusting her fist into the air.

Adora smiled at Catra and, against all better judgement, Catra smiled back.

"That wasn't so bad, was it?" Adora teased. "We actually sounded pretty good considering that was our first time singing it together."

"Yeah," Catra laughed, fidgeting with her ponytail. "I guess we did, didn't we?"

From that point on, Catra felt something shift. The idea of letting loose—of allowing the rest of the glee club to see her enjoying herself during practices—didn't make her cringe the way it used to. She actually started participating in the planning stuff, and didn't scoff or skulk away from singing with Adora. They practiced their routine again and again, choreographing a slow, subtle set of steps around one another that suited the song but wouldn't distract from their vocals. They even paired up to dance together during the opening number, and would often finish each run-through in a giggling heap on the band room floor. Catra hadn't been this happy in a very long time.

After the last glee practice of the semester, Seahawk climbed onto one of the chairs and made an announcement.

"Friends! Before we all depart for two long weeks, Mermista and I would like to invite you all to one final night of revelry!"

Everyone listened in rapt attention, and then turned their focus to Mermista in hopes that she would translate.

Mermista sighed. "Our band is performing at an end-of-semester frat party on the university campus. This is his way of inviting you all to the show."

"Your band?" Adora exclaimed. "I knew you were on the swim team, but this is the first I'm hearing about a band."

"Eh, it's just a casual jam band we joined a couple years back when Mara wouldn't let us join glee while we were doing other extracurriculars." Mermista hitched her thumb in Seahawk's direction. "He was pretty butthurt about not having a creative outlet, so we found this group of college guys who needed some vocalists. It's not a big deal."

"Um, it's a super big deal!" Bow said, all but dancing with excitement. "You're in a college band, *and* you're performing at a

college party? You guys are so cool!”

“That we are, my friend.” Seahawk smoothed his fingers over his mustache for effect.

“And you’re really inviting us?” Scorpia asked tentatively. “Like, all of us?” She gestured to DT and Catra.

“But of course!” he cried. “It will be an end-of-semester adventure!”

“Ugh, please stop,” Mermista groaned.

The room immediately devolved into excited chatter about the party, who was going and what they’d wear. Scorpia turned to Catra with a pleading look. “What do you think, Wildcat? Should we go?”

Catra stole a quick glance at Adora, who was already huddled in close with Glimmer and Bow. She overheard them making plans to get ready at Glimmer’s place and head to the party together. Normally this would have set Catra off on a spiral of jealousy, but today all she felt was a tremble of excitement somewhere deep at her core.

She shrugged as if she couldn’t care less. “Sure, why the hell not? We’ve earned a bit of fun.”

Scorpia let out a squeal of delight and started throwing together plans on the spot, inviting both Catra and DT over to her place before the party. DT made a comment about bringing refreshments just as Catra tuned out. She didn’t really care what happened next — she was looking forward to seeing where the night took her.

Later that day, after the last Valkyrie practice of the semester wrapped up and her fellow squadmates had left to start their winter breaks, Catra finished locking up the storage closet and hoisted her duffle bag strap over her shoulder.

“I am going to go home and sleep for three days straight,” she muttered to herself as she shuffled through the empty halls.

“That doesn’t sound like a very productive use of your time.”

Catra leapt with a shriek and whirled around to find Coach Weaver glowering down at her only a few short paces away. “Where the fu— I mean, where did you come from?”

Coach Weaver breezed forward, closing the distance between them. “I’m losing patience with you, Catra.”

All of the warmth and good-will Catra had been harboring for the last couple of weeks turned to ice in an instant. A hard lump formed in her throat, and she swallowed it down with a grimace.

“What are you talking about?”

“You know very well what I’m talking about.” Coach Weaver had a way of looking bigger when she was angry. “You were supposed to have the glee club dealt with by now.”

Catra dug her nails into the strap of her duffle bag. “I told you, I’m on it. Entrapta will have heard back about that internship by the time—”

“And what if that falls through, hmm? What will you do then?”

“What is your problem?” Catra snapped, exasperated. She knew she sounded desperate, but she was too tired to care. “I don’t know if you’ve noticed, but we’re doing just fine without Adora. The squad’s in better shape than ever thanks to me.”

“Do not get flippant with me, Valkyrie. You have been given an incredible opportunity — one you have neither earned nor deserve. I suggest you stop wasting your time questioning my judgement and instead focus on doing as you’re told.” Coach Weaver loomed with threatening proximity. “Do I make myself clear?”

Catra set her jaw and stared back defiantly. There were so many things she wanted to say, but all of them were guaranteed to dig her deeper into trouble, so she kept her mouth shut.

Then, just as suddenly as quickly she had appeared, Coach Weaver's demeanor changed. She softened around the edges, cupping Catra's cheek in her palm and sighing softly. "I expected more of you, Catra. Perhaps you weren't cut out for this after all."

"I just said I'm working on—"

But Coach Weaver kept talking. "Considering what Adora did to you — the fact that she would rather languish in obscurity than enjoy all the luxuries of captaincy at your side… I didn't take you for the sort of person to stand for such humiliation."

Catra's mouth hung open. She hated the way every one of Coach Weaver's calculated words hit their target. She hated herself for—well, for everything.

Coach Weaver made to push past Catra, but not before pausing at her side. She curled her fingers around Catra's shoulder and squeezed just a bit too tight.

"Stay angry, Catra," she whispered. "It's the only way you'll win this."

And then she was gone. Catra waited—one beat, and then another—until she was certain she was alone.

Then she fell to her knees and finally let herself cry.

Chapter 32

The semester was over and winter break had arrived. Adora let Glimmer and Bow shuttle her to the mall so they could shop for the party. Again, Glimmer insisted on playing Adora's personal stylist, and by now Adora knew better than to argue. Besides, Adora wasn't ashamed to admit that Glimmer had better taste than she did, so she let her friend treat her like a dress-up doll without complaint.

An hour later with their outfits in hand, the Best Friend Squad hurried back to Glimmer's house to get ready. Giddy and excited, Adora changed quickly into the clothes Glimmer had picked for her —a fitted black top with a wide neck and long sleeves, to be worn with a tight pair of high-waisted jeans and finished with cute high-heeled ankle boots—and spent the rest of the time stressing over whether to wear her hair up or down.

"I want to look nice, but not like I'm trying too hard," she explained. "Does that make sense?"

"This is literally the first time I've seen you worry about how you look," Glimmer said, grinning as she brushed on some aggressively glittery eye shadow. "Hoping to get someone's attention tonight?"

Adora's mouth fell open. From across the room, Bow chuckled.

"Don't listen to her, Adora," he said, catching her eye in the reflection of Glimmer's floor-length mirror where he was admiring his new cropped hoodie. "Why don't you try wearing your hair half up? It's like the best of both worlds!"

She gave it a shot, pulling the top half of her hair into an effortless knot at the back of her head and leaving the rest to cascade down her shoulders like a waterfall of molten gold.

Glimmer gave her an approving nod. “Crisis averted. Should we head out?”

They grabbed their coats and rushed down the stairs to the great foyer of Glimmer’s home.

“Mom! Dad! We’re leaving now!” Glimmer shouted, her hand already on the door knob.

Mrs. and Mr. Moon swept in from the kitchen. Glimmer’s dad was home for the holidays, and he smiled warmly at his daughter and her friends.

“You kids have fun tonight,” he said, his hands planted on his hips.

“But not too much fun,” Mrs. Moon added with a sharp look. “I expect you all to be responsible.”

“Don’t worry, ma’am,” Bow said. He twirled his car keys around his finger with a flourish. “I’m DDing tonight.”

Mrs. Moon raised a single, perfectly arched eyebrow. “Not that your services should be necessary, right?”

Bow shrank back and let out an awkward laugh. “Er, of course, ma’am.”

This seemed to satisfy her. Glimmer’s mom planted a kiss on her daughter’s cheek and reminded the three of them to be home by midnight. Mr. Moon hovered by the door, watching as his wife retreated back into the kitchen.

“I know you’ll all make good choices tonight,” he said, speaking in a low voice and keeping an eye on the doorway to the kitchen. “But if you do decide to, say, enjoy the host’s ‘refreshments’, just remember that you can call me anytime. I’ll come pick you kids up, no questions asked.”

Glimmer snorted a laugh and gave him a tight hug. “Got it. Thanks, Dad.”

Mr. Moon squeezed her back. "I mean it — I don't mind." He looked at Bow. "I'd rather you wake me up in the middle of the night than drive drunk."

"Dad!" Glimmer admonished.

Bow responded with a salute. "I'll have everyone home by midnight in one piece, you have my word."

At last, Glimmer was able to extricate herself from her father's grip and the friends hustled out the door to pile into Bow's car. Adora scooched into the middle seat and leaned forward.

"Your dad's pretty cool, Glimmer," she said.

Glimmer snapped her seatbelt and looked back over her shoulder at her. "Yeah, he's the best. And, for the record, I'm definitely drinking tonight."

They drove to the address Seahawk had texted them with the heat blasting and the music turned up loud. Adora was excited: she hadn't been to a party—a real party, and not just a chill hang between friends like Bow's birthday—in ages. She pulled out her phone and glanced at her messages. There was one from Spinnerella saying she and Netossa were picking up Perfuma on their way to the party, and another from Entrapta wishing everyone a good break (She hadn't even pretended to be interested in going out with everyone). Adora hesitated, her thumb raised above the 'new message' button.

You coming tonight? She hit send before she could talk herself out of it.

The ellipses popped up right away, and Adora held her breath.

Yup, Catra replied.

Adora bit her lip and smiled. *Cool! See you there :)*

As she eased back into her seat, Adora let out a slow exhale. She felt better than she had in months. Since she and Catra started working together on their duet, things finally seemed to be falling into place. Sure, Catra was still spending most of her time with Scorpia, and Adora still didn't trust Coach Weaver. But Catra and Adora weren't at each other's throats anymore, and that was better than nothing. Smiling at her reflection in the window, Adora couldn't help but feel like this party was exactly what they all needed to shake off the drama of the semester.

Bow navigated through the campus neighborhood until Glimmer spotted the frat house. It was a massive three story home that had obviously once been a stately manor of sorts. Every window blazed with light, and the sound of music and laughter was audible from the street. It took a bit of hunting, but Bow was finally able to find a parking spot a couple streets over. The three of them backtracked down the snowy sidewalk, huddled together against the cold and laughing the whole way.

Adora could feel the pulse of the party from the house's front steps. She had to ring the bell a couple of times before the heavy door finally swung open. Looming in the doorway stood a heavily muscled woman with a dark glare and a long white ponytail. She held a large can of beer in her hand.

"Oh, wow," Adora breathed.

The girl looked the friends over with a sneer, then shouted back over her shoulder.

"Hey! Which one of you fuck knuckles invited the kids?"

"We're not kids!" Adora balked, the brief infatuation fizzling out just as quickly as it started. "I mean, technically—"

"Whatever, blondie," the girl said, cutting her off and taking a long pull from her beer. She turned away and waved for them to follow. "Toss your shit in the pile and shut the door behind you."

The “pile” was a formidable mountain of coats that spilled out from an overstuffed hall closet. The friends considered it before shrugging off their own coats and adding them to the collection.

“This is so exciting!” Glimmer squealed over the thrumming sound of music. “Our first college party! What should we do first?”

Bodies squeezed passed them, people shouting and laughing as they went. A table was set up in the living room, where a group of party goers were playing a loud game of poker that involved a lot of colorful language and the shedding of clothes. Even though the night was young, there were already couples drunkenly making out on the stairs and against walls.

“I’ll text Seahawk and let him know we’re here,” Bow said, already tapping away against his phone screen.

“Tell him we’re in the kitchen grabbing something to drink,” Adora said, motioning for her friends to follow.

It was there that they found Seahawk, who was perched on the edge of the counter and telling a very animated story to the small crowd gathered in front of him. Adora caught Mermista’s eye, who straightened up and waved them over.

“You made it!” she cheered, sounding far cheerier than her usual indifferent demeanor made it seem she was capable of being. “You guys drinking?

“None for me,” Bow said with a shake of his head. He jingled his keys to drive the point home, and Mermista nodded.

“Smart. What about you two?” She pointed at Adora and Glimmer, who nodded in unison. A moment later, she thrust a red plastic cup into Adora’s hand. Adora took a tentative sip — whatever was in the cup was sweet and definitely stronger than necessary, which meant it was perfect.

Mermista waded through the crowd of people crushed into the kitchen and pulled Seahawk down from the counter. When his

eyes landed on the others, his face lit up.

“My crew!” he shouted, which earned a round of drunken cheers from complete strangers and made Adora laugh.

After hugs and high-fives Seahawk urged them to follow him downstairs to where he, Mermista and the rest of their band would be playing. The group slid between guests and tramped down the stairs in single file. The basement of the house was mercifully cooler and surprisingly massive. Most of the furniture had been pushed aside to create a dancefloor, save for a pool table in one corner and a rowdy game of beer pong that was being played in another. Through the crowd, Adora spotted Netossa, Spinnerella and Perfuma on a sofa against the wall and led the others over to them.

Already Adora could feel the alcohol warming her cheeks. It wasn’t her first time drinking, but whatever Mermista had given her was going down far too easy, and it didn’t take long for Adora to feel like her mind was getting a little fuzzy around the edges.

At one point, Glimmer dashed back upstairs to get them a refill. When she returned, she scurried back over to the group like a woman with a secret to share.

“Guess who’s heeeere,” she sang as she pressed Adora’s near-overflowing cup back into her hand. At the same moment, Perfuma sat up straight and waved.

“There they are!” she said, beaming. She cupped a hand against the side of her mouth and shouted over the noise. “Hey, you two! Over here!”

Turning, Adora followed Perfuma’s gaze, where she spotted Catra and Scorpia making their way down with drinks in hand. Adora’s stomach did a flip. Catra wore a pair of black, shredded jeans and an old red t-shirt. She had tied the shirt at the waist, exposing her toned stomach. It was so threadbare that her black bra could be seen through the thin fabric, which Adora assumed was exactly

why she chose it. Catra had pulled the whole look together with a black leather jacket, and she wore her hair loose and painstakingly straightened. It hung like a sleek, glossy curtain down her back.

Adora didn't realize how intently she'd been staring until Catra's dual colored eyes found hers across the room. The sudden recognition snapped Adora back to the present, and she had to glance away just to catch her breath.

"Where's DT?" Bow asked once the pair got close enough that he didn't have to shout.

Catra hitched a thumb over her shoulder and shrugged. "They took one look at that strip poker game and ditched us like a bad habit." Everyone laughed and Adora smiled down at her drink, trying to pretend like she wasn't over the moon that Catra was there and that, finally, all of her friends were together outside of the band room.

"So, tell us about this band of yours," Scorpia said, smiling brightly at Seahawk and Mermista. Adora cut her a glance and tried not to react to the way she hovered close at Catra's side. "Do you guys write your own music and stuff?"

"Alas," Seahawk sighed. "We're just a cover band. But I have written an original shanty or two if you're interested—"

"No," Mermista cut in, covering her boyfriend's mouth with her hand. "Nope, they're not."

Before anyone could argue to the contrary, a guy leaned into the group and told Seahawk and Mermista it was show time. The rest of the Stevenson High crew chatted excitedly among themselves as they watched the couple join the rest of their band at the make-shift stage on the other side of the room. For a moment, Adora hovered at Bow and Glimmer's side and half listened as Spinnerella told them some story at Netossa's expense. But out of the corner of her eye, she stole glances at Catra, who was talking

to Scorpia. It was impossible to hear what they were saying over the din of the party, but Adora tried anyway, straining to catch whatever Scorpia was saying that kept making Catra laugh.

Finally, Adora had enough. She slid over to Catra's side and smiled brightly at the pair. Catra blinked in surprise, then sank back into a slouch of indifference.

"Hey, Adora," she said as she lifted her bottle of beer. Adora caught herself entranced by the sight of it pressed to Catra's lips, and she had to give her head a shake just to break the spell.

"Hey yourself." Adora smiled and drummed her fingers against the half-empty plastic cup clutched in her hand. Mentally she told herself to slow down on the booze before she made an ass of herself. It was at that moment that she caught Catra and Scorpia exchanging a covert glance, and Adora rushed to fill the awkward silence. "So, how long did it take to straighten your hair?"

Groaning, Catra opened her mouth to answer, but Scorpia's booming laugh cut her off.

"Oh, man. It took forever. I can't believe how much hair you have, Wildcat."

Catra shifted and glanced away from them both. "What can I say? It's a gift."

Scorpia let out a happy little sigh. "Yeah, it sure is."

Something ugly was rearing its head somewhere deep in Adora's chest. It clenched her heart and offered up a slew of petty things she so desperately wanted to say, but was thankfully just sober enough not too. unfortunately, she wasn't sober enough to let the whole thing slide altogether. She tipped her head to the side and forced a tight smile.

"So, you two got ready together, huh?" She pretended she didn't see the way Catra's brows lifted over her beer bottle as she pressed it to her lips once more.

“Yup!” Scorpia chirped brightly. “Wildcat’s crashing at my place this weekend!” As she said this, she made a move that was no doubt intended to be a friendly pat on Catra’s shoulders. But Scorpia had never been very good at recognizing her own strength, and that pat sent Catra lurching forward, spluttering on her beer.

“Geeze, Scorpia!” Catra said between coughs. “Take it easy!”

Adora lifted her own cup to her mouth, hiding her smile as she finished her drink in a few deep swallows. She dropped her empty cup on a side table just as Seahawk’s voice soared over the noise, amplified over a speaker system.

“Greetings, friends and foes!” he cried, commanding the room’s attention. “We are The Dragon’s Daughter! I hope you’re all ready to dance!”

The crowd let out a drunken cheer. People were streaming down the stairs and crowding the floor.

“Who knew Seahawk was so cool outside of Stevenson High?” Glimmer laughed, appearing suddenly at Adora’s shoulder.

“These must be his people,” Adora agreed. The band’s drummer started to hammer out a steady beat, and Bow let out a gasp.

“I love this song!” he shouted as Seahawk broke into Stars’ “Hold On When You Get Love and Let Go When You Give It”. “C’mon, we have to dance!” He looped his arms with Glimmer on one side and Adora on the other and dragged them onto the dancefloor.

The music was loud, ricocheting off the basement walls. Already the room was twice as full as it had been only moments earlier, packed with swaying bodies who were giving The Dragon’s Daughter their full attention. Bow sang along, word for word, beat for beat. Adora and Glimmer danced with him, laughing at his shameless enthusiasm and at each other. Adora twirled, her hands raised above her head. They whistled when Mermista stepped up to the mic to croon the backup vocals of the song. Even though

they'd seen Seahawk and Mermista sing plenty of times before, there was something thrilling about watching them perform now — Adora's brain buzzed with a threat of happy tears when she thought about how proud she was of them.

The first song blended into the next. Adora kept dancing and singing along with her friends. She was so in the zone that it took her a moment to realize that a persistent nudge prodding into the small of her back wasn't someone dancing too close, but actually Catra trying to get her attention.

"Catra, hey!" Adora shouted, far louder than she intended. She pushed her sweaty hair off her face and smiled. She could see that Catra was laughing, and though she couldn't hear it over the music and the noise, that was okay — it was a sound she couldn't forget if she wanted to.

"Here, dork," Catra said, leaning in close so she didn't have to yell. She handed Adora a fresh drink and tapped the neck of her beer bottle to the cup's rim when Adora took it. They exchanged smiles —a private truce of sorts—and went back to enjoying the show. Adora swayed to the music and pretended not to notice that Catra stayed right by her side.

By the third song, the entire Stevenson High crew was on the dance floor, laughing and singing as if the show was a private concert just for them. Though she had originally intended to take it slow with this latest drink, Adora soon found her cup empty again. The good news was that she was too drunk to care.

At one point, Mermista called for someone from Vocal Rebellion to join her on stage for a song. Glimmer jumped at the chance, nearly bowling over throngs of college students on her way to the microphone. After a quick huddle, the pair launched into a cover of Zedd's "The Middle", which earned a cheer of approval from the audience — especially Adora and Catra. It was a song the two of them had spent many a late night belting out in Adora's bedroom back when it was topping the charts. Nostalgia surged through Adora, and when she looked to Catra, she knew she felt it too.

It didn’t take long for the rest of the party to fall away. To Adora, she and Catra may as well have been back in her room, wailing the lyrics at one another as they danced ever closer. She had missed this so, so much; the way they vamped, tossing their hair and making faces at one another. It all came back so easily.

So pull me closer, why don’t you pull me close?

Catra caught Adora’s hands and acted out the lyrics, pulling her in. And just like that, they were dancing together, and not just in each other’s orbit.

Then came the bridge, and as the song slowed, so did they.

Oh, baby, why don't you just meet me in the middle?

I'm losing my mind just a little.

Adora did feel like she was losing her mind. To be this drunk, this close — it was all so much in the best way. Catra was right there, smiling and laughing the way she used to. That squeaky little laugh, her brilliant eyes. Adora loved the way it felt like Catra could read her mind, the way she anticipated her in every way. Adora loved it. She loved this. She loved her.

The revelation hit Adora like a tidal wave.

Oh, shit, her vodka-soaked brain screamed. *I’m in love with Catra, aren’t I?*

Of course she was — she probably had been, and that thought alone was enough to bring a chaotic laugh bubbling to her lips. Could Catra read her mind now? Did she know?

And more importantly, did she feel the same way?

But Adora didn’t have the chance to dwell on it. The song was ending, and Catra, totally caught up in the moment, finished it off by twirling Adora in her arms and dipping her low as if they were a pair of ballroom dancers.

Adora's head spun. Laughing, Catra pulled her back upright. At the same moment, Glimmer bound through the audience and threw herself at them with a cry of victory.

"Did you see that?" Glimmer shouted. "We killed it!"

A crush of arms—Bow, Perfuma, Spinnerella, Netossa—strangled the words from Adora's reply with a group hug that seemed to come from all sides. And then the band was playing again, and everyone went back to singing and dancing. Someone—Bow—caught Adora's hand and twirled her until she felt dizzy. The room was spinning and she was laughing and she wanted to tell Catra all about it, but when she looked for her, she was gone.

"Glimmer," Adora said, squinting against the way her vision blurred when she turned her head too fast. "Glimmer did you— did you see where Catra is?"

When her friend didn't answer, Adora turned and realized she wasn't going to get any help from her. Glimmer was dancing with Bow, her arms curled around his neck. They were pressed tightly together and moving a lot slower than the beat of the song demanded.

Adora pursed her lips and wagged her finger at them. "Okay, we'll talk about this later."

If they heard her, they didn't acknowledge it.

Next, she looked for Scorpia. She was easy enough to find, towering the way she did over many of the college students. But Scorpia was just off the dance floor, laughing with Perfuma. No Catra.

So, Adora pushed through the crowd. She wove her way to the back of the room where there was space to breathe. Wondering if maybe Catra had slipped away to the washroom, Adora decided to head upstairs and investigate. She maneuvered her way to the stairs, just aware enough that she was stumbling, but too drunk to do anything about it.

And that's when she found her, perched on a step on the staircase. Catra sat alone, peeling the label off an empty beer bottle.

"Catra!" Adora cried, throwing her hands in the air. Catra sat up with a start, clearly surprised. Adora could see her mouth moving, but she couldn't hear her over the party, so she crawled up the stairs and propped herself up on Catra's knees. "It's too loud, I can't hear you. You okay?"

It was hard to tell if the flush in Catra's cheeks was from the dancing or something else. Her mismatched eyes were wide and held Adora's without blinking.

"Yeah, I'm fine," she said. "I just needed a break."

Frowning, Adora shook her head. Her vision spun. "You're lying."

"What?" Catra squawked.

"I know you, Catra," Adora said. She leaned forward so she didn't have to yell. "I know when you're lying."

Catra tensed. Her eyes dropped to her lap. "Uh, Adora?"

Adora followed her gaze downward. Somewhere, in the process of leaning forward, Adora's hand had slid into one of the many tears of Catra's jeans. The fingers clenched around Catra's bare thigh.

The sane part of Adora's brain scolded her — told her to be embarrassed. But the drunk part, which was taking up far more space in her head at this point, found it hilarious. She let out a snort of laughter and Catra shook her head.

"You are so drunk," Catra said.

"Aren't you?" Adora balked indignantly.

Now Catra laughed. "Not as drunk as you are!"

Adora pouted. “Boo. Shut up.”

Her mind and her body didn’t seem to be on speaking terms anymore. Against every shred of common sense, Adora flopped down on the steps between Catra’s knees and wrapped her arms around her waist. She nuzzled her face into the soft warmth of Catra’s neck and sighed. “I’m really glad you’re here.”

Drunk time passes differently than normal time, so Adora had no way of knowing how long they sat there in silence. Then, without speaking, Catra slid her hands around Adora’s shoulders and hugged her back.

“Yeah.” Catra’s fingers combed gently through Adora’s loose hair. “This was fun.”

“So fun!” Adora agreed, tightening her grip. “I miss this, Catra. I miss *you*.”

She could feel Catra’s body go rigid in her arms. She knew they were on the precipice, hovering in that frustrating liminal space that existed in the moments before Catra tended to pull away. Normally, this would be Adora’s sign to back off. But Adora was drunk, and there was a very good chance that she was in love with her best friend.

So, no — she wouldn’t be backing off this time.

Catra swallowed hard, her throat moving against Adora’s cheek.

Adora pulled back and smiled up at Catra, who stared back with glistening eyes.

Is she crying? Why is she crying?

“Catra, don’t cry,” Adora whispered, reaching up to brush the hair out of her face. “We can go back, y’know. We can be us again.”

Wow, she is so close...

An inscrutable look flickered across Catra's face. "Adora, I—"

Adora didn't let her finish.

Instead, she closed that whisper of space between them.

She pressed her mouth to Catra's lips, and kissed her best friend.



Chapter 33

Chapter Notes

Surprise! This was originally supposed to go up on Tuesday, October 13th but OH WELL.

CW: Underage drinking and poor choices

If Adora's lips were magic, then Catra was under their spell. She sat on the stairs, suspended in time and rendered helpless by the impossible softness of Adora's mouth on hers.

Is this happening? she thought. A kaleidoscope of butterflies took flight inside of her, their delicate wings fluttering a nonsensical rhythm against her heart.

This is actually happening.

Like the enchanted thing it was, the kiss seemed to both stretch on for eternity and be over too soon. Catra felt Adora's weight shift back, pulling away, and her heart fumbled over itself as it called out for her to stay.

Everything about this was a bad idea, but that didn't mean she wanted it to stop. So, as Adora drifted away, Catra leaned into the space she left behind. She cupped a hand around the back of Adora's neck and pulled her in again.

And Adora stayed.

This time when their lips found each other, Catra kissed Adora back. She kissed her properly and deeply, drinking her in. Adora smiled against her mouth as she sank back into the embrace, her fingertips brushing against Catra's exposed waist as she did so. *Did she mean to do that?* Catra wondered. *Or was it an accident?* Either way, the touch sent Catra's mind spinning.

They moved against one another, greedy in the way they grasped at the other's clothes and limbs. *Stay close*, their hands demanded. *Stay with me*. Each desperate kiss was followed by another. Adora placed one hand on the step next to Catra's hip and used it to hoist herself up so she could brace the other on a higher step behind Catra's head. She pressed into her, forcing Catra back against the angle of the stairs. It wasn't comfortable at all, but Catra wasn't about to complain.

Catra had spent so long wanting this. She had lost years to pining in secret, never daring to hope that Adora could ever feel the same way. And now it was happening — it was *actually* happening. And yet, as they sat tangled together—lips on lips and hands everywhere—a voice hissed in the dark recesses of Catra's mind: *why did this have to happen now?*

When Adora pulled back a second time, breathless and heavy-lidded, Catra let her go. The taste of her lingered on Catra's tongue; too much vodka laced with something sickly sweet. Adora looked up at her through the soft fan of her lashes, and Catra could see the way she swayed perilously, thrown asunder by far too much drink. When she smiled, Catra wanted nothing more than to melt back into her. But when Adora tipped her chin, dipping in for another kiss, Catra knew she couldn't let that happen.

With a gasp, Catra hoisted herself up to the next step, wrenching herself away from the dangerous temptation of Adora's lips.

"Adora, stop," Catra breathed. She pressed a palm to her chest and willed her heart to calm down.

"What?" Adora sounded wounded. "But why?"

"Because you're drunk!"

Adora's expression fell and her bottom lip trembled. "What does that have to do with anything?"

Squirming all the way out from under her, Catra stumbled to her feet. She rushed down the stairs, but Adora caught her hand.

"Catra, talk to me," she pleaded. "What's wrong?"

Self-sabotage was like second nature to Catra — she always knew exactly how to take a good thing and fuck it up. Later, she would wonder why she couldn't just let herself be happy. But in this moment, as she gazed down at Adora with her big blue eyes and perfect mouth, Catra set her expression into a mask of practiced dispassion and yanked her hand back.

"You wouldn't have done that if you were sober," she said. Her heart ached so badly that it hurt just to breathe. "And someday soon, you're going to regret that you did it at all."

Adora flinched as though she'd been kicked. "What? Catra, no. I —"

"You are *drunk*, Adora," Catra snapped. "Go. Home."

Her sudden ferocity seemed to cut through Adora's haze of intoxication like a blast of icy air. Adora crumpled where she sat, pressed her hand over her mouth, and burst into tears.

Catra whirled away, unable to watch the fallout of her carnage. Instead, she stormed across the room, shoving through party-goers and breathing hard. Eventually she found who she was looking for. Glimmer and Bow sat on the sofa — Glimmer on Bow's lap, the two of them wrapped in each other's arms, kissing like they were the only two people in the world.

"Oy, Sparkles," Catra shouted, making the couple jump.

Glimmer twisted around and shot Catra a murderous glare. "Do you mind?"

"I do, actually. Adora's fucking wasted. You need to get her home before she does something stupid."

Bow furrowed his brow. “C’mon, give Adora more credit than that. She’s not the type of person to—”

“Oh yeah?” Catra cut him off and gestured back toward the stairs. “She’s over there right now bawling her eyes out. Aren’t you three supposed to be, like, best friends or whatever? Go help her.”

“She’s *crying*?” Glimmer scampered off of Bow’s lap and thrust a finger into Catra’s face. “What did you do?”

It took every ounce of fortitude Catra had not to get pulled into an argument that would no doubt end in her saying something she’d regret. Instead, she crossed her arms and feigned indifference. “*I* didn’t do anything. And if you two decide to do the same, someone’s going to end up turning her into a sad drunk girl meme or something.”

Glimmer and Bow shared a wide-eyed look of alarm. They both knew there was a very real possibility of that coming true, so they hurried past Catra, casting suspicious looks her way as they went. Catra dropped down into their spot on the sofa and watched through the crowd as the couple found Adora, still sobbing on the stairs, and helped her to her feet. None of them spared so much as a glance back at her. Once they disappeared up the stairwell, Catra let out a quivering breath and dropped her head into her hands.

This is just my fucking luck, Catra thought miserably. In her mind, she tried to recapture every second of the kiss — the softness of Adora’s lips, the thrill of finally having her the way she’d always wanted her, even if it was all doomed from the start. But there was bitterness there, simmering just beneath the surface.

Bitterness that Adora would do something like this now — now, when their relationship was so tenuous and uncertain.

Bitterness that she herself hadn’t been brave enough to make the first move back when it would have made a difference.

And bitterness at the knowledge that it was too late for them now. She was in too deep, and no matter how much she wanted Adora, Catra didn't have the strength to stop what she'd started.

Because the truth was, she was still angry. She was so tired of being disposable, of floundering just off the fringes of worthiness. In Catra's mind, she was too close to stop now. Her deep and desperate need to prove herself—to show everyone that she was so much more than they ever thought she could be—was a runaway train, and spite kept her pinned to the tracks.

But when Catra licked her lips, she could still taste the vodka lingering there. She wasn't being dramatic when she told Adora she'd regret that kiss. If all the pieces of Catra's plan fell into place—and she knew they would—Adora was probably going to regret having even called Catra a friend.

And maybe it was better that way.

"Geeze, Kitten. You look rough."

Catra jolted upright with a squeak of surprise to find both DT and Scorpia hovering in front of her.

"How long have you two been standing there?" she demanded, her face flushed with humiliation.

"Long enough to know you probably need this more than I do," DT replied. They thrust a cup at Catra. "Drink up, it'll help."

"I don't need any help," Catra grumbled, though she took the cup anyway. She raised it to her nose and gave the contents a cautions sniff. "Ugh! What is this?"

DT shrugged. "Tequila."

"And?"

"And nothing."

Catra wrinkled her nose in disgust. “You drink tequila straight? What’s the matter with you?”

“My drinks are the only straight thing about me, darling,” DT drawled. They reached out and pushed the cup closer to Catra’s mouth. “Now drink up, you know we don’t waste.”

Despite her better judgement, Catra did as she was told. The tequila seared her mouth and left a trail of fire down her throat as she swallowed. It was awful, but the instant the alcohol hit her stomach, Catra knew it was exactly what she needed to stomp out those pesky flairs of guilt that were licking at the edges of her mind. If she had to get wasted to forget what a terrible person she was, then so be it.

As she drank, Scorpia settled gently down onto the sofa beside her. Her brows were knitted with concern. “You okay, Wildcat? You look, I dunno… distressed?”

Swallowing another sip, Catra shuddered and wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. “I’m fine. I just want to get drunk and forget this night ever happened.”

“Are you sure?” Scorpia shifted. “I mean, that sounds like fun and all, but we could always skip the hangover and just talk about it instead.”

Catra cut her a glare over the rim of her cup. “Stop being so nice to me, Scorpia. I don’t deserve it.”

Scorpia was visibly thrown. It wasn’t often that Catra was this vulnerable with her. “What? C’mon, I don’t believe that for a second. And neither does DT—” she looked up at them “—right?”

But DT lifted their hands and stepped back. “Oh, I’m not getting involved in whatever this is, honey. But I am going to get myself another drink.”

“Grab me another one while you’re up there,” Catra said, despite her grimace. “I’m gonna need it.”

As DT disappeared into the crowd, Catra steeled her nerve and threw back what was left in her cup. Already she could feel the alcohol rushing to her head. She sank into the fuzziness of the buzz and let it carry her away.

On stage, the band was coming back from a break. They picked up their instruments, looking refreshed and ready to keep the party going. The first song started and Catra swayed to the beat without really listening.

"Hey," Scorpia said, having to shout to get Catra's attention. "Wanna dance?"

Catra looked down at her empty cup, shrugged, and tossed it on the floor. "Fuck it. Sure."

With an elated smile, Scorpia jumped up and dragged Catra to her feet. They elbowed their way onto the floor and started to dance. The tequila was doing wonders for Catra's inhibitions, loosening the death grip that pride usually had over her. She danced, taking up space and letting Scorpia sweep her around while they both laughed. DT found them and handed over another cup of tequila. This one went down easier than the last, though Catra wasn't sure if that's because she was getting used to it or was just too drunk to care about the fire it lit in her belly. Together, the three of them sang and moved and Catra didn't care how she looked or what people thought of her. She was dancing to forget.

The floor was packed with sweaty, thrashing bodies. At one point someone danced up behind Catra — that buff girl who answered the door, the one with the long white ponytail. She gripped Catra's hips with her strong hands and drew her closer, grinding against her from behind. Under any other circumstance, Catra would have dropped the girl where she stood. But now, drunk and sad as she was, Catra let it happen. She moved into it, arching her back and letting the stranger's hands wander and play coyly at the hem of her shirt.

The girl leaned down and growled something into Catra's ear about finding somewhere a little more private. Catra laughed darkly.

Whatever, she thought. *I don't care anymore*.

Scorpia, however, did care. She swooped in and plucked Catra from the stranger's grip, tucking her tiny body under arm protectively. Catra was vaguely aware of some heated words being exchanged between Scorpia and the girl, until DT breezed in and broke it up.

Gently, Scorpia led Catra off the dance floor and over to a wall where it was quieter. When Catra looked up, she saw Scorpia's expression was tight with concern, and she laughed.

"Good ol' Scorpia," she said, grinning. "Always comin' to my rescue."

"Well, yeah!" Scorpia replied, looking stricken. "I wasn't going to let some rando take advantage of you when you're drunk."

Catra snorted another laugh. "You worry too much."

"Of course I do." Scorpia's tone was gentle. "I mean, I care about you, so…" She trailed off.

"You shouldn't." Catra shook her head, and the motion was nearly enough to tip her over. But Scorpia caught her and held her steady. "I'm a bad person, Scorpia. You should save your feelings for someone who deserves you."

"Stop saying stuff like that!"

Catra blinked blearily up at Scorpia, surprised. It was the first time Scorpia had ever been terse with her. She tipped her head and considered her for a moment. "You really do care, don't you?"

"Yeah," Scorpia smiled weakly. "You… You're everything to me."

You're a fool, Catra thought. She stepped closer and laid a hand on Scorpia's broad chest just to feel what the touch did to her heart.

"Then kiss me," she said, her voice low and smokey.

Scorpia jerked back. "What?"

"I said—" Catra lifted onto her toes and grabbed Scorpia's collar, pulling her down to her level "—kiss me."

A beat passed between them. Catra watched Scorpia's expression melt into one of understanding as it dawned on her that Catra was dead serious. And then, she did it. She pulled Catra in and kissed her, hard. Then she kissed her again, and then again, and Catra was surprised to discover that she was actually quite good at it. Scorpia's kisses were fierce — she was startlingly rough for someone so soft and gentle. Catra let Scorpia devour her, let her hoist her up in her strong arms and pin her to the wall so that her mouth was easier to reach. This, Catra knew, was a huge mistake, but she couldn't help herself. She needed to feel something other than self-loathing and guilt. She needed someone to help her forget the one person she actually wanted, but couldn't have.

So, Catra kissed Scorpia back. She pressed into her, rolling her hips provocatively just to watch Scorpia come undone. It was so easy. Catra tipped her head back, coming up for air and moaning shamelessly.

Someone let out a whistle.

"Get a room, you two!" DT jeered.

Their teasing pulled Catra and Scorpia out of their trance. They stared at each other for a moment in stunned silence.

Scorpia swallowed. "Catra, I'm so sorry. I—"

"Shh." Catra pressed another kiss to her lips and pretended she was someone else. "Just take me home."

*

Across town, Adora was lying on the plush carpeted floor of Glimmer's bedroom. In one hand she clutched a bottle of red Gatorade. The other was wrapped around a half eaten McDonald's double quarter pounder with cheese. Sniffling, she forced herself to take another bite. As she chewed, she rolled her head to the side so she could see Glimmer and Bow. They sat side by side, leaning back against Glimmer's bed and sharing a large order of fries.

"So," Adora said — the first word she'd spoken since they left the party. "When did this happen?" She gestured at the complete lack of space between the two of them.

Glimmer and Bow blushed at one another.

"Last night," Glimmer said, smiling meekly. "We were just waiting for the right time to tell you…"

Bow wrapped his arm around Glimmer, looking smitten. "We were actually going to take you to brunch tomorrow and tell you over pancakes."

Adora nodded and tried to smile.

"Congrats," she choked out. "I'm so… I'm really happy for you…"

She was crying before she even finished the sentence.

"Uh oh," Bow said. "There she goes again."

Glimmer sighed. "Come on, Adora. Just tell us what happened — we can't help you if we don't know what's wrong."

Up until this point, Adora hadn't been able to tell them why they'd found her a blubbering mess at the party. But now that she'd sobered up a bit, Adora knew she owed them an explanation. She rolled onto her side and pushed herself up to face them, wiping away tears with her sleeve.

“I kissed Catra,” she admitted.

Bow gasped. Glimmer gripped his forearm, her eyes wide.

“You *did*?” Glimmer sounded incredulous.

Adora nodded.

“What did she do?” Bow asked.

“She…” Adora hesitated, touching her fingertips to her lips and remembering the way Catra had pulled her in when she tried to pull away. “She kissed me back.”

Glimmer let out an elated shriek and smacked Bow’s shoulder excitedly. “It finally happened!”

“What are you talking about?” Adora looked back and forth between them, confused. This was not how she expected them to react.

Grinning, Bow leaned forward and took Adora’s hand. “Adora, we know you’re into Catra.”

“Who told you that?” Adora could feel her face heating up.

“Come on, Adora,,” Glimmer laughed. “Everyone knows. You’d have to be blind not to see it.”

Suddenly, Adora was feeling stone cold sober. “*Everyone*?”

“Well, everyone except the two of you,” Bow conceded. “The rest of us have been wondering how long it was going to take before one of you finally made a move.”

Glimmer couldn’t seem to sit still. She wiggled in place, bursting at the seams with delight. “We even came up with a ship name for you two: Catradora. Isn’t that cute?”

Adora wasn’t sure how to react to that. All she could do was gape wordless at them both.

Bow was the first to realize they had gotten distracted. He cleared his throat. "I mean, you *do* like her, don't you?"

"I— yes, I guess I…" Adora pressed her palms into her flaming cheeks. She couldn't believe she was saying this out loud. After years of harboring a crush on her best friend, this was the first time she was actually admitting to it. But this was Bow and Glimmer she was talking to — they cared about her. She could trust them with this. "I've liked her for a long time."

"Knew it," Glimmer muttered victoriously under her breath.

Bow shot her warning look before turning his attention back to Adora. "Then why are you so upset?"

Drawing in a shaky breath, Adora recalled the way Catra snatched her hand away she Adora reached for her. "She got mad at me. She said I was too drunk and had to go home."

At this, Bow and Glimmer exchanged knowing glances.

"Adora," Glimmer said, trying not to smile. "You were drunk. You're still drunk now."

"Yeah, but, she said I wouldn't have done it if I were sober and—"

"Would you, though?" Bow asked gently. "Like, sure you like her, but would you have actually kissed her if you hadn't had all that liquid courage egging you on?"

Adora's mouth fell open. She hadn't thought about it that way.

Glimmer took Adora's other hand and gave it a squeeze. "If you think about it, Catra was actually being pretty responsible about the whole thing. She was probably worried you'd regret it once you were sober. I'll bet if you two talk about it in a day or two, you'll be able to tell her how you really feel."

As she spoke, all three of their phones chimed and vibrated with text alerts, no doubt from the Vocal Rebellion group chat. But

neither Bow nor Glimmer let that distract them from the fact that Adora needed them. They smiled reassuringly at her as she swallowed down the lump in her throat.

“Thank you,” she said. “I really needed to hear that.”

Bow gave her a soft and playful shove. “Of course! That’s what friends do.”

Glimmer nodded. “And when you do decide to talk to her, we’ll be there for you no matter what happens.”

At last, Adora felt the tight knot in her chest unravel. Of course she’d been overreacting — she just needed someone to point it out to her. She exhaled and settled back, relieved to have friends who were so good at talking sense into her. The mood in the room shifted as Bow leaned forward and grinned.

“Okay, now tell us everything!”

While Adora started recounting her drunken makeout session to her friends, Glimmer finally stole a quick glance at her phone. Out of the corner of her vision, Adora watched Glimmer’s smile fade as her eyes grew round at the sight of whatever message was waiting on her screen.

“Oh, shit,” Glimmer whispered. Bow leaned in and peered down at the phone in her hand. His expression fell too, and he attempted to smother a gasp with his hand.

“What?” Adora asked, a bud of panic blossoming in her stomach. She pulled her own phone from her pocket. “Did something happen—“

“Bow!” Glimmer cried.

Adora’s eyes flicked up from a group message alert from DT just in time to see Bow lunging at her. She let out a strangled cry as he wrapped his strong arms around her and tried to wrestle the phone from her hands.

“Bow, what the hell?”

“Don’t look at that!” he grunted as Adora squirmed. Unfortunately for him, Adora was much stronger than she looked. She was able to hold him at bay with one hand while she finished opening the message with the other.

The text message, which included a photo, filled her screen. Adora’s body went numb. She stopped fighting, and Bow snatched the phone from her hand. But it was too late — she’d already seen what her friends were trying to protect her from.

Shame you three had to leave so soon! DT’s message read. *You missed these bitches getting messyyyyyy*

Underneath was a photo, a selfie with DT’s smirking face in the bottom corner. And there, clearly visible over their shoulder, was Catra kissing Scorpia.

Chapter 34

Chapter Notes

CW: Some handsy foreplay

That night, Catra's subconscious gave her a second chance to do everything right.

In her dreams, she was back on that staircase, Adora draped languidly between her legs. When Adora wrapped her arms around her, Catra didn't hesitate to return the gesture. She held Adora tight and close, savoring her comforting warmth and the floral scent of her hair.

The Adora in Catra's dream teased her fingers up Catra's back, coyly slipping under the bunched hem of her shirt and tracing nonsensical patterns up and down her spine. In her dream, Catra arched her back, needy and desperate for Adora's touch. She tipped her head back and let Adora explore her, gasping shamelessly as Adora groped at her chest before dragging her fingers lower, lower, to the top of Catra's jeans.

Catra was already breathless by the time Adora kissed her. There was no moment of tense surprise this time, only eager acceptance. Catra parted her lips and invited Adora in. She moaned against Adora's tongue as it curled around her sharp teeth like a dare. In return, Catra nipped Adora's lower lip, bruising bites marking what was hers.

This dream Adora was as bold as Catra needed her to be. She pinned Catra to the steps the same way she had in real life. But this time, as she kissed Catra over and over, her hand slid lower. First, she gripped Catra's thigh, her thumb drawing firm, teasing circles that drove Catra crazy. Catra lifted her hips and tipped her knees out wide as if to say *please, keep going. Don't stop there.*

In her dream, Catra got everything she wanted. No guilt, no regret. Just Adora's hand, sliding off her thigh so it could press into the heat between her legs instead. The pressure, the friction, it was everything Catra needed. It was so damn good. And when the feeling bloomed and hovered on the cusp of being too much, Catra cried Adora's name and awoke with a gasp.

Adora, the staircase, the dark frat house basement — it all disappeared as Catra's eyes snapped open. She regretted it immediately. The soft morning light that drifted across the room felt like icepicks driving into her eyes. Catra clamped them shut again and gulped deep, desperate breaths to calm the raging headache that had exploded just in the middle of her forehead.

Minutes passed before Catra was brave enough to open her eyes again. This time she did so gingerly, shielding them with a weak hand. Her eyes were dry and gritty, but she found it didn't hurt quite as badly if she squinted. She scowled up at the ceiling, wondering why something felt off — something about the quality of the morning light and the way it cut across the room was oddly unfamiliar.

Frowning, Catra turned her head carefully to the left and peered around. She spotted her clothes, piled carelessly on the floor. Wrinkled red t-shirt, tattered black jeans, leather jacket — the outfit she'd worn to the party.

The party.

Memories from the night before swam hazily to the surface of Catra's mind. She remembered dancing, sitting on the stairs, and Adora…

Catra's heart skipped. Adora kissed her. Catra recalled how excited she'd been in that moment, and then, how horrible she felt when she remembered the two of them weren't on the same side anymore. Regret came rushing back to her, and Catra draped her forearm over her eyes as if that would do anything to keep the memories away.

But she couldn't forget the sight of Adora's face, lovely even in tears. Catra knew those tears had been her fault, though the details of what she'd done to cause them were still lost in the fuzzy edges of her hangover. She remembered very little after that. DT pushing a red cup into her hands. Thrashing on the dancefloor with…

Scorpia.

This time when Catra's eyes flew open, she was too terrified to care about the sharp pain behind them. She looked again to the floor. Yes, those were her clothes discarded in a heap, but that wasn't her carpet. It was too clean, too new, and the wrong color entirely.

This wasn't her room.

Catra swallowed against a wave of nausea. *Oh no…*

Slowly, she turned her head to the right. There, right beside her, was Scorpia. She was on her side and facing away. Catra watched, frozen in place, as Scorpia's hulking figure rose and fell with the gentle rhythm of her sleeping breath.

No, Catra thought. *No, no, no…*

Something frantic welled up inside of her. Trembling, Catra lifted the duvet and looked down at herself. She was still in her underwear, but that was it.

Without thinking, Catra shot up. The room spun around her as she winced, but she didn't have time to ride out the ache. She had to get out of there before—

"Catra?" Scorpia's groggy voice turned Catra's blood to ice.

"What am I doing here?" Catra croaked. Her breaths came quick and shallow. "Why are my clothes on the floor? What happened?"

Catra's rising panic seemed to wake Scorpia up in an instant. She shimmied upright, and Catra was vaguely relieved to see she was fully clothed in a pair of soft pajama pants and a Stevenson High Athletics t-shirt.

"Hey, hey. It's okay. Just relax." Scorpia said softly, getting to her feet. Catra scowled up at her and clutched the duvet to her chin.

"Relax? I just woke up nearly naked in your bed and I have no idea how that happened, so excuse me if I'm freaking out a bit."

A sad expression flickered across Scorpia's face. She sighed and rounded the bed slowly, as if she might frighten Catra away if she moved too quickly.

"Do you remember anything?" she asked without looking at her. She busied herself with collecting Catra's clothes off the floor.

Catra watched her warily. "I remember us dancing. And I remember DT giving me something to drink."

Scorpia nodded solemnly. "Tequila."

That rang a bell. Catra cringed. "Right."

"Do you—" Scorpia paused to clear her throat "—do you remember, uh… kissing me?"

As soon as she said it, the memory resurfaced. It played against the inside of Catra's mind like a movie. Yes, she remembered kissing Scorpia. Or rather, she remembered telling Scorpia to kiss *her*. Catra groaned and hid her face in her hand.

"You, uh… you told me to take you home," Scorpia continued. Through the gap between her fingers, Catra could see that she looked exhausted.

"Fuck," Catra wailed. She looked at her clothes, wadded in Scorpia's arms. She couldn't remember them coming off, let alone

which of them had been the one to do the job. She drew in a shaky breath. “Did we…”

She couldn’t bring herself to finish the question. It didn’t matter though, because Scorpia’s face flushed a violent shade of red and Catra knew she understood.

“No!” Scorpia cried, shaking her head frantically. “No, no. I mean, we made out for a while, but we definitely didn’t…” She looked about as mortified as Catra felt. Scorpia took a deep breath and tried again. “A drunk person can’t consent. I wouldn’t have done that to you. You could barely stand!”

“Then why are you holding my clothes right now?”

Scorpia glanced down and let out a nervous laugh. “Well, you, uh… You took them off. I tried to stop you, but you were pretty adamant.”

Catra furrowed her brow. “So, let me get this straight: you made out with me, but you wouldn’t fuck me. Good to know where you draw the line.”

Wincing, Scorpia put the clothes down at Catra’s side, then side-stepped to the end of the bed. She sat on the edge next to Catra’s feet.

“I deserve that,” she said quietly.

They sat in terrible silence for a few moments. Catra’s heart was hammering in her chest, the adrenaline of discovering what she’d done still surging through her veins. She stole a quick glance at Scorpia, who was staring down at her feet. Poor, sweet Scorpia. Catra knew she meant well, just like she knew Scorpia was telling the truth. Scorpia wasn’t perfect, but she was certainly better than most. It was slowly starting to dawn on Catra that she could do a lot worse than be the object of this charming, lovely girl’s affection.

Clearing her throat, Catra looked for a way to lighten the mood. "So, I guess—"

"Wildcat, we need to talk," Scorpia cut her off, speaking quickly. Catra blinked in surprise. Her stomach dropped with a sense of foreboding she couldn't quite explain.

"Yeah, I know," she said, trying to sound casual. "I made an ass of myself last night. It won't happen—"

"That's not it. Can you let me— there's something I need to say to you."

Uh oh, Catra thought. Her stomach turned in a way that was completely separate from the hangover-induced gymnastics it was already doing. She nodded and Scorpia took a breath.

"I like you, Wildcat. I think you know that — I think you've probably always known it."

Oh no, Catra wanted to crawl out of her skin. *I don't think I can handle a love confession right now*.

Scorpia twisted to face her. The effort it took her to keep speaking looked excruciating. "And I know you don't feel the same way about me. Not really."

A fresh round of mortification swept through Catra. Heat raced to her cheeks. "Scorpia, where is this coming from?"

Licking her lips, Scorpia forced herself to meet Catra's gaze. Her dark eyes were filled with more than just sadness — there was undeniable pity there, and it put Catra on edge.

"You called me 'Adora' last night," Scorpia said. "We were kissing and you started taking off your… well, you know." She shrank into herself, but she didn't look away. "And you called me by her name."

Catra's mouth fell open. The room around her spun as her thoughts turned to white noise in her ears. Mortification didn't even begin to describe what she was feeling.

"I really care about you, Catra." Scorpia rushed through her words like she was reciting a well-rehearsed speech and didn't want to forget the words. For all Catra knew, that was exactly what she'd done. "But I don't want to be anyone's second choice. I deserve better than that."

There it was again: that tingling, free-falling feeling that told Catra to run. Run far, run fast; get the hell away from this horrible trainwreck and salvage whatever was left in private.

Trembling, Catra fumbled with her clothes. She couldn't bring herself to look at Scorpia anymore. All she could do was get dressed with a single-minded focus that drowned everything else out.

"I have to go," Catra muttered. She didn't even try to cover herself as she pulled on her bra, then her shirt. As she swung her legs out over the side of the bed to wriggle into her jeans, she was vaguely aware that Scorpia was trying to talk her down, but she couldn't let herself hear it.

"C'mon, Catra," Scorpia was saying. "You don't have to leave. Let's talk about this."

But Catra was already on her feet. She struggled into her jacket and snatched her bag off the floor. Her stomach rolled and her head throbbed, but she pushed through it. "Thanks for letting me crash here, Scorpia. I'll… I'll see you later or whatever."

Before Scorpia could respond, Catra threw open her bedroom door and darted for the front door. Scorpia's moms peered curiously from the kitchen and watched Catra shoved her feet into her boots and burst out into the bright winter morning without looking back.

Catra's leather jacket and ripped jeans did little to protect her from the cold, but she didn't care. The chill invigorated her, making it easier for her to ignore the effects of her hangover. She ran as fast and as far as her weak legs would carry her, out of Scorpia's fancy neighborhood and into the next where the houses were a bit smaller and a lot older. She cut down an alley, sliding on the frosty concrete as she rounded the corner and kept going until her body couldn't fight it any longer. Catra stopped and doubled over behind a dumpster where she vomited into the snow.

When her stomach was finally finished expelling its contents, Catra briefly considered curling up in a snowbank and staying there until she either felt better or died of hypothermia. Either option seemed acceptable to her at this point. But instead, she shuffled onward, trembling from exertion and the sweat on her brow as it cooled uncomfortably against her skin. She had earned this walk of shame.

By the time Catra made it home, she was as numb on the outside as she was on the inside. She kicked her boots off and propped them over the heating vent before wandering into the kitchen where Madame Razz was washing dishes.

"Hey, Razz," Catra said, her voice hoarse. She pulled a glass from the cupboard and waited for her turn at the sink.

"Hello, Catra dearie," Razz sang. She took Catra's glass and filled it for her. "I wasn't expecting you home until tomorrow."

Mumbling a word of thanks, Catra took her glass and sipped at her water like the live-giving elixir it was. "Change of plans. Hey, do you know if Adora's back?"

"Afraid not, dearie. I don't imagine we'll be seeing much of her over the holidays."

Catra paused, the rim of her glass against her lips. "What do you mean?"

Razz hummed contendedly to herself and pulled the stopper from the sink. The water swirled down the drain with a loud gurgle that ended in a pop. "She called this morning and asked if she could spend the break with her friend from that singing group you two are in. Shimmer? Glitter? I can't remember the name, dearie."

"Oh." Catra's heart clenched. "Right." She turned in a daze and cut across the room.

"Will you be here for dinner?" Razz asked. Catra paused in the doorway.

"Um, not sure. I'll let you know, 'kay?"

Razz nodded and busied herself with the teapot. "Alright, dearie. Now, go wash up. You smell like Razz's glory days. Oh, I had myself some fun when I was your age. What a time."

That was a thread Catra had no interest in pulling at, so she hurried up the stairs without another word. But she did as she was told, shedding her party outfit like a disease-touched hazmat suit and cramming it to the bottom of her already overflowing laundry hamper. She washed up and changed into sweats before bundling herself beneath her comforter. Only once she was safe in bed did she bother to look at her phone. A text from Scorpia lit up the screen.

I hope you made it home safe. I'm sorry that I upset you.

Catra rolled her eyes. Leave it to Scorpia to apologize over something that wasn't even remotely her fault. She scrolled down and found another message that Scorpia had sent separately.

I know this will probably make you angrier, but I care about you so I have to say it: I think you should talk to Adora.

She was right: it did make Catra angry. What exactly was she supposed to say to Adora now? *Hey, Adora! Get this: I've been in love with you since the day we met but you broke my heart so now I'm trying to ruin this thing you really enjoy because I'm a*

petty bitch! Oh, and I totally went home with Scorpia last night but don't worry, I pretended she was you the whole time. Isn't that cool?

Sighing, Catra tossed her phone onto her bedside table and rolled onto her back. She stared up at the ceiling, wondering what Adora actually would say if she could ever put her pride aside and just tell her the truth. After all, Adora *did* kiss her first. Even if she was drunk out of her mind, that couldn't have come out of nowhere, could it?

Catra touched her fingertips to her lips. Maybe Scorpia was right.

It took her another half an hour to find the courage to pick her phone back up. She typed a message, pouring her feelings out onto the screen, only to second-guess herself and delete it. This went on for a while, until she finally decided to go with something simple.

Hey, Adora. Can we talk about last night?

She hit send.

Tight with anxiety, Catra watched her screen for what felt like hours before those floating ellipses popped up. She held her breath and wiped her sweaty palms on her sheets. The ellipses appeared, disappeared, and reappeared in a tortuous cycle. Catra was vaguely aware that she was usually the one leaving other people waiting on her replies. It was an awful feeling.

Finally, Adora's reply pinged. Catra sprang up to sitting and peered down at her screen.

Actually I think I need some space right now Catra

Catra blinked. She shook her head and then looked at the message again just to be sure she'd read it right.

What do you mean you need space? she typed back. There was a roaring in her ears that had nothing to do with her

hangover. *You're the one who kissed me remember?*

Another agonizing stretch of time passed as Adora worked on her reply.

I know, she sent at last. *I shouldn't have done that. I'm sorry*

Catra had to clutch the edge of her bed to remind herself that she was no, in fact, falling. The ground hadn't opened up under her, swallowing her into a bottomless black pit. It just felt that way.

What the fuck Adora? Are you serious right now?

Catra's pulse raced. She couldn't wrap her mind around what was happening. When Adora didn't reply, Catra did something she never did: she called her. The line rang and rang, eventually going to voicemail. Catra swore, hung up, and tried again.

As the second call went to voicemail again, Catra's text message alert chimed in her ear. She pulled the phone away from her ear to find a text from Glimmer.

Catra, I think you should just leave her alone for a little bit

An instant, blinding rage flared up from the center of Catra's gut. Who the hell was Glimmer to tell her not to talk to Adora?

What the fuck is going on? She fired back.

Unlike Adora, Glimmer's reply was immediate. *LMAO. Are you really asking me that?*

Obviously!

This time it took a couple seconds for Glimmer to text back. When she finally did reply, all she sent was a photo.

It was a selfie of DT from the party. Catra's heart plummeted at the sight of herself in the background, pinned to the wall in Scorpia's arms.

Where did you get this? Catra demanded. She felt lightheaded. *Is this some kind of joke?*

Where do you think I got it? Glimmer replied. *And no. The only joke here is you. If you're with Scorpia then you shouldn't have kissed Adora back. Now please leave her alone*.

The wheels of Catra's mind spun into overdrive, trying to think of how to respond. But in her fury and mortification, she couldn't form a coherent thought. She needed to talk to Adora, not Glimmer. She needed her to understand that this was all a huge misunderstanding. But Adora had already made up her mind. Would anything Catra said at this point change that?

If there was, Catra didn't know what that something was. So, instead of trying, she turned off her phone. Then she hurled it across the room with a furious cry, panting hard.

Maybe Coach Weaver was right.

Maybe she really was better off staying angry.

Chapter 35

Spending the holiday break with Glimmer and her family was exactly what Adora needed after the disastrous frat party. Sure, she spent the first few days moping and nursing the pain of a broken heart, but her friends weren't about to let her spend the entire break sulking in bed.

After Glimmer intercepted Catra's calls and texts on that first day, Adora's phone was confiscated. At first she resented having her screen time managed as if she was a grounded middle-schooler. But after a couple of days, she found she actually appreciated the break. Not having her phone meant she couldn't obsessively check her messages. Without her phone, she didn't have a chance to cave to the desperate desire to call Catra — be it to fight or apologize. She needed some space to clear her head, and Glimmer's extreme approach turned out to be the best way to get it.

It still stung every time Adora's mind wandered back to that photo of Catra caught up in Scorpia's arms. She didn't want to think about how the two of them were spending the holidays, or whether they'd done more than just kiss. She hated to think of Catra whispering someone else's name.

But as the days passed, those thoughts became fewer and farther between. She let Glimmer and Bow drag her around — out for hot chocolate and holiday shopping, evening strolls to look at the brightly colored lights on houses, snowball fights in the backyard. It was the perfect distraction, and eventually Adora let herself enjoy it.

By the time New Year's Eve arrived, Adora was feeling optimistic. The clock struck midnight and the three friends let out raucous cheers as they clinked their glasses together. Adora looked away, giving Bow and Glimmer a brief moment of privacy to share a New Year's kiss. Even though she was the third wheel, Adora chose to focus on the positives: a new year was like a wide open

road stretching out in front of her, and she wasn't going to bring last year's drama along for the ride.

"So," Bow said, pausing to finish his sparkling mocktail. "Are either of you making any resolutions for this year?"

"My resolution is for Vocal Rebellion to go all the way to show choir nationals!" Glimmer replied. There was an excited and determined sparkle in her eyes that told them she was dead serious.

Bow huffed a small laugh. "Go big or go home, right?"

"Damn straight." Glimmer nodded.

"I think the way you think, Glimmer," Adora said, grinning.

"What about you, Adora?" Bow asked. "How are you planning to make this a great year?"

"Can I piggyback on Glimmer's resolution?"

"My resolution is obviously for all of us," Glimmer said. "Tell us something you want to do for yourself."

Adora rolled this over in her mind as she sipped at her drink. For so long, her goals had all been the same: work hard, make cheer force captain, rule the school. But everything about this school year had been unexpected and different — so why shouldn't her dreams for the future stay the same?

"Maybe this will be the year I learn how to relax a little." She said. "You know, stop sweating the small stuff."

Glimmer let out a bark of laughter. "Now *that* would be impressive."

"I know, I know." Adora gave her a playful shove. "But seriously, I think it would be good for me to slow down a bit. Maybe try putting myself first for a change." She blushed as she spoke,

feeling sheepish for having even said the words out loud. It was something she was working on, at the gentle encouragement of both Glimmer and Bow.

"I think that sounds awesome," Bow agreed with a smile. "And for what it's worth, I'm proud of you."

"Same," Glimmer said. She leaned in and wrapped her arms around them both, pulling them all into a tight group hug. "This year is going to be amazing!"

A twinge of shame pulled at Adora's heart. Technically she was already supposed to be having an amazing year — a perfect year, in fact. Over the holidays, she'd told Glimmer and Bow everything about the plan she and Catra had coming into their junior year. She told them about how they'd spent the first two years of high school working hard to make Adora captain of the Valkyries. In turn, her rise to stardom was supposed to make the pair of them Stevenson High royalty. In the same vein, she admitted to the guilt she'd been carrying around at having been the reason the whole plan fell apart.

"You can't do that to yourself, Adora," Bow had said.

"Yeah," Glimmer had agreed. "Things change, and you have to do what's right for you. It's not your responsibility to take care of yourself *and* Catra. She's a big girl — she just has to stop feeling sorry for herself for a hot minute so she can learn to be happy too."

That was easy for them to say. They didn't know Catra like Adora did. They didn't know how Catra's desperation to claw her way to the top of the social ladder had less to do with popularity and more to do with needing to feel untouchable. They didn't understand the things Adora and Catra had been through — the shared trauma of having to survive through the foster system. They didn't know about the promises she and Catra had made to each other through tears. laying side by side in the dark, fingers laced and holding on for dear life.

But they did know that Adora had given Catra chance after chance. And things had been going well, hadn't they? Catra actually seemed to be enjoying her time in Vocal Rebellion. Their friendship had been regaining some of the strength it had lost after Adora had finally—quite possibly for the first time in her life—decided to put herself first.

It was then that the seeds for her New Year's resolution were planted. Catra drama aside, Adora was actually happy. She loved Vocal Rebellion and having the freedom to express herself. She loved the friends she'd made along the way. And, she had come to realize, she loved not being trapped under Coach Weaver's thumb.

Yes, she was sad to know that all this happiness needed to come at the expense of her friendship with Catra. But Catra had made some selfish choices of her own, and there was nothing Adora could do about that. So, she decided to focus on the one thing in her life that she could control: herself.

*

By the time the school started again, Adora was feeling like her old self again. The whole "self-care" thing was going to take some getting used to. To help, she blocked out chunks of time in her schedule that she labeled "me time". As for what that "me time" would entail, Adora figured that would be something she made up as she went along.

"Can we really call it self-care if you literally have to schedule it in?" Glimmer asked, peering over Adora's shoulder at the open calendar app on her phone. The Best Friend Squad was striding down the hallway. It was early on the morning of the first day back. The three of them sipped at coffees as they walked laps inside the school, killing time before classes started.

"Baby steps, Glimmer," Bow said, giving his girlfriend's hand a squeeze. "Adora is, like, the most organized person we know. If

this is what it takes for her to actually take some time for herself, then so be it."

Adora clicked her phone off and shoved it in her pocket with an exaggerated huff. "Thank you, Bow. It's nice to see *someone* appreciates good time management."

"Ha! Nerd," Glimmer laughed.

As they passed the gymnasium, a familiar voice cut through the morning quiet and stopped the trio in their tracks.

"No! What is this, amateur hour? That lift was sloppy and you know it. Do it again!" Catra barked, her irritation evident even through the closed gym doors.

Adora's breath hitched. It was the first time she'd heard Catra's voice since the party — the first time since she had accused Adora of only kissing her because she was drunk, and that it was time for her to leave. Winter break was the longest Adora had gone without speaking to Catra. In fact, it was the longest she'd gone without seeing her at all. To hear her voice now brought on a swell of emotion that caught Adora off guard.

"Hey," Glimmer asked gently. "Are you okay?"

"Huh?" Adora gave her head a shake and forced a smile. "Yeah, of course. I mean… sort of. But I guess I'm going to have to get over it." She leaned over so she could peer through the rectangular window on the gym door. Inside, Catra's focus was on the Valkyries as she shouted one berating command after another. The squad looked exhausted, sweat glistening off their brows and chests heaving from the effort.

"Wow, she's really hard on them," Bow muttered as he peeked around Adora's ponytail. Adora frowned. Yes, Catra's leadership style had always been a bit more direct, but this was a lot even for her.

She's pissed, Adora thought, retreating from the window before any of her former squad mates spotted her. *And I'll bet that's my fault*.

It took her a moment to realize both Glimmer and Bow were watching her intently.

"What?" she asked.

Glimmer gave her a sympathetic smile. "Are you thinking about the duet?"

"A little," Adora admitted.

Over the break, the three of them decided that it would probably be best if Adora gave up her solo in the duet for Regionals. She couldn't imagine having to sing a song about yearning with a girl who didn't love her back. Glimmer had pointed out that, after everything that happened, Catra might pull out of it first. Adora hoped that wouldn't be the case. Not only did Vocal Rebellion need Catra's voice to help secure a win, but there was no way Adora would be able to carry the song with anyone else. It was like Sectionals all over again — it didn't matter how much she practiced on her own or with another person (and both Glimmer and Bow had certainly tried), the only time Adora seemed capable of making it through the song without screwing up the lyrics was when she was singing it with Catra.

Bow hesitated, shifting with obvious discomfort before he spoke. "I'm really sorry, Adora."

Adora swallowed hard. "It's fine. We've gotta do what's best for the team, right?"

*

The first glee club rehearsal of the semester was during the lunch hour. Adora, flanked by Glimmer and Bow, made a point to arrive first so she wouldn't have to walk into the band room under the scrutiny of Catra's glare. Slowly the rest of Vocal Rebellion trickled

in, sharing joyous shouts of hello and tight hugs as if they had been apart for months instead of just a couple weeks. Adora braced herself for questions or whispers about what had gone down at the party, but it already seemed to be old news.

When Scorpia pushed through the door, Adora pretended to be busy with her phone. Not that she was doing a good job of hiding her discomfort — she loathed her inability to stop the slow creep of heat that inched its way up her neck and gave her away in situations like this.

Only once Scorpia took a seat on the other side of the room did Adora dare to steal a glance. She had been expecting Catra to be there, glued to her new girlfriend's side. In her stress dreams, Adora's mind tortured her with scenarios in which she had to sit idly by while Catra perched on Scorpia's lap, stealing kisses and whispering secrets in her ear. But the only person with Scorpia was DT, who noticed Adora staring and cut her a sly grin. She snapped her attention back to her phone when they wiggled their fingers at her in a teasing wave. Meanwhile, Scorpia chatted brightly with Perfuma, completely unaware of the uncomfortable exchange happening beside her.

Maybe Catra's not coming, Adora thought. Concern and curiosity mixed inside of her like a cocktail. *Maybe she's dropping out of the glee club. Oh shit, what if she drops out because of me? Shit, shit, shit….*

Just then, the door swung open and Catra sulked inside. She frowned miserably, keeping her eyes down so as to avoid meeting anyone's eyes. Her massive hair was back in curls, held up by her captain's ribbons. Even though she wore her reds every single day, Adora was having a hard time reconciling this version of Catra with the girl she'd kissed at the party.

"Saved you a seat, Kitten," DT called out to her, patting the empty chair beside them. Adora watched out of the corner of her eye as Catra tensed and hesitated. Scorpia gave her a quick look and a small smile, but that was it. Finally, Catra slumped into the empty

seat and crossed her arms. DT slipped an arm around her shoulder and whispered something in her ear that sent a flicker of unease across Catra's face. But in true Catra fashion, she caught herself, and pulled her expression back into a sour scowl.

"I wonder what's going on over there," Bow muttered just loud enough for Adora and Glimmer to hear.

Before either of them could respond, the band room door opened again. This time, Mrs. Moon stepped in, looking grim, with a beaming Entrapta at her side.

"Apologies for my tardiness everyone," Mrs. Moon said, her soft voice somehow managing to render the whole room silent without even trying. "Before we begin today's rehearsal, I have an announcement to make."

Adora shot a curious look at her friends. They glanced back at her with their eyebrows raised.

Mrs. Moon cleared her throat and gestured to Entrapta, who was bouncing from one foot to the other with barely controlled excitement. "Today will be Entrapta's last day with us."

The members of Vocal Rebellion let out a series of surprised noises. Adora's mouth fell open.

"How come?" she said, asking the question that was no doubt on everyone else's minds.

In response, Entrapta let out an elated squeal. "I've been accepted for a super competitive internship at one of the leading robotics companies in the country! I get to spend the next four months working with my idol and learning from some of the smartest minds in the industry! Isn't that so cool?"

"But, what about school?" Glimmer asked, her voice high and tense. "And what about us?"

Neither of these questions seemed to phase Entrapta, who waved her off with a wave and laugh. "Well, *obviously* I'm going to get school credit for the internship. And you guys will be fine! It's not like you need the extra numbers anymore. If you think about it, everything worked out perfectly for all of us!"

Adora looked to Glimmer. She could tell from the tight expression on her face that she was mentally running through the logistics of losing Entrapta this late in the game.

Across the room, Catra laughed. "I don't know about everyone else, but I am *super* excited for you, E."

Again, Entrapta squealed, dancing in place. "It never would have happened if you hadn't encouraged me to apply, Catra!" She paused and fiddled with one of her pigtails, suddenly sheepish. "You're the only one who really seemed to believe in me."

Adora's head snapped to Catra, who was settling back in her seat with a satisfied smirk.

"Aw, I didn't do anything special," Catra said, deftly ignoring the intensity of Adora's stare with a blasé shrug of her shoulder. "I mean, I'd have to be a real jerk not to support a friend." She tipped her head to the side, her eyes catching Adora's for a fraction of a second as her smile widened. "Right?"

Heat raced up Adora's neck.

Was that supposed to be a dig at me? Adora, wrenched her eyes away and focused her gaze squarely on Entrapa. *Who am I kidding? Of course it was.*

But Catra was right — had anyone else in the room ever paid enough attention to Entrapta to even know that she had been interested in some fancy, big-brained internship opportunity, let alone to encourage her to go for it? Adora wasn't stupid — she knew this wasn't all benevolence on Catra's part. But it certainly didn't make the rest of them look like very supportive friends.

“Brava,” DT said, applauding lightly. “You’re doing amazing, sweetie.”

“Yeah, congrats, Entrapta!” Scorpia cheered. “You’re going to have such a great time!”

Entrapta smiled brightly. “I know!”

Finally, the rest of Vocal Rebellion managed to shake off their surprise enough to offer Entrapta their congratulations and bid her farewell before she scurried excitedly out of the room and onto bigger and better things. A low hum of whispered conversation filled the space she left behind.

“Good thing she didn’t have a major solo or anything,” Mermista remarked. “It shouldn’t be too hard to rearrange the routines, right?”

“Ha ha, yeah…” Glimmer laughed nervously as she got to her feet and walked to the front of the room. Adora gave her an apologetic smile. “Speaking of rearranging the routines, we have one more change to make.”

Adora clenched her knees and stared down at the ground, ashamed. Even though both Glimmer and Bow had supported her decision to bow out of the duet, Adora couldn’t help but feel like she was letting her friends down. She had never been the dramatic sort before now, and there was no reason she couldn’t be professional and suck it up for the sake of the team. Maybe this was a mistake...

“Adora has decided to give up her part in the duet,” Glimmer continued, barrelling through the announcement as if that would make it any less shocking. It didn’t work — the room let out a collective gasp as she kept talking. “So we’re going to need to pick someone else to sing with Catra. Are there any—”

“I don’t think so,” Catra said, cutting Glimmer off. Adora’s heart sank into her stomach as she and every other person turned to Catra in surprise. “If Adora’s out, then so am I.”

Stunned, Adora gaped at Catra. She could sense every pair of eyes in the room shift over to catch her reaction, which was nothing more than graceless stammering as she tried to figure out what to say. She quickly stole a glance at Scorpia, and was surprised to find her smiling, if not a bit sadly.

"But…" Adora gave her head a shake. "But why?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Oh, get over yourself. Regionals are only a couple of weeks away. I'm not re-learning how to perform this song with a new partner at the last minute. In case you've forgotten, I also have a national cheerleading competition to get ready for. I don't have time for—" she made a flippant gesture in Adora's direction "—whatever this is all about."

Adora let out an incredulous laugh. For a split-second, she forgot where she was, or that she was surrounded by other people. "Whatever *this* is all about? Are you serious—"

"Let me put it this way," Catra snapped over her. "Either we keep the number as is, or I'm out. And I don't just mean out of the song." She pointed to the door. "I'll pull an Entrapta and dip out of this club altogether."

Glimmer tensed, her hands curling into tight fists at her sides. She turned to Adora helplessly.

"What's it gonna be, princess?" Catra asked. Her words sounded vaguely threatening.

Closing her eyes, Adora sighed. It was only the first day back and she was already failing at her New Year's resolution.

So much for self-care.

"Fine," she relented. "I'll stay."

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NEW: Gleera merch is now available exclusively on Redbubble! Get prints, posters, stickers, notebooks, and more at redbubble.com/people/maggiederrick/shop

Chapter 36

Adora's original plan was to spend her last weekend before regionals getting ahead on her school work. With only one week left before the big competition, she knew there wasn't going to be a lot of time for anything other than classes and show prep in the coming days. So, she woke up early on Saturday and got herself set up with a list of assignments and readings. She was completely determined to finish before the weekend was over and clear her schedule so she could focus all of her attention on Vocal Rebellion.

Unfortunately, by 8:30 a.m., the only thing Adora was focused on was her group chat with Glimmer and Bow. Her textbooks and notes sat in a neat and neglected pile beside her laptop. The school work was going to have to wait: her friends needed her.

There is NO way we're going to be able to get the platform onto the bus, Glimmer texted. *Don't get me wrong, I LOVE the idea. But how are we going to get it there?*

She was talking about a raised platform on wheels that had been one of DT's many ideas to make their set more theatrical. The idea was that the platform would carry the piano Bow would be playing during Adora and Catra's duet, and be maneuvered gently out of the wings by stage hands like a boat drifting on the water. It was a great idea in theory, but the logistics were proving to be far more troublesome than any of them had anticipated.

What if we take it apart and reassemble it when we get there? Adora replied, her thumbs flying across the screen. *I'll bet your mom could borrow a power drill from woodshop for us*

But Glimmer shot that idea down. *Too risky. We won't know what the schedule will look like until we get there. What if there isn't enough time? The last thing we need to be worrying about on the day of the competition is some stupid platform*

Adora felt like Glimmer might have been overreacting a bit, but she bit her tongue. She knew better than to say something like that to Glimmer when she was already in full-blown meltdown mode.

Oh! Bow's message popped up after a moment of digital contemplative silence. *Maybe I could convince a couple of my brothers to help me bring it up a day early. I'll probably end up owing them a favor or two, but it would be worth it*

Where would we store it? Adora asked. *Hide it in the woods and hope no one steals it?*

Bow's response was immediate. *LOL! No, Adora! We can ask the theater if they would be willing to store it for us*

In her desk chair, Adora slapped her palm to her forehead. *Oh. Right. Duh.*

That could work… Glimmer wrote. *I guess I can give them a call when I get home from picking up the costumes. Ugh! My to-do list is out of control!*

Don't worry about it, babe, Bow replied. *I'll call them and get it figured out*

Aw you're the best 😘

What about me? Adora chimed in. Anxiety was starting to bubble inside of her, and sitting in her room doing nothing wasn't helping.

You're awesome too! Glimmer texted.

That's not what I meant! I mean how can I help? I feel so useless 😟

Oh LOL

You're not useless, Adora, Bow assured her. *Getting ahead in your work so you can focus IS helping*

“Oh, c’mon,” Adora muttered under her breath. She knew they were just trying to make her feel better. They knew perfectly well that she hadn’t been doing a very good job of following her New Year’s resolution to put herself first, just like they could tell how the duet was slowly taking over her life. Adora still didn’t understand why Catra insisted on singing with her, and she didn’t believe the excuse that it was too late to change the routine.

But, even though she was still hurt by what happened at the frat party, Adora wasn’t ready to give up on Catra altogether. A part of her—a secret part she wouldn’t even share with Glimmer and Bow—hoped that they’d eventually find their way back to each other, even if it was just as friends. But until that happened, she would have to be content with the many hours they spent practicing and most definitely not talking about what happened.

Besides, even if she didn’t care about Catra (which she definitely still did, for better or worse), Adora *did* care about the team. The last thing she wanted to do was let them down.

Please give me something to do, she texted. *I’m literally begging you*

It took a minute for either for them to respond. Adora rolled her eyes, knowing full well that they were probably having a separate conversation in a different chat about whether caving to her now would count as enabling. While she waited, she opened Instagram to do some mindless scrolling.

A photo flashed across her screen that made her pause. Adora scrolled back up her feed until she found it again. The picture had been posted by Perfuma. In it, she and Scorpia grinned into the camera, their rosy cheeks squished together. They were bundled up outside by the lake just outside of town. The caption underneath read, *Skate date with this cutie!* 🛼💘

Adora sat up straight. Curious, she tapped Perfuma's screen name to pull up her profile and was surprised to find that wasn’t the only picture of she and Scorpia looking cozy. The two of them

seemed to be spending an awful lot of time together, both in and out of school. And of all the photos, Catra wasn't in any of them.

A new text from Glimmer popped up on Adora's screen.

How about you come over tomorrow and help me organize the supplies? My room is a disaster and I'm worried I might have missed something.

It took a beat for Adora to remember what they were talking about.

Yeah, sure. That sounds good to me, she replied.

She hesitated, wondering if her friends had also noticed how close Scoria and Perfuma had become, and whether they'd take her seriously if she brought it up. Adora navigated back to Instagram and typed in Catra's screen name. Her profile popped up, but gave away nothing — she hadn't posted anything new since before the holidays. Frowning, Adora returned to the group chat.

Do you think Scorpia and Perfuma are dating? She asked, pasting a link to the photo with her message.

The ellipses of both Glimmer and Bow's replies popped up on the screen, but before either of them could hit send, there was a knock on Adora's door. Her heart jumped. She didn't think Catra was home, but what if—

"Adora, dearie!" Madame Razz called through the door in her usual cheerily distracted tone. "You have a visitor!"

"A what now?" Adora got to her feet and hurried to her door, pulling it open to find Razz smiling serenely up at her. She glanced up and down the hall for good measure, but they were alone. "Did you say I had a visitor?"

"I certainly did, dearie. He's at the front door. Hurry now, it's rude to keep company waiting."

Mind churning, Adora shuffled down the hall. She couldn't imagine who would be visiting her randomly on a Saturday, and the fact that it was a guy made the whole thing that much stranger. She poked her head around the corner. There in the entryway was a man she'd never seen before, with hair greying around the temples and his cheeks flushed from the cold. He was dressed professionally, with one hand buried in the deep pocket of his well-tailored peacoat while the other navigated his cell phone.

Adora's first thought was that he must be a social worker. It could have been a random check-in — those happened from time to time, when the agency sent someone by the group home unannounced just to make sure everything was okay. But those social workers never asked to speak to any one kid by name. Adora's reached back in her memories, wondering if she'd forgotten about an appointment. Then her thoughts flipped to Catra. What if she was in trouble? Her stomach dropped, and the worry was enough to urge her out of her hiding place.

"Hello?" Adora said cautiously, inching toward the stranger. "You wanted to see me?"

The man lifted his eyes. A warm smile spilled across his face as he dropped his phone into a pocket and reached his now empty hand out toward her. "Hello there! Adora, right?"

"That's right," Adora replied. She accepted his outstretched hand and gave it a shake. "And you are…"

"Joseph DiTillio. I'm the recruiter from Eternia University?" He said it like a question, as if the name was supposed to mean something to her. When all she was able to offer him was a polite smile, he continued. "I apologize for stopping by unannounced. I realize it's not very professional of me, but I was passing through town on my way to a conference, and I thought I'd try my luck and see if I could meet you in person."

Adora hoped she didn't look as confused as she felt.

"No, it's okay," she lied. "Um…" She looked back to Razz, who was hovering curiously in the doorway to the kitchen.

Razz smiled and adjusted her thick-lensed glasses. "Would you like to come in for tea?"

Joseph DiTillio waved politely. "I'd love to but I'm afraid I can't stay long. I left the house a bit later than I originally planned and, at this rate, I'm going to arrive just in time." He turned his full attention back to Adora, his perfectly white smile shining back at her. "But like I said, I couldn't resist stopping by to introduce myself."

A jumble of thoughts wrestled each other for Adora's attention. Part of her assumed he must have been mistaken — wrong house, wrong Adora. But what were the chances of that? She had no idea why a recruiter from Eternia University would be interested in meeting her, but judging by the way he was talking to her, it sounded like she should. She was debating whether she should give up and admit that she didn't know what was going on, when he pulled a card from his inside coat pocket and handed it to her.

"I realize you still have quite a bit of time before you need to decide which school you'd like to attend after graduation, and I'm sure someone as talented as you has had plenty of offers. But I wanted to stress just how excited we are at the prospect of you joining our varsity cheerleading squad."

Adora's mouth fell open just as Joseph DiTillio's phone rang.

"Oh, shoot," he muttered, pulling out his phone to glance at the screen. He sent the call to voicemail. "I'll call him back in a second. Anyway, I'm so sorry to interrupt your Saturday, but like I said I just wanted to introduce myself and give you my contact information in person. I'm sure your coach is encouraging you to consider all your options, and I totally understand. But if you have any questions at all—about the offer, the school, anything—please don't hesitate to get in touch, okay?"

Before Adora could say anything, his phone started ringing again. Joseph DiTillio apologized and offered a small wave.

"Thank you for your hospitality, and sorry again for dropping by unannounced." He pulled the door open and backed out into the day, but not before pointing at Adora and holding her gaze with that great, wide smile of his. "Great to meet you Adora. Like I said — any questions, let me know. See you at nationals!"

And just like that, he was gone. Adora stood at the door and watched the recruiter hurry to his car, phone pressed to his ear. Madame Razz joined her and hummed to herself.

"Now, what was all that about, dearie?"

Adora frowned. "I'm not sure, Razz."

Giving her house mother a quick hug, Adora excused herself and escaped back to her room. Her phone lay abandoned on her desk, the screen ablaze with frenzied speculation between Glimmer and Bow.

OMG! A text from Glimmer read. *I didn't realize they were hanging out outside of glee club. Maybe they ARE together??*

That would explain why they're always sitting next to each other during rehearsal, Bow offered.

Another message from Glimmer appeared in reply. *Ok but what about Catra? Has she said anything to you Adora?*

Yeah, has she brought any of this up to you?

Adora?

Where did she go?

Adora had to give her head a shake before she could reply. She looked down at the business card in her hand. Suddenly the

potential drama of a Catra/Scorpia/Perfuma love triangle felt like the least of her concerns.

Hey. Sorry, I'm here, she wrote. *You guys aren't going to believe what just happened.*

Chapter 37

Catra panted as she finished another lap around the gym. Her brow was beaded with sweat and her lungs burned. With a grunt of exertion, she picked up the pace and started the circuit all over again.

Despite being overwhelmingly exhausted, Catra had barely slept the night before. She tossed in bed until quarter after five, at which point she gave up. After dressing in the dark, she slipped out into the darkness and bundled through the cold to the school. She used her captain's key to get inside—the one Coach Weaver had somehow managed to bully Principal Hope into giving the squad to accommodate those early morning and late evening practices—and made a beeline for the gym. There was still plenty of time before the Valkyries were scheduled to arrive for their morning practice, but Catra didn't care. She needed to move, needed to do something to dissipate the constant humming that had been rattling her bones since winter break.

So, she ran.

Running was one of those things Catra secretly loved, something that came as naturally to her as breathing. When she sprinted, the world fell away until all that remained was the hammering of her heart and the rhythm of her breath. Had it not been for Adora and the Valkyries, she probably would have wound up on the cross-country team. It certainly would have been easier.

But it was too late for that now. Catra gave her head a shake and pumped her arms harder, pushing herself faster across the lacquered hardwood court. She was here now, at the top of her game; there was no room for what-ifs and could-have-beens.

Catra knew she had to stay focused on what was coming. She couldn't afford to let where she'd been or the mistakes she'd made distract her, especially not now. Not if she had any hope of getting through the next couple of weeks.

She had long since lost track of her laps when she heard the gym door slam. Glancing over her shoulder, Catra saw DT slink into the room with that ever-present air of superiority they wore so effortlessly. Catra slowed to a trot and snatched up a towel she'd left on the bleachers, mopping her face with it so she wouldn't have to look at DT as they made their way over to her.

DT was the sort of person whose only concern was themself: it wasn't an insult, just a fact they happen to be very proud of. Their unabashed honesty and indifference to other people's feelings was something Catra had always privately admired about them. To her, DT was unshakable. No one could hurt someone like that. Catra used to watch them the way a zoologist studies a rare species, trying to figure out their secrets from a respectful distance. She wanted to know what it took to be unshakable too.

Of course, that was before she'd seen the photo. That stupid, awful photo that was still burned into her mind like a cattle brand; DT's gleeful grin in the corner of the frame, Scorpia pinning her to the wall in the background. Every time Catra thought of that photo—and worse, every time she thought of the fact that Adora had seen it—she wanted to throw up.

The day after the frat party, in the aftermath of Glimmer forwarding her the photo, Catra had marched straight to DT's house. Her hangover was no match for her rage, and it propelled her through the cold like a woman on a warpath.

When DT answered the door, they had smiled down at her like they'd been expecting her. They didn't invite her inside.

"Ooh la la, if it isn't everyone's favourite makeout bandit," they'd purred, looking extremely satisfied with themself. "To what do I owe the pleasure?"

"What were you thinking?" Catra snarled through chattering teeth, her voice breaking embarrassingly. "Why did you send that picture to Adora?"

DT let out a dramatic sigh and slumped against the doorframe. “Because I’m tired, Kitten.”

“Tired of what?”

“Tired of waiting for you to make a move.” The mirth in DT’s expression fell away. “You’ve gotten a little too comfortable with our little side hustle, darling. In case you’ve forgotten, you’re supposed to be blowing this thing up, not sleeping with the enemy.”

The intensity of Catra’s blush thawed her frozen cheeks in an instant.

“Besides,” DT continued with a shrug, “would you rather get the nudge from me or Coach Weaver?”

Catra’s breath caught in her throat like a frozen ghost. “Coach Weaver put you up to this?”

“Of course! I’m not a total monster.” DT paused and considered what they’d said for a moment. “Well, maybe sometimes. But I digress.”

In that moment, Catra had been certain she was falling in slow motion. A rushing sound filled her ears as she gaped up at DT, stunned and voiceless. Of course Coach Weaver had been behind this. Of course she was still manipulating the strings, pulling Catra and Adora further apart as if they were nothing more than a pair of puppets.

“Oh, it’s not all bad, sweetie,” DT cooed. “After all, from where I was standing, it sure looked like you were having a good time last night.” They reached out and tapped their index finger against the tip of Catra’s nose, startling her out of her horrified reverie. “Anyhoo, it is fucking freezing out here, so I really best be going. See you in the New Year, Kitten!”

They didn’t even wait for Catra to respond — they simply slid back inside and left Catra standing in the frigid twilight alone.

Things had been strained between them ever since. Even now, as she felt DT hovering a few paces behind her, waiting to be acknowledged, her skin crawled. Catra didn't trust them further than she could throw them. But that didn't matter now: there was a job to be done.

"Where's Scorpia?" Catra asked without turning around. She threw her towel down and snatched up her water bottle to keep her hands busy.

"Well good morning to you too, sunshine," DT huffed. "And I don't know where she is, I don't keep—"

The door slammed again. Catra finally forced herself to look back and found Scorpia trudging across the gym floor with a sheepish wave. For all the ways Catra's already tenuous friendship with DT had been shaken, it was nothing compared to the tension that existed between her and Scorpia now. Just looking at Scorpia made Catra want to drop dead of humiliation, and that in turn only made her angrier. It didn't matter that Scorpia had been right about everything — as far as Catra was concerned, she was just as untrustworthy as DT.

The sooner they could finish the plan, the sooner she could untether herself from both of them.

"Morning team," Scorpia said, forcing a smile. "How was your weekend?"

"Not now, Scorpia," Catra snapped, cutting a glance at the clock on the scoreboard. "We only have a few minutes before the rest of the team starts showing up."

Scorpia shrank back. "Right, gotcha."

"So what's the plan here, Kitten?" DT asked, twisting the end of their ponytail with disinterest. "Regionals are this Saturday — when are we pulling the pin on this grenade?"

"Friday," Catra answered. "The later the better."

Scorpia pursed her lips and fidgeted with the strap of her bag. “Isn’t that cutting it a little close?”

“Exactly.” Catra folded her arms. “It’ll leave them scrambling at the last minute — they won’t even have the time to come up with a back-up plan.”

A shark-like smile slid across DT’s face. “Oooh, devious. I love it.”

Catra forced herself to look Scorpia in the eyes. “Are you going to be able to handle this?”

Scorpia’s cheeks flushed, but she held Catra’s gaze. “Yeah, of course.”

She didn’t look very sure of herself, but Catra chose not to point it out.

“Good,” she said instead. She whirled around, unable to look at either of them without her stomach twisting. “We can’t afford to screw this up. Five more days and it’ll all be over.”

As she marched toward the locker room to change into her reds, Catra heard DT laugh.

“Hardly! That’s when the real drama begins.”

Throat dry, Catra swallowed hard and kept walking.

She didn’t want DT to know just how right they were. After all, sabotaging Vocal Rebellion was only half of the plan. Coach Weaver still expected her to somehow bring Adora back to the Valkyries once the glee club went up in flames.

Catra didn’t like her chances of pulling that part off, but she didn’t want to let anyone know that either.

*

Catra was running on fumes. Classes, Valkyries practice, and glee rehearsal made for busy enough days without the sleepless nights that followed. To manage her fatigue, Catra took to sneaking away for power naps in bathroom stalls and the library's stacks between periods. It wasn't much, but it was the best she could do.

There was only one free period in her schedule, tucked between lunch and world history on Wednesday afternoons. As soon as the lunch hour—and the frantic glee club rehearsal that filled it—ended, Catra broke away from the band room and headed straight for the library. She elbowed past other students as she rounded the towering shelves and let out a sigh of relief when she found her favorite spot was free.

A worn seat with cracked vinyl cushions sat nestled in an oft-ignored corner of the stacks. It was tucked back in a way that made it a popular spot for class skippers and handsy couples alike. But today, the chair and the privacy it offered would serve as a makeshift cot on which Catra hoped to catch a few blessed moments of sleep.

Throwing herself down on the chair with a huff, Catra pulled up her knees and curled into a tight ball in the bowl of the seat. Normally she would have put in her earbuds and put on a chill playlist to help drown out any distractions, but just the thought of fishing them out of her bag felt like a colossal task. Instead, she put her phone on vibrate, set an alarm, and burrowed under her varsity jacket for warmth.

Just as she was starting to drift off, the sound of whispered conversation pulled Catra back from the edge of sleep.

Son of a bitch, she thought bitterly. *This what I get for being too lazy to get my earbuds—*

She froze.

Catra recognized the voices.

“Okay, what did you find?”

Adora.

Holding her breath, Catra sat perfectly still. She peered out over the collar of her jacket and spotted Adora’s blonde ponytail waving in the space between a row of books and the shelf above them. Glimmer and Bow huddled in close to her so they could keep their voices low.

“Remember at that cheer event, when we had to keep an eye on Coach Weaver?” Glimmer asked.

“Yeah…” Adora sounded wary. There was a sound of shuffling paper. “What’s this?”

“It turns out that person who was interviewing her was a writer for a website called *Cheer Nation*,” Bow said. “This is the article they wrote.”

There were a couple beats of silence as Adora read. Breathless with curiosity, Catra wondered if she’d be able to retrieve her phone from her jacket pocket without attracting their attention.

“What?” Adora yelped, only to be immediately shushed by the others. “This doesn’t make any sense. Why is she acting like I’m still a Valkyrie? I quit the squad weeks before this interview even happened.”

“Maybe she was embarrassed?” Glimmer offered. “It probably wouldn't be great for her reputation if word got out that her star cheerleader quit the squad.”

Adora hummed skeptically.

“That could be it,” Bow agreed. “But whatever the reason, I’m willing to bet it has something to do with that recruiter.”

Catra was seconds away from blowing her cover. Part of her wanted to storm around the corner and demand answers. What

recruiter were they talking about? And why would that be connected to Coach Weaver trying to save face on some stupid cheerleading blog?

"Well, whatever it is, it's going to have to wait until after regionals," Adora said. Catra could hear her folding the pages and shoving them into her bag. "Thanks for looking into this for me, Bow."

"Of course! That's what friends do."

Fuck right off, Catra thought, biting her bottom lip to stop herself from saying the words out loud.

Not that it would have mattered — the trio was already retreating back through the stacks. Catra waited until she was sure they were gone before pulling out her phone. With her heart pounding, she typed in a search and quickly found the article from *Cheer Nation*.

She scanned the article — a feature piece about the reigning champ Valkyries, complete with a photo of the squad mid-performance. Adora and Catra were suspended in time, side by side in matching poses and smiles. Looking at the image, remembering how happy she was in that moment, made Catra's heart clench.

Then, a few paragraphs down the screen, Catra found what she was looking for.

"I saw Adora's potential from day one, and she has yet to disappoint," says Weaver, Stevenson High School's long-time cheer coach. "That she is the future of the Valkyries Cheer Force was never in question. She is a natural born leader, and in her short time as captain she has taken an already strong squad and turned them into something exceptional."

If anyone would recognize an exceptional performance, it's her. With six consecutive national championships to her credit, Weaver has a long history of recognizing and cultivating talent.

"There is no doubt in my mind that Adora is destined for greatness," she insists. "Mark my words."

The blood in Catra's veins turned to ice.

"What is she talking about?" she hissed under her breath, her hands trembling. "*I'm* the one who's made the squad exceptional. *I'm* the captain."

I'm the one who stayed.

Shame and humiliation filled Catra completely. All this time she had chalked Coach Weaver's obsession with getting Adora back on the squad to a bruised ego. It was a power trip — a power play designed to put a dissenting minion back in their place.

But now, Catra realized it was so much more than that. Even after everything, Adora was still Coach Weaver's golden girl, her pride and joy. And Catra? She was just keeping Adora's throne warm.

How could I have been so stupid? She thought, the threat of tears stinging behind her eyes. Would it ever matter how hard she worked? Would Coach Weaver ever see her as the loyal and competent leader she was trying so hard to be?

Her hand lifted absently to the captain's ribbons on her head. Would these even still be hers in a couple of weeks from now?

Not if Adora was back on the squad.

As that realization crystalized in her mind, Catra's shame turned to blind, furious determination. Coach Weaver may have wanted Adora back on the squad, but Catra was going to prove that the squad didn't need her.

That she didn't need her.

She opened the group chat she shared with Scorpia and DT.

Change of plans, she sent.

Scorpia's reply came first: *??*

PLEASE tell me this is about what I hope it's about, DT said.

Forget Friday, Catra wrote. *We're doing this today.*

DT's response was an immediate *YES DIVA!!*

Scorpia's floating ellipses came and went a few times. Then a separate text from her popped up on Catra's screen, one without DT in it.

Are you sure you want to do this? Like, REALLY sure? Because it's not too late you know...

I'm tired of waiting, Scorpia, Catra typed. She took a deep breath, and forced a shaky smile as finished her message.

It's time to blow this shit up.

Chapter 38

The news hit the Vocal Rebellion group chat like a bomb going off.

First came replies expressing confusion and disbelief. When those went unanswered, the mood turned hostile and frantic.

Glimmer called an emergency meeting for the end of the day. When classes ended, the glee club convened in the band room, minus three members.

Adora couldn't pry her eyes away from the message that started it all. She sat in the middle of the band room, curled over her phone as the buzz of anxious conversation pressed in around her, and read those lines over and over again.

Sorry team. Coach Weaver wants our full attention on the Valkyries.
You're going to have to head to regionals without us. Good luck 🤞 - C

That was it. No follow up from Scorpia or DT, no acknowledgement of the flurry of replies sent from everyone else in the chat. Just a silence that felt as cold as the betrayal itself.

On the surface, the message seemed innocuous enough. The national cheer competition was only a couple weeks after regionals, and the pressure from Coach Weaver would be intense.

But Adora wasn't stupid. She had suspected something was amiss from the moment Catra, Scorpia, and DT demanded to audition for Vocal Rebellion.

I can't believe I fell for it, she thought. Her whole body tingled with adrenaline as she clutched her phone so tightly that her palms hurt. *I can't believe I thought Catra actually cared*.

But of course she had. This was Catra—*her* Catra. And for all the ways Catra could be vindictive and impulsive, Adora never truly

believed that she would stoop this low. She hadn't thought Catra would ever hurt her. Not like this.

I can't believe I ever thought she might love me back.

"Okay, so what do we do now?" Netossa was shouting over the multiple conversations happening around the room. Adora looked up, blinking as if she couldn't remember how she got there in the first place. Netossa was on her feet. A few seats away, Perfuma sat between Seahawk and Mermista, who comforted her gently as she sobbed loudly into her hands.

"We're going to have to rework the entire set," Mermista said, scowling. "Like, maybe Adora can just sing her song as a solo or something, but Scorpia was the only lead for the final number."

Beside her, Perfuma let out a heartbroken wail. Adora's breath hitched, although less for Perfuma than for herself. There was no way she'd be able to sing that song without Catra. She shot an anxious glance at Bow and Glimmer, who gazed sympathetically back at her.

Bow stood up and addressed his crestfallen teammates. "Everyone just needs to stop and take a breath. We're going to figure this out. There's still time."

"Besides, we have a bigger problem on our hands," Glimmer added. "With the Valkyries *and* Entrapta gone—"

Adora groaned. "We don't have enough people on the team to qualify for the competition."

It was as if the air had been sucked from the room. After a beat of silence, the glee club broke into another round of frenzied panic. Now, Adora *really* felt like a fool. She thought of Entrapta, excited and beaming at the front of the room when she announced that she'd be leaving for her coveted internship for the rest of the semester. She remembered the way she'd thanked Catra specifically, for encouraging her to apply in the first place.

This, Adora realized, had been Catra's plan all along. Catra had been playing the long game, and if Adora and the others didn't act fast, she was going to win.

Adora looked around the room at her devastated friends and teammates. They'd worked too hard and accomplished too much for this to be the way it all came crashing down. Climbing up on her chair, Adora stuck her fingers in her mouth and let out a piercing whistle that shocked the whole room into silence.

"Listen," she said once she had everyone's attention. "I know things don't look great right now, but we can get through this! Technically, we're only short by one person. We just need to find someone to join us for the competition. They don't even have to do anything — they can just sway in the background and mouth the lyrics if that's all we have time to teach them. As long as they're from the school and on stage, we'll be fine."

Glimmer gave an enthusiastic nod, her bright hair bouncing. "Adora's right. We can start canvassing right now. Message your friends. I'll get some flyers printed tonight and we can put them up around the school first thing tomorrow morning."

The mood in the room lightened immediately. As her friends started firing off texts to everyone in their contacts and on social media, Adora jumped down from her chair with a sigh of relief. Bow met her with a high five.

"Coach Weaver may have been lying in that article about you still being on the squad," he said, "but she was right about one thing: you really are a great leader."

Adora shook her head. "I didn't do anything special. We all just need to focus on the task at hand — there's no reason we can't make this work."

Glimmer stepped in closer and laid a hand on Adora's shoulder. "What about you, Adora? Are you okay? I mean, Catra—"

“She made her choice,” Adora said, cutting her off. “Now she can live with it.”

Bow and Glimmer looked at one another, and Adora could tell they weren’t buying her indifference. She smiled and took them both by the hand.

“Right now, the only thing that matters is making sure we get to compete on Saturday.” She gave their hands a reassuring squeeze. “So, let’s go find our newest Rebel. I mean, it’s just one person — how hard can it be?”

*

Adora didn’t mean to issue a challenge to the universe when she asked that question. After all, finding one extra student who’d be willing to sway in the background on stage for a Saturday afternoon really shouldn’t have been hard. But by lunch on Friday, Vocal Rebellion was no closer to recruiting a stand-in for regionals, and the team was getting desperate.

“I jinxed it,” Adora lamented as she tried to hand a flyer to yet another unwilling student in the halls. “I should have just kept my mouth shut.”

She, Glimmer, and Bow were standing outside of the cafeteria, trying to entice someone to join their cause. So far nothing the team tried had worked. None of the friends and classmates everyone had texted at the emergency meeting on Wednesday had come through, and the wide-spread postering campaign hadn’t drummed up any leads either. With less than 24 hours before the competition, they were very quickly running out of options.

“You didn’t jinx anything, Adora,” Glimmer grumbled. “But there’s definitely something weird going on here.”

As if on cue, Adora watched the freshman Bow was pitching to suddenly catch sight of something down the hall, tense, and then

hurry away without so much as a word. Curious, Adora tried to find whatever had spooked the kid, but all she found was Kyle.

Their eyes met. Kyle froze and flashed her a nervous smile.

"Hey, Kyle," Adora called to him. "Can you come here for a sec?"

His eyes darted back and forth. "Uh, sorry Adora. I need to, um—"

His hesitation was all the time Adora needed to stride the few paces between them. She stepped into his path, and planted her hands on her hips. Kyle let out a startled yelp.

"Why did that freshman take off when he saw you?" she asked, cutting straight to the point.

He swallowed hard. "He, uh… owes me money?"

"C'mon, Kyle."

By now, both Glimmer and Bow had joined them. Kyle shrank back, his eyes searching for an exit. But he knew he was surrounded, and because he was, well, Kyle, he caved.

"We're supposed to be making sure no one helps the glee club," he said, the words tumbling out of him in a rapid jumble.

Adora blinked. "Who's 'we'?"

"The Valkyries. Catra said—"

Catra.

Whatever Kyle said next, Adora didn't hear it. The world around her blurred, everything else falling away until all that was left was the feeling of complete and utter heartbreak.

"Don't worry about him, Adora," Bow said, his gentle voice pulling her back to the moment. She blinked and realized Kyle was already gone. "I'm sure there's someone who—"

“There isn’t,” she whispered. “You don’t understand how much power the Valkyries have in this school. If they’re telling people not to help us, then we’re screwed. End of story.”

“Well, we have to try,” Glimmer replied, her expression tight and determined. “We’re going to keep handing out flyers and asking everyone we see. Someone is going to say yes, Adora — I just know it.”

Adora didn’t have the heart to tell her that she didn’t believe it herself. She’d spent two years enjoying the benefits of the Valkyries’ influence, and she knew just how much they could get away with. But Glimmer did make a good point.

“You’re right,” she said, forcing a smile. “And if it doesn’t work out, I want to at least be able to say we did everything we could.”

Bow pulled them both into a tight group hug. “That’s the spirit. Now come on, we still have 15 minutes left before lunch is over.”

Unfortunately, optimism and hard work were no match for the Valkyries. By the time classes ended that day, the members of Vocal Rebellion were back in the band room, dejected and out of time.

Spinnerella was the first to break the silence that hung heavy over the group.

“So… is that it then? There’s nothing else we can do?”

Glimmer let out a sigh. “Unless one of you can pretend to be your own twin for a day, I think we’re out of options.”

Just then, a knock came from the band room door. Adora sat up straight. She looked at Glimmer, who shrugged.

The knock sounded again, light and polite.

Adora got up and crossed the floor. She hesitated a moment, her hand resting on the doorknob. Then she turned it, and pulled the

door open wide.

Scorpia stood on the other side. She was dressed in normal clothes, not her uniform, and she looked nervous.

“Uh, hey there,” she said, fidgeting in place. “Can I come in? I need to talk to you guys.”

Chapter 39

While the rest of the Valkyries ran through their pre-practice stretches, Catra checked her phone for the dozenth time.

"Well?" Coach Weaver snapped, making her jump. "Where is she?"

Good question, Catra thought. She hadn't heard from Scorpia all afternoon, and now that she hadn't shown up for practice, Catra was getting nervous.

"She can't make it," she lied. "One of her moms is sick and her family needs her home."

Coach Weaver clicked her tongue with irritation. "Since when do we make exceptions for family emergencies? The bylaws clearly state a Valkyrie may only miss practice in cases of coma or—"

"Deadly bleeds. Yes, I know. Don't worry about it — I'll deal with her."

"You had better," Coach Weaver said through gritted teeth. "As force captain, a Valkyrie's performance—or lack thereof—reflects directly on your leadership. If Scorpia's absence tonight impacts the squad's readiness for nationals—"

Catra couldn't help but groan. "It'll be my fault. *I know*." She crossed her arms and held her coach's fiery glare. "Like I said, I'll handle it. Besides, we have more important things to talk about. I've been trying to get a meeting with you since we pulled the plug on glee club on Wednesday — we need to talk."

Coach Weaver regarded her for a long moment — one that stretched on into an uncomfortable silence. Catra stood her ground, until finally the coach relented with a disgruntled huff.

"Fine. Meet me in my office after practice." She waved a hand toward the rest of the squad who were finished stretching and

now sat around gossiping.

Breathing a sigh of relief, Catra turned away from her coach and stormed onto the floor to start practice. Ever since essentially breaking up with Vocal Rebellion via text message, she'd been trying to get a few minutes of Coach Weaver's time to tell her about her change of plans.

Over the past couple of days, any time she hadn't spent threatening the student body about helping the glee club by penalty of social sabotage, Catra had used to rehearse what she wanted to say to Coach Weaver. Again and again, she went over every carefully crafted word about how she was done doing her dirty work, and how she had no intention of bringing Adora back to the Valkyries. She was going to tell Coach Weaver that it was time to start trusting her. They didn't need Adora, and Catra was hell bent on proving it.

Catra took a deep, steadying breath. She was *so* ready to take control of her destiny.

Knowing that her meeting with Coach Weaver was waiting on the other side of practice seemed to make it drag on more than usual. By the time she finally dismissed the squad, Catra was all but vibrating with anticipation. She shouldered her backpack and caught Coach Weaver's eye, motioning impatiently toward the door. Coach Waver, who was busy reprimanding Kyle over who-knows-what, gave her an equally brusque flick of her hand.

"I will meet you in a moment, Catra." Her words were clipped and curt.

"You'd better not blow me off," Catra grumbled beneath her breath as she pushed out through the gym doors and into the empty halls of Stevenson High.

Aside from a handful of other groups and clubs, there were very few people left in the school on a Friday evening. Catra's footsteps, brisk and light, echoed off the lockers and polished

floors. On late practice nights like this, she and Adora used to try to freak each other out. They'd make up ghost stories about the school—about a cranky old teacher who died marking papers at her desk, a janitor who suffered a heart attack the evening spring break started and whose body wasn't found until classes resumed, a student who was crushed on stage by a fallen prop during a school production of *The Wizard of Oz*. It had been funny and stupid then, but now, as she walked the empty halls without Adora at her side, Catra couldn't help the shiver of fear that raced up her spine.

She picked up her pace, and ran the rest of the way to Coach Weaver's office.

Not that she felt much safer there. Catra dropped into one of the chairs that faced Coach Weaver's desk and looked around. The walls were covered with framed photos and news clippings, and shelves adorned with ribbons and medals that were stacked high with trophies. Coach Weaver's office was a shrine to her own success and the years she'd spent molding championship cheer squads. It was the type of space that most people probably found impressive; a one-woman hall of fame. But to Catra, this room held only bad memories — memories of being yelled at, berated, reprimanded. Memories of being made to feel useless and unworthy, no matter how hard she tried.

But that would all change tonight. From this point on, Catra would be the one calling the shots. Just the thought of it—of the freedom that would come with finally being the one in charge—made her feel stronger. She couldn't wait for Coach Weaver to show up so she could finally, *finally* tell her exactly how she felt.

Unfortunately, Coach Weaver seemed to be taking her sweet time. Catra tapped her foot and stole another glance at her phone. She didn't know what was more annoying: the fact that Scorpia still hadn't answered any of her messages or the fact that she'd already been waiting for fifteen minutes. With every minute that passed, the gauge of Catra's confidence sank lower. To ward off

the creeping anxiety, she got to her feet and wandered around the room.

Coach Weaver had a strict no-touching policy when it came to the stuff in her office. As such, Murphy's Law dictated that the moment Catra started picking up trophies and getting her fingerprints on the perfectly polished medals, Coach Weaver would show up. So, that's exactly what Catra did. She worked her way around the room, scanning the articles and names of Valkyries who came before her. She plucked awards off the shelves and put them back at skewed angles or in the wrong places altogether.

Eventually she made it to the desk, which she eyed critically. It was much nicer than the desks of other faculty members. Even her chair looked expensive. Shrugging, Catra pulled it out from where it was neatly tucked under the desk and sank into it.

"Swanky," she said, admiring the sleek tan leather of the arm rest. She toed the floor and spun the chair around in place. On one of her rotations, Catra's elbow bumped the desk, earning a sharp hiss of pain from her and waking up the computer monitor in the process. Catra rubbed her arm and turned to face the glowing screen. It was open to Coach Weaver's email.

For a split second, Catra turned away and started to rise. But curbing her curiosity had never been one of her strengths. Slowly, she sat back down. She lifted her eyes and trained them on the open office door for a moment, then another.

The hall was still perfectly quiet. She was still alone.

And so, she read.

There was already an email open — something Coach Weaver must have been reading right before practice that evening. Catra read the name of the sender, some guy named Joseph DiTillio. She didn't know him, and was about to click on a message from

principal Hope instead when her eyes caught a glimpse of Adora's name in the body of the email.

The message itself was brief, a reply to a previous email sent by Coach Weaver.

If you insist. I look forward to speaking with both you and Adora at the national championship.

Below sat the sender's email signature

Joseph DiTillio

Enrollment recruiter — Eternia University

Catra's eyes widened. She thought back to that day in the library, and recalled Adora whispering to Glimmer and Bow about a recruiter. This must have been the same one, it had to be.

Scrolling down, Catra found that the email thread consisted of one long conversation that stretched back for months. Eventually, she came to an email sent right after the cheer competition Adora had subbed in for when Lonnie rolled her ankle.

It was wonderful to see the Valkyries compete this past weekend, read DiTillio's message*. It was inspiring to see Adora perform during the freestyle number. It certainly solidified her as a worthy candidate for our scholarship program.*

I was hoping to speak with you before you left, but I must have just missed you. Do you happen to know if Adora has any questions for our admissions team here at Eternia University? I realize she still has plenty of time to make her decision, but I'm sure she'd like to have all of the pertinent information at her disposal when evaluating her post secondary options.

Coach Weaver's reply was brief.

As I'm sure you can imagine, Adora is focused on her captain's duties right now. I'll be sure to arrange for a call between the two

of you when the time comes. In the meantime, have you had any luck securing the funding for the coaching position?

"What the fuck?" Catra whispered to herself. She scrolled further back, searching for more context. From what she could tell, DiTillio first reached out to Coach Weaver the year before, during sophomore year. The details were laid out in black and white: Eternia University was impressed with Adora, so much so that they were willing to offer her a full scholarship.

Catra sat back, confused. Why was this the first time she was hearing about this? She and Adora knew everything about each other. Or, at least they had before this disaster of a year. Still, this offer was extended back when the two of them were still joined at the hip, and Adora had never once mentioned a scholarship to Eternia University.

As a pair of orphaned foster kids, Catra and Adora had spent more than a few evenings perched on the garage of their group home, lamenting the grim prognosis that was their futures. Once the system was done with them, they'd be on their own, and they knew it. They would talk about college without voicing a fact they both knew but didn't want to admit: it was a pipe dream, a long shot for both of them. As much as they liked to daydream about what they'd major in or where they'd study, they both knew that student loans would only get them so far.

Catra shook her head. No, if there had been a scholarship offer, Adora would have said something. She was sure of it.

So, she kept reading. She scanned the messages quickly, trying to take in as much information as she could before Coach Weaver eventually showed up, trying to find the answer. Trying to find the truth.

And when she found it, the truth took her breath away.

After DiTillio initially reached out with Eternia's scholarship offer, Coach Weaver spent the next few weeks stringing him along and

playing coy. She'd send long, glowing reviews about Adora's work ethic and potential, then wait days before acknowledging DiTillio's enthusiastic replies. It was obvious to Catra just how badly Eternia wanted Adora; it seemed like they were willing to do just about anything to win her over.

Apparently it was obvious to Coach Weaver, too.

Mr. DiTillio, I'm sure you can appreciate that Adora is under enormous pressure right now. She's in exceptionally high demand, as Eternia is not the only university of repute to notice that she would make an excellent addition to their cheer programs. She has a lot to consider, and I am trying to give her the space to do so.

Adora is a precocious girl. She has enormous talent, but it takes the right person to coax that potential out of her. Under the right direction, I have no doubt she will flourish and make herself an invaluable asset to whichever squad is fortunate enough to have her. I just hope that, whatever squad that may be, they have the right coaching staff to get the best out of her.

Eternia is an exceptional academic institution, but I understand your eagerness to recruit a talent such as Adora: your performance in the world of competitive cheerleading has, shall we say, left a lot to be desired. Perhaps there is an opportunity for us to help one another…

Catra pressed a hand to her mouth as the pieces finally clicked into place: Coach Weaver was leveraging a university's interest in Adora to get a prestigious job for herself.

All this time, her obsession with bringing Adora back to the Valkyries hadn't been a power trip: it was a power grab.

White hot fury raced through Catra's veins.

She thought of those evenings on the garage roof. She thought about herself and about Adora: two kids full of promise, but with nothing in their corner to help them reach their dreams.

But here was a school who wanted Adora for everything that she was—for everything she had always been—and Coach Weaver was keeping it from her.

"That fucking bitch," Catra snarled between clenched teeth. She looked around — she had to do something. Her eyes landed on the high tech printer beside the desk. Briefly, she considered hitting print on the entire email thread. But it was too risky. What if—

The sound of voices left Catra frozen in place.

Raised, arguing voices echoed through the hall. One was unmistakably Adora's.

The other was Coach Weaver's.

Heart racing, Catra grabbed the mouse and hit the forward button. She typed in her own email address and hit send. The phone in her jacket pocket vibrated — message received.

The voices were getting closer.

Catra glanced around and found the wardrobe that stood in the corner. Without thinking, she jumped to her feet and flung the doors open. It was full of uniform samples and a few boxes, but there was just enough room for her.

She backed into the wardrobe, crouching low and pulling the doors closed just as Coach Weaver and Adora blew into the office.

Coach Weaver slammed the door shut.

Catra was trapped.

Chapter 40

Adora was furious.

She wasn't angry at Scorpia — if anything, she was proud of her. It couldn't have been easy for her to decide that enough was enough, let alone for her to actually do something about it. After everything Scorpia told her and the rest of Vocal Rebellion, Adora couldn't even find it in herself to stay mad about what happened at the frat party.

It was the rest of Scorpia had confessed to that left Adora so enraged that she literally shook. She stormed out of the band room and made her way to the gym. According to Scorpia, the Valkyries would just be finishing their practice. If she hurried, she might just catch them. So, Adora ran. The pounding of her heart was so loud that it drowned out the sound of her shoes slapping against the linoleum flooring. A duffle bag hung over her shoulder, and she had to clutch it to stop it from swinging. Her grip was so tight that her fingers ached.

It wasn't until she rounded the corner and the gym doors came into view that a small voice in the back of Adora's mind wondered if this was a good idea. But the moment Coach Weaver stepped through the doors, that tiny bit of nagging doubt evaporated. Fresh fury surged through Adora like floodwaters through a burst dam.

Coach Weaver was talking to Kyle about something. Adora was still too far away to hear what was being said, but she could tell by Kyle's shrinking posture that it wasn't kind. Lonnie and Rogelio loitered close by, looking equally as cowed, even though they didn't seem to be the targets of the lecture.

That woman couldn't be nice to someone if her life depended on it, Adora thought as she closed the distance between them. Even though her former squadmates had barely spoken to her since she left the Valkyries, Adora still felt bad for them. It had taken getting

away from Coach Weaver's influence for Adora to realize that being part of something great didn't have to come at the expense of her own sense of self-worth. And, it had taken learning the truth of what Coach Weaver was capable of for Adora to see how terrible the woman actually was.

"Hey!" Adora shouted once she was close enough. "Leave them alone."

She could tell by the viper-like way Coach Weaver whirled around that she was prepared to lash out at whoever dared talk to her like that. But when her eyes landed on Adora, Coach Weaver faltered. It only took her a split second to regain her composure, and it gave Adora chills to see how easily she morphed back into her usual cool and calculating self. Behind her, the Valkyries stood gaping back at Adora with a mix of awe and fear.

"Adora, what a pleasant surprise," Coach Weaver said, clasping her hands in front of her.

"Actually, I imagine you were probably expecting me," Adora countered. "Maybe not quite this soon, but you knew I'd come to you eventually, didn't you?"

Coach Weaver cocked her head and regarded Adora with a perplexed stare. "Is everything alright, Adora? You're coming across as rather paranoid."

"You *know* everything's not alright."

"Ah, I see." Coach Weaver gave a few condescending clicks of her tongue. "Is this about the glee club's competition tomorrow? I'm terribly sorry, Adora, but you know how important these final weeks leading up to nationals are. The squad needs to focus on their training."

Adora bristled. It was taking everything she had not to start screaming right there.

"I know what you did," Adora replied through gritted teeth.

"Well, of course you do." Coach Weaver's tone was patronizing, speaking to Adora as if she were a child throwing a tantrum. "It wasn't a secret that I told the Valkyries that they wouldn't be permitted to continue with your little club. They were discovering the hard way just how challenging it is to manage both commitments, and their performance was slipping. You of all people should—"

"Stop it!" Adora snapped. Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio gasped in unison, wide-eyed with disbelief. "You know what I mean."

"I'm afraid I—"

"Scorpia told us everything." Adora dropped that bit of information and let it hang for a moment. "And I do mean *everything*."

At last, Coach Weaver's bravado slipped. She straightened up and lifted her chin so she could narrow her glare down at Adora with a quiet, simmering ferocity. Adora held that glare with one of her own. There was a time when it would have been ashamed to be on the receiving end of a look like that from Coach Weaver. That look meant failure and disappointment — it meant penalty and guilt. But Adora knew better now: she didn't need Coach Weaver's praise anymore, and she wasn't afraid to let her know it.

After a few tense moments, Coach Weaver looked back to the Valkyries. "You may go now."

The trio hesitated, but under that withering glare, they relented. They took off for the exit, glancing back at Adora over their shoulders as they escaped into the night.

"Shall we discuss this in my office?" Coach Weaver offered, her words tight and dangerous.

"Fine," Adora said. She whirled around on her heel and stomped away, not bothering to wait for Coach Weaver to join her.

The walk to her office was tense. Neither of them so much as looked at one another, let alone spoke. Adora could feel the rage

emanating off of her former coach, burning into her from sheer proximity alone. But she didn't care — she was already stoking her own wildfire of rage, and she was getting ready to dowse it with kerosine.

Adora blew into the office and Coach Weaver slammed the door shut behind them. Folding her arms, Adora watched Coach Weaver stalk around her desk and lower herself into her chair.

"Have a seat," Coach Weaver said, motioning to one of the chairs across from her.

"I'll stand," Adora replied.

Coach Weaver sat back and pressed her fingertips together. She stared Adora down for a few moments without speaking. Not that long ago, the awkward silence would have eaten away at Adora until it eventually left her fumbling over herself to fill it. But those days were gone now. Instead, she stared back with a fiery gaze and refused to relent until finally, Coach Weaver cleared her throat.

"What is it that you want from me, Adora?" she asked. The earlier faux bemusement was gone from her voice. She was all business now.

"I want to know why you did it," Adora replied, her hands clenched into fists at her sides. "I want to know why you couldn't just let me have this."

"I don't know what Scorpia told you, but if it has you this upset, it can't possibly be true."

Adora scowled. Even now, Coach Weaver was still trying to manipulate the situation. "She told me how you made her, Catra, and DT join Vocal Rebellion just so they could sabotage us. She said that's the real reason they dropped out — so we wouldn't have enough people to qualify for regionals tomorrow. I knew something weird was going on when they wanted to audition! You

wouldn't let me be on both teams, but you were willing to make an exception for them?"

Coach Weaver shook her head and sighed. "That's quite the convoluted conspiracy theory, Adora. What reason would I have to sabotage the glee club? In case you've forgotten, I'm the coach of a national championship cheer squad."

"That's what I want to know." Adora stared hard at her, as if the answers she was looking for could be found somewhere on the coach's face or clothes.

There was a long stretch of silence. Coach Weaver regarded Adora with an expression that was impossible to read. Adora braced herself — whatever was going through the woman's mind couldn't have been good.

"I'm not the naive old woman you students think I am," Coach Weaver said at last, leaning her elbows atop her desk. "I notice things. And just like you no doubt have, I too have noticed Scorpia's, shall we say, *affinity* for Catra. Have you considered that perhaps Scorpia is lying to you to protect Catra from what she's done? That maybe this whole, unfortunate situation is just the result of a spiteful little girl who didn't want to accept that you moved on?"

Adora fumed.

"Stop it," she hissed.

"I wouldn't put it past Catra, and neither would you." Coach Weaver rose to her feet, holding Adora's gaze as she moved. "After all, if you trusted her, you wouldn't have suspected anything was amiss in the first place. Why wouldn't you have been anything but grateful to have your best friend by your side again?"

"I said *stop!*" Adora cried, loud enough that her voice reverberated off the office walls. For a moment, the only sound to follow was her heavy breathing as she tried to calm herself down. Her arms and legs trembled with rage.

“I know it hurts,” Coach Weaver said softly. She rounded the desk and placed a hand on Adora’s shoulder, ignoring the way she tensed under it. “I’m sure losing the glee club would be painful enough without Catra’s betrayal being the reason for it. But, perhaps I can help. Come back to the Valkyries, Adora. I will reinstate your captaincy, and you can go back to leading a real winning team.”

Slowly, Adora turned her head. She lifted her eyes up to meet Coach Weaver’s. “Wait. If I came back, you’d make me captain again?”

“Of course. The captaincy has always been yours.”

Adora could tell by her hopeful tone that Coach Weaver thought she was getting through to her — that she thought she was winning. But Adora was done doubting her instincts when it came to Coach Weaver and her motivations, and right now, every one of her instincts was on high alert.

“Why?” she asked, pulling herself out of Coach Weaver’s grip. “You have Catra. She’s been a great captain.”

“She isn’t *you*, Adora.” Coach Weaver reached out to her, but Adora backed away again.

“You’re right, she’s not. She stayed, and she put in the work. You always lectured us about being loyal to the squad, but now you’re telling me you’d make *me* captain—after I *left*—over someone who stuck around? That doesn’t make any sense!”

Coach Weaver’s long fingers curled into fists. She tossed back her dark hair, fighting to compose herself.

And that’s how Adora knew she had her exactly where she wanted her.

“This wouldn’t happen to have anything to do with the recruiter from Eternia University who showed up at my door the other day, would it?”

For the first time since they entered the office, Coach Weaver's expression faltered.

"What?"

"You know, the guy from the school that wants to offer me a cheer scholarship?" A bitter smirk curled across Adora's mouth to see Coach Weaver so caught off guard. "The offer you conveniently never thought to mention to me?"

A beat passed between them. Adora could all but see the wheels turning in the old woman's mind.

"I was protecting you, Adora," Coach Weaver said. "A scholarship of this prestige comes with a lot of pressure — I didn't want that pressure to distract you."

Adora let out a bark of laughter. "Give me a break! If this was about me, you could have said something when I quit the squad. You didn't have to sabotage Vocal Rebellion or—" she had to pause and blink back the threat of tears "—you didn't have to turn my best friend against me! If you actually cared about me, you would have told me!"

Again, Coach Weaver reached out and caught Adora by the arm. "Enough, Adora. I—"

"Yeah, enough is right," Adora snapped, cutting her off. She wrenched her arm from Coach Weaver's grip. "Whatever you're up to, I don't want any part of it. I'm done. Now, if you'll excuse me, I have a competition to get ready for." Pushing past Coach Weaver, Adora pulled the office door open, pausing to toss the duffle bag onto the floor between them. "That's Scorpia's stuff. She wanted me to tell you that she's quitting the Valkyries."

Before Coach Weaver could reply, Adora took off running.

"Wait!" Coach Weaver bellowed desperately.

Adora glanced back to find her hurrying down the hall after her. But it didn’t matter — within a few seconds, Adora was out the front doors to where Bow’s car idled in wait. In the back seat, Perfuma shoved the door open so Adora could squeeze in beside her and Scorpia.

They sped out of the parking lot and away from Stevenson High without saying a word.

Chapter 41

Adora was staring out the bus window when she felt Bow ease into the seat beside her.

"I thought you said you were going to sleep on the bus," he whispered.

"I know," she groaned, scrubbing a hand across her tired eyes. "I tried, but…" She trailed off.

Bow nodded. "Still thinking about yesterday?"

Adora huffed a halfhearted laugh. "Yup."

"I get it," Bow said. The other members of Vocal Rebellion were dozing in their seats, so he kept his voice soft and low. "It was a lot to process. How are you feeling? Aside from tired, obviously."

Tired was an understatement. Every moment of the previous evening had been a whirlwind. After scrambling into Bow's waiting car, Adora had relayed what happened in Coach Weaver's office. Bow and Glimmer, in their usual seats up front, and Scorpia and Perfuma in the back, were all righteously furious on Adora's behalf. It had helped ebb some of the sting left by her former mentor's betrayal.

But there had been no time to obsess over the details — Scorpia's defection from the Valkyries meant Vocal Rebellion would be going to regionals after all, and that left the team with a lot to do and not a lot of time to do it in.

Thankfully, Mrs. Moon hadn't cancelled the bus rental that was now carrying the team to the state capital. But all other preparations had ground to a halt earlier in the week when every member of the glee club turned their efforts to the doomed last minute recruitment campaign. Now that the show was back on, the team was left scrambling to pull together the finishing touches

on their costumes, pack their bags, and do whatever last minute practicing they could muster.

It had been a long and busy night, which had left Adora without a moment to think about everything that had happened until she was in bed without anything else to distract her. She was tucked in on one side of Glimmer's massive bed. In the dark, she heard Glimmer's soft and shallow breathing from the other side, as well as Bow's deep snores from where he was laid out on Glimmer's futon. The two of them had probably passed out as soon as their heads hit the pillow.

But Adora was wide awake. Exhausted, yes, but how was she supposed to sleep after what had happened in Coach Weaver's office? How could she possibly be expected to quiet her mind with all the things Scorpia said running through it?

She was still awake when Glimmer's alarm went off that morning. And, even though she'd promised her friends to make up for her lack of sleep during the drive to the city, Adora's mind was still churning.

The sun hadn't even begun its ascent, and the world outside the bus was dark save for the occasional flash of headlights from oncoming traffic on the highway. Adora's weary reflection blinked back at her from the window. Bow watched over her shoulder, waiting politely for her to answer him.

Adora sighed.

"I don't know," she said. "Kind of numb, I guess. And stupid. I knew Coach Weaver was up to something, I should have—"

Bow took her hand and gave it a squeeze. "Don't do that to yourself, Adora. Sure, you knew Coach Weaver was shady, but there's no way you could have known this was what she was up to. It's genuinely messed up, especially for someone in her position." He caught her bleary eyes with his and held her stare. "None of this is your fault."

"I know, I know," she replied, even though she didn't believe it herself. "It's just… a lot."

"You know that Glimmer and I are going to help you through this, no matter what that ends up looking like," Bow said, wrapping her in a one-armed hug. "But there's nothing any of us can do about it right now. Don't let her take this day from you, Adora. You deserve to get up on that stage, sing your heart out, and have a great time."

Adora smiled weakly. She knew he was right, but just thinking about being on stage brought up a whole new set of things for her to worry about.

"Thanks, Bow," she said, pushing those thoughts into the back of her mind. "You're a really great friend."

"So are you," he replied. "Now, please try to get some sleep, okay? It's going to be a long day. A fun one! But also long."

"You got it, boss."

Shaking his head, Bow smiled and slid back into the row ahead, where Glimmer was sleeping soundly. Adora dropped her head back against the seat and sighed. She glanced across the aisle to where Scorpia and Perfuma sat, bundled under Scorpia's coat and dozing peacefully in one another's arms.

After Scorpia came clean about how Coach Weaver had enlisted her, Catra, and DT to sabotage the glee club, Perfuma had been quick to forgive her. It was an act of grace that brought Scorpia to tears, and one Adora couldn't fault her for. After all, despite all the jealousy she'd felt toward Scorpia over the years, she couldn't deny that Scorpia's heart was always in the right place. Disobeying Coach Weaver—not to mention walking away from Catra—couldn't have been easy, and Adora wasn't sure if she'd ever really be able to thank her for it enough.

As she watched Scorpia sleep, Adora's thoughts wandered back to what else she'd said. Just before Adora stormed from the band

room in search of Coach Weaver, Scorpia had pulled her aside.

"I'm assuming the answer is no, but I figured I'd ask — did Catra ever talk to you after the whole… y'know, frat party, uh, thing?"

Adora's face flushed as she remembered Catra's many attempts to text, then call, the day after the party.

"We haven't really talked since that night," she deflected, shifting uncomfortably. "Not about anything other than regionals, anyway."

"I figured," Scorpia sighed. "Well, just so you know, nothing happened that night. I mean, yeah, we kissed or whatever, but we didn't—" she paused to clear her throat "—we didn't sleep together."

The relief Adora felt in that moment was so intense, she worried she might break out into a fit of inappropriate laughter.

"Okay," she said, doing her best to feign indifference.

"And we were never together," Scorpia continued. "Like, dating and stuff."

"Right…" Adora regarded her curiously. "Why are you telling me all this, Scorpia?"

Fidgeting, Scorpia took a beat before answering.

"When this is all over, I think you should reach out to her." Her brows knit together over dark, earnest eyes. "You two have a lot to talk about."

Adora hadn't been able to stop thinking about those words. They haunted her, even now as she sat alone on the quiet bus en route to the city. She pulled out her phone and opened her messaging app. Before going to bed and failing to sleep the night before, she had texted Catra.

Can we talk?

The message glowed back at Adora, unanswered now just as it had been every time she'd checked it throughout the night. She wasn't really surprised — she hadn't actually expected Catra to answer her. But what did strike her as odd was the tiny word beneath the message that read, 'delivered'.

Delivered. Not read, and then ignored, which is what Catra normally did.

Adora turned off the screen and pressed her phone to her chest. Catra was probably mad right now — livid, even. Given the circumstances, Adora felt like she finally understood. She could only hope that, when she finally got the chance to talk to Catra again, she'd at least be willing to listen. Because Scorpia was right: they did have a lot to talk about.

Somewhere amid those idle thoughts, Adora finally dozed off. She slept deeply and without dreaming, waking only when the bus jostled its way into a parking lot.

"Rise and shine!" Glimmer sang. Adora peered up to find her hanging over the seat back and grinning widely. "It's show time!"

*

Organized chaos: that was the only way Adora could think of to describe what followed. The regional show choir competition was happening in a massive performing arts theater — the kind of place where people put on productions of Shakespeare and ballet companies performed holiday renditions of The Nutcracker. Crowds of people milled around, talking and laughing excitedly as they signed in and surveyed the program of the day's event. It all reminded Adora of the atmosphere at cheer competitions, and that familiarity helped shift her mind into performance mode. Bow was right: she could go back to worrying about Catra and Coach Weaver when the day was done, for now she had a routine to focus on.

Mrs. Moon checked them in and brought over a stack of schedules.

"There are quite a few more teams competing today than there were at sectionals," she explained as she passed a sheet to each member of Vocal Rebellion. Adora scanned the list of teams while she listened. "You will be the sixth team to perform."

"That gives us plenty of time," Glimmer said, a triumphant smile on her lips. "Let's go!"

They followed the signs that directed all performers to the backstage area. Once there, Glimmer broke away from the group to deliver their stage directions. Someone from the event staff directed the team to where they could store their gear and get ready, informing them that all performers would be spending the duration of the event backstage rather than being able to watch parts of the show from the audience.

"It helps limit disruptions," the chipper stage hand explained.

While the others got started with their preparations, Adora crept away from the group. She wandered the cavernous backstage area, peeking at the other teams who were already there. Adora realized quickly that Vocal Rebellion would be the smallest team performing today, and she hoped that wouldn't hurt them. Every so often, she inadvertently caught another performer's eye, and they would nod before going back to whatever they'd been working on. Unlike the competition at sectionals, everyone here was too focused on themselves to worry about flinging snide comments about other teams. Adora recognized that focus from cheer — every single one of these teams was here to win.

Before heading back to the others, Adora paused at the heavy velvet curtain that separated the stage from the audience. She ran her finger along the fabric and contemplated stealing a peek out, but she could tell by the way a pair of stage hands were eyeing her warily that it was probably a bad idea. On the other side, voices chattered, echoing through what was still a relatively empty

auditorium. Doors didn't open to the public for another hour. Adora wondered who would be in the audience this time.

"There you are!" Glimmer's unexpected appearance at her side made Adora jump. "Everything okay?"

"Yeah, I'm fine," Adora replied, hiking her bag higher on her shoulder. "I just wanted to get the lay of the land."

Glimmer put her hands on her hips and nodded. "Looks like we might have our work cut out for us." She glanced around at the other teams, then back at Adora. "Are you nervous?"

Adora swallowed. She knew what Glimmer was getting at. Because they'd wasted so much time trying to find an extra member for the team, Vocal Rebellion didn't have a chance to rework any of the numbers. Scorpia's return meant that two out of the three songs wouldn't have to change — they would just be down by a couple of voices in the ensemble. But there wasn't enough time to prepare anyone to sub in for Catra, which meant Adora would be tackling the ballad solo.

When she took too long to answer, Glimmer stepped forward and took Adora by the shoulders. "It's gonna be okay. No one's going to care if you mess up some of the lyrics. The fact that we're even here in the first place is awesome enough! Just go out there and have fun, okay?"

Smiling, Adora nodded. She wasn't sure Glimmer really meant the part about no one caring, but it was the thought that counted.

Together, she and Glimmer headed back to the others, where a pair of stage hands were wheeling over a stately baby grand piano on a draped, mobile platform — it was on loan from the theater, and much nicer than the one they'd wanted to haul up on their own. From that point on, it was all hands on deck.

The team got busy changing and working on their hair and makeup. Despite their part in trying to sabotage Vocal Rebellion, at least DT's ideas as artistic director had been genuine,

(Apparently the theater was sacred — the one place safe from their mischief.) which meant the blacklight makeup was still a go. Adora caked her face in stage-worthy foundation, before painting her eyelids and lips. Next she pulled her hair into a half-ponytail, then coiled the length of it into a tightly wound bun at the back of her head.

The team's costumes were simple but effective: blindingly sparkling tops—t-shirts, tanks, crops, whatever—under crisp black blazers that each person had painted designs of broken hearts and tears onto with UV paint. The look was finished with black slacks and shoes.

Adora however, had one extra piece in her wardrobe: a floor-length skirt of sparkling black tulle, which she would don for her ballad. While the others buzzed around her, she made her way over to the costume rack and opened the garment bag that Glimmer had packed the skirt in. The thing was massive, and when worn over her pants with her glittering corset, the whole outfit actually looked quite elegant. She fluffed the skirt's layers and smiled, remembering Glimmer's ingenuity — the absurd amount of tulle was designed to hide the fact that skirt was actually just a wrap, which would make it easier for Adora to shed before the final number like some magical girl transformation.

By the time the competition officially started, the members of Vocal Rebellion were dressed to the nines, shimmering and fabulous. Mrs. Moon took a few group photos, before their hair and makeup had a chance to be sweated off and danced out of place. For the first couple of numbers, the team walked through their choreography, refreshing their memories and smoothing out any bumps along the way. But it didn't take long for the action on stage to lure them from their last minute rehearsal.

A couple of TV screens were set up backstage, which displayed a livestream of the performances. Almost every team that wasn't performing was clustered around those screens, watching their competition with eagle-eyed focus. Adora stared at one of the TVs between the heads of others. The massive ensembles of the other

teams filled the stage with electricity. They moved with the kind of precision that reminded Adora of the Valkyries. These kids were pros.

"What do you think?" Bow asked quietly from where he and Glimmer stood at Adora's side.

"They're good," Adora replied. "Like, really good."

"Well, we'll just have to be better," Glimmer said. "C'mon, let's get the team together for a huddle — we're almost up!"

She walked away, and Bow made to follow. But when he noticed Adora hanging back, he paused.

"Bow, what am I going to do?" Adora asked, panic creeping into her voice.

He cocked his head curiously. "About what?"

"About the ballad!" she hissed back, pulling away from the people still crowded around the TV. "I'm going to the screw up the lyrics up and I know Glimmer said it doesn't matter but it does matter because these other teams are so good and—"

"Woah! Take a breath," Bow said. "You need to stop being so hard on yourself. Glimmer wouldn't have said that if she didn't mean it. And you don't know that you're going to screw anything up."

"Yes, I do," Adora insisted. She started pacing. "I can't do this without Catra."

Bow sighed. "That's not true. She wasn't around during sectionals, and you crushed that solo!"

Adora met his gaze and drew in a shaky breath. "That's the thing: she *was* around. She was in the audience that day — I saw her when we entered up the aisles." Groaning, Adora had to remind herself not to drag her hands through her carefully coiffed hair. "I

know it doesn't make any sense, but something about her being there… it helped. And now..."

"Oh."

"Yeah."

A moment stretched between them. Adora swallowed one deep breath after another in an effort to quell her rising anxiety.

"Maybe she's out there today." Bow said. Adora blinked at him, incredulous.

"C'mon, Bow. You and I both know that she's not."

He shook his head. "No, we don't. We have no idea who's in the audience right now."

A flicker of hope played in Adora's chest. "Do you really think…" She couldn't bring herself to finish that thought.

"It doesn't matter what I think. The important thing is that she could be out there, and you don't know that she isn't." Bow leaned in and winked. "So, sing as if she's here, Adora."

It was such a silly thing, but for some reason, it worked. The tight knot of worry in Adora's stomach unfurled. The breath she'd been holding escaped her parted lips like a bird through an open cage door. She laughed.

"Have I ever told you what an amazing friend you are?"

Bow draped an arm over her shoulder. "Once or twice."

The rest of Vocal Rebellion was already huddled and waiting by the time Adora and Bow got back to them. They smiled and waved for them to join in. The glitter of their tops blinked and sparkled. In the dim backstage light, Adora thought her friends, all clustered together, looked a lot like a star-filled night sky.

“Get in here!” Glimmer said, shifting to make room.

Adora and Bow did as they were told. They added their hands to the pile made by the others in the middle of the circle. A current of excitement ran through the group. Glimmer cleared her throat.

“Okay, Rebels, it’s almost time,” she said, grinning wide. “No matter what happens out there, I want you all to know that I am so proud to be here with you. You’re amazing performers and even better friends, and I wouldn’t want to do this with anyone else.”

A chorus of awes filled the circle. Even Mermista looked emotional as she dabbed discreetly at the corners of her eyes with the knuckles of her free hand.

Glimmer looked around, meeting everyone’s gaze as she did so. “So, what do you say? Are you ready to put on a show?”

“You bet, Captain,” Adora replied, followed by a murmur of agreement from others.

A stagehand flitted up to the edge of the circle. “Vocal Rebellion, you’re up!”

“This is it!” Glimmer squealed. The team quivered with excitement. “Team cheer on three: one, two, three—”

“FOR THE REBELLION!”


Tw: @maggiederrick
IG: @maggie.derrick

Chapter 42

The audience was silent and the stage dark. Adora stood in position, scanning the crowd as she waited for the music to start. Even with the stage lights down, there were too many faces lining the rows that receded back into the darkened auditorium. If Catra was out there, Adora couldn't tell.

But she could imagine.

The first few repeating trills of Vocal Rebellion's first song filled the auditorium. Adora took a breath and mentally reminded herself to focus as Seahawk stepped into the single spotlight that illuminated centerstage and started to sing.

"*I am bound to you with a tie that we cannot break, with a night that we can't replace. I'm lost but found with you, in a bed that we'll never make. It's a feeling we always chase…*"

Now the lights came up, revealing the ensemble. The rest of the team vocalized through the pre-chorus and danced their gracefully, carefully structured choreography. Adora swooped and slid, moving around her teammates as Seahawk crooned sorrowfully. A thrill of excitement raced through her as the chorus approached.

When it was time, the entire mood of the performance changed. All of Vocal Rebellion belted the chorus as their movements became more exciting and dynamic. Their countless hours of practice meant they moved with the perfect synchronicity of a K-pop music video.

"*Oh, in another place...*"

The lighting flicked to blue light, illuminating the UV makeup and paint the team wore, and earning a wave of *oohs* and *ahhs* from the audience.

As the chorus came to an end, Mermista marched to centerstage and launched into her verse. She was as flawless and powerful on stage as she was in life, and the audience let out a quick cheer of excitement. If it was chemistry that Glimmer was after, Mermista and Seahawk brought it in spades. The fact that it was just a song never seemed to make a difference for Seahawk — he looked like his heart was breaking with every word he sang. Anyone watching the performance could tell that he was head over heels in love with Mermista. And though she tried to play it cool, Mermista's longing for him was no less obvious. It was a perfect duet.

When the song entered the bridge, Adora and Bow fell back behind the others and slipped backstage. They had less than a minute to get ready for the ballad. Bow grabbed the tulle skirt while Adora unpinned her hair and let it cascade down her shoulders. Then she shrugged out of her blazer and traded it for the skirt. Adora gave herself a quick once-over in the mirror. For a split-second, she was thrown by how well the look came together. Her glittering gown and golden curls were so glamorous: she looked like a star.

Adora took a deep breath and gave her reflection a quick nod before lifting the skirt's hem and dashing back to the platform. Bow offered his hand, and she let him pull her up beside him.

"How are you feeling?" he whispered into her ear.

"Good," she replied, meeting his eyes in the dim backstage light. "You?"

Bow grinned. "Awesome."

Out on stage, the song was coming to an end. Bow settled onto the bench while Adora took her place in the bend of the piano's tail. She fluffed her skirt until she was certain she was as ready as she'd ever be, and then she closed her eyes.

In her mind, Adora mapped the auditorium. She imagined a seat next to the aisle in one of the last rows. In it, Catra was sitting

low, her wild hair smothered beneath an old ball cap, just like the day she sneaked in to watch Vocal Rebellion perform at sectionals. It was all in Adora's imagination, but just pretending Catra was out there steadied her nerves. Adora exhaled: she was ready.

On the other side of the curtain, the audience was cheering. A stagehand caught Adora's eyes and flashed her a thumbs-up. It was time.

"You got this Adora," Bow whispered as the curtains began to part. And then he started to play.

A hushed, awed whisper drifted from the audience as the platform was directed out onto the stage. The lights caught the glitter on Adora's costume and cast winking starlight in every direction. The rest of Vocal Rebellion stood in an evenly-spaced arc at the back of the stage, seamlessly filling in the space through which the platform had drifted. They bowed their heads as if in reverent prayer, swaying in tandem like a choir as Bow played.

Okay, Adora, she thought as she focused her eyes on the spot where the Catra of her imagination was sitting. *Sing as if she's out there*.

In the original plan, Catra was supposed to start the song, carrying Rihanna's part of the duet with her powerful voice. Adora didn't have Catra's power, but she was going to give it everything she had anyway.

She took a breath, held her head high, and she sang.

"*All along it was a fever. A cold sweat, hot headed believer…*"

The words came to her as naturally as breathing. Her pitch was perfect, her voice like a bell. And all the while, she sang right to Catra.

"*I threw my hands in the air, said, 'Show me something'—*" Adora made a split-second decision, and changed the pronoun in the next line "*—She said, 'If you dare, come a little closer'…*"

Now, as she came to the pre-chorus, Adora stepped lightly from the platform and swept to the front of the stage.

"*Round and around and around and around we go…*" Adora's heart clenched — these lyrics were too honest. Suddenly, she felt exposed, like everything she'd been feeling was spilling out of her through the song. On one hand, that emotion and passion was bringing the song to life. On the other hand, it was getting harder for her to ignore the swell of tears stinging at her eyes. "*Ooh, now tell me now, tell me now, tell me now you know…*"

Something in Adora's voice gave as she sang that last line. A delicate tremble—the unevenness that foreshadowed tears—warbled the last few syllables. She could feel her friends watching her as she pressed her fingers to her painted lips.

No, she thought desperately as the first hot tears raced down her flushed cheeks. *Keep it together, Adora. You can't fall apart now*.

"*Not really sure how to feel about it. Something in the way you move…*"

Adora whirled around, her long skirt swirling as she moved.

There, stepping out of the shadows of stage left, was Catra.

She was dressed in her costume — a glittering tanktop and her old ratty black jeans under a handsome blazer. Her hair was loose and untamed, just the way Adora liked it best, and she was still adjusting her headset's mic. As she made her way across the stage, she held Adora's teary gaze with an intense stare of her own.

"*Makes me feel like I can't live without you, it takes me all the way…*" Catra reached out. "*I want you to stay…*"

The world fell away. All Adora could see was Catra standing before there, reaching out for her. If she hesitated at all, it wasn't long. With an elated sob, Adora grabbed Catra's hand and held on as if her life depended on it.

A wave of steadiness and certainty washed over Adora. She felt invincible — like there was nothing she couldn't do. Catra gave her hand a squeeze and the lyrics crystalized in Adora's mind.

"*It's not much of a life you're living*," she sang. She watched Catra shrink back with shame, as if the words had been written specifically with her in mind. "*It's not just something you take, it's given…*"

Just like they'd practiced, Adora lifted her hand and let Catra twirl her gently. "*Round and around and around and around we go."* The ensemble joined in now, harmonizing as Adora sang. "*Ooh, now tell me now, tell me now, tell me now you know…*"

She and Catra drifted closer into one another's orbit. Softly, Catra combed her fingertips through the curls on Adora's shoulder. Adora shivered as she sang, stronger now.

"*Not really sure how to feel about it, something in the way you move.*" Palm to palm, the pair circled one another in perfectly synced steps. Adora held Catra's gaze, watching to make sure she was hearing what she said. "*Makes me feel like I can't live without you, it takes me all the way. And I want you to stay.*"

Adora nodded. Please, this time, maybe Catra would hear her. Maybe this time she would stay.

"*Oooh, the reason I hold on…*" Catra twirled Adora again while they sang, the ensemble's voices soaring around them. Adora harmonized, though her breath hitched when Catra pressed against her back and trailed her fingers from Adora's wrist up her arm. It was all part of their choreography, but it felt completely different now. "*Oooh, 'cause I need this hole gone*."

As they moved through the bridge, the dance called for the two of them to move apart — to sing the next lines as if they were speaking their own private soliloquies. Instead, Adora turned back around so she could keep singing to Catra.

"*Well, funny you're the broken one, but I'm the only one who needed saving...*"

Catra took hold of Adora's hand again, clutching it desperately to her heart as she sang. With her free hand, Adora softly stroked the hair from Catra's glistening eyes.

"*'Cause when you never see the light, it's hard to know which one of us is caving…*"

The final chorus had arrived, and it was Catra's time to shine. Adora stepped back to harmonize with the ensemble, who were moving forward to join the pair. As she watched Catra take centerstage, Adora felt everything at once: heartbreak and anger played with love and pride. She wasn't ready to forgive Catra—not completely—but she was so glad she was here now.

"*Not really sure how to feel about it, something in the way you move,*" Catra looked back and reached for Adora again. Her gaze was emploring — this wasn't part of the choreography either. Adora let her pull her back in. "*Makes me feel like I can't live without you, it takes me all the way. I want you to stay…*"

Catra closed her eyes, voice soaring as she hit the song's power note. The audience let out a thrilled cheer and Adora couldn't help but beam.

"*Stay.*" Catra opened her eyes again. She spun Adora away, only to whirl her back in closer. "*I want you to stay…*"

They were face to face now, so tantalizingly close. Adora was so mesmerized, watching Catra hit that final high note that carried out the song, that she caught her off guard when Catra moved her hands and leaned her back into a low, romantic dip.

The crowd roared to life with applause and cheers, but all Adora could see was Catra's face above hers, staring back with the same expression of surprise and uncertainty she wore herself. Adora opened her mouth to speak, but the words wouldn't come. Meanwhile, Catra's cheeks flush crimson.

“Guys!” Glimmer hissed from behind them as she and the others rushed to change the stage over for their final number. “C’mon!”

Catra’s eyes grew wide. “Shit!”

In one swift motion, she pulled Adora back upright. Her hands slid around Adora’s waist, and for a split second Adora was certain Catra was pulling her in for a kiss.

Instead, she felt Catra pull at the snap on the back of the tulle skirt, and Adora instantly remembered what they were supposed to be doing. She twirled in place and Catra pulled the skirt free with a flourish, earning another *ooh* from the crowd. When Catra turned to toss the skirt to Spinnerella who was rushing by, Adora peeled back the shoulders of Catra’s blazer and passed it off to Netossa as she hurried in the opposite direction. They only had a moment to dash off to their next positions, sharing a brief glance as they went.

Now, every member of Vocal Rebellion had shed their blazers, leaving the stage a sea of glitter. Scorpia stepped up to a mic that was set at center stage during the flurry of activity, and the music swelled to life.

“*Seeing the sun go down again, staying in my bed for too long now…*”

Scorpia’s smooth voice was perfect for the song. While she serenaded the audience, the rest of Vocal Rebellion paired up. Where their choreography at the beginning of their routine had seen them dancing apart, the final number brought them together — a theatrically happy ending to their theme of yearning, despite the song’s ardent lyrics.

“*Heard you were out last night. My friends say you're looking well, you seem happy…*”

Once again, Adora found herself in Catra’s arms. Only this time, she was leading their dance.

"*But you're a liar if you say that you're fine. Bet you wonder if I think of you now...*"

Adora pulled Catra in, closer than necessary. They were face to face once more, and in that moment, it was just like old times again. Adora grinned, and Catra did too.

"*Done my best to stay away, but I think I'm going crazy…*"

The song was upbeat and full of energy. Adora moved through her parts with ease, harmonizing with her teammates and moving in perfect step with Catra as her dance partner. As the song neared its end, Seahawk and Mermista joined Scorpia for a reprise of their song from earlier, which they had seamlessly blended in to make a slight mash-up. As expected, the audience loved it — their reaction so loud that it almost drowned out the song itself.

All the while, Adora and Catra barely took their eyes off of one another. It was as if they were the only people left in the world, singing and dancing like nothing else mattered. As she sang through the final chorus, Adora sang it to Catra, just like she'd always planned.

"*But in my head you say, say you still want it. That you're done with being lonely now,*" she sang. "*It's you and I...*" Adora and Catra moved as one. "*You and I.*"

The song ended with everyone planted firmly in place, hand in hand as they vocalized in unison. The cheers from the audience swallowed every other sound in the room, including Adora's joyful laughter as she turned to Catra with a smile.

But Catra wasn't smiling or laughing — she was crying. While the rest of the team took their bows, Catra pulled her hand from Adora's and darted into the wings. But Adora was so used to Catra running that she wasn't surprised, and she didn't think twice about following her either.

"Catra!" she shouted as she darted around other show choirs and stagehands. "Catra, stop!"

As Catra lunged for a door that led to the concourse, Adora grabbed for her. She caught Catra's wrist in her hand and jerked her back to face her.

"You can't just swoop in here like this and then run away without talking to me," Adora said, snatching Catra's other wrist as she tried to wriggle away. "Not after everything that's happened. Please, Catra—"

"Adora, listen to me!" Catra cried, raising her voice over Adora's. "You have to let me go."

"No," Adora said, shaking her head. "Not until you and I talk."

Catra pulled back again, this time freeing one of her hands from Adora's grip. Trembling, she pulled something from her back pocket — a square of folded paper. Adora eyed it warily.

"Take this," Catra said, pressing the paper into Adora's hand. It was thicker than Adora expected — a bundle made up of multiple pages.

Confused, Adora reluctantly let go of Catra and started to unfold the paper. "What is—"

Catra laid her hands over hers and held them tight. She leaned in close.

"I'm sorry," she said, her voice breaking. Adora blinked back at her earnest and tearful face in shock. "For everything."

Before Adora could respond, Catra whirled around and pushed through the door. This time, Adora let her go, watching Catra's wild mane trail behind her as the door swung shut between them.

"Adora?" Bow's voice brought her back to the moment. Adora blinked and looked back to find her friends hurrying over to her, looking baffled. "Where's Catra?"

At the sound of Catra's name, Adora's eyes dropped to the paper still clutched in her hands. Carefully, she unfolded the square to reveal its contents: it was a stack of emails. Pages of them. She squinted at the to and from lines, then gasped when she saw the names.

To: *Joseph DiTillio, Eternia University*

From: *Coach S. Weaver, Stevenson High School athletics department*

Adora's stomach dropped.

"Holy shit."

Chapter 43

Chapter Notes

> [[CW: This chapter contains a scene of physical abuse against a minor]]

Catra stood at the front entrance of Stevenson High School and took a breath.

After escaping the theatre, she'd spent the rest of the weekend avoiding everybody. Sunday was whiled away loitering in the mall and public library, and riding the train aimlessly around town until it was late enough to sneak back into the group home unseen. In the darkest hours of the night, she'd waited until every light in the house was out, then scaled her way up onto the garage roof. She had just enough time for a quick nap before waking up obscenely early just so she could sneak back out again without running into anyone. Catra wasn't even sure that Adora came home after the competition—for all she knew, Adora spent the rest of the weekend at Glimmer's house—but it was better to be safe than sorry.

She wasn't ready to talk to anybody, which is why she hadn't turned her phone back on since boarding the bus to the city early Saturday morning. At first, she found herself craving the distraction of doom scrolling or dumb videos — anything to save her from having to spend quality time with her own mind. But after a while, Catra came to appreciate the silence.

But for all the things a Valkyrie could get away with, skipping practice this close to nationals was not one of them. So when Monday came, Catra knew she had no choice but to change into her reds and finally face everything she'd done with her ponytailed head held high.

The halls were pretty much empty, save for a few coffee cup-clutching faculty members who waved and nodded as Catra

hurried by. Her mind was preoccupied, running through various scenarios of what would happen once she reached the gym. She wondered if Coach Weaver knew that she'd performed at regionals, or if she was too pissed off over losing their strongest base when Scorpia quit the team. Not that Catra was supposed to know about that. Catra had been lucky enough to sneak out of the uniform closet without getting caught—making her frantic escape when Coach Weaver stormed out of the office after Adora—and she was determined to make sure no one ever found out she'd been in the first place.

Outside the gym doors, Catra took a moment to steel herself before pushing inside. The fluorescents were already buzzing, but the only person inside was DT.

"Morning, Kitten," they sang from where they lounged on the bleachers. "Tell me everything — spare no details!"

"Tell you everything about what?" Catra asked, feigning calm.

DT raised an eyebrow. "About how your little betrayal went over with the glee club?"

"First of all, it was *our* little betrayal," Catra snapped, tossing her bag and jacket onto the bench beside them. "And how should I know how it went over?"

"You live with Adora. I assumed the two of you would have had an epic bitch brawl over the weekend."

A thrill raced through Catra's veins. If DT, the greatest gossip Stevenson High had ever known, didn't know what she'd done, then she was in the clear. She let her shoulders relax for the first time since she woke up and let out a snort of laughter. "Nah, I made myself scarce."

"Probably for the best, I suppose," DT drawled. They examined their fingernails with a scowl, no doubt bitter at having been deprived of some fresh drama.

Over the next few minutes, the rest of the Valkyries drifted in. Kyle wondered aloud about Scorpia's mysterious absence, so Catra redirected everyone's attention by leading a group stretch. They were just about to start their first drill when the gym doors slammed open.

Catra looked over her shoulder — Coach Weaver was storming across the hardwood floor.

Here we go, she thought, swallowing hard. She and the rest of the squad jumped into formation and waited.

Coach Weaver stopped a handful of paces away. She was panting like an enraged bull, and she clutched her clipboard in a white-knuckled grip. She pointed one of her long fingers right at Catra.

"You," she snarled. "Come here, now."

Catra felt every set of eyes in the room turn to her in unison. She lifted her chin and strode forward, keeping her expression as impassive as possible. For a few, breathless moments, neither of them said a word. Then, Coach Weaver closed the gap between them, looming over Catra menacingly.

"What did you do?" she shouted, her voice booming throughout the gymnasium. Under normal circumstances, Catra would have replied with something witty and cutting. But there was something dark and unfamiliar about Coach Weaver's rage this time — unlike her usual tantrums, this outburst carried a hint of peril.

"I don't know what you're talking about," Catra lied. She kept her voice low and steady.

But Coach Weaver was too caught up in her own anger to hear her. "You treacherous, duplicitous brat." She circled around Catra as if she were a wild animal cornering her prey. "I have always been a disappointment, but you have somehow managed to fall below even my lowest expectations."

Catra's heart clenched. She'd expected something like this, but that didn't make Coach Weaver's words hurt any less.

"I did everything you asked," Catra replied through gritted teeth. "No one else would have worked as hard for you as I have, and you know it."

Coach Weaver let out an ominous peel of laughter. "That's interesting. I don't recall *asking* you to go behind my back and perform alongside the glee club at their regional competition."

The falling feeling came on fast. A numbness overcame Catra's extremities, and weightlessness filled her stomach like helium in a balloon. *Danger*, it announced. *Danger*.

"You are selfish, you are worthless," Coach Weaver snarled, "and apparently you don't know how to delete emails from a sent folder."

Catra's eyes grew wide. She flinched back, and Coach Weaver bled into the miniscule space she left behind.

"What did you do with those emails?" Coach Weaver whispered, so only Catra could hear. But when Catra refused to answer, Coach Weaver's voice soared to a wild, unhinged shriek. "I asked you a question!"

She moved so fast, lashing out with her open palm aimed right at Catra's face. The rest of the Valkyries let out a collective, startled cry.

But Catra moved just as quickly, catching Coach Weaver's hand only inches from her face. She held on tightly, and narrowed her eyes into a cutting glare.

"Nice fucking try," Catra said. Anger mixed with adrenaline. It coursed through her body with each thud of her frantic heart. Knowing that Coach Weaver had actually crossed that line made her feel sick to her stomach, but she was too caught up in survival mode to worry about that now. "I've been smacked around

enough in my life to know when it's coming." She shoved Coach Weaver with both hands, sending the miserable old woman stumbling back. "I know I'm a bad person who makes nothing but shitty decisions. But those emails? Let's just say I finally did one good thing with my life. I'm not letting you use Adora — not now, not ever again."

"No," Coach Weaver breathed in disbelief. "What have you done…"

Catra whirled around, not bothering to answer. She wasn't sure what she was going to do now, but she definitely wasn't going to stick around. All she needed to do was grab her stuff and then she could go back to being alone.

A feral scream filled the gymnasium. Catra barely had time to register the shock on her squadmates' faces before she was jerked back by her hair. She shrieked in both pain and surprise as she lost her balance and tumbled back.

"You bitch!" Coach Weaver howeled "You've ruined everything I've worked for! Everything!"

Her fingers dug into the base of Catra's thick ponytail, ripping at her hair as she yanked and shook. Terrified, Catra screamed and clawed at the woman's hand, trying desperately to free herself. Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle launched forward, shouting words Catra couldn't hear over her own panic.

"Give me these ribbons!" Coach Weaver screamed. Her grip was unrelenting. "You never deserved them! Never!"

At last, the captain's ribbons gave way with a snap. Catra fell forward, landing hard on her knees. She could hear Coach Weaver still spitting her wild vitriol as the others yelled frantically — yelled at Catra, at their coach, at each other. It was chaos, and Catra's brain screamed for her to escape.

So she abandoned her things. She didn't even look back as she took off across the gym floor and slammed into the hallway. Students were arriving now, and they stopped in the middle of

their morning routines to watch as Catra flew past them in tears. Outside, snow was falling fast and heavy. But Catra didn't care — she shoved her way out the doors and just kept running.

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By the time Mrs. Moon pulled the car into her usual spot in the faculty lot, Adora was almost vibrating with anxiety. Her seatbelt was undone before the car was even in park, and she spilled out the door as soon as Mrs. Moon turned off the ignition. Glimmer and Bow hurried out after her, each of them just as amped up as she was.

Thick, fluffy flakes fell from the cold grey sky. A blizzard was moving in, and already the ground was blanketed in a fresh layer of snow. It was peaceful in the way snowfalls usually were, which was a stark contrast to the melee of emotions battling one another inside of Adora's mind. She was nervous, and she was hopeful. She was scared, and she was furious.

At last, Mrs. Moon rose from the driver's seat and locked the car doors behind her. She looked to Adora, her gaze resolute. "Are you ready?"

"Yes," Adora nodded. "Let's do this."

The stack of emails was folded and tucked safely in her jacket pocket. Adora wrapped her hand around the square and held it like a talisman as the four of them hurried across the slick parking lot and into the school. Inside the front doors, Scorpia and Perfuma stood waiting for them.

"Hey, Scorpia," Adora said as Scorpia pulled her into a warm hug. She gave herself a beat to enjoy it before pulling back. "Thank you for being here. Are you absolutely sure you want to do this? Because I'll understand if you've changed your mind — telling Principal Hope what Coach Weaver's been doing is a big deal."

Scorpia shook her head. "Nope, I'm going with you. Enough is enough, right?"

At her elbow, Perfuma beamed proudly up at her girlfriend. “And we’ll all be here for moral support when you’re finished.”

“That’s right,” Glimmer agreed, looping her arm with Adora’s. Bow took the other arm and nodded.

“We better hurry if we want to catch Principal Hope,” Mrs. Moon said, checking her watch. “Follow me.”

The group strode with purpose, marching through the halls to the school’s administrative offices. Adora was reaching for the door handle when she heard voices calling her name.

“Do you guys hear that?” she asked.

“It’s the Valkyries,” Scorpia said, pointing down the hallway.

Adora turned to find Lonnie, DT, Kyle, Rogelio sprinting toward them. Their expressions were stricken — they looked panicked. Adora and Scorpia glanced at one another, concerned.

“What’s going on?” Adora asked when the Valkyries reached the rest of the group. She looked between them, their grim expressions sending a chill up her spine. Her mind immediately went to Catra. Had Coach Weaver found out about regionals. “Where’s Catra?”

Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio turned to DT in unison, who stood with their cell phone clutched tightly to their chest. That fact that they looked just as upset as others struck Adora as a bad sign.

“Here,” they said, thrusting their phone into Adora’s hands. “Watch this.”

With her friends clustered around her, Adora hit play on a video that was cued up on the screen. By the camera’s angle, it looked as if the video had been recorded surreptitiously. After a second or two of fumbling, the camera focused, and Catra and Coach Weaver came into frame. They were in the middle of a heated conversation.

In the video, Coach Weaver screamed. When her hand came down at Catra, Adora clutched the phone so hard she thought it might snap in her hands. Her alarm was replaced with a swell of pride when Catra intercepted the blow, and her heart tripped at Catra's words.

"*I'm not letting you use Adora — not now, not ever again*."

When Coach Weaver wrenched Catra back by her hair and threw her to the ground, Adora and everyone else watching cried out as one.

"What is the meaning of this?" Mrs. Moon demanded.

"It just happened," Lonnie explained. She shifted nervously from one foot to the other, throwing furtive looks over her shoulder. "At cheer practice. DT's the one who filmed it."

"Why?" Bow asked, his voice cracking with incredulity.

"Yeah," Glimmer chimed in. "Why didn't you do something to help?"

DT recoiled, looking scandalized. "Um, excuse you. As any self-respecting Valkyrie will tell you, no one gets in the way when Coach is in one of her rages. Not unless you have a death wish, anyway."

"They're right," Scorpia admitted quietly. She shrank back, ashamed.

"Besides," DT continued, "I may love drama, but even I know when to draw the line. But you can't take down a tyrant without a little ammunition, hence the blackmail video."

Adora's hands shook. The world spun around her.

"Where is she?" she asked. Everyone turned to her. "Where is Catra?"

“She took off,” Kyle said. “We don’t know where she went.”

Everything else fell away. In Adora’s mind, nothing else mattered. “I have to go. I need to find her.”

She pressed DT’s phone back into their hands and whirled around.

“Adora!” Glimmer called after her. “What about your meeting with Principal Hope?”

That was enough to bring Adora back to her senses. Turning back, she pulled the folded emails from her pocket and handed them to Glimmer. “Here, take these. I’m sorry, but I have to do this.”

“We know,” Bow said, wrapping her in a quick hug. “We’ll take care of things here.”

“Thank you,” Adora replied. Her voice quivered with the threat of grateful tears. She offered her friends a smile, then turned on her heel and ran for the door.

She didn’t care if she had to search the whole damn town — she was going to find Catra.

Chapter 44

The snow was coming down hard by the time Adora made it to the group home. Winds had picked up, whipping fresh power around so fiercely that she had to pull her hood low just to keep it from stinging her eyes and biting at her cheeks. She jogged up the front walk and stumbled inside where it was mercifully warm and dry.

"Catra? Madame Razz?" she called. "Is anyone home?"

She wasn't necessarily surprised to find the house quiet — Razz usually waited until the kids went to school before heading out to run errands. She also wasn't really surprised that Catra hadn't responded. Adora wasn't sure that Catra would be there at all, but she wasn't sure where else to look, and she had to start somewhere.

Shaking the snow off her jacket, Adora didn't bother to remove her boots. Instead, she ran to her bedroom. She found it empty and, even though she didn't really expect Catra to be hiding out in there the way she used to, it still raised a fresh wave of worry inside of her. Turning on her heel, Adora ran to the stairs. She shook her head as she climbed, trying desperately to dislodge the memory of what she'd seen on that video. The image of Catra's face, terrified as Coach Weaver wrenched her around by her hair, made Adora's stomach turn and her heart hurt. It was a horrible thing for anyone to witness, but only Adora understood just how awful it must have been for Catra.

Growing up, Adora was the only person Catra ever really confided in. No amount of counselors or social workers could get Catra to tell the whole truth about the things she'd been through in the system. But Adora knew — Adora understood. Which is why she knew she needed to find Catra, and she needed to find her fast.

When she pushed her way into Catra's room without knocking, the first thing Adora noticed was how cold the room was. The second

thing she noticed was that Catra wasn't there.

But something was.

Something dark was scattered all over the floor, but Adora couldn't make out what it was. She fumbled for the lightswitch and flipped it on. In the light she saw the kitchen scissors lying abandoned in the middle of Catra's messy floor. Adora blinked as her brain tripped to process what she was looking at, and when it hit her, she gasped.

It was hair. Clumps of thick, brown hair were strewn over the carpet. The ends were jagged, evidence of having been hacked off.

"Oh, Catra," Adora breathed, her hands pressed over her mouth. "What did you do?"

Her mind churned. Clearly Catra had been here, but where was she now? Adora turned, ready to search every inch of the house, when she heard something rattle. Her eyes snapped to the window above Catra's bed. Only then did she realize she could hear the wind. The blinds wafted, then fell back against the window frame with a clatter.

"Shit," she hissed, bounding across the room in two long strides. Adora scrambled over Catra's mattress and yanked the blinds out of the way. The world outside was a blur of snow, and Adora had to squint just to see.

Then, just for a moment, the wind let up and through the drifting flakes, she saw her: Catra, still in her reds, huddled at the far corner of the garage roof. She was curled into a tight ball, with her face pressed to her knees and her arms slung over her head as if they might provide any measure of protection against the elements. From the window, Adora could see the way Catra's shoulders trembled, though whether it was from the cold or tears, she couldn't tell.

“Catra!” Adora shouted through the open window, shivering despite her jacket still being on. Catra must have been freezing — at least she was still wearing her shoes. “Catra, what are you doing out there?”

The wind howled again, sending snow whipping across the roof. Through the squall, Adora could just make out Catra’s dual-colored eyes peering over her shoulder, her pupils constricted into points.

Adora pulled her hood up and swung her legs over the window sill. Carefully, she lowered herself onto the roof. The layer of snow that blanketed the shingles shifted under her feet, reminding her to tread carefully. Step by careful step, Adora inched her way to Catra. Every time a gust of wind rushed by, she had to pause and brace herself against the snow, making the trek both treacherous and painfully slow.

“What are you doing?” Catra called at last, her voice high and wavering over the wind.

“What does it look like?” Adora replied. “I’m coming to get you!”

Catra shook her head. The snow left her shorn hair matted against her head. “Don’t be an idiot, Adora! Just leave me alone.”

“No! It’s dangerous out here.”

“So?”

“You might get hurt!”

“It’s what I deserve.” Catra’s voice cracked. She let out a sob and burrowed tighter into herself. “I don’t matter anyway.”

A mighty blast of wind sent snow and ice flying. Catra yelped. The cold stole Adora’s breath from her lungs. She dropped low to steady herself.

“You matter to me, Catra!” Adora shouted. She reached out. “So, please — come back inside with me!”

Catra squinted through the snow, her teary gaze locked on Adora’s hand. She trembled, frightened, and Adora worried she was going to pull away again. But then, Catra’s shoulders sagged and her expression softened. Wordlessly, she shifted onto her knees, then to her feet. She shuffled forward, shivering violently.

Adora held her breath and took another tentative step. She stretched toward Catra, who reached for her too.

Another gust of wind raced through the air. It was fast and strong, and Catra pitched sideways with a shriek. Snow or not, she wasn’t used to balancing on the roof with shoes on — she had come to rely on the feeling of the shingles beneath her bare feet. She couldn’t feel how slick the roof had become, and when she flinched back from the bracing wind, her feet shot out from under her. She hit the roof hard and started to slide.

Without thinking, Adora lunged forward and threw herself on top of Catra. She kicked out and dug her winter boots into the snow. Their grip found purchase, biting in just enough to bring the girls to a skidding halt.

Adora’s chest heaved as adrenaline surged through her. She looked down to where Catra clung to her jacket.

“I’ve got you,” she said. “Are you okay?”

Catra gave a quick, wide-eyed nod. Adora breathed a sigh of relief and carefully eased back onto her knees.

“Okay, let’s go,” Adora said gently. “Keep low and stay close.”

She led the way, bracing Catra to her side away from the wind. The seconds it took them to reach the window felt like hours. Adora didn’t take a breath until they reached their destination. She helped Catra through the window first, and then hauled herself in after her. Once safely back in Catra’s room, Adora pulled

the window closed with a heavy *thunk* and locked it for good measure.

Sinking down with a sigh, Adora looked to Catra, who was huddled and shivering at the foot of the bed. Adora shed her snow-covered jacket and kicked off her boots. Then she pulled the comforter from where it was wadded carelessly against the wall and pulled it over Catra's shoulders. She wrapped her in it like she was swaddling an infant, then pulled her into her lap and held on for dear life. Catra pressed into her, tucking her wind-bitten face into the warm crook of Adora's neck. She stayed that way for a long time, teeth chattering and bones quaking in the safety of Adora's embrace.

Neither of them spoke. Adora rubbed slow, open-palmed circles against Catra's back and waited patiently. Eventually, Catra's shivering ebbed, and Adora felt her swallow against her throat.

"Why are you here?" Catra asked without lifting her head.

"I was worried about you," Adora answered. "The squad told me what happened — DT recorded the whole thing." Catra tensed in her arms. "I'm so, so sorry."

Catra huffed a dark laugh, her breath hot against Adora's skin. "Don't be. I got what I deserved."

Adora pushed Catra back, holding her just far enough away that she could meet her eyes.

"No, Catra. No matter what you've done, no matter what's happened, you did not deserve that."

Lip trembling, Catra looked away. Softly, Adora laid her hand to her cheek and turned Catra back to face her.

"I'm serious," she said. "What Coach Weaver did was wrong. You get that, right?"

Catra melted into Adora touch. She blinked, and a rogue tear traced its way down her face. “You should hate me.”

Adora shook her head. “I could never hate you, Catra.”

At this, Catra let out a sob. Adora pulled her back in and held her while she cried.

“You’re safe now,” she whispered. “I’ve got you.”

When Catra’s weeping subsided into sniffles and hiccups, she sat back again. It took her another moment before she lifted her eyes —so sad and tired—to meet Adora’s soft gaze. Adora smiled.

“You should change,” she said. “I’ll find you something warm to wear.”

She hurried around the room, fishing a pair of sweats and a hoodie from the mound of clean but unfolded laundry heaped on Catra’s desk chair. After handing them to Catra, she turned her back to give her some privacy. While she waited, she surveyed the carnage at her feet. It made her chest ache to see Catra’s beautiful hair on the ground. She could only imagine the headspace Catra must have been in when she took the scissors to it.

“It’s bad, isn’t it?” Catra said softly.

Adora turned and saw Catra sitting on the edge of her mattress, looking so small and meek in her oversized sweats. Her eyes were trained on the mess too. Absently, she ran a hand through the choppy mess on her head.

“She—” Catra started, then stopped. She swallowed and tried again. “I didn’t want—”

“It’s okay, Catra,” Adora said, crouching down in front of her. “I get it. Let me help you clean this up, okay?”

They worked like felons trying to clean up a crime scene. While Catra shoved handfuls of her hair into a garbage bag, Adora retrieved the vacuum and cleaned up the rest. With that task complete, Adora grabbed a chair from the kitchen and pulled it into the bathroom, where she sat Catra down and got to work fixing what was left of her hair. When she finished, Adora looked at Catra in the mirror.

"What do you think?"

"Well, it doesn't look like I had a complete mental breakdown anymore." Catra toyed with the tips of her new pixie cut. She lifted her eyes and offered Adora a sheepish smile. "Thanks."

With the chair and scissors back in their rightful places, the girls retreated to Adora's room and crawled under the covers. They lay side by side, facing one another in strange silence.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked after a while.

Catra considered the question for a moment, then shook her head slowly against the pillow. "I don't think so."

"That's okay," Adora said. "Take as much time as you need."

Apparently that wasn't the right thing to say, because Catra started to cry again. Adora panicked.

"I'm sorry! I didn't mean to—"

A small laugh escaped between Catra's sobs. She wiped her eyes and smiled weakly.

"You're such an idiot."

Adora relaxed. "Yeah, I know."

Catra's eyes searched Adora's face. "I really am sorry, Adora," she whispered.

Now it was Adora’s turn to chuckle. “Yeah, I know that too.”

So much hung in the silence between them — so many things they needed to say to one another. But there would be time enough for that. For now, just being close was enough.

Surprisingly exhausted, Adora closed her eyes. Then, just as she was starting to drift off, she felt Catra shift. A slender arm snaked around Adora’s waist, and the soft fuzz of Catra’s new hair tickled at her nose. She peeked down and watched Catra wriggle in closer, curling herself into Adora’s body.

In that moment, everything else melted away. Every terrible thing that waited for them outside of the four walls of Adora’s room could wait. Smiling wide, Adora draped her arm around Catra’s shoulders, pulled her in tight, and let her best friend’s gentle purring lull her to sleep.

Chapter 45

Adora and Catra stood side by side on a carefully shoveled walkway, staring at the main entrance of Stevenson High School.

"I really don't want to go in there," Catra mumbled, her voice muffled from behind her coat collar.

Adora gave her a sympathetic smile. "I know, but we've got to get this over with."

"Do we though?"

"Yes, we do."

Catra sighed and shrank further into her coat, her ears flattened miserably against her new haircut.

"It's going to be okay, Catra," Adora said. She reached out and took Catra's hand in her own. "We're going to do this together."

At some point the night before, Adora awoke and was surprised to find Catra at her side, breathing softly in the dark. After a disordienting moment, the nightmare of the day came flooding back to her. Quietly, she crept into the hallway and checked her phone. The screen lit up with dozens of messages and missed calls, none of which she had the stomach to read. So she texted Glimmer instead, who caught her up.

Principal Hope wants to meet with you both first thing tomorrow morning, Glimmer wrote. *Do you think you can get Catra to come back?*

Definitely, Adora replied, even though she knew it wouldn't be easy.

Ok great. I'll ask Mom to call Principal Hope and set it up.

Thanks, Glimmer, Adora wrote. *Btw, we cut Catra's hair last night. Don't ask. Can you tell the others not to make a big deal about it?*

Glimmer replied with 👀 followed quickly by, *I'm on it!* 👍

Now, Catra reached back with her free hand and pulled her hood up over that freshly shorn hair. Then she gave Adora's hand a squeeze. "Okay, let's get this over with."

Hand in hand, they pushed through the doors and into the school's main lobby where all of their friends stood waiting for them in an anxious, whispering cluster. Catra froze, but Adora tugged her gently after her. Their friends surged forward and surrounded the girls like a protective bubble, throwing their arms around them in a massive group hug. Their voices came from everywhere.

"We were so worried about you!" Bow exclaimed, his voice quivering on the edge of tears.

"I'm so sorry about what happened to you, Catra," Spinerella said.

"Fuck Coach Weaver," Lonnie shouted, earning a murmur of assent from the others.

When at last the loving mob backed up, Adora shot a glance at Catra, whose face was flushed scarlet. Standing there, shrinking under the affection of the very people she'd spent months trying to hurt, Catra was a shadow of her former self. Dressed in her favorite ripped jeans and Adora's SHS Athletics hoodie instead of her Valkyrie reds and signature ponytail, it was almost hard to believe she was the same girl who, only 24 hours ago, could command the entire school with a single pointed glare.

This new Catra—this *real* Catra—looked to Adora, who nodded back. Catra swallowed hard.

"Thanks," Catra said quietly, gripping so tightly that Adora started to lose feeling in her fingertips. "And I know it doesn't even begin

to make up for everything I did, but…" She paused to take a deep, shaking breath. "For whatever it's worth, I'm really, *really* sorry."

Glimmer glanced around at the others, all of whom smiled back. She put her hand on Catra's shoulder. "We know. And if Adora can forgive you, I think the rest of us can too."

Before Catra could reply, Scorpia wrapped both her and Adora in a crushing hug, lifting them off their feet. "Ah, I'm so happy!"

The others laughed, and when Scorpia put them back down, a cacophony of chatter broke out. Catra stood, smiling weakly as the others took turns wrapping her in hugs and telling her how glad they were that she was okay. Adora stood back, smiling so hard that her face hurt.

"Oh! Did Adora tell you the good news?" Perfuma asked brightly.

Confused, Catra raised an eyebrow at Adora, who could only shrug in reply. She wasn't sure what Perfuma was getting at either.

"No?" Catra said, to which Perfuma responded with an excited squeal.

"Thanks to your duet, we came in second at regionals!"

Catra's face fell. She rounded on Adora, her expression horrified. "You *lost*? Why didn't you tell me?"

But Glimmer laughed. "Just because we didn't come in first doesn't mean we lost."

"Yeah," Bow agreed, draping his arm over his girlfriend's shoulder. "This is the first time Stevenson High's glee club has ever made it to regionals. For a team as inexperienced as ours to come in second against all those other huge ensembles is a big deal!"

"We'll crush it next year," Glimmed said, beaming wide.

Adora couldn’t help but chuckle at the stunned look on Catra’s face. She knew all too well what was going through her mind: coming from the Valkyries, anything other than first place was an embarrassing loss.

“It turns out winning isn’t everything,” she said.

“I guess not,” Catra replied, sounding no less bewildered.

The sound of someone clearing their throat got the group’s attention. Adora looked over her shoulder to find Mrs. Moon waiting a few feet away. She smiled softly.

“Adora, Catra — Principal Hope is ready for you.”

*

Principal Hope already knew what happened. She’d listened to Scorpia and Glimmer, she’d watched the video and read the emails. Still, she wanted to hear the story straight from Adora and Catra. She sat in pensive, respectful silence as the girls started from the beginning and told her everything, looking away only to jot down a note here and there.

By the time they were finished, Adora was exhausted. Rehashing the details hurt her heart and left her feeling drained. She looked to Catra, who ran a shaky hand back through her hair. The other was still wrapped securely in Adora’s grip.

A light knock came from the office door.

“Come in,” Principal Hope said. Her voice conveyed a steadiness that made Adora feel safe.

The door inched open and Mrs. Moon leaned in.

“They’re here,” she said.

Principal Hope nodded. “Send them in.”

Adora and Catra exchanged curious looks as Mrs. Moon stepped aside to make way for a procession of people. First came Madame Razz, who scurried over to the girls. She was followed by a police officer and the social worker responsible for Catra's case file.

The blood in Adora's veins turned to ice. Instinctively, she threw her arms around Catra's shoulders the way she had ever since they were kids.

"What's going on?" she demanded. She was ready to fight — if they thought they were going to take Catra away from her, after everything they'd been through, they had another thing coming.

But Madame Razz put her hands on the girls' shoulders and smiled. "It's okay, girls. They're here to help." She tutted, fretting over Catra's hair and hugging each of them in turn. "Oh, my girls. I wish you'd told Madame Razz what you were going through."

Catra eyed the police officer and social worker with justified suspicion. "What do you mean they're here to help?"

"Coach Weaver will be relieved of her duties," Principal Hope said. She nodded to the police officer and social worker. "As for the criminal nature of her conduct, these two are here to discuss next steps."

Despite her best efforts, Adora wasn't allowed to be part of that conversation. Those next steps could only be discussed between Catra and the authorities, apparently. Adora only managed to catch snippets like "assault" and "press charges" as Mrs. Moon ushered her out into the hall and closed the door with an apologetic smile. To make matters worse, classes had started, which meant her friends had already scattered, leaving Adora to pace the hallway alone.

She fretted, worrying laps in front of the office door. Her hand felt uncomfortably light and cold without Catra's in it, and she hated that she couldn't be in there with her.

“I should check on her,” Adora muttered to herself as she turned to march back to the door. “Just make sure they’re not upsetting her or any—”

Adora froze mid-step. There, being escorted up the hallway by another police officer at her elbow, was Coach Weaver. Her hair and clothes were a disheveled mess, and it was the first time Adora had ever seen her wear anything other than her Valkyries tracksuit. Their eyes locked, and for a breathless moment, the world fell away.

Then, Adora saw red. Fury exploded like a bomb in her chest. Never had she wanted to make someone suffer as much as she did now.

“You monster,” she shouted, surging forward to close the distance so she could tear the disgraced coach limb from limb. The police officer stepped between them, ready to ward Adora off, but it didn’t matter — a hand closed around Adora’s arm and pulled her back.

“Adora, stop!”

The sound of Catra’s voice startled Adora back to her senses. She turned and found Catra staring beseechingly back at her.

“But—”

“No,” Catra said, shaking her head. “Just let it go. She’s not worth it.”

It took everything in Adora’s power to stand down, but she knew Catra was right. Instead of arguing, she backed up to make way for Principal Hope and the original police officer as they marched to where Coach Weaver stood scowling. The police informed no-longer-coach Weaver that she was under arrest for the assault of a minor, and led her out of the building. She didn’t even bother to look back.

“Wow,” Adora breathed. “It’s over. She’s really gone.”

Catra slid her hand down Adora’s arm and wove their fingers together once more.

“Good riddance.”



Chapter 46

In the wake of Coach Weaver's arrest, things at Stevenson High changed surprisingly fast.

Though the police managed to bar DT from sharing the video online, there was nothing they could do to stop the story from spreading through the school like wildfire. What remained of the Valkyries season was cancelled, and with the fall of their teenaged dynasty, the social order began to shift. The lines that separated different groups blurred, and the hierarchies lost their power. After all, if the Valkyries weren't infallible after all, what did that mean for everything else?

But Adora didn't realize just how much things were changing until the day the social committee asked Vocal Rebellion if they would perform at the upcoming Valentine's dance. It turns out Glimmer and Bow were right: coming in second at regionals didn't make losers out of them after all. Just because their competitive season was over, it didn't mean the team had to stop singing together.

"Is it weird that I'm more nervous about singing in front of the school than I was about singing in front of strangers?" she asked a few weeks later as Catra walked her to the bandroom.

"Not really," Catra replied with a shrug. "If you make an ass of yourself on stage, you still have to see all these people again afterwards."

Adora shook her head. "Gee, thanks. That makes me feel so much better."

"Oh, c'mon." Catra nudged her playfully with her ewlbow. "You've been performing in front of this school for years. This won't be any different."

They arrived at the bandroom. Catra leaned against the wall, arms crossed, while Adora hesitated.

“But you’re definitely going to be there, right?” Adora pinned Catra under her stare.

Catra tossed her hands up. “Yes, you dummy! I already told you I’d go to the dance with you. Don’t worry -- I’ll be front row center, making faces at you while you try to concentrate. You’ll be so glad I came.”

This earned a snort of laughter from Adora. “Okay, good. I guess I’ll see you at home then?”

“Yup.” Catra flicked her a quick salute as she pushed off the wall and started down the hall. “Tell the rest of the nerds I say hey.”

Adora smiled and waited for her to disappear around the corner. It took a lot of self control not to reach out and tug Catra back — to pull her into her arms and hold her for a while. But she’d been doing her best to play it cool and move slow. With so much changing around them, the last thing Adora wanted to do was come on too strong, too fast.

Besides, in the matter of confessing her feelings, Adora was already hard at work on a plan. Until then, she would just have to keep giving Catra her space.

Of all the things that had changed, Catra might be the one that changed the most. When Vocal Rebellion decided to keep meeting, they all made it clear that Catra was more than welcome. But it was an offer she politely declined.

“My counselor says I need to spend some time ‘working on myself’,” she’d explained when she turned them down. Though she acted as if the regular school-mandated counseling was a big inconvenience, Adora knew Catra actually appreciated it. And, as much as Adora wanted Catra back in the glee club, she was glad that she was finally getting the help she’d spent years insisting she didn’t need.

For Catra, “working on herself” looked like a lot of quiet self care. Every day, she and Adora went for a run together through the

dark and chilly streets before class. Sometimes, when Adora was at glee practice, Catra dug into her school work, getting ahead on her assignments and readings for the first time in her life. Other times she'd mess around with the acoustic guitar Bow had lent her, spending hours teaching herself to play with the help of videos online. It was a series of small steps, but Catra was putting in the work, and Adora was endlessly proud of her for it.

Adora was lost in this pride, smiling at the now empty hallway, when the band room door flew open beside her. She leapt back with a shout of surprise.

"Are you coming in or what?" Glimmer asked.

"Yeah, yeah. Sorry, I was just saying goodbye to Catra."

Bow looked up from his sheet music and smiled. "Did you find out for sure if she's coming to the dance?"

"Yup." Adora nodded, a wide grin stretching across her face. "She'll be there."

Glimmer let out a squeal of excitement and gave Adora a tight squeeze around her middle. "I guess that means we've got some work to do, don't we?"

The rest of the team laughed and teased as Adora, blushing fiercely, hurried to take her place at center stage.

"Okay, everyone! You heard Adora," Glimmer shouted, clapping her hands over the noise. "The target is confirmed, so let's move on to the next part of the plan!"

*

The day of the dance seemed to materialize out of nowhere. One minute Adora and Catra were being dragged through the mall by Glimmer and Bow, on the hunt for the perfect outfits for their performance, and the next they—along with the rest of the team

—had taken over the second floor of the Moon household to get ready for the big night.

Vocal Rebellion opted to go with a white and gold color scheme instead of matching costumes. Even though she wouldn't be joining them on stage, Catra even let Adora pick out a suit jacket that matched the dress she chose for herself. For the first time, Adora was actually excited to get dolled up for a dance.

In the bathroom, Adora fussed with the pristine white skirt that fell halfway down her thighs and adjusted the metallic gold straps on her shoulders. She was jittery with nerves, though at this point it had little to do with performing in front of her classmates.

A knock came from the door.

"Adora?" Catra called. "C'mon, everyone's downstairs already!"

"Coming!"

Adora pulled the door open wide to find Catra standing at the threshold looking like a fairytale prince. Her short hair was slicked back and playfully tousled. Over her half-unbuttoned dress shirt, she wore the white jacket, with its gold-edged cuffs and lapel draped on her shoulders like a cloak. The pair stared at one another in breathless silence. Adora could feel her cheeks burning as Catra offered her arm out to her with a grin.

"Ready to roll, princess?"

The group didn't have much time to enjoy the dance before Vocal Rebellion was due on stage. They milled around the crowded gymnasium under strings of fairy lights, and helium-filled red, white, and pink balloons, saying hello to friends as they waited for their cue. Adora marveled to see football players on dates with band kids, and former Valkyries openly joking around the drink table with students they never would have acknowledged only a handful of weeks earlier. It was truly a strange new world, and she loved to see it. All the while, Catra stayed pressed close to her side, looking like she'd rather crawl out of her own skin than face

the pitying, knowing glances of her peers, but keeping her complaints to herself for Adora's sake.

When the time came for the team to gather backstage, Adora turned to Catra and whispered, "Are you going to be okay on your own?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "I can handle standing alone for a few songs." Then she winked. "Like I said, I'll be front row center — no pressure!"

The time for witty banter was over. Glimmer grabbed Adora by the hand and dragged her back stage where the team was getting mic'd up. As they took their positions in front of the red velvet stage curtain, Scorpia caught Adora's eyes and grinned. Adora nodded back and took a deep breath — it was go time.

Coming up with a routine for the school dance was much easier than building one for a competition. Without having to worry about scoring points or winning over judges, Vocal Rebellion was free to do whatever they wanted. The occasion called for upbeat, poppy love songs, and that was exactly what they planned to deliver.

The team started with their backs to the audience. Adora watched the light sweep across the stage as the curtain was raised, letting in the curious and excited murmuring of the crowd. When the opening notes of Carly Rae Jepsen's "Cut To The Feeling" filled the gymnasium speakers and the team started to clap in time, the room erupted in cheers, and from that point it was easy.

With her boundless peppy energy, Glimmer was a perfect pick to lead the song. As she sang, the rest of Vocal Rebellion filled in the harmonies, turning to face the audience with each beat. Adora's eyes immediately fell to the front row center and, as promised, she found Catra, flanked by the other Valkyries, grinning back at her. That was all she needed to see. Her pre-performance jitters were forgotten — all Adora cared about now was throwing herself into the performance and having fun with her friends. She

bounded through the choreography and belted out the lyrics, heart soaring as the sound of the crowd singing along filled her ears. From her place on the floor, Catra looked back over her shoulders, taking in the excitement of their peers. When her eyes found Adora's again, they were bright with pride.

The first song ended to raucous applause. Bow slid up beside Glimmer and took her hand. He gave her a twirl and dipped her low, pulling her back up just in time to start crooning the opening lines of "What A Man Gotta Do" by the Jonas Brothers. He and Seahawk took the lead on this one, while the rest of the team laughed and sang their way through the Grease-inspired dance moves they had adapted from the music video. Catra howled with laughter as Adora jived by, throwing her a wink as she went. The energy filled the room to bursting as everyone clapped along. Adora was having so much fun, she almost didn't want it to end.

But eventually it did end, and that's when the nerves came back in full force. Her friends and teammates stepped aside to give her center stage, smiling and flashing her encouraging thumbs-ups as she moved into the spotlight. It was sectionals all over again as Adora's stomach twisted itself into knots.

And then, just like at sectionals, her eyes found Catra, and all that worry fell away.

"Let's hear it for Vocal Rebellion!" Adora exclaimed in her best cheer captain voice. The audience obliged with shouts and whistles. "We hope you've enjoyed the performance so far. We've got one last song for you all, but before for we start…" She paused to swallow and smooth her sweaty palms over her skirt. "I just wanted to say that this one is dedicated to someone really special. Um, I mean special to me, that is." As the crowd laughed and ooh'd playfully, Adora's eyes dropped back down to Catra, who seemed frozen in the moment, staring up at her with an expression that hovered somewhere between confusion and comprehension. Adora gave her a hopeful smile. "Okay, here goes everything."

A high school pop-infused performance about love wouldn't be complete without some Taylor Swift. There were certainly more popular songs from the megastar's discography they could have gone with, but Adora had picked this one carefully.

She took a step back, and the music to "How You Get The Girl" began.

"Stand there like a ghost, shaking from the rain.

She'll open up the door and say, are you insane?"

Most of the performance had been planned to let Adora sing directly to Catra. While the rest of Vocal Rebellion danced and filled the stage, she had one job: make sure Catra heard what she was so desperately trying to tell her.

"Say it's been a long six months, and you were too afraid to tell her what you want…"

Catra's eyes widened with surprise. Lonnie and Kyle, DT and Rogelio all jostled her, teasing lightheartedly when they realized what was going on. But as far as Catra was concerned, Adora was the only other person in the world.

"And that's how it works", Adora sang with a sheepish little smile. *"That's how you get the girl."*

The song exploded into the chorus, and Adora sang her heart out.

"And then you say I want you for worse or for better.

I would wait for ever and ever.

Broke your heart, I'll put it back together.

I would wait for ever and ever…"

If there had been any confusion left in Catra's mind, it was long gone now. Her cheeks blushed as Adora sang directly to her. She

didn’t dare so much as blink.

“And that's how it works, that's how you get the girl.”

Now came the part that Adora had struggled most with during rehearsals — the part that made her feel most vulnerable. If Catra heard nothing else, Adora needed her to hear this.

“Remind her how it used to be with pictures in frames of kisses on cheeks.

Tell her how you must've lost your mind when you left her all alone and never told her why.

And that's how it works. That's how you lost the girl…”

Even through the noise of the crowd and the sound of her own singing, Adora was certain she could hear Catra gasp. She watched her press her hand over her mouth, her eyes still trained unblinkingly up at her as Adora sang through the chorus yet again.

The song slowed at the bridge — Adora’s last opportunity to sing to Catra before being swept up in choreography that would end with her making her way off the stage to sing the last line face-to-face. They held one another’s gaze with every word Adora sang, until finally the bridge came to a close and she was forced to step back into the blur that was Vocal Rebellion. The final part of the dance was a spectacle of motion, featuring the most intricate moves of the entire performance. Adora danced through it on pure muscle memory alone.

The song moved into its final bars. Adora stepped across the stage, only to immediately forget what she was doing when she realized that Catra was gone.

Catra’s spot, front row center, was empty.

The world slowed to a crawl as Adora’s mind tripped over itself.

A million thoughts careened through her brain in a split second. She had embarrassed Catra in front of the whole school. Catra didn't feel the same way — she never had. Everything was ruined.

But the miniscule part of Adora that was still capable of rational thought noticed the Valkyries, who seemed to be shouting something up at her. They were smiling and pointing somewhere to Adora's left. Slowly, she turned, and at the same moment, the crowd broke into a frenzy as Catra's voice filled the air.

"*And that's how it works*..." Catra stood at the edge of the stage, singing into the headset that Scorpia held out to her. "That's how you got the girl."

Before Adora could react, Catra crossed the stage in three quick strides, took Adora's face in her hands, and kissed her.

In that moment, the rest of the world ceased to exist. Was the crowd still cheering? Were they shocked into a silence so perfect that you could hear a pin drop? Adora didn't know, nor did she care. All that mattered was Catra and this kiss — everything else could wait.

When Catra finally pulled back, Adora blinked back at her in a daze.

"Wow," she said, forgetting she was still mic'd and earning a wave of laughter from the audience. Catra shook her head.

"Don't ruin it." Catra replied.

And then she kissed Adora again, just because she could.



Chapter 47

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

For the rest of the night, Adora only let go of Catra's hand if she absolutely had to. Every moment felt like a dream, and she was afraid that if she released her grip, she might suddenly wake up and lose it all.

But this was no dream: Catra's hand was warm in hers, her smile was bright, and her lips fit against Adora's as though they were made just for her to kiss.

"I can't believe you did that," Catra laughed against Adora's cheek as they danced, tightly wrapped in each other's arms. "What would you have done if your grand romantic gesture didn't work?"

Adora felt lightheaded just thinking about it. "I probably would have dropped dead right there on stage. There would have been no coming back from something like that." She pulled back so she could lean her forehead against Catra's. "But at least I would have died knowing I took my shot."

Catra grinned and bit her bottom lip. "Yeah, well, I'm glad you didn't let a potential death sentence stop you." She ran her fingertips lightly along Adora's jawline, her eyes raking over her features like she was seeing her for the first time.

"Is it cheesy to say you were worth the risk?" Adora asked.

"Very. But don't let that stop you."

That night, when the dance was done and the afterparty at Glimmer's place wound down, the newly minted couple zipped their sleeping bags together, curled into one another and fell asleep in one another's arms. It was something they'd been doing for nearly half their lives, but somehow it felt different now. Now,

with their truths out there, being tangled up in one another didn't just feel nice and safe: it felt like destiny.

The group slept late the next morning, rousing only when their hunger became too much to ignore. They made the pilgrimage to a local diner and clamored into a corner booth for brunch. As Adora gazed around the table, her heart was as fuller than it had ever been. She was surrounded by friends -- from both glee and cheer alike -- all of whom were laughing together and enjoying one another's company as if it had always been this way. And at her side was the girl of her dreams, their fingers still firmly knitted together. They leaned into one another and stole kisses when they thought the others weren't looking. Of course, the others were always looking, but Adora didn't mind their playful teasing if it meant she got to keep kissing Catra.

Adora was shoving the last of her pancakes into her mouth when she felt her phone vibrate. Catra glanced down.

"Is that a phone in your pocket or are you just happy to see me?" she asked, making Adora choke on her last bite.

While Adora attempted to wash down her pancakes, Catra wrestled the phone from her pocket and glanced at the caller ID before picking it up.

"Hey Razz." She listened for a moment. "No, you called the right number. Adora's just drowning in maple syrup at the moment… Yeah, she'll survive." There was another beat of silence as Catra listened to their house mother. Adora, no longer at risk of breakfast-related asphyxiation, watched with curiosity.

"Sure," Catra said at last, her brows furrowing ever so slightly. "We'll be there in a few."

"Be where?" Adora asked as Catra ended the call.

"Apparently you've got a visitor waiting for you at home."

The couple paid their bill and said goodbye to their friends before rushing home. On the bus, Adora fidgeted anxiously. Razz had apparently been vague on the phone, not giving any indication of who had decided to drop in unannounced. Privately, she wondered if it had something to do with the Coach Weaver situation, which likely would have meant they'd find a lawyer or police officer waiting inside. That thought made Adora squirm.

"Relax," Catra said, giving her a squeeze. "I'm sure it's fine. And if it's not--" she lifted their clutched hands "--we got this, right?"

Adora smiled. "Right."

But when they rushed into the house, it was neither a lawyer nor a police officer they found waiting: it was Joe DiTillio, the recruiter from Eternia University.

"Mr. DiTillio!" Adora exclaimed when she found him sitting at the dining room table, talking over tea with Madame Razz. "What are you doing here?"

"Hello again, Adora!" he replied, getting to his feet. "Sorry for dropping in unannounced again -- I promise I'm not usually this unprofessional, but given the circumstances, I thought it might be best if we could chat face to face." His gaze shifted to Catra, who stood pressed against Adora's side, and extended his hand. "Catra, right?"

Adora turned to her with surprise. "How do you know each other?"

"I may have reached out to him after I, uh, *accidentally* read Coach Weaver's emails," Catra said as she shook the recruiter's hand.

"That's right." Mr. DiTillio nodded. "She filled me in on what's been going on. Now I understand why you seemed so confused the last time I was here."

Adora let out an awkward laugh. She shot a quick look at Catra, looking for some clue as to what she was thinking or what exactly she'd said to Mr. DiTillio. But Catra kept her eyes trained on the recruiter, staring at him expectantly.

"I also touched base with Principal Hope," Mr. DiTillio continued. He spoke gently, as if alluding to Coach Weaver's recent fall from grace was a delicate subject. "I realize this has probably been a challenging year, Adora. And I know you technically aren't part of the Valkyries Cheer Force anymore. But after discussing your situation with the admissions board, we all agreed that it wouldn't be fair to rescind our offer when you weren't even aware it was there. I don't know if you would have made different decisions had you been fully informed, but let's just pretend you would have."

Catra released a sigh of relief, and the tense grip she had on Adora's hand relaxed. Adora looked between the two of them, confused.

"I don't understand. What are you saying?"

Mr. DiTillio smiled. "I'm saying if you choose to continue with your school's cheer program next year once it's been reinstated, Eternia University's offer of scholarship will stand. We'd love to have you on our team."

Since learning about the scholarship, Adora hadn't let herself think about it. In her mind, the whole thing was too unattainable, especially since she'd quit the Valkyries. But now that it was back on the table, she didn't know what to feel.

"I… That's very kind of you, Mr. DiTillio, but I don't think I can accept that offer," she said.

"What?" Catra balked, her voice squeaking indignantly. She turned to Mr. DiTillio. "Will you give us a sec? We'll be right back."

Before he could answer, Catra dragged Adora down the hallway and shoved her into her bedroom.

“What are you doing?” Catra hissed once they were alone.

“I’m being honest!” Adora replied. “Catra, I quit the squad. I have no business accepting a cheerleading scholarship when I’m not a cheerleader anymore!”

Catra groaned and massaged her temples. “Okay, first of all, you’d still be a Valkyrie if Coach Weaver hadn’t forced you to choose between the squad and glee. Second, he literally just said that doesn’t matter! All you have to do is be on the team next year and you’re set!”

Adora swallowed. “But what if I don’t want to be a cheerleader anymore? I mean, if anyone deserves this scholarship it’s you -- you were a way better captain than I would have been and--”

The rest of her words were smothered out of existence as Catra silenced her with a kiss. When she pulled back, Catra glared at her.

“Just so you know, that wasn’t an affectionate kiss. That was a ‘please stop talking because you sound like an idiot’ kiss.”

“Hey!”

“Adora, listen to me.” Catra cupped Adora’s face in her hands and stared sternly into her eyes. “They don’t want the captain -- they want *you*. They’ve wanted you all along. And nobody’s saying you have to be a professional cheerleader. This is just a means to an end. Without Coach Weaver around, you’ll be able to do both cheer and glee next year if that’s what you want, and you’ll still have a full ride to an amazing school waiting for you at the end of it.” Her expression softened as she searched Adora’s eyes. “You used to love cheerleading, Adora. Don’t let Coach Weaver take that from you. And don’t let this shitty year be what stands between you and the future you deserve.”

Her speech took Adora’s breath away.

“But what about you?” Adora asked in a quiet voice. “You deserve to be happy too. And I--” she didn’t even realize she’d started crying until Catra wiped away a tear with her thumb “-- I’m not going to leave you behind again, Catra.”

Despite the tears swimming behind her eyes, Catra found it in herself to laugh. “Who said anything about leaving me behind?”

“You’d come with me?”

Now, Catra glanced away. She shrugged sheepishly. “It might be a long shot, but my guidance counselor thinks I could be eligible for some academic scholarships if I start applying myself.”

Adora let out a soft gasp. “Is that why you’ve been studying so much lately?”

“I figured it was worth a try,” Catra mumbled, her cheeks flushing. “And I’m going to try out for the track team too. But even if I don’t get a scholarship, that doesn’t mean I can’t go with you. I’m gonna get a job -- I’ll apply for loans if I have to. I mean, if it comes down to it, we could just get an apartment in the city or something, and I’ll keep working while I save up.”

“Wow.” Adora smiled. “You’ve really thought this through, haven’t you?”

Catra flashed a cheeky grin. “Maybe. Now get in there and tell that guy that you accept!”

She ushered Adora back out of the room, pausing at the stairs.

“I’ll be in my room,” Catra said. “Come find me when you’re done.”

And so, Adora returned to the dining room, striding confidently and smiling wide.

“Mr. DiTillio,” she announced. “Please let the admissions board know that I accept their offer.”

*

It was a while before Mr. DiTillio finally took his leave. He'd brought a stack of paperwork with him, and insisted on walking Adora through the details. When Adora showed him to the door, her mind was spinning with information, but her heart was very full. She and Madame Razz stood on the front steps and waved as Mr. DiTillio pulled away.

"I'm so proud of you, dearie," Madame Razz said, hugging Adora around her middle--the highest point she could reach. "I think I'll make some pie to celebrate!"

"Thanks, Razz," Adora replied. "That sounds great."

As her house mother bustled back into the kitchen, Adora stole up the stairs. The sound of chords being played on an acoustic guitar drifted from the open crack in Catra's bedroom door. Adora hovered in the hallway and peered inside.

Catra sat cross-legged on her bed, bent over the guitar Bow had lent her. Despite being brand new to the instrument, her fingers already moved deftly across the fretboard as if she'd been playing for years. Her ears quirked.

"I know you're out there," she said without looking up. "Get in here, creeper."

Adora did as she was told. She closed the door behind her and came to sit at Catra's side.

"So?" Catra asked. "Is it official?"

"Yup." Adora smiled. "Thanks for… Well, thanks for everything, I guess."

By way of response, Catra snorted a laugh, but said nothing. Her hands continued to dance over the guitar strings and she started to play a song. Adora gave her a nudge.

“Are you planning on joining a band or something? You’ve been practicing a lot.”

Again, Catra laughed, but this time Adora noticed the touch of red in her cheeks.

“Not exactly.” Catra said, starting the song over again.

“It figures you’re already so good at it,” Adora continued, leaning back on her hands. “Seriously, is there anything you can’t do?”

At last, Catra looked up. She pinned Adora under an exasperated glare. “Will you stop for, like, two and a half minutes? I’m trying to do something romantic here and you keep ruining it.”

“Oh!” Adora sat up in surprise. “I, uh, sure. What should I--” she shrank back under yet another cutting look from Catra. “Right. Shutting up now.”

Once she was satisfied, Catra cleared her throat and started to play. This time, Adora recognized it -- an indie song by an artist named John-Allison Weiss who Catra had long adored in secret. It was songs like this--the hidden gems that others often overlooked--that Catra liked best, and this was one in particular that she usually put on whenever she got to pick the music.

Blushing deeply, Catra sang in that lovely voice of hers.

“*I was an island before you came along.*

Put your boat in my sand, your hand in my hand, your heart in my songs.

I was a fighter, and I was so brave.

But I lowered my sword when you held me and swore you'd stay, stay, stay oh…”

Adora’s breath caught in her throat. Her lips started to tremble, so she covered them with her hands. If Catra noticed, she didn’t let

on. Instead, she kept singing.

"*I can't do this alone anymore, 'cause I'm no good on my own anymore.*

What did I do to deserve this? What did you do to me?

Baby, come back. You know I don't want to be free.

"*I was a rebel, but I had a cause.*

'Til you came to town, pushed me around, and showed me what love was.

I was a wolf, dear, apart from the pack.

But you answered my cries in the dead of the night, and told me that you had my back…"

Catra lifted her eyes and locked her gaze with Adora's. There was a softness there -- a vulnerability that she never let anyone else see. For the first time in so long, she looked truly happy. A real, beautiful smile lit up her face as she played into the final chorus.

"*I can't do this alone anymore, 'cause I'm no good on my own anymore.*

What did I do to deserve this? What did you do to me?

Baby, come back. You know I don't want to be free, no, no, no.

Baby, come back. You know I don't want to be free."

She finished with a flourish that made Adora laugh.

"That was amazing," Adora said, her heart fluttering in her chest. "Did you…" She hesitated, feeling a little foolish. "Did you learn that for me?"

"Of course."

Adora licked her lips. “How come?”

She knew what she wanted the answer to be, but she wanted Catra to say it. She needed to hear it from Catra’s lips.

Flustered in a way Adora had never seen before, Catra groaned. She put the guitar down.

“Don’t you get it?” Catra cupped Adora’s cheek with one hand and pulled her close with the other. “I love you. I always have.”

And that was all it took to bring Adora to tears. “You love me?”

Catra shook her head and grinned. “You’re such an--”

Adora didn’t let her finish. She leaned in and cut her off with a long, deep kiss. She only stopped for a moment -- just long enough to whisper back,

“I love you too.”

*

Adora was quickly learning that it was very easy to lose track of time when she was tangled in Catra’s arms. They made out for hours, until their mouths were sore and their necks were peppered with tell-tale bruises. By the time the sun went down, they were each wearing less than they had been before, and found warmth instead by curling up together beneath Catra’s comforter. Adora combed the tips of her fingers through Catra’s hair and enjoyed the gentle rumble of her purring, like thunder in the distance.

“Y’know,” Adora said, looking at Catra’s head on her chest, watching it rise and fall gently with each breath she took. “If someone told me six months ago that we’d be here now, I would have laughed in their face.”

“You’re too nice to laugh in anyone’s face,” Catra replied. She tipped her face back and grinned, and it made Adora’s heart soar.

They fell back into comfortable silence, enjoying the peace of finally being together the way they'd always dreamed. Suddenly, Catra's purring stopped.

Adora glanced down again. "Everything okay?"

"Yeah," Catra replied. She rolled onto her back and laid her head back against Adora's shoulder. "I was just thinking… Remember 'Operation: One Perfect Year at Stevenson High'?"

It was something Adora hadn't thought about in months -- about their big plan to become teenage royalty and rule the school, side by side. Everything about it felt like it was from a different lifetime. The two of them had changed so much.

Adora nodded with a hum. "What about it?"

Catra shifted, somehow managing to snuggle in even closer. "If everything had worked out the way we planned, do you think we'd be here now?"

"Huh." Adora frowned. "That's a good question. What do you think?"

"I don't know," Catra said with a shrug of her bare shoulder. "It sounds weird now, after everything that happened, but I don't think I would have wanted to risk losing you."

Adora understood completely. She probably would have gone on, loving Catra in secret indefinitely instead of risking what they had by being honest. Maybe losing it all was exactly what they needed. Adora smiled.

"What?" Catra asked, warily. "And do *not* say 'everything happens for a reason'."

At this, Adora couldn't help but giggle. She wiggled onto her side so that she and Catra were face to face.

“I wasn’t going to say that. I was just thinking about how the year hasn’t been perfect, but this part sure is.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. Adora braced herself for the teasing -- for a jab about how being in love had made her soft and corny.

Instead, Catra pressed a soft kiss to Adora’s lips and smiled.

“Agreed,” she said. “And the year isn’t over yet.”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean we’ve still got lots of time to make this our year, dummy.” Catra reached up and gave Adora a playful poke in the forehead. “We just have to figure out what that looks like.”

Adora’s face lit up, as a world of possibilities opened up before her -- before *them*.

“In that case, what do you say to ‘Operation: One Perfect Year at Stevenson High’, take two?”

The rumble of Catra’s purring started again as Adora pulled her in close. Catra nuzzled her face against Adora’s jawline and sighed happily.

“Sounds good to me.”

- THE END -

Chapter End Notes

- If you love this story, PLEASE SHARE IT WITH YOUR FRIENDS ON SOCIAL MEDIA! It's the best way to help new readers find the story, and it helps keep me motivated to keep writing fics! If you’d like to tip me, I also accept donations at ko-fi.com/Maggie

- You can follow me on Twitter (@ MaggieDerrick) and Instagram (@Maggie.Derrick) if you want to stay updated on

my future projects

- By request, I've designed a few Gleera-inspired shirts, featuring designs mentioned in the fic. You can get them, along with art prints, on Redbubble (Just search for GLEERA)

- Don't forget to check out the official Gleera playlist on Spotify! Just search for "Glee-Ra: The Official Playlist of One Perfect Year at Stevenson High"

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